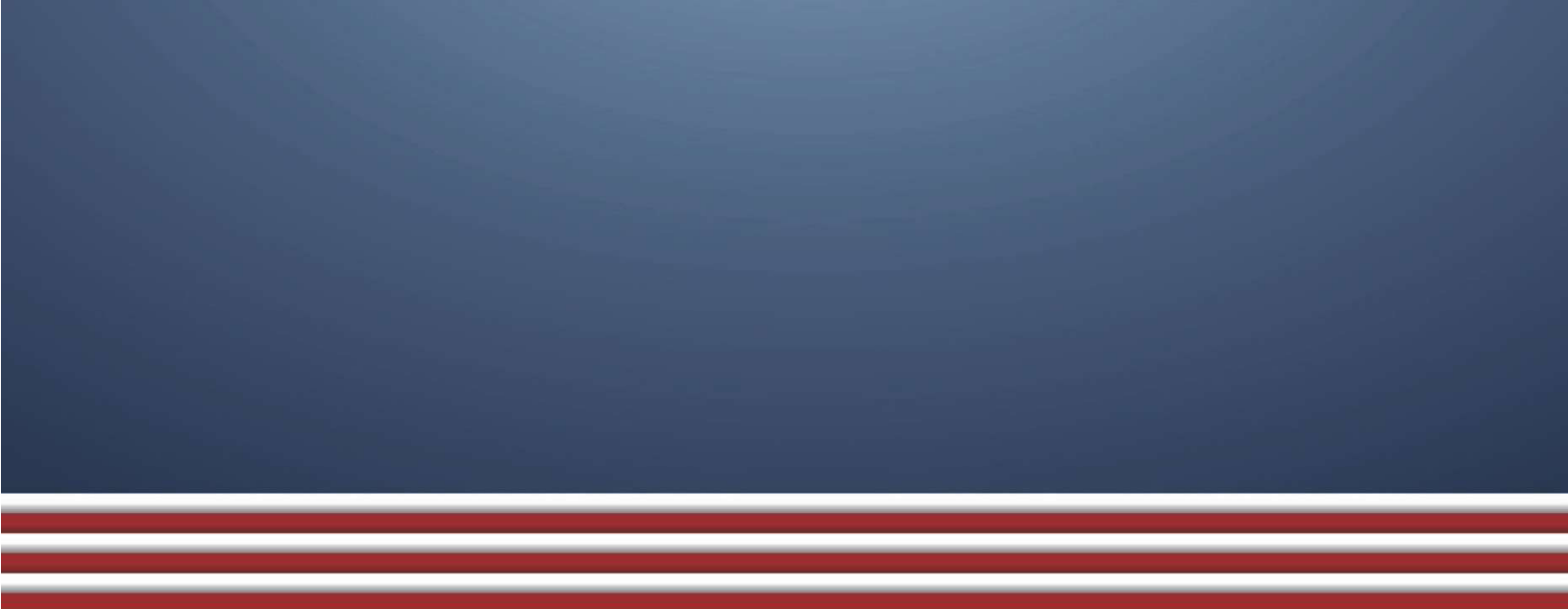




2022 Missile Defense Review



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I. INTRODUCTION

The 2022 Missile Defense Review (MDR) provides direction to the Department of Defense (DoD) and guidance to its interagency partners on U.S. missile defense strategy and policy in support of the National Defense Strategy (NDS). The MDR provides a framework for U.S. missile defenses that is informed by: defense priorities and deterrence objectives as indicated in the NDS; the framework of integrated deterrence; and the multifaceted elements of U.S. missile defenses. The MDR also identifies how the United States is integrating missile defense with its Allies and partners to strengthen international cooperation against shared threats.

Since the release of the last MDR in 2019, missile-related threats have rapidly expanded in quantity, diversity, and sophistication. U.S. national security interests are increasingly at risk from wide-ranging missile arsenals that include offensive ballistic, cruise, and hypersonic weapons, as well as lower-tier threats such as Uncrewed Aircraft Systems (UAS).

The United States will continue to rely on strategic deterrence – underwritten by a safe, secure, and effective nuclear arsenal, and reinforced by a resilient sensor and Nuclear Command, Control and Communications (NC3) architecture – to address and deter large intercontinental-range, nuclear missile threats to the homeland from the People’s Republic of China (PRC) and the Russian Federation (Russia). As the scale and complexity of the Democratic People’s Republic of Korea (North Korea) missile capabilities increase, the United States will also continue to stay ahead of North Korean missile threats to the homeland through a comprehensive missile defeat approach, complemented by the credible threat of direct cost imposition through nuclear and non-nuclear means.

Missile defeat encompasses the range of activities to counter the development, acquisition, proliferation, potential and actual use of adversary offensive missiles of all types, and to limit damage from such use. In support of the homeland missile defense mission, continued modernization and expansion of the Ground-based Midcourse Defense (GMD) system will remain an essential element of our comprehensive missile defeat approach. In addition, as part of this comprehensive approach, the United States will also continue to improve defensive capabilities to address the threat of evolving cruise missile strikes by any adversary against the homeland.

To strengthen regional defense and deterrence, close cooperation with Allies and partners on Integrated Air and Missile Defense (IAMD) will remain an important priority. As such, the United States will continue to pursue Joint, Allied and partner IAMD capabilities needed to maintain a credible level of regional defensive capability for joint maneuver forces and critical infrastructure against all missile threats from any adversary in order to protect U.S. forces abroad, maintain freedom of maneuver, and strengthen security commitments to our Allies and partners.

II. EVOLVING AIR AND MISSILE THREAT ENVIRONMENT

Adversaries are developing, fielding, and integrating more advanced air and missile capabilities into their strategies in order to favorably shape the course of a potential crisis or conflict. These air and missile capabilities pose an expanding and accelerating risk to the U.S. homeland, U.S. forces abroad, and our Allies and partners.

Current and emerging ballistic, cruise, and hypersonic missile capabilities, as well as new threats such as small Uncrewed Aircraft Systems (sUAS), are complicating the traditional roles of air and missile defense. Potential adversaries are acquiring longer-range and more complex missiles, and are seeking meaningful military advantage with advanced conventional missiles, enabled by sophisticated information systems and sensors. Threat actors are developing and deploying mobile missile systems to reduce the ability of the United States, Allies, and partners to detect, identify, and respond to launch preparations. Hypersonic weapons, designed to evade U.S. sensors and defensive systems, pose an increasing and complex threat due to their dual (nuclear/conventional) capable nature, challenging flight profile, and maneuverability.

PRC. As outlined in the NDS, PRC efforts and activities to contest the rules-based international order make it the pacing challenge for the Department. Over the past two decades, the PRC has dramatically advanced its development of conventional and nuclear-armed ballistic and hypersonic missile technologies and capabilities, through intense and focused investment, development, testing, and deployments. The PRC currently utilizes Russian-developed air and missile defense systems while also pursuing indigenous capabilities that are growing in sophistication. In many areas such as conventional ballistic and hypersonic missile technologies, the PRC continues to close the gap with the United States, and will likely continue to develop and expand its missile capabilities. Increasingly sophisticated and proliferated space-based Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR) networks, and improved Command and Control (C2) systems, have greatly improved the precision and accuracy of missile systems the PRC would employ to deter and counter U.S. forward presence and operations, especially in the Western Pacific region.

Russia. The unprovoked Russian invasion of Ukraine clearly signals the re-emergence of a more militaristic Russia that seeks to overturn the post-Cold War European security system and challenge the broader rules-based international order. Through its hostile actions, Russia seeks to expand its control over portions of the former Soviet empire in order to reclaim what it regards as its rightful position on the world stage. In Ukraine, Russia has used thousands of air, land, and sea-launched cruise and ballistic missiles, including hypersonic missiles. Current battlefield losses threaten to reduce Russia's modernized weapons arsenal, and coordinated and wide-ranging economic sanctions and export controls may hinder its future ability to effectively produce modern precision-guided munitions.

As noted in the NDS, Russia also seeks to advance its interests by directly challenging U.S. national interests. Over the last 10 years, Russia has prioritized modernization of its intercontinental range missile systems and is developing, testing, and deploying new, diversified capabilities that pose new challenges to missile warning and defense of the U.S. homeland. Russia is developing and fielding a suite of advanced precision-strike missiles that can be launched from multiple air-, sea-, and ground-based platforms, and feature many capabilities designed to defeat missile defenses. Russia has retained and upgraded its own missile defense system designed to protect Moscow against a U.S. strike, and has developed several lower-tier air defense systems for its own use and export as a foreign policy instrument.

North Korea. North Korea continues to improve, expand, and diversify its conventional and nuclear missile capabilities, posing an increasing risk to the U.S. homeland and U.S. forces in theater, as well as regional Allies and partners. In 2017, North Korea flight-tested two different types of domestically-produced road-mobile Intercontinental Ballistic Missiles (ICBM), both of which can reach the U.S. homeland. In 2020, North Korea displayed a new, larger ICBM during a military parade. Additionally, North Korea has a range of domestically-produced missile systems, including short-, medium-, and Intermediate-Range Ballistic Missiles (IRBM) that can hold deployed U.S. forces, Allies, and partners at risk. Most of North Korea's ballistic missiles have an assessed capability to carry nuclear payloads. North Korea has publicly stated its intent to continue advancing the size and complexity of its ballistic missile program regardless of future U.S. regional or homeland missile defense capabilities or postures. Additionally, since September 2021, North Korea has conducted multiple flight tests of what it claims are hypersonic missiles. In January 2022, North Korea conducted another series of tests of a variety of missile systems, including an IRBM – its first such test since 2017.

Iran. The Islamic Republic of Iran (Iran) maintains a large and growing regional missile and UAS capability, which it leverages (often through proxies) to conduct attacks in the region, ensure regime survival, deter attacks against its territory, and respond if attacked. Iran continues to maintain the largest missile force in the Middle East, augmented with a growing UAS capability. Its missiles pose a risk to U.S. forces, Allies, and partners in the Middle East and beyond, but cannot currently reach the U.S. homeland. Iran also continues to pursue a space program, which could shorten the pathway to a future long-range missile capability.

Non-State Actors. Non-state actors pose an increasing threat to U.S. regional interests, including Allies and partners, particularly in the Middle East and Africa. On today's battlefields, non-state actors are employing increasingly complex offensive sUAS, rocket, and missile capabilities, and continue to benefit from technology transfer by U.S. adversaries.

UAS. UAS are an inexpensive, accessible, flexible, expendable, and plausibly deniable way to carry out armed attacks and project outsized power over a variety of domains. Accelerating technology trends continue to transform applications of UAS, making them increasingly capable platforms in the hands of both state and non-state actors. UAS can have similar lethality to cruise

missiles and can launch from a wide array of locations, virtually undetected. UAS are generally not perceived by adversaries as having the same destabilizing geostrategic implications as larger missile forces, making them an increasingly preferred method to carry out tactical-level strikes. Adversaries also are utilizing multiple types of missile salvos – such as one-way attack UAS in combination with rockets – in an effort to defeat missile defense systems. UAS usage will likely expand and continue to pose a threat to U.S. personnel overseas, Allies and partners, and potentially to the U.S. homeland.

III. STRATEGY AND POLICY FRAMEWORK

As outlined in the NDS, integrated deterrence is a framework weaving together all instruments of national power – with diplomacy at the forefront – to work seamlessly across warfighting domains, theaters, the spectrum of conflict, and our network of alliances and partnerships. Tailored to specific circumstances, integrated deterrence applies a coordinated, multifaceted approach to reducing competitors’ perceptions of the net benefits of aggression relative to restraint. Integrated deterrence is enabled by combat-credible forces and backstopped by a safe, secure, and effective nuclear deterrent.

Missile defenses, as one component of this integrated, multilayered framework, are critical to the top priority of defending the homeland and deterring attacks against the United States. Whether protecting the homeland, deployed U.S. forces, or our Allies and partners, missile defenses deny the benefits of an attack by adversaries and limits damage should deterrence fail.

The continued evolution and progress of missiles as a principal means by which adversaries seek to project conventional or nuclear military power makes missile defense a core deterrence-by-denial component of an integrated deterrence strategy. Missile defense capabilities add resilience and undermine adversary confidence in missile use by introducing doubt and uncertainty into strike planning and execution, reducing the incentive to conduct small-scale coercive attacks, decreasing the probability of attack success, and raising the threshold for conflict. Missile defenses also reinforce U.S. diplomatic and security posture to reassure Allies and partners that the United States will not be deterred from fulfilling its global security commitments. In the event of crisis or conflict, missile defenses offer military options that help counter the expanding presence of missile threats, and may be less escalatory than employing offensive systems. Damage limitation offered by missile defenses expands decision making space for senior leaders at all levels of conflict, and preserves capability and freedom of maneuver for U.S. forces.

Within the framework of integrated deterrence, missile defense and nuclear capabilities are complementary. U.S. nuclear weapons present a credible threat of a robust response and overwhelming cost imposition, while missile defenses contribute to deterrence by denial. If deterrence fails, missile defenses can potentially mitigate some effects from an attack. Missile defense contributes directly to tailored U.S. deterrence strategies to dissuade attacks on the United States from states like North Korea, and contributes to extended deterrence for U.S. Allies and partners, and our respective forces abroad.

To address intercontinental-range, nuclear threats from Russia and the PRC, the United States will continue to rely on strategic deterrence – underwritten by safe, secure, and effective nuclear forces – to deter such threats as outlined in the 2022 Nuclear Posture Review (NPR). Ensuring the continued credibility of this deterrent will require investments in missile warning, missile tracking, and resilient NC3 to keep pace with the evolving PRC and Russian threats, and avoid the possibility of evading U.S. sensor networks in a surprise attack. For states like North Korea,

missile defenses and the U.S. nuclear arsenal are complementary and mutually reinforcing, as both capabilities contribute to deterring an attack against the United States and our Allies and partners.

Homeland Missile Defense. The Department's top priority is to defend the homeland and deter attacks against the United States. For the purposes of this review, homeland missile defense refers to the defense of the 50 states, all U.S. territories, and the District of Columbia against missile attacks. Missile defenses can raise the threshold for initiating nuclear conflict by denying an aggressor the ability to execute small-scale coercive nuclear attacks or demonstrations. Further, the presence of missile defense complicates adversary decision-making by injecting doubt and uncertainty about the likelihood of a successful offensive missile attack.

Missile defense systems such as the GMD offer a visible measure of protection for the U.S. population while reassuring Allies and partners that the United States will not be coerced by threats to the homeland from states like North Korea and potentially Iran. In the event of crisis, globally integrated domain awareness capabilities increase warning and allow for flexible decision-making to respond, as necessary and appropriate, with escalatory options such as kinetic strike. Should deterrence fail, missile defenses can help mitigate damage to the homeland and help protect the U.S. population.

The U.S. homeland ballistic missile defense architecture centers on the GMD system, consisting of interceptors emplaced in Alaska and California, a network of space-based and terrestrial-based sensors, and an integrated C2 system. Together, these U.S. homeland defense capabilities provide the means to address ballistic missile threats from states like North Korea and Iran.

Though the United States maintains the right to defend itself against attacks from any source, GMD is neither intended for, nor capable of, defeating the large and sophisticated ICBM, air-, or sea-launched ballistic missile threats from Russia and the PRC. The United States relies on strategic deterrence to address those threats.

As part of an integrated approach to deterrence, the United States recognizes the interrelationship between strategic offensive arms and strategic defensive systems. Strengthening mutual transparency and predictability with regard to these systems could help reduce the risk of conflict.

As North Korean ballistic missile threats to the U.S. homeland continue to evolve, the United States is committed to improving the capability and reliability of the GMD system. This includes development of the Next Generation Interceptor (NGI) to augment and potentially replace the existing Ground-Based Interceptors (GBI). In addition to the GMD system, the United States will leverage and improve its full spectrum of missile defeat capabilities, complemented by the credible threat of direct cost imposition through nuclear and non-nuclear means, to continue to counter North Korean missile threats to the homeland. To deter attempts by adversaries to stay under the nuclear threshold and achieve strategic results with conventional capabilities, the United States will examine active and passive defense measures to decrease the risk from any cruise missile strike against critical assets, regardless of origin.

Within the context of homeland defense, an attack on Guam or any other U.S. territory by any adversary will be considered a direct attack on the United States, and will be met with an appropriate response. Additionally, Guam is home to key regional power projection platforms and logistical nodes, and is an essential operating base for U.S. efforts to maintain a free and open Indo-Pacific region. The architecture for defense of the territory against missile attacks will therefore be commensurate with its unique status as both an unequivocal part of the United States as well as a vital regional location. Guam's defense, which will include various active and passive missile defense capabilities, will contribute to the overall integrity of integrated deterrence and bolster U.S. operational strategy in the Indo-Pacific region.

Regional Missile Defense. The United States will continue to strengthen defenses for U.S. forces, and with Allies, and partners against all regional missile threats from any source. As part of an integrated, interoperable, and multi-layered approach to deterrence, IAMD capabilities need to keep pace with expanding regional missile threats, while protecting and enabling U.S., Allied, and partner maneuver forces to conduct operations.

Regional missile threats continue to expand in capability, capacity, and complexity, challenging existing U.S., Allied, and partner regional IAMD capabilities and placing all at risk. Likely designed for employment below the U.S. nuclear threshold, adversaries are pursuing and demonstrating advanced, long-range space and missile systems capable of traversing entire Combatant Command Areas of Responsibility (AORs). Attacks from these systems could increasingly blur the line between regional and homeland defense and challenge existing IAMD architectures. In addition to missile threats, U.S. forces, Allies and partners also face the proliferation of lower-tier threats (e.g., rockets, armed UAS, etc.) as adversaries seek to take advantage of these relatively inexpensive, flexible, and expendable systems while exploiting inherent difficulties with attribution and its implications for deterrence.

Cooperation with like-minded nations is crucial. The United States will continue to seek ways to integrate and interoperate with Allies and partners as well as encouraging greater integration among Allies and partners to fill gaps against the increasing spectrum of regional threats. Additionally, as the ability to share sensor information and data is critical to regional defense, the United States will continue to streamline processes for information and data sharing, while encouraging Allies and partners to enhance their information protection posture and cyber security.

The United States will also continue to develop active and passive defenses against regional hypersonic missile threats, and pursue a persistent and resilient sensor network to characterize and track all hypersonic threats, improve attribution, and enable engagement. Acquisition strategies for new sensors, interceptors, and C2 systems must be fully aligned – with sensors as the priority. As appropriate, the United States will pursue joint research and development on hypersonic defense programs with key Allies and partners.

IAMD. Nested within our broader missile defeat approach, IAMD is the integration of capabilities and overlapping operations to defend the homeland, Allies and partners, protect the Joint and combined forces, and enable freedom of action by negating an adversary's ability to create adverse effects with air and missile capabilities.

IAMD represents an effort to move beyond platform-specific missile defense toward a broader approach melding all missile defeat capabilities – defensive, passive, offensive, kinetic, non-kinetic – into a comprehensive joint and combined construct.

Developing and fielding IAMD systems is a complex problem set. To address the rapidly evolving threat, the acquisition community must continue to exploit adaptive acquisition approaches to ensure the timely and cost-effective development, procurement, sustainment, and improvement of IAMD systems, while providing a clear investment strategy over the near-, medium-, and long-terms.

The Department must develop, design, acquire, and maintain Joint IAMD systems that are integrated, interoperable, and sufficiently mobile, flexible, and affordable to protect the homeland and dispersed joint and combined maneuver forces from the full spectrum of air and missile threats. Interoperability breeds efficiency and economy of resources. To enhance this effect in IAMD, the Department must develop and exercise innovative combinations of Service, national, and Allied and partner capabilities to meet mission needs.

One area of importance related to IAMD is the increasing challenge of counter-UAS (C-UAS). UAS are an inexpensive, flexible and plausibly deniable way for adversaries endeavoring to carry out tactical-level attacks below the threshold for major response, making them an increasingly preferred capability for state and non-state actors alike. UAS capabilities are also growing in variety, quality, and quantity. The homeland and regionally forward deployed forces require the fielding of technical and integrated C-UAS solutions with cross-DoD and interagency synchronization to ensure they can meet the range of threats and appropriately hedge against future advancements. Within the homeland, protecting the population from UAS threats is a combined interagency mission.

Future Technologies. The United States requires responsive, persistent, resilient, and cost-effective joint IAMD sensor capabilities to detect, characterize, track, and engage current and emerging advanced air and missile threats regionally, and to improve early warning, identification, tracking, discrimination, and attribution for missile threats to the homeland. Sensors must be integrated into a cohesive architecture with increasingly capable C2 in order to provide leaders with a maximized decision space for informed actions.

Sensors should be able to seamlessly transition from theater-level threats, to homeland defense, to global threats, by sharing and transmitting data with C2 as threats move in and out of the atmosphere. Because of their global nature, persistence, and greater access to denied regions, resilient space-based infrared, radar, and associated data transport systems will be critical to any

future integrated sensor network. Likewise, modern over-the-horizon radar capabilities are essential to improving warning and tracking against cruise missile and other threats to the homeland.

Advanced sensor capabilities need to facilitate different mission areas simultaneously. These include strategic and theater missile warning and tracking to: alert national leadership and cue missile defenses in the event of a missile launch; offer space domain awareness to provide indications and warning of threats; support mission assurance of the space architecture; and prompt ISR to provide persistent, and often unwarned, global information essential to the whole of government. Therefore, the ability to operate these sensors through common, joint and combined all-domain integrated and survivable C2 networks and architectures is paramount. The United States will continue to leverage industry, academia, government, and allied and partner solutions to augment existing Department of Defense capabilities and foster rapid future capability employment.

Advanced and innovative technologies and more effective battle management will be crucial to moving the United States towards a cost-effective and integrated set of offensive and defensive capabilities. To cope with rapidly increasing adversary development of missile-centric Anti-Access/Area-Denial (A2/AD) threats, the Department must seek new technologies and hedge against continuing adversary missile developments and emerging capabilities such as hypersonic weapons, multiple and maneuvering warheads, and missile defense countermeasures. Future air and missile defense capabilities must also be more mobile, flexible, survivable, and affordable, and emphasize disaggregation, dispersal, and maneuver to mitigate the threat from adversary missiles. Finally, these technologies and platforms – including those enabling NC3 – must be inherently cyber-secure, joined by resilient, redundant and hardened networks, and monitored by an agile defensive cyber force operating under a clear, unified C2 construct.

IV. STRENGTHENING INTERNATIONAL COOPERATION WITH ALLIES AND PARTNERS

America's alliances and close partnerships around the world are one of its greatest assets. Working closely with select countries in North America, the Indo-Pacific, Europe, and the Middle East to enhance our collective IAMD efforts continues to be an important priority for the United States. From a strategic standpoint, cooperation in this area strengthens common protection, enhances extended deterrence, and provides assurances essential to the cohesion of our alliances and partnerships in the face of growing regional missile threats, coercion and attacks. Operationally, IAMD-related coordination, including in the crucial areas of sensing and tracking threats, plays an important role in improving interoperability while mitigating the effectiveness of adversary A2/AD capabilities. To pursue these objectives and goals, the Department of Defense engages Allies and partners in extensive bilateral and multilateral IAMD-focused security cooperation activities that: coordinate policy development and operational planning; conduct missile defense experimentation; share information on regional and global missile threats; exchange operational IAMD visions; strengthen and align information protection efforts; support modernization and future capability development; and advance new opportunities for joint research, training, and collaborative development and production.

North America. The United States and Canada have worked together in the defense of North America for decades. Over the years, our shared homeland defense concerns have grown more acute as adversaries have developed increasingly sophisticated conventional missile capabilities that are able to target critical infrastructure in North America. Through the binational North American Aerospace Defense (NORAD) Command, the United States and Canada will continue to work together to improve early warning surveillance for potential incursions or attacks originating from any direction into North America.

Indo-Pacific. The pacing challenge posed by the PRC, as well as the growing North Korean missile threat, have magnified the importance of collaborative regional air and missile defense efforts in the Indo-Pacific region. To counter these threats, the U.S. conducts missile defense cooperation with Allies and partners throughout the region, which is strongest with Japan, Australia, and the Republic of Korea (ROK). Our cooperation with these countries strengthens collective regional deterrence and defense efforts while offering assurances critical to the unity of our alliances. Japan, Australia and the ROK practice and signal their respective defensive military capabilities through sustained investment in air and missile defense systems, as well as participation in regular exercises and training with the United States. We will continue to work closely with these Allies and partners, encouraging them to pursue ground- and space-based sensor systems for warning and tracking, and exploring joint opportunities to invest in the cooperative development of complementary IAMD technologies and capabilities such as hypersonic defenses to address advanced and increasingly diverse air and missile threats.

Europe. The United States works multilaterally within NATO and also cooperates bilaterally with specific NATO and non-NATO countries in Europe to counter air and missile threats from potential adversaries.

NATO IAMD addresses cruise and ballistic missile threats in a 360-degree defense, encompassing a mixture of lower-tier air and missile defenses (e.g., PATRIOT, National Advanced Surface-to-Air Missile System (NASAMS), Surface-to-Air Missile Platform/Terrain (SAMP/T)). NATO IAMD is an essential and continuous mission in peacetime, crisis, and times of conflict, which contributes to deterrence and defense, and the indivisible security and freedom of action of the Alliance, including NATO's capability to reinforce, and to provide a strategic response. NATO has enhanced its IAMD mission and taken steps to improve NATO IAMD forces' readiness and responsiveness in peacetime, crisis, and times of conflict – strengthening our ability to ensure that all necessary measures are implemented for the security of the Alliance.

The NATO Ballistic Missile Defense (NATO BMD) system defends European NATO territory from ballistic missiles originating from outside the Euro-Atlantic region. These efforts include a voluntary U.S. national contribution to the NATO BMD system, the European Phased Adaptive Approach (EPAA). EPAA includes an AN/TPY-2 radar based in Turkey, one Aegis Ashore site in Romania, one Aegis Ashore site under construction in Poland, plus Aegis BMD capable ships homeported in Spain.

The United States will continue to work closely with its NATO Allies and other European partners to strengthen both NATO IAMD and NATO BMD through improved readiness and preparedness, greater integration and coherence, multilateral and bilateral exercises, Foreign Military Sales, and international armaments cooperation initiatives where applicable.

Middle East. The United States has a long history of working with Israel and other partners in the Middle East to counter air and missile threats. With Israel, we have a longstanding relationship of robust cooperation on missile defense. The United States also has strong bilateral air and missile defense cooperation with many Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states, including the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Saudi Arabia, as well as collectively with GCC itself, that includes regular engagements with air and missile defense forces in support of operational activities. An ongoing, longer-term goal with the GCC and other regional states is to establish a network of air and missile defense capabilities across the Middle East to facilitate greater cooperation while bolstering defense through a layered approach. Ongoing normalization efforts between Israel and key Arab states provide additional opportunities to strengthen regional air defenses given shared missile and UAS threats.

V. CONCLUSION

The evolution of offensive air and missile threats has accelerated greatly since the United States began developing its first ballistic missile defense systems over fifty years ago. This trend represents a growing national security challenge expected to multiply in scope and complexity over the coming decade. To meet these challenges, U.S. IAMD posture must be comprehensive, layered, mobile, and ready to degrade, disrupt, and defeat adversary missiles at every opportunity and in all phases of flight, and include evolving warfighting concepts that emphasize dispersal and maneuver to ensure resilience in contested environments. To be most effective, it must also be integrated and interoperable with Allies and partners, and underpinned with increasingly robust domain awareness capabilities within a pliable missile defense network.

As a proven capability within an integrated deterrence approach, active and passive missile defenses remain essential elements in the suite of solutions against advanced and changing threats to the United States, and its Allies and partners. It is a strategic imperative for the United States to continue investments and innovation in the development of full spectrum missile defeat capabilities in order to maintain deterrence and offer protection, while hedging against uncertainty.





AIR FORCE DOCTRINE PUBLICATION 1

THE AIR FORCE



U.S. AIR FORCE

10 March 2021

CSAF PERSPECTIVE ON DOCTRINE

Our Nation needs an Air Force that can *fly, fight, and win* as part of the joint team. Commanders must articulate intent and prepare to take the initiative in dynamic, contested environments. Doctrine offers an agreed upon, operationally relevant body of best practices and principles that articulates how we fight, captures our airpower experience, and guides how we operate within a joint force. It provides a starting point, so we don't reinvent the wheel with every operation and allows us to continue to be the world's most capable Air Force.

In today's complex global security environment, victory goes to the rapid integrator of ideas. These ideas are driven by training and the distilled knowledge all Airmen bring to the fight. I'm relying on every Airman to innovate and incorporate concepts and technologies that will develop new best practices to shape future doctrine. We must prioritize and make difficult choices as we field a lethal, resilient, and rapidly adapting joint force. Leaders must push decisions to the lowest competent, capable level using doctrine as a foundation for sound choices.

Doctrine is an opportunity to educate, empower, and prepare for the future fight. It guides us, but does not bind us. I'm relying on every Airman to understand the lessons of doctrine, and then draw on them to innovate and incorporate concepts and technologies that will develop new best practices to shape future doctrine. This is how we solve difficult problems, make necessary changes, and how we accelerate change in our Air Force.

The tools in doctrine provide an excellent opportunity to build our foundation for future Airmen and forge unbeatable airpower for our Nation. Airmen should read, understand, contemplate, and prepare for the full spectrum of operations, from competition to armed conflict. Never forget General LeMay's words: "At the very heart of warfare lies doctrine."

CHARLES Q. BROWN, JR.
General, USAF
Chief of Staff, United States Air Force

PREFACE

Air Force doctrine is the extant and emerging best practices in the application of airpower. Doctrine describes the operations and activities that create convergence of effects across the [competition continuum](#). Doctrine is organized as basic, operational, and tactical level doctrine. Basic doctrine states the most fundamental and enduring beliefs describing airpower and the Airman's perspective. [Operational doctrine](#) describes more detailed organization of forces and applies the principles of basic doctrine to military actions. Tactical doctrine is contained in Air Force and Multi-Service Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures publications.

Blue underlined text denotes a hyperlink to another source document, normally Air Force or joint operational doctrine, for additional discussion.

Air Force Doctrine Publication (AFDP) 1, *The Air Force*, forms the basis of our Service culture. It defines airpower, as **the ability to project military power through control and exploitation in, from and through the air**. Airpower is employed to achieve [joint force commander](#) (JFC) objectives in support of the [National Defense Strategy](#) (NDS).

AFDP 1 addresses four fundamental topics:

- ★ **Why We Fight - War**: our foundational purpose as a Service.
- ★ **Who We Are - Airmen**: our values.
- ★ **What We Do - Airpower**: airpower fundamentals and perspective.
- ★ **How We Do It - Tenets of Airpower**: airpower employment considerations.

Ideas presented here enable Airmen to describe what the Air Force provides to [joint all-domain operations \(JADO\)](#).

Air Force Doctrine Publication 1, *The Air Force*

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Chapter 1 – WHY WE FIGHT: WAR

In our victory over Japan, airpower was unquestionably decisive. That the planned invasion of the Japanese Home islands was unnecessary is clear evidence that airpower has evolved into a force in war co-equal with land and sea power, decisive in its own right and worthy of the faith of its prophets.

**General Carl A. Spaatz, 1st Chief of Staff,
United States Air Force**



NATURE OF WAR

War is one of the means used by nation-states, sub-national groups, or supranational groups to achieve their objectives. Conducting war from the air underpins the reason for the Air Force's existence. Airpower is an instrument of national power and can be employed in warfare. There are three basic truths that the Air Force believes are fundamental to warfare:

- ✦ **War is an extension of politics by other means.** War has been described as a violent clash of interests characterized by the use of force. The Air Force conducts warfare as an extension of our national policy.
- ✦ **War is a complex and chaotic human endeavor.** Uncertainty and unpredictability, sometimes called the “fog of war”, combine to create what Clausewitz called “friction” which makes simple operations unexpectedly, and sometimes even insurmountably, difficult. The tenets of airpower help Airmen apply airpower effectively within this environment.
- ✦ **War is a clash of opposing wills.** War is a collision of two or more forces, producing a dynamic interplay of action and reaction. The will of the people and the character of their leaders are critical components of warfare.

Sound doctrine, good leadership, effective organization, moral values, and realistic training can reduce the effects of uncertainty, unpredictability, and unreliability present in war.

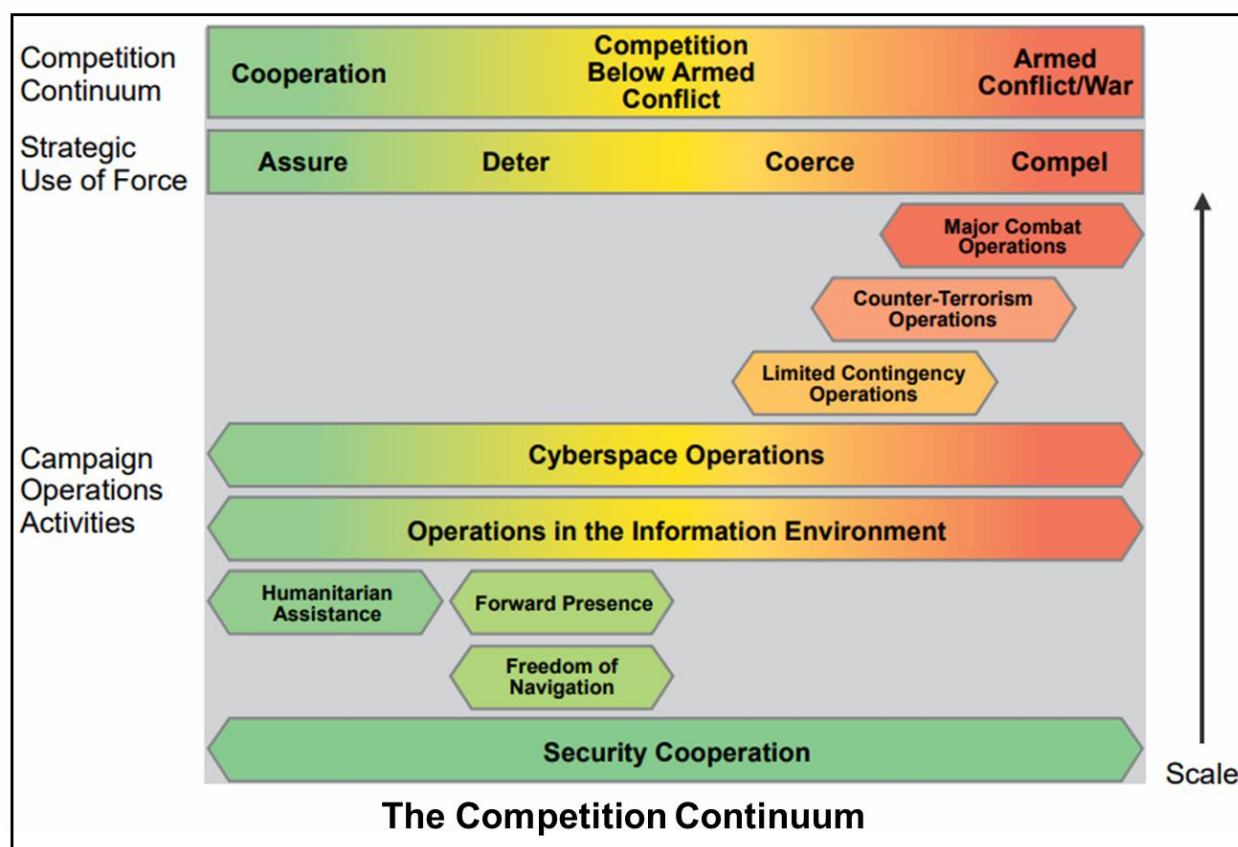
LEVELS OF WARFARE

Airpower creates effects across all three levels of warfare: strategic, operational, and tactical. The strategic level of war defines *why* and *with what* the conflict occurs. The operational level of war determines *what* courses of action, in *what* order, and for *what*

duration forces are employed in the conflict. Finally, the tactical level of war defines *how* we create the operational effects. Actions in war occur at the tactical level, but an understanding of the operational and strategic implications of those actions is key to the employment of airpower in pursuit of our national objectives.

AIRPOWER IN THE COMPETITION CONTINUUM

The Air Force employs forces in pursuit of our national objectives across the [competition continuum](#). Rather than the traditional binary classifications of peace and war, the competition continuum describes a world of enduring competition conducted through a mixture of cooperation, competition below armed conflict, and armed conflict. The Air Force creates effects across the continuum through the conduct of operations, military engagement, security cooperation, deterrence, and other activities.



For detailed discussion on the competition continuum, see [Joint Doctrine Note 1-19, Competition Continuum, 3 June 2019](#).

NATIONAL DEFENSE STRATEGY & OBJECTIVES

The [National Defense Strategy](#) sets the context in which Airmen must anticipate and plan across the competition continuum. Long-term strategic competition and the expansion of our adversary's military capabilities threaten the United States' prosperity

and security. Joint force operations are increasingly interconnected, interdependent, and challenged. Our adversary's anti-access and area denial focus and proliferation of advanced technologies create contested environments that reduce airpower's ability to conduct global operations across the competition continuum, reduce freedom of maneuver, and challenge the Air Force's ability to operate. This operating environment requires examining how forces will sense, plan, decide, and act in concert across all domains.

The National Defense Strategy delivers the framework that defines the [Department of the Air Force's functions](#). The Air Force, as part of the Department of the Air Force, provides the Nation with global vigilance, global reach, and global power. Service doctrine describes how to fulfill that responsibility.

- ★ **Global Vigilance** is the ability to gain and maintain awareness anywhere; to provide warning and to determine intent, opportunity, capability, or vulnerability; then to fuse this information with data received from other Services or agencies and use and share relevant information with the [joint force commander](#) (JFC).
- ★ **Global Reach** is the ability to project military capability responsively—with unsurpassed velocity and precision—anywhere, and provide mobility to rapidly supply, position, or reposition joint forces.
- ★ **Global Power** is the ability to hold at risk or strike any target anywhere, assert national sovereignty, safeguard joint freedom of action, and create swift, decisive, precise effects.

The Air Force prepares and employs forces within this strategic environment to achieve our national objectives. These objectives include defend the homeland, remain the preeminent military power in the world, ensure the balances of power remain in our favor, and advance an international order that is most conducive to our security and prosperity. When the Air Force mobilizes in the pursuit of these objectives, they are integrated as a part of the joint force, led by a JFC.

The Air Force organizes, trains, and equips forces to be an air component to a JFC. As part of the joint force's air component, our forces must be prepared to accomplish JFC objectives. The air component commander's administrative authorities are derived from Title 10, U.S. Code and exercised as the commander, Air Force forces (COMAFFOR). The air component commander's operational authorities are delegated from the JFC and exercised as both the COMAFFOR, over Air Force Forces, and as the functional joint force air component commander (JFACC), over joint air forces made available for tasking. Thus, the air component commander leads Air Force forces as the COMAFFOR and the JFC's joint air operations as the JFACC. This duality of authorities is expressed in the axiom: Airmen work for Airmen and the senior Airman works for the JFC.

Chapter 2 – WHO WE ARE: AIRMEN

Our Airmen are the competitive edge we have over our adversaries and the reason we are the world's greatest Air Force.

JoAnne S. Bass, 19th Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force



All Airmen support and defend the Constitution of the United States and live by Air Force core values. Historically, the term Airman is associated with uniformed members of the US Air Force (officer or enlisted; regular, Reserve, or Guard) regardless of rank, component, or specialty.¹ Today, Air Force civilians and members of the Civil Air Patrol, when conducting missions as the official Air Force Auxiliary, are incorporated within the broader meaning of the term, Airman.

Airmen espouse Air Force core values:

- ★ **Integrity first.**
- ★ **Service before self.**
- ★ **Excellence in all we do.**

Success hinges on the incorporation of these values into the character of every Airman. Air Force core values are a commitment each Airman makes when joining the Air Force. They provide a foundation for leadership, decision-making, and success, no matter their rank, the difficulty of the assigned task, or the dangers presented by the mission.

Every Airman is a leader and positively influences others to accomplish the mission. Leadership is the art and science of motivating, influencing, and directing Airmen to understand and accomplish JFC objectives.² Two fundamental elements of leadership are the mission and the Airmen who accomplish it. Effective leadership transforms human potential into effective performance in the present and prepares capable leaders for the future. Airmen step forward to lead others in accomplishing the mission while simultaneously serving as followers. You can be a commander without being a leader,

¹ This broader meaning does not, however, mean or imply that anyone other than uniformed members of the US Air Force are members of the Armed Services in other contexts. For example, in the context of punitive Air Force instructions or law of war regulations, care must be taken to ensure the rights and obligations imposed under those regulations are not uniformly applied to both Service members and civilians.

² Air Force Manual 35-15, *Air Force Leadership* (1948): "Leadership is the art of influencing people to progress with cooperation and enthusiasm toward the accomplishment of a mission." Air Force Pamphlet 35-49, *Air Force Leadership* (1985): "Leadership is the art of influencing and directing people to accomplish the mission." The definition in the text is a distillation of these earlier efforts.

or you may be a fine leader without a command, but you must be a good leader to be an effective commander.³



I'm firmly convinced that leaders are not born; they're educated, trained, and made, as in every other profession. To ensure a strong, ready Air Force, we must always remain dedicated to this process.

General Curtis E. LeMay, 5th Chief of Staff, United States Air Force

Airmen understand the attributes of airpower and should apply airpower with an appreciation for the breadth, scope, and uniqueness it brings to joint all-domain operations. Airpower is fundamentally distinct from other forms of military power. Its inherent flexibility allows it to be applied independently or in concert with other forms of military power. Airmen have a distinct point of view forged from air operations throughout history and our unique operating domains.

³ Concept dates to AFM 35-15 pg 4 (1948).

Chapter 3 – WHAT WE DO: AIRPOWER

Regardless of our respective ranks and positions, we must execute to the best of our abilities and we must do it right the first time because the application of airpower is serious business where half-hearted efforts and playing for second place are not options.

**General Charles Q. Brown, Jr.,
22d Chief of Staff, United States Air Force**



DESCRIPTION OF AIRPOWER

Airpower is defined as the ability to project military power through control and exploitation in, from and through the air. Elevation above the earth's surface provides relative advantages and creates a mindset that sees competition from a broad perspective. The air domain allows Airmen to exploit airpower's attributes of speed, range, precision, tempo, lethality, and adaptability to create effects in all domains. These attributes of airpower change the dynamics of competition in ways that enhance the effectiveness of joint forces through greater mobility and responsiveness. Airmen have an appreciation for airpower's broad potential. Airmen do not view or study airpower as an auxiliary or complementary capability subordinate to another Service. Airmen view their expertise in the application of airpower as the main reason for the Service's existence. The Air Force employs airpower to achieve JFC objectives and to complement other components of the joint force.

The attributes of airpower create effects throughout the operational environment and competition continuum. Airmen apply airpower by bypassing geographical limitations or striking with precision at critical vulnerabilities within adversary [centers of gravity](#) (COGs) at long ranges, on short notice, and for sustained periods. Airpower can control the tempo of operations in our favor and leaders employ airpower in concert with all forms of military power. Airmen integrate capabilities across multiple domains to create effects in support of JFC objectives through [joint all-domain operations](#). While all Services rely heavily on such integration, joint all-domain integration is fundamental to how Airmen employ airpower as part of the joint force.

To enable convergence of effects in all domains, Airmen support JADO by conducting operations principally in, from, and through:

- ★ The [air domain](#), defined as “the atmosphere, beginning at the Earth's surface, extending to the altitude where its effects upon operations become negligible.”
- ★ The [Information Environment](#) (IE), which includes the [cyberspace domain](#). The IE is “the aggregate of individuals, organizations, and systems that collect, process,

disseminate, or act on information,” while cyberspace consists of “the interdependent networks of information technology infrastructures and resident data, including the Internet, telecommunications networks, computer systems, and embedded processors and controllers.” The effective use of information as an instrument for affecting perceptions and behaviors and to support human and automated decision-making is an increasingly important element of [joint operations](#).

- ★ The [electromagnetic spectrum](#) (EMS) is defined as “the entire range of electromagnetic radiation.” It is critical for connecting the joint force and as a medium for creating effects, freedom of action in the EMS at the time, place, and parameters of the joint force’s choosing, is a [required precursor](#) to the successful conduct of operations in all domains.

A comprehensive understanding of operations within the warfighting domains, the EMS, and IE are critical to achieving JFC objectives.

The other Services have air arms—magnificent air arms—but their air arms must fit within their Services, each with a fundamentally different focus. So those air arms, when in competition with the primary focus of their Services, will often end up on the short end, where the priorities for resources may lead to shortfalls or decisions that are suboptimum. It is therefore important to understand that the core competencies of [airpower] are optional for the other Services. They can elect to play or not play in that arena. But if the nation is to remain capable and competent in air and space [sic], someone must pay attention across the whole spectrum; that is why there is a US Air Force.



**General Ronald R. Fogleman, 15th Chief of Staff,
United States Air Force**

FOUNDATIONS OF AIRPOWER

The evolution of airpower stems from the Airman’s original vision of combat from a distance, bypassing the force-on-force clash of surface combat. Originally manifested in long-range aircraft delivering kinetic weapons, airpower has evolved to include other global capabilities, notably non-kinetic forces and capabilities that can produce lethal or non-lethal effects. Airpower evolution accelerated as technological advancements allowed Airmen to conduct a greater percentage of operations globally versus regionally.

Airpower has successfully influenced strategic political outcomes outside of armed conflict since the Berlin Airlift of 1948. Throughout the Cold War, and continuing under various international arms control agreements, Air Force assets have observed and verified compliance, leveraging our national ability to negotiate and influence diplomacy.

The Air Force provides JFCs options across the competition continuum, which may accomplish objectives without the application of lethal force. Airpower has the ability to respond rapidly to crises anywhere in the world with flexible options that contribute to global influence and stability, and communicate US capabilities and resolve to worldwide audiences. Examples include:

- ★ The deterrent role played by the Air Force's [nuclear-armed bombers and intercontinental ballistic missiles](#) against the existential threat posed by adversaries' strategic forces.
- ★ The role [mobility](#) forces play in humanitarian assistance and disaster response worldwide.
- ★ Aviation [foreign internal defense](#) by [Air Force Special Operations](#) combat aviation advisors, to build partner capacity and help them protect their societies from subversion, insurgency, or extremism.

Airmen apply the foundations of airpower across the competition continuum; translate the benefits of airpower into meaningful objectives and desired effects; and influence the overall joint planning and execution effort. As experts in the joint application of airpower, the Airman's perspective provides the ability to force multiple dilemmas on adversaries, decreasing their decision space for potential courses of action.

AIRPOWER FROM AN AIRMAN'S PERSPECTIVE

Effective airpower application requires an Airman's unique perspective. Airmen gained this perspective through a century of air operations experience. These distilled truths should be at the forefront of an Airman's perspective when operating with joint partners.

- ★ **Control of the air is a necessary precondition for control of the surface.** The first mission of an air force is to defeat or neutralize the enemy airpower so friendly operations in all domains can proceed.
- ★ **Airpower creates effects at the strategic level of warfare.** Airpower, through global reach and global power, can hold an enemy's strategic COGs and critical vulnerabilities at risk immediately and continuously through kinetic or non-kinetic means. Airpower also has capability for nonlethal strategic influence, as in humanitarian relief and building partnership activities.
- ★ **Airpower exploits the principles of mass and maneuver simultaneously.** There are no natural boundaries to prevent air capabilities from quickly concentrating

(physically or in terms of delivered effects) at any point. Airpower can dominate the fourth dimension—time—and compress events to produce physical and psychological shock.

- ★ **Airpower applies force against many facets of enemy power.** Global power enables airpower to be brought to bear against any lawful target in an enemy system simultaneously or separately. It enables rapid expression of our national will wherever and whenever necessary.
- ★ **Airpower is not bound by geographical operating areas and creates effects throughout a theater.** Airmen view the application of force more from a functional than geographic standpoint and classify targets by generated effects rather than physical location.
- ★ **Airpower's attributes combine to make it one of the most versatile components of military power.** Its versatility allows it to be rapidly employed against strategic, operational, and tactical objectives and in support of multiple theaters simultaneously.
- ★ **The choice of appropriate capabilities is a key aspect in the realization of airpower.** Achieving the full potential of airpower requires timely, actionable intelligence and sufficient command and control (C2) capabilities to permit commanders to exploit airpower attributes.
- ★ **Airpower is a critical component of operations in the information environment.** All Air Force actions, including written or spoken words and displayed or related images, have [informational](#) aspects that communicate some message or intent, which can be leveraged to support the achievement of JFC objectives. Shaping and leveraging those messages are integral to operations and planning.
- ★ **Airpower provides more than lethal effects.** Global vigilance enables airpower to alleviate crises and provide a visible symbol of international support and power projection. Assisting partner nations, building alliances and the perception of credible airpower, supports deterrence and assurance activities that lead to greater regional stability and security.
- ★ **Airpower requires protection and sustainment to enable air operations and requires effective integration of capabilities, people, weapons, bases, logistics, and supporting infrastructure.** No single aspect of airpower should be treated in isolation since all elements are essential and interdependent. The Air Force depends on Airmen who command, operate, and sustain forces in any environment including chemical, biological, radiological, and nuclear. The Air Force's [combat support](#) capability and [agile combat employment](#) provide the ability to deploy globally, begin operations, and sustain the initiative. Counterair and force protection capabilities provide defense for forces. Airpower supports and is supported by

military power in other domains, from other components, and from other Services.

- ★ **Airpower's unique attributes necessitate it be centrally controlled by an Airman.** Experience has shown the Air Force to be the preferred choice of JFCs to exercise command and control (C2) over the joint air effort. Airmen tend to take a broad view of competition; their focus is on applying airpower to accomplish the JFC's objectives. Airmen apply airpower through the tenet of mission command.
-

Chapter 4 – HOW WE DO IT: TENETS OF AIRPOWER

Strategic air assault is wasted if it is dissipated piecemeal in sporadic attacks between which the enemy has an opportunity to readjust defenses or recuperate.

Henry H. Arnold, General of the Air Force



The application of airpower is refined by its tenets:

- ★ Mission Command.
- ★ Flexibility and versatility.
- ★ Synergistic effects.
- ★ Persistence.
- ★ Concentration.
- ★ Priority.
- ★ Balance.

These tenets reflect the unique aspects of airpower and complement [principles of joint operations](#). The Air Force recognizes unity of effort as the 13th principle to highlight its importance.⁴ **While the principles provide general guidance on the application of military force, the tenets provide specific considerations for the employment of airpower. Like principles of joint operations, airpower tenets**

Principles of Joint Operations (JP 3-0)

Unity of command – purpose is to ensure unity of effort under one responsible commander for every objective.

Objective - purpose is to direct every military operation toward a clearly defined, decisive, and achievable goal.

Offensive – purpose of action is to seize, retain, and exploit the initiative.

Mass - purpose is to concentrate the effects of combat power at the most advantageous place and time to produce decisive results.

Maneuver - purpose is to place the enemy in a position of disadvantage through the flexible application of combat power.

Economy of force - purpose is to expend minimum essential combat power on secondary efforts to allocate maximum combat power on primary efforts.

Security - purpose is to prevent the enemy from acquiring unexpected advantage.

Surprise - purpose is to strike at a time or place or in a manner for which the enemy is not prepared.

Simplicity - purpose is to increase the probability that plans and operations will be executed as intended by preparing clear, uncomplicated plans, and concise orders.

Restraint - purpose is to prevent the unnecessary use of force.

Perseverance - purpose is to ensure the commitment necessary to achieve national objectives.

Legitimacy - purpose is to maintain legal and moral authority in the conduct of operations.

Unity of Effort (additional Air Force principle) - purpose is to ensure that a wide range of agencies operating during a contingency coordinate their resources and focus on the same goal.

⁴ Joint doctrine recognizes Unity of Effort as a “common operating precept.” See Joint Publication 3-0, [Joint Operations](#).

require informed judgment in application. Airmen tailor the application of tenets to the operational environment. The competing demands of the principles and tenets (for example mass versus economy of force, concentration versus balance, and priority versus objective) require an Airman's nuanced understanding to strike the required balance. Competition is interactively complex, and no two operations are identical. Airmen apply professional judgment and experience as they employ airpower.

MISSION COMMAND

The Airman's philosophy for the C2 of airpower is [mission command](#). **Mission command** is an approach to C2 that empowers subordinate decision-making for flexibility, initiative, and responsiveness in the accomplishment of commander's intent. **Mission command** provides Airmen operating in environments of increasing uncertainty, complexity, and rapid change with the freedom of action needed to exploit emergent opportunities and succeed. Given the global reach and strategic effects of airpower, the Air Force's approach to mission command balances the need for tactical flexibility with the management of global risks. Core principles of mission command are:

- ★ **Build teams through mutual trust.** Built over time through shared experiences, mutual trust is shared confidence between commanders, subordinates, and partners that they can be relied on and are competent to carry out the mission.
- ★ **Create shared understanding.** A common understanding of the environment that includes an operation's purpose, challenges, and ways of solving them equips decision-makers at all levels with the insight and foresight needed to make effective decisions and manage associated risks.
- ★ **Provide clear commander's intent.** A clear and concise expression of the purpose of an operation, the desired outcome, and acceptable risks provides focus and helps subordinate and supporting commanders succeed, even when events do not unfold as planned. Commander's intent succinctly describes what constitutes success.
- ★ **Use mission-type orders (MTOs) when appropriate.** An MTO is an order that contributes to the accomplishment of the total mission assigned to the higher headquarters; it does not necessarily specify how tasks are to be accomplished. [Mission type orders](#) focus on the purpose of an operation rather than the details of how to accomplish it. They empower subordinates with the greatest possible freedom of action within the guidelines of commander's intent. MTOs are most applicable and effective when there is a reasonable expectation that the assumptions captured in commander's intent will remain valid during execution. MTOs should be based on higher-level headquarters priorities and intent, nested within the five-paragraph order format, which can be adapted and applied to peer and lower echelons. The planning orders (PLANORDs), operation orders

**USAF Modified
Five-Paragraph Order
Format (JP 5-0)**

1. Situation
2. Mission
3. Execution
4. Force Sustainment
5. Command, Signal and Communications

(OPORDs), [joint air operation plan](#) (JAOP), and the [air operations directive](#) (AOD), should serve as foundational documents for issuing MTOs.

- ★ **Exercise disciplined initiative.** Disciplined initiative is the proactive application of inventiveness and creativity when existing orders no longer fit the situation or when unforeseen threats or opportunities arise. It is informed by a clear understanding of mission objectives, desired effects, overall commander's intent, and broader strategic context.
- ★ **Accept prudent risk.** All military operations contain uncertain, complex, and ambiguous elements. Commanders must analyze risks in collaboration with their subordinates to balance the tension between protecting the force and accepting and managing risks that must be taken to accomplish the mission.

Airmen execute **mission command** through **centralized command**, **distributed control**, and **decentralized execution**. Centralized command is the organizing standard for the effective and efficient means of employing airpower; it enables the principle of mass while maintaining the principle of economy of force. Because of airpower's potential to directly affect the strategic and operational levels of warfare, it should be commanded by a single Airman, the air component commander. Distributed control exploits airpower's flexibility and versatility to ensure that it remains responsive, survivable, and sustainable. Decentralized execution is the delegation of authority to achieve effective span of control, foster disciplined initiative, and empower subordinates to exploit fleeting opportunities.

Centralized command gives the commander the responsibility and authority for planning, directing and coordinating a military operation using the C2 philosophy of mission command. Centralized command is best accomplished by an Airman at the functional component commander level who maintains a broad focus on the JFC's objectives to direct, integrate, prioritize, plan, coordinate and assess the use of airpower across the competition continuum. Centralized command empowers the air component commander to respond to changes in the environment and enables priority and balance while still allowing subordinate echelons to exercise initiative. Centralized command promotes effectiveness and preserves flexibility and versatility at the operational level.

Distributed control enables commanders to delegate planning and coordination activities to dispersed locations or subordinate echelons in order to achieve an effective span of control. The benefits inherent in distributed control and decentralized execution are maximized when clearly communicated commander's intent guides subordinate actions. Distributed control allows subordinate commanders to respond to changes in the operational environment and take advantage of fleeting opportunities. Contested environments may require a greater degree of distributed control than uncontested environments. Commanders should empower subordinates at the lowest capable level through MTOs, and with command by negation rather than micromanagement.

Decentralized execution is the delegation of authority to achieve effective span of control and foster disciplined initiative at the tactical level. It allows subordinates to exploit fleeting opportunities in dynamic situations. To achieve decentralized execution, the air component commander and subordinate echelons use MTOs with clearly communicated commander's intent to empower front-line decision makers (e.g., strike package leaders, air battle managers, forward air controllers) to make effective on-scene decisions during complex, rapidly unfolding operations. Decentralized execution promotes effectiveness and resilience at the tactical level.

The balance among centralization, distribution, and decentralization is situationally dependent. Some situations (e.g., high-value targets, time-sensitive targets, political sensitivities, covert/ clandestine operations, offensive cyberspace operations, nuclear employment) may require a level of centralized execution of specific operations, most notably when the JFC wants to control strategic effects and manage risks at the sacrifice of tactical efficiency. In all cases, commanders balance overall execution against the need for tactical resilience and effectiveness.

The effectiveness of airpower depends on Airmen ensuring assets are employed efficiently and effectively to achieve commander's intent. Operations in denied, degraded, and disrupted environments require flexible and adaptive Airmen who maintain unity of effort by exercising the philosophy of mission command, based on trust, shared awareness, and shared intent.

FLEXIBILITY AND VERSATILITY

Although often used interchangeably, flexibility and versatility are different.

Flexibility is the ability for airpower to seamlessly transition between mission sets while simultaneously exploit the principles of mass and maneuver. Flexibility allows airpower to shift from one JFC objective to another, quickly and decisively; to re-role assets quickly from a preplanned mission to support an unanticipated need.

Versatility is the ability to employ airpower effectively at the strategic, operational, and tactical levels of warfare and provide a wide variety of tasks in concert with other joint force elements. Airpower has the potential to achieve synergy through asymmetric and parallel operations.

SYNERGISTIC EFFECTS

The proper application of a coordinated force across multiple domains can produce effects that exceed the contributions of forces employed individually. An objective of modern warfare is the precise, coordinated application of the various elements of military power to bring disproportionate pressure on adversaries. This synergistic effect forces adversaries to comply with our national will (affecting their intent) or to cause functional defeat of their forces (affecting their capability). Airpower allows commanders

to observe adversaries which enables JFCs to counter enemy movements with unprecedented speed and agility.

PERSISTENCE

Airpower operations are often conducted continuously against a broad spectrum of objectives. Its attributes allow forces to visit and revisit multiple targets without occupying terrain or remaining in proximity to areas of operation to bring force upon targets. Persistence denies an adversary an opportunity to seize the initiative or to directly accomplish assigned tasks.

CONCENTRATION

Focusing overwhelming power at a decisive time and place is a warfighting imperative, supported by the principles of mass and economy of force. The flexibility and versatility of airpower with its attributes and persistence makes it an attractive option for concentration. The demand for airpower often exceeds the available forces and Airmen should guard against the inadvertent dilution of airpower effects resulting from this high demand.

PRIORITY

Commanders should prioritize the use of airpower. Limited resources require that airpower be applied where it can make the greatest contribution to the most critical JFC objectives. The air component commander should assess the possible use of forces, analyze their strengths and capabilities to support the overall joint campaign, and have an informed dialogue with the JFC regarding effective prioritization of airpower. The application of airpower is balanced against its ability to conduct simultaneous operations at all levels of warfare.

BALANCE

Much of the skill of the air component commander is reflected in the dynamic and correct balancing of the principles of joint operations and the tenets of airpower to bring Air Force capabilities together to produce synergistic effects. An air component commander should weigh combat opportunity, necessity, effectiveness, efficiency, and the impact on accomplishing assigned objectives against the associated risk to friendly forces. An Airman is uniquely suited to determine the proper theater-wide balance between offensive and defensive air operations, and among strategic, operational, and tactical applications to best accomplish the JFC's objectives.

CONCLUSION

At the very heart of warfare lies doctrine. It represents the central beliefs for waging war in order to achieve victory. Doctrine is of the mind, a network of faith and knowledge reinforced by experience which lays the pattern for the utilization of [Airmen], equipment, and tactics. It is the building material for strategy. It is fundamental to sound judgment.

General Curtis E. LeMay, 5th Chief of Staff, United States Air Force

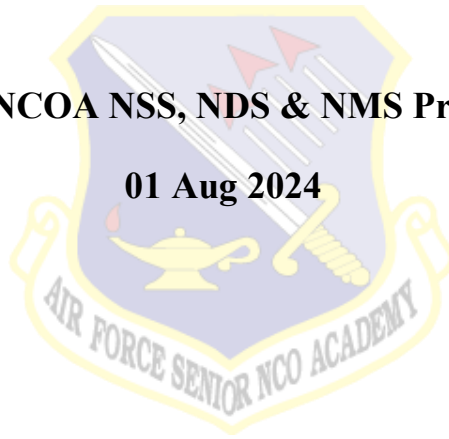


Airmen understand airpower and how to employ it to accelerate change in, from, and through the air. Airmen exemplify the core values of integrity, service and excellence, and are the foundation of the Air Force. The Air Force and Airmen exist to provide expert application of airpower to a JFC across the competition continuum in support of the *National Defense Strategy*. The doctrine presented in this publication and its subordinate operational and tactical documents underscore the reason for our existence and provide Airmen the basis for success.

Module 2 – NSS, NDS & NMS Primer

AFSNCOA NSS, NDS & NMS Primer

01 Aug 2024



National Security Council (<https://crsreports.congress.gov/product/pdf/R/R44828>)

The National Security Council (NSC) was established by statute in 1947 to create an interdepartmental body to advise the President on matters of national security. More specifically, the NSC was created to **integrate domestic, foreign, and military policies related to national security, and to facilitate cooperation among the military services and other government departments and agencies in matters of national security.** Currently, statutory members of the NSC are the President, the Vice President, the Secretary of State, the Secretary of Defense, the Secretary of Energy and the Secretary of the Treasury. Other senior officials participate in NSC deliberations at the President's request. The Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff and the Director of National Intelligence are statutory advisers.

The President clearly holds final decision-making authority in the executive branch. Over the years, however, the NSC staff has emerged as a major factor in the formulation (and at times in the implementation) of national security policy. Similarly, the head of the NSC staff, the National Security Adviser, has played an important, and occasionally highly public, role in policymaking.

The organization and influence of the NSC have varied significantly from one Administration to another, ranging from highly structured and formal systems to loose-knit teams of experts. Although it is universally acknowledged that the NSC staff should be organized to meet the particular goals and work habits of an incumbent President, the history of the NSC provides ample examples of the advantages and disadvantages of different types of policymaking structures. Congress enacted the statute creating the NSC and has altered the character of its membership over the years. Congress annually appropriates funds for its activities, but Congress does not, routinely, receive testimony on substantive matters from the National Security Adviser or from NSC staff. Proposals to require Senate confirmation of the Security Adviser have been discussed but not adopted.

"Its regular attendees are the Vice President, the Secretary of State, the Secretary of the Treasury, the Secretary of Defense, the Secretary of Energy, the Attorney General, the Secretary of Homeland Security, the Representative of the United States of America to the United Nations, the Administrator of the U.S. Agency for International Development, the Chief of Staff to the President, and the Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs. The Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff is the military advisor to the Council, and the Director of National Intelligence is the intelligence advisor. Counsel to the President and the Legal Advisor to the NSC are invited to attend every NSC meeting. The heads of other executive departments and agencies, as well as other senior officials, including the COVID-19 Response Coordinator and the Special Presidential Envoy for Climate, are invited to attend meetings of the NSC when appropriate..."

Figure 1 - National Security Council, <https://www.whitehouse.gov/nsc/>

Module 2 – NSS, NDS & NMS Primer

National Security Council Functions

(Title 50, U.S.C. §3021, <https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/USCODE-2022-title50/pdf/USCODE-2022-title50-chap44-subchapI-sec3021.pdf>)

The National Security Council today has four primary functions:

1. Advise the President with respect to the integration of domestic, foreign, and military policies relating to the national security so as to enable the Armed Forces and the other departments and agencies of the U.S. government to cooperate more effectively in matters involving the national security;
2. Assess and appraise the objectives, commitments, and risks of the United States in relation to the actual and potential military power of the United States, and make recommendations thereon to the President;
3. Make recommendations to the President concerning policies on matters of common interest to the departments and agencies of the U.S. government concerned with the national security; and
4. Coordinate, without assuming operational authority, the U.S. Government response to malign foreign influence operations and campaigns.

NSS, NDS & NMS Relationship (2022 NSS, NDS & NMS Summary)

Relationships between the National Security Strategy (NSS), National Defense Strategy (NDS), and National Military Strategy (NMS):

National Security Strategy (NSS):

- The NSS is produced by the President of the United States and outlines the nation's overarching approach to national security and foreign policy. It provides a broad framework for addressing the country's strategic interests, goals, and priorities on a global scale.
- The NSS typically integrates economic, diplomatic, military, and other instruments of national power to advance U.S. interests and protect national security.

National Defense Strategy (NDS):

- The NDS is developed by the Department of Defense (DoD) and translates the objectives and priorities of the NSS into specific defense priorities and/or capabilities.
- It focuses primarily on military capabilities, force posture, and the readiness needed to implement the broader national security strategy.
- The NDS is updated periodically to reflect changes in global threats, technological advancements, and strategic priorities.

National Military Strategy (NMS):

- The NMS is developed by the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff in consultation with combatant commanders and other military leaders.



Figure 2 - NSS, NDS & NMS, by AFSNCOA

Module 2 – NSS, NDS & NMS Primer

- It translates the NDS into more detailed military plans, operational concepts, and priorities. The NMS guides the Armed Forces in how they will organize, train, equip, and employ forces to achieve national security objectives.
- The NMS ensures alignment between military strategy and national defense priorities outlined in the NDS and the broader NSS.

Relationship:

- **ENDS:** The NSS provides **overarching strategic guidance and objectives** that inform both the NDS and the NMS.
- **WAYS:** The NDS translates the NSS into **specific defense priorities and capabilities** required to protect national interests and security.
- **MEANS:** The NMS operationalizes the NDS by detailing **how military forces will be employed** to achieve strategic objectives and support national security goals.

In essence, the NSS sets the direction, the NDS outlines defense priorities, and the NMS specifies military actions and capabilities needed to implement these strategies effectively. Together, these documents ensure a coordinated and coherent approach to U.S. national security policy and military planning.

Instruments of Power (*The Joint Team (Purple Book), JDN 1-18*)

As the global security landscape evolves, U.S. Presidents emphasize broad objectives in the National Security Strategy (NSS) to address enduring and emerging threats that endanger these interests. Subsequently, U.S. government departments and agencies build their own strategies to translate and refine the NSS into more detailed guidance for their individual organizations. To advance national interests, appropriate government officials, often with National Security Council direction, employ the instruments of national power to achieve strategic objectives. These instruments include diplomatic, informational, military, economic, financial, intelligence, and law enforcement (DIME-FIL) activities. Each instrument of national power works most effectively when it is supported by and operates harmoniously with the other elements. Accordingly, all departments and agencies work within their unique lanes to support the President's foundational strategy via what is often referred to as a whole of government approach.

- **Diplomatic.** Diplomacy is the principal instrument for engagement with other states and foreign groups to advance U.S. values, interests, and objectives and to solicit foreign support for U.S. military operations.
- **Information.** Every DoD action that is planned or executed, every word that is written or spoken, and every image that is displayed or relayed communicates the intent of DoD and, by extension, the U.S. government, to achieve strategic effects.

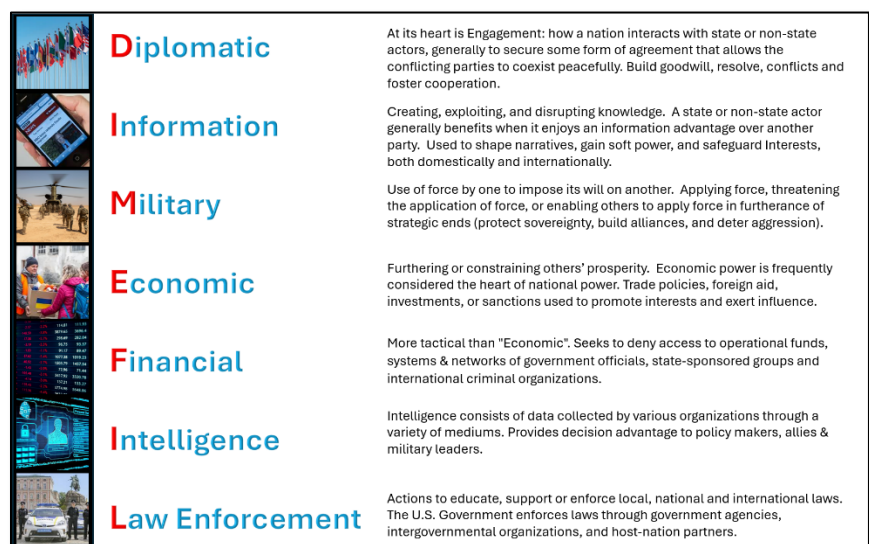


Figure 3 - Instruments of National Power (DIME-FIL) by AFSNCOA, Information sourced from: JP 1-1, The Purple Book & JDN 1-18

Module 2 – NSS, NDS & NMS Primer

- **Military.** The U.S. employs the military at home and abroad in support of its national security goals. While the ultimate purpose of the U.S. Armed Forces is to fight and win the Nation's wars, military activities also include capacity and capability building of partner militaries and humanitarian aid and assistance operations.
- **Economic.** A strong economy with free access to global markets and resources is fundamental to general welfare, the enabler of a strong national defense. The Department of Treasury works with other U.S. Government agencies, governments of other nations, and international finance institutions to encourage economic growth and prevent economic or financial crises.
- **Financial.** The U.S. Government utilizes an array of resources to deny access to specified individuals or groups, including states and non-state actors, from formal or informal financial systems, networks, or sources of funding. Some of these resources include foreign aid, trade agreements, tariffs, embargos, and economic sanctions.
- **Intelligence.** Intelligence consists of data collected by various organizations through a variety of mediums. Ambiguous data is translated into coherent information about the environment, future capabilities and intentions, and relevant actors to provide advantage to decision makers, including commanders and policy makers.
- **Law Enforcement.** The U.S. Government enforces laws through government agencies, intergovernmental organizations, and host-nation partners. Law enforcement enables the U.S. Government to secure the homeland, detain criminals, and assist mission partners with security needs.

NSS, NDS & NMS Primer – Attachment 1 Reflection Questions

Question 1: The 2022 NSS & NDS both mention “modernization” extensively. How could modernization benefit or impact your current work center?

(Optional) Use the SEE-I format for the question above

State: *Modernization could benefit or impact my work center by:*

Elaborate: *This is important because:* OR *In other words:*

Exemplify (examples): *For example:*

Illustrate: *This is similar to:* OR *This is like:*

Question 2: How could you as a SNCO communicate the goals/priorities in the NSS, NDS or NMS to the people you lead?

Question 3: How might we as leaders bring relevance to conversations related to National Security?

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 28 horizontal blue or grey lines spaced evenly apart, typical of notebook paper. The lines extend across the entire width of the page, leaving small margins at the top and bottom. There are no vertical lines, text, or other markings on the page.

NSS, NDS & NMS Primer – Attachment 3 Resources

Student Preparation:

2022 National Security Strategy (archived)

<https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/wp-content/uploads/2022/11/8-November-Combined-PDF-for-Upload.pdf>

2017 National Security Strategy

<https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/wp-content/uploads/2017/12/NSS-Final-12-18-2017-0905.pdf>

2022 National Defense Strategy

<https://media.defense.gov/2022/Oct/27/2003103845/-1/-1/1/2022-NATIONAL-DEFENSE-STRATEGY-NPR-MDR.PDF>

2022 National Military Strategy Summary (Unclassified)

<https://www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/NMS%202022%20%20Signed.pdf>

Putting the “FIL” into “DIME”: Growing Joint Understanding of the Instruments of Power

<https://ndupress.ndu.edu/Media/News/News-Article-View/Article/2106566/putting-the-fil-into-dime-growing-joint-understanding-of-the-instruments-of-pow>

National Security Council

<https://crsreports.congress.gov/product/pdf/R/R44828#:~:text=More%20specifically%2C%20the%20NSC%20was,in%20matters%20of%20national%20security>

NATIONAL SECURITY STRATEGY

OCTOBER 2022



THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON



THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

October 12, 2022

From the earliest days of my Presidency, I have argued that our world is at an inflection point. How we respond to the tremendous challenges and the unprecedented opportunities we face today will determine the direction of our world and impact the security and prosperity of the American people for generations to come. The 2022 National Security Strategy outlines how my Administration will seize this decisive decade to advance America's vital interests, position the United States to outmaneuver our geopolitical competitors, tackle shared challenges, and set our world firmly on a path toward a brighter and more hopeful tomorrow.

Around the world, the need for American leadership is as great as it has ever been. We are in the midst of a strategic competition to shape the future of the international order. Meanwhile, shared challenges that impact people everywhere demand increased global cooperation and nations stepping up to their responsibilities at a moment when this has become more difficult. In response, the United States will lead with our values, and we will work in lockstep with our allies and partners and with all those who share our interests. We will not leave our future vulnerable to the whims of those who do not share our vision for a world that is free, open, prosperous, and secure. As the world continues to navigate the lingering impacts of the pandemic and global economic uncertainty, there is no nation better positioned to lead with strength and purpose than the United States of America.

From the moment I took the oath of office, my Administration has focused on investing in America's core strategic advantages. Our economy has added 10 million jobs and unemployment rates have reached near record lows. Manufacturing jobs have come racing back to the United States. We're rebuilding our economy from the bottom up and the middle out. We've made a generational investment to upgrade our Nation's infrastructure and historic investments in innovation to sharpen our competitive edge for the future. Around the world, nations are seeing once again why it's never a good bet to bet against the United States of America.

We have also reinvigorated America's unmatched network of alliances and partnerships to uphold and strengthen the principles and institutions that have enabled so much stability, prosperity, and growth for the last 75 years. We have deepened our core alliances in Europe and the Indo-Pacific. NATO is stronger and more united than it has ever been, as we look to welcome two capable new allies in Finland and Sweden. We are doing more to connect our partners and strategies across regions through initiatives like our security partnership with Australia and the United Kingdom (AUKUS). And we are forging creative new ways to work in common cause with partners around issues of shared interest, as we are with the European Union, the Indo-Pacific Quad, the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework, and the Americas Partnership for Economic Prosperity.

These partnerships amplify our capacity to respond to shared challenges and take on the issues that directly impact billions of people's lives. If parents cannot feed their children, nothing else matters. When countries are repeatedly ravaged by climate disasters, entire futures are wiped out. And as we have all experienced, when pandemic diseases proliferate and spread, they can worsen inequities and bring the entire world to a standstill. The United States will continue to prioritize leading the international response to these transnational challenges, together with our partners, even as we face down concerted efforts to remake the ways in which nations relate to one another.

In the contest for the future of our world, my Administration is clear-eyed about the scope and seriousness of this challenge. The People's Republic of China harbors the intention and, increasingly, the capacity to reshape the international order in favor of one that tilts the global playing field to its benefit, even as the United States remains committed to managing the competition between our countries responsibly. Russia's brutal and unprovoked war on its neighbor Ukraine has shattered peace in Europe and impacted stability everywhere, and its reckless nuclear threats endanger the global non-proliferation regime. Autocrats are working overtime to undermine democracy and export a model of governance marked by repression at home and coercion abroad.

These competitors mistakenly believe democracy is weaker than autocracy because they fail to understand that a nation's power springs from its people. The United States is strong abroad because we are strong at home. Our economy is dynamic. Our people are resilient and creative. Our military remains unmatched—and we will keep it that way. And it is our democracy that enables us to continually reimagine ourselves and renew our strength.

So, the United States will continue to defend democracy around the world, even as we continue to do the work at home to better live up to the idea of America enshrined in our founding documents. We will continue to invest in boosting American competitiveness globally, drawing dreamers and strivers from around the world. We will partner with any nation that shares our basic belief that the rules-based order must remain the foundation for global peace and prosperity. And we will continue to demonstrate how America's enduring leadership to address the challenges of today and tomorrow, with vision and clarity, is the best way to deliver for the American people.

This is a 360-degree strategy grounded in the world as it is today, laying out the future we seek, and providing a roadmap for how we will achieve it. None of this will be easy or without setbacks. But I am more confident than ever that the United States has everything we need to win the competition for the 21st century. We emerge stronger from every crisis. There is nothing beyond our capacity. We can do this—for our future and for the world.

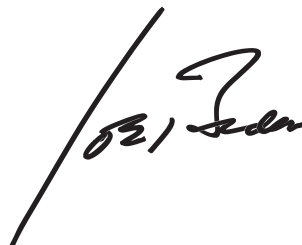
A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Joe Biden", with a long diagonal line extending from the bottom left of the signature.



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PART I: THE COMPETITION FOR WHAT COMES NEXT

“The world is changing. We’re at a significant inflection point in world history. And our country and the world—the United States of America has always been able to chart the future in times of great change. We’ve been able to constantly renew ourselves. And time and again, we’ve proven there’s not a single thing we cannot do as a nation when we do it together—and I mean that—not a single solitary thing.”

PRESIDENT JOSEPH R. BIDEN, JR

United States Coast Guard Academy's 140th Commencement Exercises

Our Enduring Vision

We are now in the early years of a decisive decade for America and the world. The terms of geopolitical competition between the major powers will be set. The window of opportunity to deal with shared threats, like climate change, will narrow drastically. The actions we take now will shape whether this period is known as an age of conflict and discord or the beginning of a more stable and prosperous future.

We face two strategic challenges. The first is that the post-Cold War era is definitively over and a competition is underway between the major powers to shape what comes next. No nation is better positioned to succeed in this competition than the United States, as long as we work in common cause with those who share our vision of a world that is free, open, secure, and prosperous. This means that the foundational principles of self-determination, territorial integrity, and political independence must be respected, international institutions must be strengthened, countries must be free to determine their own foreign policy choices, information must be allowed to flow freely, universal human rights must be upheld, and the global economy must operate on a level playing field and provide opportunity for all.

The second is that while this competition is underway, people all over the world are struggling to cope with the effects of shared challenges that cross borders—whether it is climate change, food insecurity, communicable diseases, terrorism, energy shortages, or inflation. These shared challenges are not marginal issues that are secondary to geopolitics. They are at the very core of national and international security and must be treated as such. By their very nature, these challenges require governments to cooperate if they are to solve them. But we must be clear-eyed that we will have to tackle these challenges within a competitive international environment where heightening geopolitical competition, nationalism and populism render this cooperation even more difficult and will require us to think and act in new ways.



This National Security Strategy lays out our plan to achieve a better future of a free, open, secure, and prosperous world. Our strategy is rooted in our national interests: to protect the security of the American people; to expand economic prosperity and opportunity; and to realize and defend the democratic values at the heart of the American way of life. We can do none of this alone and we do not have to. Most nations around the world define their interests in ways that are compatible with ours. We will build the strongest and broadest possible coalition of nations that seek to cooperate with each other, while competing with those powers that offer a darker vision and thwarting their efforts to threaten our interests.

Our Enduring Role

The need for a strong and purposeful American role in the world has never been greater. The world is becoming more divided and unstable. Global increases in inflation since the COVID-19 pandemic began have made life more difficult for many. The basic laws and principles governing relations among nations, including the United Nations Charter and the protection it affords all states from being invaded by their neighbors or having their borders redrawn by force, are under attack. The risk of conflict between major powers is increasing. Democracies and autocracies are engaged in a contest to show which system of governance can best deliver for their people and the world. Competition to develop and deploy foundational technologies that will transform our security and economy is intensifying. Global cooperation on shared interests has frayed, even as the need for that cooperation takes on existential importance. The scale of these changes grows with each passing year, as do the risks of inaction.

Although the international environment has become more contested, the United States remains the world's leading power. Our economy, our population, our innovation, and our military power continue to grow, often outpacing those of other large countries. Our inherent national strengths—the ingenuity, creativity, resilience, and determination of the American people; our values, diversity, and democratic institutions; our technological leadership and economic dynamism; and our diplomatic corps, development professionals, intelligence community, and our military—remain unparalleled. We are experienced in using and applying our power in combination with our allies and partners who add significantly to our own strengths. We have learned lessons from our failures as well as our successes. The idea that we should compete with major autocratic powers to shape the international order enjoys broad support that is bipartisan at home and deepening abroad.

The United States is a large and diverse democracy, encompassing people from every corner of the world, every walk of life, every system of belief. This means that our politics are not always smooth—in fact, they're often the opposite. We live at a moment of passionate political intensities and ferment that sometimes tears at the fabric of the nation. But we don't shy away from that fact or use it as an excuse to retreat from the wider world. We will continue to reckon openly and humbly with our divisions and we will work through our politics transparently and democratically. We know that for all of the effort that it takes, our democracy is worth it. It is the only way to ensure that people are truly able to live lives of dignity and freedom. This American project will never be complete—democracy is always a work in progress—but that will not stop us from defending our values and continuing to pursue our national security interests in the world. The quality of our democracy at home affects the strength and credibility of our leadership abroad—just as the character of the world we inhabit affects our ability to enjoy security, prosperity, and freedom at home.



Our rivals' challenges are profound and mounting. Their problems, at both home and abroad, are associated with the pathologies inherent in highly personalized autocracies and are less easily remedied than ours. Conversely, the United States has a tradition of transforming both domestic and foreign challenges into opportunities to spur reform and rejuvenation at home. This is one reason that prophecies of American decline have repeatedly been disproven in the past—and why it has never been a good bet to bet against America. We have always succeeded when we embrace an affirmative vision for the world that addresses shared challenges and combine it with the dynamism of our democracy and the determination to out-compete our rivals.

The Nature of the Competition Between Democracies and Autocracies

The range of nations that supports our vision of a free, open, prosperous, and secure world is broad and powerful. It includes our democratic allies in Europe and the Indo-Pacific as well as key democratic partners around the world that share much of our vision for regional and international order even if they do not agree with us on all issues, and countries that do not embrace democratic institutions but nevertheless depend upon and support a rules-based international system.

Americans will support universal human rights and stand in solidarity with those beyond our shores who seek freedom and dignity, just as we continue the critical work of ensuring equity and equal treatment under law at home. We will work to strengthen democracy around the world because democratic governance consistently outperforms authoritarianism in protecting human dignity, leads to more prosperous and resilient societies, creates stronger and more reliable economic and security partners for the United States, and encourages a peaceful world order. In particular, we will take steps to show that democracies deliver—not only by ensuring the United States and its democratic partners lead on the hardest challenges of our time, but by working with other democratic governments and the private sector to help emerging democracies show tangible benefits to their own populations. We do not, however, believe that governments and societies everywhere must be remade in America's image for us to be secure.

The most pressing strategic challenge facing our vision is from powers that layer authoritarian governance with a revisionist foreign policy. It is their behavior that poses a challenge to international peace and stability—especially waging or preparing for wars of aggression, actively undermining the democratic political processes of other countries, leveraging technology and supply chains for coercion and repression, and exporting an illiberal model of international order. Many non-democracies join the world's democracies in forswearing these behaviors. Unfortunately, Russia and the People's Republic of China (PRC) do not.

Russia and the PRC pose different challenges. Russia poses an immediate threat to the free and open international system, recklessly flouting the basic laws of the international order today, as its brutal war of aggression against Ukraine has shown. The PRC, by contrast, is the only competitor with both the intent to reshape the international order and, increasingly, the economic, diplomatic, military, and technological power to advance that objective.

Just as the United States and countries around the world benefited greatly from the post-Cold War international order, so too did the PRC and Russia. The PRC's economy and geopolitical influence grew rapidly. Russia joined the G8 and G20 and recovered economically in the 2000s. And yet, they concluded that the success of a free and open rules-based international order posed a threat to their regimes and stifled their ambitions. In their own ways, they now seek to remake



the international order to create a world conducive to their highly personalized and repressive type of autocracy.

Their pursuit of this vision is complicated by several factors. The PRC's assertive behavior has caused other countries to push back and defend their sovereignty, for their own, legitimate reasons. The PRC also retains common interests with other countries, including the United States, because of various interdependencies on climate, economics, and public health. Russia's strategic limitations have been exposed following its war of aggression against Ukraine. Moscow also has some interest in cooperation with countries that do not share its vision, especially in the global south. As a result, the United States and our allies and partners have an opportunity to shape the PRC and Russia's external environment in a way that influences their behavior even as we compete with them.

Some parts of the world are uneasy with the competition between the United States and the world's largest autocracies. We understand these concerns. We also want to avoid a world in which competition escalates into a world of rigid blocs. We do not seek conflict or a new Cold War. Rather, we are trying to support every country, regardless of size or strength, in exercising the freedom to make choices that serve their interests. This is a critical difference between our vision, which aims to preserve the autonomy and rights of less powerful states, and that of our rivals, which does not.

Cooperating to Address Shared Challenges in an Era of Competition

Heightened competition between democracies and autocracies is just one of two critical trends we face. The other is shared challenges—or what some call transnational challenges—that do not respect borders and affect all nations. These two trends affect each other—geopolitical competition changes, and often complicates, the context in which shared challenges can be addressed while those problems often exacerbate geopolitical competition, as we saw with the early phases of the COVID-19 pandemic when the PRC was unwilling to cooperate with the international community. We cannot succeed in our competition with the major powers who offer a different vision for the world if we do not have a plan to work with other nations to deal with shared challenges and we will not be able to do that unless we understand how a more competitive world affects cooperation and how the need for cooperation affects competition. We need a strategy that not only deals with both but recognizes the relationship between them and adjusts accordingly.

Of all of the shared problems we face, climate change is the greatest and potentially existential for all nations. Without immediate global action during this crucial decade, global temperatures will cross the critical warming threshold of 1.5 degrees Celsius after which scientists have warned some of the most catastrophic climate impacts will be irreversible. Climate effects and humanitarian emergencies will only worsen in the years ahead—from more powerful wildfires and hurricanes in the United States to flooding in Europe, rising sea levels in Oceania, water scarcity in the Middle East, melting ice in the Arctic, and drought and deadly temperatures in sub-Saharan Africa. Tensions will further intensify as countries compete for resources and energy advantage—increasing humanitarian need, food insecurity and health threats, as well as the potential for instability, conflict, and mass migration. The necessity to protect forests globally, electrify the transportation sector, redirect financial flows and create an energy revolution to head off the climate crisis is reinforced by the geopolitical imperative to reduce our collective dependence on states like Russia that seek to weaponize energy for coercion.



It is not just climate change. COVID-19 has shown that transnational challenges can hit with the destructive force of major wars. COVID-19 has killed millions of people and damaged the livelihoods of hundreds of millions, if not more. It exposed the insufficiency of our global health architecture and supply chains, widened inequality, and wiped out many years of development progress. It also weakened food systems, brought humanitarian need to record levels, and reinforced the need to redouble our efforts to reduce poverty and hunger and expand access to education in order to get back on track to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030. Meanwhile, communicable diseases like Ebola continue to reemerge and can only be dealt with if we act early and with other nations. The pandemic has made clear the need for international leadership and action to create stronger, more equitable, and more resilient health systems—so that we can prevent or prepare for the next pandemic or health emergency before it starts.

The global economic challenges resulting from the COVID-19 pandemic have been extended and deepened globally as uneven, recovering demand has outpaced suppliers and put strains on supply chains. Consumers and policymakers the world over have also struggled with surging energy prices and mounting food insecurity, which sharpen security challenges like migration and corruption. Moreover, autocratic governments often abuse the global economic order by weaponizing its interconnectivity and its strengths. They can arbitrarily raise costs by withholding the movement of key goods. They leverage access to their markets and control of global digital infrastructure for coercive purposes. They launder and hide their wealth, often the proceeds of foreign corrupt practices, in major economies through shell and front companies. Nefarious actors—some state sponsored, some not—are exploiting the digital economy to raise and move funds to support illicit weapons programs, terrorist attacks, fuel conflict, and to extort everyday citizens targeted by ransomware or cyber-attacks on national health systems, financial institutions and critical infrastructure. These various factors constrain our policy options, and those of our allies and partners, to advance our security interests and meet the basic needs of our citizens.

We have also experienced a global energy crisis driven by Russia’s weaponization of the oil and gas supplies it controls, exacerbated by OPEC’s management of its own supply. This circumstance underscores the need for an accelerated, just, and responsible global energy transition. That’s why — even as we continue to explore all opportunities with our allies and partners to stabilize energy markets and get supplies to those who need it — we are also focused on implementing the most significant piece of climate legislation in our nation’s history, to bring innovative energy technologies to scale as quickly as possible.

We must work with other nations to address shared challenges to improve the lives of the American people and those of people around the world. We recognize that we will undertake such effort within a competitive environment where major powers will be actively working to advance a different vision. We will use the impulses released by an era of competition to create a race to the top and make progress on shared challenges, whether it is by making investments at home or by deepening cooperation with other countries that share our vision.

Overview of Our Strategic Approach

Our goal is clear—we want a free, open, prosperous, and secure international order. We seek an order that is free in that it allows people to enjoy their basic, universal rights and freedoms. It is open in that it provides all nations that sign up to these principles an opportunity to participate in,



and have a role in shaping, the rules. It is prosperous in that it empowers all nations to continually raise the standard of living for their citizens. And secure, in that it is free from aggression, coercion and intimidation.

Achieving this goal requires three lines of effort. We will: 1) invest in the underlying sources and tools of American power and influence; 2) build the strongest possible coalition of nations to enhance our collective influence to shape the global strategic environment and to solve shared challenges; and 3) modernize and strengthen our military so it is equipped for the era of strategic competition with major powers, while maintaining the capability to disrupt the terrorist threat to the homeland. This is covered in Part II of this strategy.

We will use these capabilities to outcompete our strategic competitors, galvanize collective action on global challenges, and shape the rules of the road for technology, cybersecurity, and trade and economics. This is covered in Part III. Our approach encompasses all elements of national power—diplomacy, development cooperation, industrial strategy, economic statecraft, intelligence, and defense—and is built on several key pillars.

First, we have broken down the dividing line between foreign policy and domestic policy. We understand that if the United States is to succeed abroad, we must invest in our innovation and industrial strength, and build our resilience, at home. Likewise, to advance shared prosperity domestically and to uphold the rights of all Americans, we must proactively shape the international order in line with our interests and values. In a competitive world, where other powers engage in coercive or unfair practices to gain an edge over the United States and our allies, this takes on a special importance. We must complement the innovative power of the private sector with a modern industrial strategy that makes strategic public investments in America's workforce, and in strategic sectors and supply chains, especially critical and emerging technologies, such as microelectronics, advanced computing, biotechnologies, clean energy technologies, and advanced telecommunications.

Second, our alliances and partnerships around the world are our most important strategic asset and an indispensable element contributing to international peace and stability. A strong and unified NATO, our alliances in the Indo-Pacific, and our traditional security partnerships elsewhere do not only deter aggression; they provide a platform for mutually beneficial cooperation that strengthens the international order. We place a premium on growing the connective tissue—on technology, trade and security—between our democratic allies and partners in the Indo-Pacific and Europe because we recognize that they are mutually reinforcing and the fates of the two regions are intertwined. The United States is a global power with global interests. We are stronger in each region because of our affirmative engagement in the others. If one region descends into chaos or is dominated by a hostile power, it will detrimentally impact our interests in the others.

Third, this strategy recognizes that the PRC presents America's most consequential geopolitical challenge. Although the Indo-Pacific is where its outcomes will be most acutely shaped, there are significant global dimensions to this challenge. Russia poses an immediate and ongoing threat to the regional security order in Europe and it is a source of disruption and instability globally but it lacks the across the spectrum capabilities of the PRC. We also recognize that other smaller autocratic powers are also acting in aggressive and destabilizing ways. Most notably, Iran interferes in the internal affairs of neighbors, proliferates missiles and drones through proxies, is plotting to harm Americans, including former officials, and is advancing a nuclear program



beyond any credible civilian need. The Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) continues to expand its illicit nuclear weapons and missile programs.

Fourth, we will avoid the temptation to see the world solely through the prism of strategic competition and will continue to engage countries on their own terms. We will pursue an affirmative agenda to advance peace and security and to promote prosperity in every region. A more integrated Middle East that empowers our allies and partners will advance regional peace and prosperity, while reducing the resource demands the region makes on the United States over the long term. In Africa, the dynamism, innovation, and demographic growth of the region render it central to addressing complex global problems. The Western Hemisphere directly impacts the United States more than any other region so we will continue to revive and deepen our partnerships there to advance economic resilience, democratic stability, and citizen security.

Fifth, we recognize that globalization has delivered immense benefits for the United States and the world but an adjustment is now required to cope with dramatic global changes such as widening inequality within and among countries, the PRC's emergence as both our most consequential competitor and one of our largest trading partners, and emerging technologies that fall outside the bounds of existing rules and regulations. We have an affirmative agenda for the global economy to seize the full range of economic benefits of the 21st century while advancing the interests of American workers. Recognizing we have to move beyond traditional Free Trade Agreements, we are charting new economic arrangements to deepen economic engagement with our partners, like the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework for Prosperity (IPEF); a global minimum tax that ensures corporations pay their fair share of tax wherever they are based in the world; the Partnership for Global Investment and Infrastructure (PGII) to help low- and middle-income countries secure high-standard investment for critical infrastructure; updated rules of the road for technology, cyberspace, trade, and economics; and ensuring the transition to clean energy unlocks economic opportunities and good jobs around the world.

Finally, the community of nations that shares our vision for the future of international order is broad and includes countries on every continent. We share in common a desire for relations among nations to be governed by the UN Charter; for the universal rights of all individuals—political, civil, economic, social and cultural—to be upheld; for our environment, air, oceans, space, cyberspace and arteries of international commerce to be protected and accessible for all; and for international institutions, including the United Nations, to be modernized and strengthened to better address global challenges and deliver more tangible benefits for our citizens. The order we seek builds on what came before, but addresses serious shortcomings, new realities, and the attempts by some states to advance a much less free and open model. To preserve and increase international cooperation in an age of competition, we will pursue a dual-track approach. On one track, we will cooperate with any country, including our geopolitical rivals, that is willing to work constructively with us to address shared challenges. We will also fully engage with, and work to strengthen, international institutions. On the other track, we will deepen our cooperation with democracies and other like-minded states. From the Indo-Pacific Quad (Australia, India, Japan, United States) to the U.S.-EU Trade and Technology Council, from AUKUS (Australia, United Kingdom, United States) to I2-U2 (India, Israel, UAE, United States), we are creating a latticework of strong, resilient, and mutually reinforcing relationships that prove democracies can deliver for their people and the world.

The world is now at an inflection point. This decade will be decisive, in setting the terms of our competition with the PRC, managing the acute threat posed by Russia, and in our efforts to deal



with shared challenges, particularly climate change, pandemics, and economic turbulence. If we do not act with urgency and creativity, our window of opportunity to shape the future of international order and tackle shared challenges will close. Those actions must begin with developing the means to execute our strategy, by making renewed investments at home and abroad.



PART II: INVESTING IN OUR STRENGTH

“As we look ahead, we will lead. We will lead on all the greatest challenges of our time—from COVID to climate, peace and security, human dignity and human rights. But we will not go it alone. We will lead together with our Allies and partners and in cooperation with all those who believe, as we do, that this is within our power to meet these challenges, to build a future that lifts all of our people and preserves this planet. But none of this is inevitable; it’s a choice. And I can tell you where America stands: We will choose to build a better future.”

PRESIDENT JOSEPH R. BIDEN, JR

76th Session of the United Nations General Assembly

Investing in Our National Power to Maintain a Competitive Edge

To outcompete our rivals and tackle shared challenges, America will need to maintain and refine its competitive edge by making critical domestic investments. In an interconnected world, there is no bright line between foreign and domestic policy. The future of America’s success in the world depends upon our strength and resilience at home—and especially the strength of our middle class, which is critical to our national security as an engine of economic growth and a key source of democratic vibrance and cohesion. The reverse is also true. Our success at home requires robust and strategic engagement in the world in line with our interests and values to make life better, safer, and fairer for the American people. That is why we must make far-reaching investments in the sources of our natural strength while building our resilience.

Implementing a Modern Industrial and Innovation Strategy

The private sector and open markets have been, and continue to be, a vital source of our national strength and a key driver of innovation. However, markets alone cannot respond to the rapid pace of technological change, global supply disruptions, nonmarket abuses by the PRC and other actors, or the deepening climate crisis. Strategic public investment is the backbone of a strong industrial and innovation base in the 21st century global economy.

That is why the United States is pursuing a modern industrial and innovation strategy. We are identifying and investing in key areas where private industry, on its own, has not mobilized to protect our core economic and national security interests, including bolstering our national resilience. We are securing our critical infrastructure, advancing foundational cybersecurity for critical sectors from pipelines to water, and working with the private sector to improve security defenses in technology products. We are securing our supply chains, including through new forms of public-private collaboration, and using public procurement in critical markets to stimulate demand for innovation. In 2021, we boosted our competitiveness by enacting the largest investment in physical infrastructure in nearly a century, including historic investments in



transportation, broadband, clean water, and energy infrastructure that will increase economic growth for decades to come. We recognize the importance of the semiconductor supply chain to our competitiveness and our national security, and we are seeking to reinvigorate the semiconductor industry in the United States. The CHIPS and Science Act authorizes \$280 billion for civilian investment in research and development, especially in critical sectors such as semiconductors and advanced computing, next-generation communications, clean energy technologies, and biotechnologies. Through the National Biotechnology and Biomanufacturing Initiative, we are investing more than \$2 billion to harness the full potential of biotechnology and biomanufacturing, create jobs at home, strengthen supply chains, and reduce carbon emissions.

In 2022, we enacted the Inflation Reduction Act which will invest in domestic energy production and manufacturing, and reduce carbon emissions by roughly 40 percent by 2030. Combatting the climate crisis, bolstering our energy security, and hastening the clean energy transition is integral to our industrial strategy, economic growth, and security. We are incubating and deploying new technologies and solutions, allowing us to lead the world while creating new markets and scalable approaches. Together, these investments will keep the United States at the leading edge, increase economic capacity, and support millions of jobs and trillions of dollars in economic activity over the next decade. Across these efforts, we are mobilizing the talent, grit, and innovation of American workers, who can out-compete anyone. We are also prioritizing equity and investing in regional economic development to ensure the future is made across all of America, by all Americans.

As we do this work, we are also protecting our investments and bolstering their resilience through tracking, attributing, and defending against the activities of malicious actors in cyberspace. And we are countering intellectual property theft, forced technology transfer, and other attempts to degrade our technological advantages by enhancing investment screening, export controls, and counterintelligence resources. Just as we seek to pool technical expertise and complementary industrial capacity with our allies and partners, we are also enhancing our collective capacity to withstand attempts to degrade our shared technology advantages, including through investment screening and export controls, and the development of new regimes where gaps persist.

Investing In Our People

We are focused on strengthening the economy by building from the bottom up and the middle out. To that end, we know the most impactful public investments are the ones we make in our people. We seek to increase equitable access to affordable health care and child care; career-long training and skill building; and high-quality education and training, including science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM), especially for women and girls. These investments will boost our economic capacity by ensuring our workforce is better educated, healthier, and more productive. This stronger workforce will also build enduring advantages that bolster our strength and resilience. We are also supporting workers by promoting union organizing and collective bargaining, and improving workers' job quality.

As we create the conditions for our people to thrive, we will also continue to make America the destination of choice for talent around the world. Since the founding of our Nation, America has been strengthened and renewed by immigrants seeking opportunity and refuge on our shores—a unique strategic advantage. We will continue working with Congress and taking executive action to ensure our immigration and refugee systems are fair, orderly, humane, easier to navigate, and



consistent with our values and the law. And we will take further measures to ensure the United States remains the world's top destination for talent.

Strengthening Our Democracy

Our democracy is at the core of who we are, and America's democratic experiment has long been a source of inspiration for people around the world. Our system of government enshrines the rule of law and strives to protect the equality and dignity of all individuals. Deliberation and informed debate propel us to correct our mistakes, better meet public needs, and expand the circle of opportunity. We have not always lived up to our ideals and in recent years our democracy has been challenged from within. But we have never walked away from our ideals and in each challenging moment, citizens have stepped forward to uphold them. In times of crisis or lapses in judgment, we look to more democracy—not less—to forge the path forward. Our democracy is a work in progress—and by reckoning with and remedying our own shortcomings, we can inspire others around the world to do the same.

As Americans, we must all agree that the people's verdict, as expressed in elections, must be respected and protected. We also believe that critical reforms continue to be needed to strengthen our system of governance. This is why we have taken executive action and urged essential legislation to protect and promote voting rights and expand democratic participation, and why we are building on the work of generations of activists to advance equity and root out systemic disparities in our laws, policies, and institutions. Indeed, pluralism, inclusion, and diversity are a source of national strength in a rapidly changing world. We are reaffirming the rights to free speech, a free press, peaceful assembly, and other core civil liberties. And at the same time, we are standing up to threats to our democracy such as domestic terrorism by implementing our nation's first-ever National Strategy for Countering Domestic Terrorism and tackling head-on global forces like weaponized corruption, information manipulation operations, political interference, and attacks on the rule of law, including in elections. America will not tolerate foreign interference in our elections. We will act decisively to defend, and deter disruptions to our democratic processes, and we will respond to future interference using all appropriate tools of national power.

Using Diplomacy to Build the Strongest Possible Coalitions

The United States' unrivaled network of allies and partners protects and advances our interests around the world—and is the envy of our adversaries. Building on this network, we will assemble the strongest possible coalitions to advance and defend a world that is free, open, prosperous, and secure. These coalitions will include all nations that share these objectives. At the heart of this coalition, to ensure it is as transformative as possible, are democratic nations who share our interests and values. To make our coalitions as inclusive as possible, we will also work with any country that supports a rules-based order while we continue to press all partners to respect and advance democracy and human rights.

Transformative Cooperation

To solve the toughest problems the world faces, we need to produce dramatically greater levels of cooperation. The key to doing this is to recognize that the core of our inclusive coalition are those partners who most closely share our interests. America's treaty alliances with other



democratic countries are foundational to our strategy and central to almost everything we do to make the world more peaceful and prosperous. Our NATO and bilateral treaty allies should never doubt our will and capacity to stand with them against aggression and intimidation. As we modernize our military and work to strengthen our democracy at home, we will call on our allies to do the same, including by investing in the type of capabilities and undertaking the planning necessary to bolster deterrence in an increasingly confrontational world.

America's alliances and partnerships have played a critical role in our national security policy for eight decades, and must be deepened and modernized to do so into the future. NATO has responded with unity and strength to deter further Russian aggression in Europe, even as NATO also adopted a broad new agenda at the 2022 Madrid Summit to address systemic challenges from the PRC and other security risks from cyber to climate, as well as agreeing to Finland and Sweden's application to join the alliance. The newly established U.S.-EU Trade and Technology Council is coordinating approaches to setting the rules of the road on global technology, economic, and trade issues based on shared democratic values. Our AUKUS security partnership with Australia and the United Kingdom promotes stability in the Indo-Pacific while deepening defense and technology integration. We continue to deepen cooperation with the Five Eyes (with Australia, Canada, New Zealand, and the United Kingdom). The revitalized Quad, which brings the United States together with Japan, India, and Australia, addresses regional challenges and has demonstrated its ability to deliver for the Indo-Pacific, combating COVID-19 and climate change, to deepening cybersecurity partnerships and promoting high standards for infrastructure and health security. Our intelligence relationships with our allies are a strategic asset that will increasingly factor in to our competition with our rivals, especially in technological competition.

We will continue to prioritize seeking out new ways to integrate our alliances in the Indo-Pacific and Europe and develop new and deeper means of cooperation. We have revitalized the G7 as the steering committee of the world's advanced industrial democracies and believe it has a critical role to play in supporting our shared vision for the international order. The G7 is at its strongest when it also formally engages other countries with aligned goals, such as at the 2022 summit where Argentina, India, Indonesia, Senegal, South Africa, and Ukraine also participated. U.S. interests are best served when our European allies and partners play an active role in the Indo-Pacific, including in supporting freedom of navigation and maintaining peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait. Similarly, we want our Indo-Pacific allies to be engaged cooperatively with our European allies on shaping the order to which we all aspire, and by standing up to Russia and cooperating with the European Union and United Kingdom on our competition with the PRC. This is not a favor to the United States. Our allies recognize that a collapse of the international order in one region will ultimately endanger it in others.

These democratic allies and partners are also essential to supporting democracy and human rights around the world. Actions to bolster democracy and defend human rights are critical to the United States not only because doing so is consistent with our values, but also because respect for democracy and support for human rights promotes global peace, security, and prosperity. Global threats to accountable and transparent governance also threaten our own democratic system. We will continually update our range of tools to advance democracy and counter authoritarianism. The Presidential Initiative for Democratic Renewal qualitatively increases our ability to combat defining challenges of the 2020s, like grand corruption, digital repression, and attacks on elections and independent media. By the same token, we are responding to the ever-evolving ways in which authoritarians seek to subvert the global order, notably by weaponizing



information to undermine democracies and polarize societies. We are doing so by working with governments, civil society, independent media, and the private sector to prevent credible information from being crowded out, exposing disinformation campaigns, and strengthening the integrity of the media environment - a bedrock of thriving democracies. Together with our allies and partners, we are also holding states accountable for violations and abuses of human rights, including against ethnic and religious minorities, treating the fight against corruption as the core national security interest it is, countering transnational repression, and standing with people around the world on the front lines of the fight for dignity, equality and justice. We reaffirm our commitment to work with the international community to achieve sustainable, long-term solutions to what is the most severe refugee crisis since World War Two—including through resettlement. We raised our annual refugee admissions cap to 125,000 and are rebuilding and improving the U.S. Refugee Admissions Program to enable us to achieve that goal.

An Inclusive World

The vast majority of countries want a stable and open rules-based order that respects their sovereignty and territorial integrity, provides a fair means of economic exchange with others and promotes shared prosperity, and enables cooperation on shared challenges. They strongly disapprove of aggression, coercion, and external interference. They have no interest in overturning longstanding rules and norms to make the world safe for aggression and repression.

We will help construct and preserve coalitions that engage all of these countries and leverage their collective strengths. We recognize that some may harbor reservations about American power and our foreign policy. Others may not be democratic but nevertheless depend upon a rules-based international system. Yet what we share in common, and the prospect of a freer and more open world, makes such a broad coalition necessary and worthwhile. We will listen to and consider ideas that our partners suggest about how to do this.

Building this inclusive coalition requires reinforcing the multilateral system to uphold the founding principles of the United Nations, including respect for international law. 141 countries expressed support at the United Nations General Assembly for a resolution condemning Russia's unprovoked aggression against Ukraine. We continue to demonstrate this approach by engaging all regions across all issues, not in terms of what we are against but what we are for. This year, we partnered with ASEAN to advance clean energy infrastructure and maritime security in the region. We kickstarted the Prosper Africa Build Together Campaign to fuel economic growth across the continent and bolster trade and investment in the clean energy, health, and digital technology sectors. We are working to develop a partnership with countries on the Atlantic Ocean to establish and carry out a shared approach to advancing our joint development, economic, environmental, scientific, and maritime governance goals. We galvanized regional action to address the core challenges facing the Western Hemisphere by spearheading the Americas Partnership for Economic Prosperity to drive economic recovery and by mobilizing the region behind a bold and unprecedented approach to migration through the Los Angeles Declaration on Migration and Protection. In the Middle East, we have worked to enhance deterrence toward Iran, de-escalate regional conflicts, deepen integration among a diverse set of partners in the region, and bolster energy stability.

A prime example of an inclusive coalition is IPEF, which we launched alongside a dozen regional partners that represent 40 percent of the world's GDP. This framework's four pillars—trade and the digital economy, supply chains and resilience, clean energy and decarbonization,



and tax and anticorruption—will allow this partnership to determine the rules of the road for an economically vital region, and therefore the global economy.

The United States, alongside our G7 partners, launched PGII to meet the enormous infrastructure need in low- and middle-income countries. PGII is catalyzing public and private finance to advance climate and energy security, health and health security, digital connectivity, and gender equality—all while creating opportunities for American businesses. We secured over \$3 billion in commitments from the Gulf Cooperation Council for projects that align with PGII goals. We have taken a similar approach in a number of other development initiatives, also built around multi-stakeholder coalitions that can mobilize a wide array of resources to show in various ways that “democracy delivers,” including the longstanding President’s Emergency Plan for AIDS Relief (PEPFAR), and the Global Fund. We are rallying the world to take bold action and raise our collective ambition to reach the Global Fund’s \$18 billion target to fight HIV/AIDS, tuberculosis, and malaria over the next three years, and requested \$2 billion in our FY 2023 budget to anchor a \$6 billion three-year pledge from the United States. This investment will strengthen health systems, accelerate progress to achieve universal health coverage, and expand the global health workforce.

The United States will work pragmatically with any partner willing to join us in constructive problem-solving, reinforcing and building new ties based on shared interests. This includes not just nation states, but also civil society groups, private companies, philanthropies, and sub-national governments at home and around the world. Through proven initiatives like Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance; new platforms that meet the moment, such as COVAX, and new historic efforts to improve global health security financing, including the Financial Intermediary Fund for Pandemic Prevention, Preparedness, and Response, we will forge fit-for-purpose coalitions and public-private alliances to take on the world’s toughest challenges.

A Prosperous World

We also will build new ways to work with allies and partners on development and the expansion of human dignity because we recognize they are integral to the security and prosperity of all Americans. Infectious diseases, terrorism, violent extremism, irregular migration, and other threats often emerge or accelerate due to deeper development challenges, and once they do, they do not recognize national borders. Transnational threats, in turn, undermine development, fuel poverty and human suffering, and feed a vicious circle.

The COVID-19 pandemic has eroded development gains and illuminated persistent inequities. Protracted conflicts, growing fragility, a resurgence of authoritarianism, and ever-more frequent climate shocks threaten people’s lives and livelihoods and global stability. Russia’s war against Ukraine has only aggravated these threats, contributing to a surge in food and energy prices, exacerbating poverty and eroding food security worldwide.

We will work to confront these shared challenges and recommit to advancing the Sustainable Development Goals by pursuing more inclusive development partnerships, especially by putting local partners in the driver’s seat, and by deploying a more expansive set of tools, including catalytic financing and integrated humanitarian, development, and peacebuilding actions. We are already applying this approach to helping vulnerable nations build resilience to the devastating impacts of the climate crisis through the President’s Emergency Plan for Adaptation and



Resilience (PREPARE) and in support of democratic renewal through the Partnerships for Democratic Development (PDD). We are also implementing this development approach to advance global health security and systems and to take principled humanitarian action while addressing the root causes of fragility, conflict, and crisis, including through the Global Fragility Act. We will use our humanitarian, development, and peacebuilding tools more cohesively. And we will invest in women and girls, be responsive to the voices and focus on the needs of the most marginalized, including the LGBTQI+ community; and advance inclusive development broadly.

Across our development work, we will continue to employ best practices that distinguish the United States and our partners from our competitors: transparency and accountability; high environmental, social, labor, and inclusion standards; respect for human rights; and local partnerships supported by foreign assistance and sound, sustainable financing. The international financial institutions, including the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund, are also a force multiplier for our values and interests. Stronger, more stable growth abroad means a stronger economy here at home. As other economies prosper, demand for U.S. exports of goods and services increases, creating U.S. jobs. We will work to enhance the responsiveness of these institutions to U.S. priorities, including how to better support developing countries as they weather the pandemic and now the spillovers of the Russian war on Ukraine.

Modernizing and Strengthening Our Military

The American military is the strongest fighting force the world has ever known. America will not hesitate to use force when necessary to defend our national interests. But we will do so as the last resort and only when the objectives and mission are clear and achievable, consistent with our values and laws, alongside non-military tools, and the mission is undertaken with the informed consent of the American people.

Our approach to national defense is described in detail in the 2022 National Defense Strategy. Our starting premise is that a powerful U.S. military helps advance and safeguard vital U.S. national interests by backstopping diplomacy, confronting aggression, deterring conflict, projecting strength, and protecting the American people and their economic interests. Amid intensifying competition, the military's role is to maintain and gain warfighting advantages while limiting those of our competitors. The military will act urgently to sustain and strengthen deterrence, with the PRC as its pacing challenge. We will make disciplined choices regarding our national defense and focus our attention on the military's primary responsibilities: to defend the homeland, and deter attacks and aggression against the United States, our allies and partners, while being prepared to fight and win the Nation's wars should diplomacy and deterrence fail. To do so, we will combine our strengths to achieve maximum effect in deterring acts of aggression—an approach we refer to as integrated deterrence (see text box on page 22). We will operate our military using a campaigning mindset—sequencing logically linked military activities to advance strategy-aligned priorities. And, we will build a resilient force and defense ecosystem to ensure we can perform these functions for decades to come. We ended America's longest war in Afghanistan, and with it an era of major military operations to remake other societies, even as we have maintained the capacity to address terrorist threats to the American people as they emerge.



A combat-credible military is the foundation of deterrence and America's ability to prevail in conflict. We will modernize the joint force to be lethal, resilient, sustainable, survivable, agile, and responsive, prioritizing operational concepts and updated warfighting capabilities. The war in Ukraine highlights the criticality of a vibrant Defense Industrial Base for the United States and its allies and partners. It must not only be capable of rapidly manufacturing proven capabilities needed to defend against adversary aggression, but also empowered to innovate and creatively design solutions as battlefield conditions evolve. As emerging technologies transform warfare and pose novel threats to the United States and our allies and partners, we are investing in a range of advanced technologies including applications in the cyber and space domains, missile defeat capabilities, trusted artificial intelligence, and quantum systems, while deploying new capabilities to the battlefield in a timely manner. Incorporating allies and partners at every stage of defense planning is crucial to meaningful collaboration. We also seek to remove barriers to deeper collaboration with allies and partners, to include issues related to joint capability development and production to safeguard our shared military-technological edge.

Nuclear deterrence remains a top priority for the Nation and foundational to integrated deterrence. A safe, secure, and effective nuclear force undergirds our defense priorities by deterring strategic attacks, assuring allies and partners, and allowing us to achieve our objectives if deterrence fails. Our competitors and potential adversaries are investing heavily in new nuclear weapons. By the 2030s, the United States for the first time will need to deter two major nuclear powers, each of whom will field modern and diverse global and regional nuclear forces. To ensure our nuclear deterrent remains responsive to the threats we face, we are modernizing the nuclear Triad, nuclear command, control, and communications, and our nuclear weapons infrastructure, as well as strengthening our extended deterrence commitments to our Allies. We remain equally committed to reducing the risks of nuclear war. This includes taking further steps to reduce the role of nuclear weapons in our strategy and pursuing realistic goals for mutual, verifiable arms control, which contribute to our deterrence strategy and strengthen the global non-proliferation regime.

The most important investments are those made in the extraordinary All-Volunteer Force of the Army, Marine Corps, Navy, Air Force, Space Force, Coast Guard—together with our Department of Defense civilian workforce. Our service members are the backbone of America's national defense and we are committed to their wellbeing and their families while in service and beyond. We will maintain our foundational principle of civilian control of the military, recognizing that healthy civil-military relations rooted in mutual respect are essential to military effectiveness. We will strengthen the effectiveness of the force by promoting diversity and inclusion; intensifying our suicide prevention efforts; eliminating the scourges of sexual assault, harassment, and other forms of violence, abuse, and discrimination; and rooting out violent extremism. We will also uphold our Nation's sacred obligation to care for veterans and their families when our troops return home.



Integrated Deterrence

The United States has a vital interest in deterring aggression by the PRC, Russia, and other states. More capable competitors and new strategies of threatening behavior below and above the traditional threshold of conflict mean we cannot afford to rely solely on conventional forces and nuclear deterrence. Our defense strategy must sustain and strengthen deterrence, with the PRC as our pacing challenge.

Our National Defense Strategy relies on integrated deterrence: the seamless combination of capabilities to convince potential adversaries that the costs of their hostile activities outweigh their benefits. It entails:

- **Integration across domains**, recognizing that our competitors' strategies operate across military (land, air, maritime, cyber, and space) and non-military (economic, technological, and information) domains—and we must too.
- **Integration across regions**, understanding that our competitors combine expansive ambitions with growing capabilities to threaten U.S. interests in key regions and in the homeland.
- **Integration across the spectrum of conflict** to prevent competitors from altering the status quo in ways that harm our vital interests while hovering below the threshold of armed conflict.
- **Integration across the U.S. Government** to leverage the full array of American advantages, from diplomacy, intelligence, and economic tools to security assistance and force posture decisions.
- **Integration with allies and partners** through investments in interoperability and joint capability development, cooperative posture planning, and coordinated diplomatic and economic approaches.

Integrated deterrence requires us to more effectively coordinate, network, and innovate so that any competitor thinking about pressing for advantage in one domain understands that we can respond in many others as well. This augments the traditional backstop of combat-credible conventional and strategic capabilities, allowing us to better shape adversary perceptions of risks and costs of action against core U.S. interests, at any time and across any domain.



PART III: OUR GLOBAL PRIORITIES

“[T]he challenges we face today are great indeed, but our capacity is greater. Our commitment must be greater still. So let’s stand together to again declare the unmistakable resolve that nations of the world are united still, that we stand for the values of the U.N. Charter, that we still believe by working together we can bend the arc of history toward a freer and more just world for all our children, although none of us have fully achieved it. We’re not passive witnesses to history; we are the authors of history. We can do this—we have to do it—for ourselves and for our future, for humankind.”

PRESIDENT JOSEPH R. BIDEN, JR

77th Session of the United Nations General Assembly

The steps outlined in the previous section—building our strength at home to maintain a competitive edge; using our diplomatic power to build the strongest possible coalition to support a world that is open, free, prosperous, and secure; and modernizing and strengthening our military will position the United States to strengthen an international order that has delivered broad benefits for the American people for decades and to outcompete our rivals who offer a different vision. The breadth and complexity of our global interests mean that we need to use that power strategically. Three interlinked lines of effort are of paramount importance—dealing with the challenges to the international order posed by our strategic competitors, addressing shared global challenges, and shaping the rules of the road for technology, cybersecurity, and trade and economics.

Out-Competing China and Constraining Russia

The PRC and Russia are increasingly aligned with each other but the challenges they pose are, in important ways, distinct. We will prioritize maintaining an enduring competitive edge over the PRC while constraining a still profoundly dangerous Russia.

China

The PRC is the only competitor with both the intent to reshape the international order and, increasingly, the economic, diplomatic, military, and technological power to do it. Beijing has ambitions to create an enhanced sphere of influence in the Indo-Pacific and to become the world’s leading power. It is using its technological capacity and increasing influence over international institutions to create more permissive conditions for its own authoritarian model, and to mold global technology use and norms to privilege its interests and values. Beijing frequently uses its economic power to coerce countries. It benefits from the openness of the international economy while limiting access to its domestic market, and it seeks to make the world more dependent on the PRC while reducing its own dependence on the world. The PRC is



also investing in a military that is rapidly modernizing, increasingly capable in the Indo-Pacific, and growing in strength and reach globally – all while seeking to erode U.S. alliances in the region and around the world.

At the same time, the PRC is also central to the global economy and has a significant impact on shared challenges, particularly climate change and global public health. It is possible for the United States and the PRC to coexist peacefully, and share in and contribute to human progress together.

Our strategy toward the PRC is threefold: 1) to invest in the foundations of our strength at home – our competitiveness, our innovation, our resilience, our democracy, 2) to align our efforts with our network of allies and partners, acting with common purpose and in common cause, and 3) compete responsibly with the PRC to defend our interests and build our vision for the future. The first two elements— invest and align— are described in the previous section and are essential to out-competing the PRC in the technological, economic, political, military, intelligence, and global governance domains.

Competition with the PRC is most pronounced in the Indo-Pacific, but it is also increasingly global. Around the world, the contest to write the rules of the road and shape the relationships that govern global affairs is playing out in every region and across economics, technology, diplomacy, development, security, and global governance.

In the competition with the PRC, as in other arenas, it is clear that the next ten years will be the decisive decade. We stand now at the inflection point, where the choices we make and the priorities we pursue today will set us on a course that determines our competitive position long into the future.

Many of our allies and partners, especially in the Indo-Pacific, stand on the frontlines of the PRC's coercion and are rightly determined to seek to ensure their own autonomy, security, and prosperity. We will support their ability to make sovereign decisions in line with their interests and values, free from external pressure, and work to provide high-standard and scaled investment, development assistance, and markets. Our strategy will require us to partner with, support, and meet the economic and development needs of partner countries, not for the sake of competition, but for their own sake. We will act in common purpose to address a range of issues – from untrusted digital infrastructure and forced labor in supply chains and illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing. We will hold Beijing accountable for abuses – genocide and crimes against humanity in Xinjiang, human rights violations in Tibet, and the dismantling of Hong Kong's autonomy and freedoms – even as it seeks to pressure countries and communities into silence. We will continue prioritizing investments in a combat credible military that deters aggression against our allies and partners in the region, and can help those allies and partners defend themselves.

We have an abiding interest in maintaining peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait, which is critical to regional and global security and prosperity and a matter of international concern and attention. We oppose any unilateral changes to the status quo from either side, and do not support Taiwan independence. We remain committed to our one China policy, which is guided by the Taiwan Relations Act, the Three Joint Communiques, and the Six Assurances. And we will uphold our commitments under the Taiwan Relations Act to support Taiwan's self-defense and to maintain our capacity to resist any resort to force or coercion against Taiwan.



Though allies and partners may have distinct perspectives on the PRC, our diplomatic approach, and the PRC's own behavior, has produced significant and growing opportunities to align approaches and deliver results. Across Europe, Asia, the Middle East, Africa, and Latin America, countries are clear-eyed about the nature of the challenges that the PRC poses. Governments want sustainable public finances. Workers want to be treated with dignity and respect. Innovators want to be rewarded for their ingenuity, risk-taking, and persistent efforts. And enterprising businesses want open and free waters through which their products can be traded.

While we compete vigorously, we will manage the competition responsibly. We will seek greater strategic stability through measures that reduce the risk of unintended military escalation, enhance crisis communications, build mutual transparency, and ultimately engage Beijing on more formal arms control efforts. We will always be willing to work with the PRC where our interests align. We can't let the disagreements that divide us stop us from moving forward on the priorities that demand that we work together, for the good of our people and for the good of the world. That includes on climate, pandemic threats, nonproliferation, countering illicit and illegal narcotics, the global food crisis, and macroeconomic issues. In short, we'll engage constructively with the PRC wherever we can, not as a favor to us or anyone else, and never in exchange for walking away from our principles, but because working together to solve great challenges is what the world expects from great powers, and because it's directly in our interest. No country should withhold progress on existential transnational issues like the climate crisis because of bilateral differences.

While we have profound differences with the Chinese Communist Party and the Chinese Government, those differences are between governments and systems – not between our people. Ties of family and friendship continue to connect the American and the Chinese people. We deeply respect their achievements, their history, and their culture. Racism and hate have no place in a nation built by generations of immigrants to fulfill the promise of opportunity for all. And we intend to work together to solve issues that matter most to the people of both countries.

Russia

Over the past decade, the Russian government has chosen to pursue an imperialist foreign policy with the goal of overturning key elements of the international order. This culminated in a full-scale invasion of Ukraine in an attempt to topple its government and bring it under Russian control. But, this attack did not come out of the blue; it was preceded by Russia's 2014 invasion of Ukraine, its military intervention in Syria, its longstanding efforts to destabilize its neighbors using intelligence and cyber capabilities, and its blatant attempts to undermine internal democratic processes in countries across Europe, Central Asia, and around the world. Russia has also interfered brazenly in U.S. politics and worked to sow divisions among the American people. And Russia's destabilizing actions are not limited to the international arena. Domestically, the Russian government under President Putin violates its citizens' human rights, suppresses its opposition, and shuts independent media. Russia now has a stagnant political system that is unresponsive to the needs of its people.

The United States, under successive administrations, made considerable efforts at multiple points to reach out to Russia to limit our rivalry and identify pragmatic areas of cooperation. President Putin spurned these efforts and it is now clear he will not change. Russia now poses an immediate and persistent threat to international peace and stability. This is not about a struggle between the West and Russia. It is about the fundamental principles of the UN Charter, which



Russia is a party to, particularly respect for sovereignty, territorial integrity, and the prohibition against acquiring territory through war.

We are leading a united, principled, and resolute response to Russia's invasion and we have rallied the world to support the Ukrainian people as they bravely defend their country. Working with a broad and durable international coalition, we have marshalled near-record levels of security assistance to ensure Ukraine has the means to defend itself. We have provided humanitarian, economic and development assistance to strengthen Ukraine's sovereign, elected government and help the millions of refugees who have been forced to flee their homes. We will continue to stand with the people of Ukraine as they fight back against Russia's naked aggression. And we will rally the world to hold Russia accountable for the atrocities they have unleashed across Ukraine.

Alongside our allies and partners, America is helping to make Russia's war on Ukraine a strategic failure. Across Europe, NATO and the European Union are united in standing up to Russia and defending shared values. We are constraining Russia's strategic economic sectors, including defense and aerospace, and we will continue to counter Russia's attempts to weaken and destabilize sovereign nations and undermine multilateral institutions. Together with our NATO Allies, we are strengthening our defense and deterrence, particularly on the eastern flank of the Alliance. Welcoming Finland and Sweden to NATO will further improve our security and capabilities. And we are renewing our focus on bolstering our collective resilience against shared threats from Russia, including asymmetric threats. More broadly, Putin's war has profoundly diminished Russia's status vis-a-vis China and other Asian powers such as India and Japan. Moscow's soft power and diplomatic influence have waned, while its efforts to weaponize energy have backfired. The historic global response to Russia's war against Ukraine sends a resounding message that countries cannot enjoy the benefits of global integration while trampling on the core tenets of the UN Charter.

While some aspects of our approach will depend on the trajectory of the war in Ukraine, a number of elements are already clear. First, the United States will continue to support Ukraine in its fight for its freedom, we will help Ukraine recover economically, and we will encourage its regional integration with the European Union. Second, the United States will defend every inch of NATO territory and will continue to build and deepen a coalition with allies and partners to prevent Russia from causing further harm to European security, democracy, and institutions. Third, the United States will deter and, as necessary, respond to Russian actions that threaten core U.S. interests, including Russian attacks on our infrastructure and our democracy. Fourth, Russia's conventional military will have been weakened, which will likely increase Moscow's reliance on nuclear weapons in its military planning. The United States will not allow Russia, or any power, to achieve its objectives through using, or threatening to use, nuclear weapons. America retains an interest in preserving strategic stability and developing a more expansive, transparent, and verifiable arms control infrastructure to succeed New START and in rebuilding European security arrangements which, due to Russia's actions, have fallen in to disrepair. Finally, the United States will sustain and develop pragmatic modes of interaction to handle issues on which dealing with Russia can be mutually beneficial.

The United States respects the Russian people and their contributions to science, culture and constructive bilateral relations over many decades. Notwithstanding the Russian government's strategic miscalculation in attacking Ukraine, it is the Russian people who will determine Russia's future as a major power capable of once more playing a constructive role in



international affairs. The United States will welcome such a future, and in the meantime, will continue to push back against the aggression perpetrated by the Russian government.

Cooperating on Shared Challenges

The United States must maintain and increase international cooperation on shared challenges even in an age of greater inter-state competition. In an ideal world, governments would compete responsibly where their interests diverge and cooperate where they converge—but things have not always worked out this way in practice. The United States, for example, has made clear that we will not support the linkage of issues in a way that conditions cooperation on shared challenges, but some in Beijing have been equally clear that the PRC should expect concessions on unrelated issues as a prerequisite to cooperation on shared challenges, such as climate change. We have also seen how the PRC chose not to cooperate adequately with the World Health Organization and the international community on the global response to COVID-19, including on the investigation into its origins. It also continues to endanger the world with inadequate action on climate change domestically, particularly regarding massive coal power use and build up.

Our strategy to tackle the shared challenges that require global cooperation involves two simultaneous tracks: on one track, we will fully engage all countries and institutions to cooperate on shared threats, including by pressing for reforms where institutional responses have proven inadequate. At the same time, we will also redouble our efforts to deepen our cooperation with like-minded partners. Across both tracks, we will also seek to harness the positive effects of competition, promoting a race to the top, to increase international efforts on these challenges.

Climate and Energy Security

The climate crisis is the existential challenge of our time. A warming planet endangers Americans and people around the world—risking food and water supplies, public health, and infrastructure and our national security. Without immediate global action to reduce emissions, scientists tell us we will soon exceed 1.5 degrees of warming, locking in further extreme heat and weather, rising sea levels, and catastrophic biodiversity loss.

Global action begins at home, where we are making unprecedented generational investments in the clean energy transition through the IRA, simultaneously creating millions of good paying jobs and strengthening American industries. We are enhancing Federal, state, and local preparedness against and resilience to growing extreme weather threats, and we're integrating climate change into our national security planning and policies. This domestic work is key to our international credibility, and to getting other countries to up their own ambition and action.

The United States is galvanizing the world and incentivizing further action. Building on the Leaders' Summit on Climate, Major Economies Forum, and Paris Agreement process, we are helping countries meet and strengthen their nationally determined contributions, reduce emissions, tackle methane and other super pollutants, promote carbon dioxide removals, adapt to the most severe impacts of climate change, and end deforestation over the next decade. We're also using our economic heft to drive decarbonization. Our steel agreement with the EU, the first-ever arrangement on steel and aluminum to address both carbon intensity and global overcapacity, is a model for future climate-focused trade mechanisms. And we are ending public



finance for unabated coal power, and mobilizing financing to speed investments in adaptation and the energy transition.

Events like Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine have made clear the urgent need to accelerate the transition away from fossil fuels. We know that long-term energy security depends on clean energy. Recognizing this transition will not happen overnight, we will work with partners and allies to ensure energy security and affordability, secure access to critical mineral supply chains, and create a just transition for impacted workers. Through collaborative work in the International Energy Agency, the U.S.-EU Task Force on European Energy Security, the Clean Energy Ministerial and Mission Innovation, Power Africa, the Eastern Mediterranean Gas Forum, the Partnership for Transatlantic Energy and Climate Cooperation, and other critical fora, we will drive concrete action to achieve an energy secure future.

Many low-income and lower-middle income countries need assistance, especially for mitigation and adaptation efforts. That is why we are aiming to provide over \$11 billion in annual climate funding, and are pressing partners to increase their own contributions. We are embedding climate change into the investment strategies of our development finance institutions, including through PGII, and working with international organizations like the World Bank and regional development banks to do the same.

Pandemics and Biodefense

COVID-19 has killed nearly 6.5 million people around the world, including more than 1 million Americans, but the next pandemic could be much worse—as contagious but more lethal. We have a narrow window of opportunity to take steps nationally and internationally to prepare for the next pandemic and to strengthen our biodefense.

In the United States, that requires preparing for catastrophic biological risks, including by improving early warning and disease surveillance, data sharing and forecasting; speeding development, domestic manufacturing, and delivery of medical countermeasures; advancing safe biotechnology development and manufacturing; and overcoming inequities in care quality and access.

Internationally, it requires action on multiple fronts. The United States has recommitted to COVAX, to which we are the largest donor, the World Health Organization, and a cooperative approach toward global health security. We recognize that no one is safe until everyone is safe, which is why we have donated more vaccines internationally than any other country, with no political strings attached. We are working with allies and partners, including philanthropic organizations and the private sector, to boost sustainable vaccine manufacturing in Africa and South Asia.

We recognize that we must engage with all countries on global public health, including those with whom we disagree, because pandemics know no borders. We also acknowledge that some of our international institutions have fallen short in the past and need to be reformed. While we believe that many of these reforms can be agreed upon and implemented over the lifetime of this administration, we also recognize that ultimately some may fall short because other countries do not share our belief in greater transparency and sharing critical data with the international community. Therefore, as we engage globally and through international institutions, we will also deepen our cooperation with like-minded states to push for reforms on pandemic preparedness and if necessary to work more closely together to set higher standards that others can emulate.



We will also tackle the increasing risk posed by deliberate and accidental biological risks, including through our ability to rapidly detect, identify, and attribute agents, and to develop medical countermeasures. Working with partners and allies, we will strengthen the Biological Weapons Convention to deter state biological warfare capabilities; prevent terrorist acquisition or use of biological weapons; and reinforce international norms against biological weapons' development and use. We will also reduce biological risks associated with advancements in technologies and dual-use research and development, including by establishing and strengthening international biosafety and biosecurity norms and practices.

Food Insecurity

Global food systems today are under threat from a variety of sources, including Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the economic impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic, climate events, and protracted conflicts—all of which threaten to push 75-95 million more people into extreme poverty in 2022 than were expected before the pandemic. The food insecurity crisis has become particularly dangerous because of Russia's aggression against Ukraine, which took much of Ukraine's grain off the market and exacerbated an already worsening global food insecurity problem. To address the needs of the hundreds of millions of people now suffering as a result, the United States is providing more humanitarian assistance than ever before. We remain the largest contributor to the World Food Programme and the leading donor in nearly every country experiencing a humanitarian food crisis.

Over the longer term, we are rallying the world to find ways to deal with the broad set of challenges for the world's food supply achieving sustained global food security demands constant vigilance and action by all governments, in partnership with multilateral institutions and non-governmental organizations. Working together with our partners, we launched the Roadmap for Global Food Security: A Call to Action which urges the more than 100 signatory states to take several actions including keeping food and agricultural markets open, increasing fertilizer production, and investing in climate-resilient agriculture. The United States is also implementing the Global Food Security Strategy, which focuses on reducing global poverty, hunger, and malnutrition by supporting inclusive and sustainable agriculture-led economic growth; strengthening resilience among people and food systems; and supporting well-nourished healthy populations, especially among women and children. This requires working across entire food systems to consider every step from cultivation to consumption, and to integrate these efforts within larger climate, health, conflict mitigation, and peacebuilding work. To ensure these efforts are durable and sustainable requires centering equity and inclusion, and partnering both with local partners and international bodies. Going forward, the United States must continue to address both acute needs and work collaboratively to build sustained food security for the long term.

Arms Control and Non-Proliferation

Nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons proliferation is a vitally important and enduring global challenge, requiring sustained collaboration to prevent the spread of weapons of mass destruction and fissile material, their means of delivery, and enabling technologies. The United States will work with allies and partners, civil society, and international organizations to strengthen arms control and nonproliferation mechanisms, especially during times of conflict when escalation risks are greater. We will address the existential threat posed by the proliferation



of nuclear weapons through renewed arms control and nonproliferation leadership. We will continue to seek pragmatic engagement with competitors about strategic stability and risk reduction. Our approach will emphasize measures that head off costly arms races, reduce the likelihood of miscalculation, and complement U.S. and allied deterrence strategies.

We will lead bilateral and multilateral arms control efforts and strengthen existing regimes, frameworks, and institutions, including the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty Organization, International Atomic Energy Agency, and other United Nations bodies, to extend the more than seven-decade record of nuclear non-use. We will support the Organization for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons and the Biological Weapons Convention and reinforce norms against the possession and use of chemical and biological weapons. We will continue to lead the world in coordinated efforts to lock down nuclear and radiological materials and prevent terrorist acquisition. And we will ensure multilateral export control regimes are equipped to address destabilizing emerging technologies and to align export policies in likeminded states toward countries of concern.

Terrorism

Today's terrorist threat is more ideologically diverse and geographically diffuse than that of two decades ago. Al-Qa'ida, ISIS, and associated forces have expanded from Afghanistan and the Middle East into Africa and Southeast Asia.

Syria, Yemen, and Somalia remain terrorist sanctuaries; local affiliates have become entrenched actors in regional conflicts. Many of these groups still intend to carry out or inspire others to attack the United States and our interests abroad, even as years of sustained counterterrorism and law enforcement pressure have constrained their capabilities, and enhanced security measures and information sharing have improved our defenses. Meanwhile, we face sharply increased threats from a range of domestic violent extremists here in the United States.

America remains steadfast in protecting our country and our people and facilities overseas from the full spectrum of terrorism threats that we face in the 21st century. As the threat evolves, so too must our counterterrorism approach. To that end, last year, we ended America's longest war, in Afghanistan, having long ago achieved our objective of delivering justice to Osama Bin Laden and other key leadership of al-Qa'ida. We are confident in our ability to maintain the fight against al-Qa'ida, ISIS, and associated forces from over the horizon, as we demonstrated with the operation to kill Ayman al-Zawahiri. We will ensure Afghanistan never again serves as a safe haven for terrorist attacks on the United States or our allies and we will hold the Taliban accountable for its public commitments on counterterrorism.

Around the world, we will increase cooperation and support to trusted partners, shifting from a strategy that is "U.S.-led, partner-enabled" to one that is "partner-led, U.S.-enabled." That requires building or expanding systems to prevent, detect, and respond to threats as they develop—including by strengthening partners' law enforcement and judicial systems, improving threat information sharing, enhancing border security, countering terrorist financing, targeting terrorist prevention and extremist disengagement programming, and preventing online and offline terrorist recruitment and mobilization to violence. It also necessitates addressing the root causes of radicalization by leveraging U.S. and partner efforts to support effective governance, promote stabilization and economic development, and resolve ongoing conflicts.



Where necessary, we will use force to disrupt and degrade terrorist groups that are plotting attacks against the United States, our people, or our diplomatic and military facilities abroad. We will do so consistent with domestic and international law and in a manner that minimizes civilian casualties, while promoting greater transparency and accountability. We are committed to continuing to work with the Congress to replace outdated authorizations for the use of military force with a narrow and specific framework appropriate to ensure that we can continue to protect Americans from terrorist threats. Here at home, we will continue to work with state, local, tribal, and territorial partners and the private sector to share information and disrupt terrorist plots that threaten our citizens.

We face an increased and significant threat within the United States from a range of domestic violent extremists, including those motivated by racial or ethnic prejudice, as well as anti-government or anti-authority sentiment. Continuing to implement our first-ever National Strategy for Countering Domestic Terrorism will enable us to better understand and share information regarding the domestic terrorist threat, prevent recruitment and mobilization to violence, and disrupt and deter domestic terrorist activity and any transnational linkages—all while reinforcing respect for civil rights and civil liberties. Already, we are providing more and better information on domestic violent extremist threats to state, local, territorial, and tribal partners, and using new mechanisms, such as smartphone-based applications, to do so in real time. We are investing millions of dollars in data-driven violence prevention efforts, including through grant programs available to Federal, state, territorial, tribal, and nonprofit partners, as well as to houses of worship as they face increased threats. We are working with like-minded governments, civil society, and the technology sector to address terrorist and violent extremist content online, including through innovative research collaborations. And we are confronting the long-term contributors to domestic violent extremist threats, including working with Congress to advance commonsense gun laws and policies, and addressing the crisis of disinformation and misinformation, often channeled through social and other media platforms, that can fuel extreme polarization and lead some individuals to violence.



Combatting Transnational Organized Crime

Transnational organized crime impacts a growing number of victims while amplifying other consequential global challenges, from migration to cyber-attacks. Transnational criminal organizations (TCOs) are involved in activities such as the trafficking of drugs and other illicit goods, money laundering, theft, human smuggling and trafficking, cybercrime, fraud, corruption, and illegal fishing and mining. These activities feed violence in our communities, endanger public safety and health, and contribute to tens of thousands of drug-overdose deaths in the United States each year. They degrade the security and stability of our neighbors and partners by undermining the rule of law, fostering corruption, acting as proxies for hostile state activities, and exploiting and endangering vulnerable populations. We will accelerate our efforts to curb the threat posed by transnational organized crime, integrating the vital work of law enforcement with diplomatic, financial, intelligence, and other tools, and in coordination with foreign partners. As part of this effort, we will work to reduce the availability of illicit drugs in the United States, especially the growing scourge of fentanyl and methamphetamines, by bringing all the tools of government to bear to interdict drugs and disrupt TCO's supply chains and the financial networks that enable their corrosive activities. Recognizing that this is a problem with global reach we will work closely with our international partners to stop TCOs from getting precursor chemicals and work closely with private industry to increase vigilance and prevent the diversion of chemicals for illicit fentanyl production.

Shaping the Rules of the Road

Since 1945, the United States has led the creation of institutions, norms, and standards to govern international trade and investment, economic policy, and technology. These mechanisms advanced America's economic and geopolitical aims and benefited people around the world by shaping how governments and economies interacted—and did so in ways that aligned with U.S. interests and values. These mechanisms have not kept pace with economic or technological changes, and today risk being irrelevant, or in certain cases, actively harmful to solving the challenges we now face—from insecure supply chains to widening inequality to the abuses of the PRC's nonmarket economic actions. We are endeavoring to strengthen and update the UN system and multilateral institutions generally. Nowhere is this need more acute than in updating the rules of the road for technology, cyberspace, trade, and economics.

By doing so in close coordination with our allies and partners, we will establish fair rules while also sustaining our economic and technological edge and shape a future defined by fair competition—because when American workers and companies compete on a level playing field, they win.

Technology

Technology is central to today's geopolitical competition and to the future of our national security, economy and democracy. U.S. and allied leadership in technology and innovation has long underpinned our economic prosperity and military strength. In the next decade, critical and emerging technologies are poised to retool economies, transform militaries, and reshape the



world. The United States is committed to a future where these technologies increase the security, prosperity, and values of the American people and like-minded democracies. Our technology strategy will enable the United States and like-minded democracies to work together to pioneer new medicines that can cure diseases, increase the production of healthy foods that are sustainably grown, diversify and strengthen our manufacturing supply chains, and secure energy without reliance on fossil fuels, all while delivering new jobs and security for the American people and our allies and partners. With bipartisan support, we have launched a modern industrial strategy and already secured historic investments in clean energy, microelectronics manufacturing, research, and development, and biotechnology, and we will work with Congress to fully fund historic new authorizations for research and development. We also are doubling down on our longstanding and asymmetric strategic advantage: attracting and retaining the world's best talent. Attracting a higher volume of global STEM talent is a priority for our national security and supply chain security, so we will aggressively implement recent visa actions and work with Congress to do more.

These investments will enable the United States to anchor an allied techno-industrial base that will safeguard our shared security, prosperity and values. This means working with allies and partners to harness and scale new technologies, and promote the foundational technologies of the 21st century, especially microelectronics, advanced computing and quantum technologies, artificial intelligence, biotechnology and biomanufacturing, advanced telecommunications, and clean energy technologies. We also will partner with like-minded nations to co-develop and deploy technologies in a way that benefits all, not only the powerful, and build robust and durable supply chains so that countries cannot use economic warfare to coerce others.

We are already rallying like-minded actors to advance an international technology ecosystem that protects the integrity of international standards development and promotes the free flow of data and ideas with trust, while protecting our security, privacy, and human rights, and enhancing our competitiveness. That includes work through the U.S.-EU Trade and Technology Council to foster transatlantic coordination on semiconductor and critical mineral supply chains, trustworthy artificial intelligence, disinformation, the misuse of technology threatening security and human rights, export controls, and investment screening, as well as through the Indo-Pacific Quad on critical and emerging technologies, open, next-generation digital infrastructure, and people-to-people exchanges. Across this work, we seek to bolster U.S. and allied technology leadership, advance inclusive and responsible technology development, close regulatory and legal gaps, strengthen supply chain security, and enhance cooperation on privacy, data sharing, and digital trade.

We must ensure strategic competitors cannot exploit foundational American and allied technologies, know-how, or data to undermine American and allied security. We are therefore modernizing and strengthening our export control and investment screening mechanisms, and also pursuing targeted new approaches, such as screening of outbound investment, to prevent strategic competitors from exploiting investments and expertise in ways that threaten our national security, while also protecting the integrity of allied technological ecosystems and markets. We will also work to counter the exploitation of American's sensitive data and illegitimate use of technology, including commercial spyware and surveillance technology, and we will stand against digital authoritarianism.

To achieve these goals, the digital backbones of the modern economy must be open, trusted, interoperable, reliable, and secure. That requires working with a broad range of partners to



advance network infrastructure resilience in 5G and other advanced communication technologies, including by promoting vendor diversity and securing supply chains. These investments cannot just be made in wealthy countries; we must also focus on providing high-quality digital infrastructure in low- and middle-income countries, bridging digital divides by emphasizing access among marginalized groups. To ensure these investments support positive technological outcomes, we will partner with industry and governments in shaping technological standards that ensure quality, consumer safety, and global interoperability, and to advance the open and transparent standards process that has enabled innovation, growth, and interconnectivity for decades. And in all that we do we will strive to ensure that technology supports, and does not undermine, democracy, and is developed, deployed, and governed in accordance with human rights.

Securing Cyberspace

Our societies, and the critical infrastructure that supports them, from power to pipelines, is increasingly digital and vulnerable to disruption or destruction via cyber attacks. Such attacks have been used by countries, such as Russia, to undermine countries' ability to deliver services to citizens and coerce populations. We are working closely with allies and partners, such as the Quad, to define standards for critical infrastructure to rapidly improve our cyber resilience, and building collective capabilities to rapidly respond to attacks. In the face of disruptive cyber attacks from criminals, we have launched innovative partnerships, to expand law enforcement cooperation, deny sanctuary to cyber criminals and counter illicit use of cryptocurrency to launder the proceeds of cybercrime. As an open society, the United States has a clear interest in strengthening norms that mitigate cyber threats and enhance stability in cyberspace. We aim to deter cyber attacks from state and non state actors and will respond decisively with all appropriate tools of national power to hostile acts in cyberspace, including those that disrupt or degrade vital national functions or critical infrastructure. We will continue to promote adherence to the UN General Assembly-endorsed framework of responsible state behavior in cyberspace, which recognizes that international law applies online, just as it does offline.

Trade and Economics

America's prosperity also relies on a fair and open trade and international economic system. The United States has long benefited from international trade's ability to promote global economic growth, lower consumer prices, and access to foreign markets to promote U.S. exports and jobs. At the same time, the longstanding rules that govern trade and other means of economic exchange have been violated by non-market actors, like the PRC; were designed to privilege corporate mobility over workers and the environment, thereby exacerbating inequality and the climate crisis; and fail to cover the frontiers of the modern economy, including digital trade. The United States must once again rally partners around rules for creating a level playing field that will enable American workers and businesses—and those of partners and allies around the world—to thrive.

As our recent work to create IPEF and the Americas Prosperity for Economic Prosperity show, we are working to update the current trading system to promote equitable and resilient growth—encouraging robust trade, countering anticompetitive practices, bringing worker voices to the decision-making table, and ensuring high labor and environmental standards. We will seek new export opportunities that benefit American workers and companies, especially small- and



medium-sized enterprises, push back on abuses by non-market economies, and enforce rules against unfair trade and labor practices, including intellectual property theft, discriminatory regulations, forced labor, the denial of the right to organize, and other forms of labor repression. We will also use trade tools to advance climate priorities, as we are doing with the landmark steel and aluminum agreement with the EU. These arrangements will be accompanied by real adjustment assistance, ensuring all Americans have a dignified place in our shared future. Taken together, these efforts will create growth and innovation that benefits not only Americans, but people around the world.

Beyond trade, we are working to build an international economic system fit for contemporary realities. We will tackle the harms caused to U.S. workers, consumers, and businesses by currency manipulation; counter corruption and illicit finance; and end the race to the bottom for corporate taxation through promotion of the OECD's Global Minimum Tax. We will partner with countries on sustainable development, including by responding to global debt challenges and financing quality infrastructure through PGII. We will explore the merits and responsibly lead development of digital assets, including a digital dollar, with high standards and protections for stability, privacy, and security to benefit a strong and inclusive U.S. financial system and reinforce its global primacy. And we will address growth-stymying legal, structural, and cultural barriers that undermine labor force participation for women and marginalized groups. We will also support efforts by the international financial institutions will also need to continue to evolve to meet the challenges of our times. Many of the biggest challenges in our world today—such as pandemics and health, climate change, fragility, migration and refugee flows—cross borders and disproportionately affect the poorest, most vulnerable populations. Bolstering these institutions is also critical to tackling serious long-term challenges to the international order, such as those posed by the PRC.

Hostages and Wrongful Detainees

Using human beings as pawns is antithetical to American values and to the global order to which we aspire. Yet, that is what governments, regimes, and non-state actors do when they hold Americans against their will as hostages and wrongful detainees. We are working with our partners to deter and thwart those inhumane tactics. That includes our issuance in July 2022 of an executive order implementing a recent U.S. law called the Levinson Act and unlocking new tools for punishing those who wrongfully kidnap or detain Americans abroad. And it includes working with key international partners to promote and implement the Canadian-launched Declaration Against Arbitrary Detention in State-to-State Relations so as to turn the tide against this inhumane practice and forge international norms against it.



Countering Corruption

Corruption poses a fundamental threat to the rule of law. When government officials abuse public power for private gain, it degrades the business environment, subverts economic opportunity, and exacerbates inequality. Corruption also contributes to reduced public trust in state institutions, which in turn can add to the appeal of illiberal actors who exploit popular grievances for political advantage. In today's globalized world, international financial systems are used to stash illicit wealth abroad and to send bribes across borders. The United States Strategy on Countering Corruption recognizes the unique threat corruption poses to our national security and places a special emphasis on recognizing the ways in which corrupt actors have used the U.S. financial system and other rule-of-law based systems to launder their ill-gotten gains. In response to Russia's continued invasion of Ukraine, the United States ramped up its kleptocracy initiatives aimed at recovering corruption proceeds as well as both identifying and repatriating the laundered proceeds of crime. Finally, the United States will elevate and expand the scale of diplomatic engagement and foreign assistance, including by enhancing partner governments' capacities to fight corruption in cooperation with U.S. law enforcement authorities and bolstering the prevention and oversight capacities of willing governments.



PART IV: OUR STRATEGY BY REGION

“There’s a fundamental truth of the 21st century within each of our own countries and as a global community that our own success is bound up with others succeeding as well. To deliver for our own people, we must also engage deeply with the rest of the world. To ensure that our own future, we must work together with other partners—our partners—toward a shared future. Our security, our prosperity, and our very freedoms are interconnected, in my view, as never before. And so, I believe we must work together as never before.”

PRESIDENT JOSEPH R. BIDEN, JR.

76th Session of the United Nations General Assembly

The United States can meet the challenges of this decisive decade only by partnering with countries and people around the world. Americans rely on and benefit from our broad and deep relationships in every region; invest in and trade with nearly every country; and study, work, and live on every continent. Our future and the world’s are interlinked. That is why our strategy is global.

Promote a Free and Open Indo-Pacific

The Indo-Pacific fuels much of the world’s economic growth and will be the epicenter of 21st century geopolitics. As an Indo-Pacific power, the United States has a vital interest in realizing a region that is open, interconnected, prosperous, secure, and resilient.

The United States will work with other regional states to keep the Indo-Pacific open and accessible and ensure that nations are free to make their own choices, consistent with obligations under international law. We support open societies through investments in democratic institutions, free press, and civil society and are cooperating with partners to counter information manipulation and corruption. And we will affirm freedom of the seas and build shared regional support for open access to the South China Sea—a thoroughway for nearly two-thirds of global maritime trade and a quarter of all global trade.

A free and open Indo-Pacific can only be achieved if we build collective capacity. We are deepening our five regional treaty alliances and closest partnerships. We affirm the centrality of ASEAN, and seek deeper bonds with Southeast Asian partners. We will expand our regional diplomatic, development, and economic engagement, with a particular focus on Southeast Asia and the Pacific Islands. As we work with South Asian regional partners to address climate change, the COVID-19 pandemic, and the PRC’s coercive behavior, we will promote prosperity and economic connectivity across the Indian Ocean region. The Quad and AUKUS will also be critical to addressing regional challenges, and we will further reinforce our collective strength by weaving our allies and partners closer together—including by encouraging tighter linkages between likeminded Indo-Pacific and European countries.



The prosperity of everyday Americans is linked to the Indo-Pacific and the United States has long been a regional trade and investment leader. With our regional partners, we are developing IPEF to drive inclusive, broad-based prosperity and advance our shared interests in resilient, fair, digital, and low-carbon economies. Leadership through Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) will complement these efforts.

For 75 years, the United States has maintained a strong and consistent defense presence and will continue to meaningfully contribute to the region's stability and peace. We reaffirm our iron-clad commitments to our Indo-Pacific treaty allies—Australia, Japan, the Republic of Korea, the Philippines, and Thailand—and we will continue to modernize these alliances. We reaffirm our unwavering commitment to the defense of Japan under our mutual security treaty, which covers the Senkaku Islands. As India is the world's largest democracy and a Major Defense Partner, the United States and India will work together, bilaterally and multilaterally, to support our shared vision of a free and open Indo-Pacific. We will seek sustained diplomacy with North Korea to make tangible progress toward the complete denuclearization of the Korean Peninsula, while strengthening extended deterrence in the face of North Korean weapons of mass destruction and missile threats. The brutal military coup in Burma has undermined regional stability, and we will continue working closely with allies and partners, including ASEAN, to help restore Burma's democratic transition.

We will also work to enhance partners' resilience to transnational challenges, including climate and biological threats. The Indo-Pacific is the epicenter of the climate crisis but is also essential to climate solutions, and our shared responses to the climate crisis are a political imperative and an economic opportunity. We are also partnering to help the region build resilience to pandemic disease and to strengthen their health systems, drive investments in global health security, and expand the region's ability to prevent, detect, and respond to emergencies.

We have entered a consequential new period of American foreign policy that will demand more of the United States in the Indo-Pacific than has been asked of us since the Second World War. No region will be of more significance to the world and to everyday Americans than the Indo-Pacific. We are ambitious because we know that we and our allies and partners hold a common vision for its future.

Deepen Our Alliance with Europe

With a relationship rooted in shared democratic values, common interests, and historic ties, the transatlantic relationship is a vital platform on which many other elements of our foreign policy are built. Europe has been, and will continue to be, our foundational partner in addressing the full range of global challenges. To effectively pursue a common global agenda, we are broadening and deepening the transatlantic bond—strengthening NATO, raising the level of ambition in the U.S.-EU relationship, and standing with our European allies and partners in defense of the rules-based system that underpins our security, prosperity, and values.

Today, Europe stands at the front lines of the fight to defend the principles of freedom, sovereignty, and non-aggression, and we will continue to work in lockstep to ensure that freedom prevails. America remains unequivocally committed to collective defense as enshrined in NATO's Article 5 and will work alongside our NATO Allies to deter, defend against, and build resilience to aggression and coercion in all its forms. As we step up our own sizable



contributions to NATO capabilities and readiness—including by strengthening defensive forces and capabilities, and upholding our long-standing commitment to extended deterrence—we will count on our Allies to continue assuming greater responsibility by increasing their spending, capabilities, and contributions. European defense investments, through or complementary to NATO, will be critical to ensuring our shared security at this time of intensifying competition. We stand behind NATO’s continued adaptation to modern security challenges, including its emphasis on defense in cyberspace, climate security, and the growing security risks presented by the PRC’s policies and actions.

America maintains our fundamental commitment to the pursuit of a Europe that is whole, free, and at peace. Russia’s further invasion of Ukraine poses a grave threat to this vision, which is why we are determined to support Ukraine in defending its sovereignty and territorial integrity while imposing severe costs on Moscow for its aggression. We have supported Ukraine with security, humanitarian, and financial assistance. We have joined with allies and partners in Europe and around the globe to impose sanctions and export controls that will degrade Russia’s ability to wage future wars of aggression. We have partnered with the European Commission on an ambitious plan to reduce Europe’s dependence on Russian fossil fuels, strengthen European energy security, and advance shared climate goals. Across these efforts, the EU—an integrated market of over 450 million people—is an indispensable partner, and we support efforts to foster EU unity. We also encourage close cooperation on matters of mutual interest between the EU and the United Kingdom. In addition, we underscore our support for the Good Friday Agreement which is the bedrock of peace, stability, and prosperity in Northern Ireland.

As we support Ukraine, we will also work to enhance the stability and resilience of other democracies. We will support the European aspirations of Georgia and Moldova and their commitment to important institutional reforms. We will assist partners in strengthening democratic institutions, the rule of law, and economic development in the Western Balkans. We will back diplomatic efforts to resolve conflict in the South Caucasus. We will continue to engage with Turkey to reinforce its strategic, political, economic, and institutional ties to the West. We will work with allies and partners to manage the refugee crisis created by Russia’s war in Ukraine. And, we will work to forestall terrorist threats to Europe. Elsewhere in Eurasia, we will continue to support the independence, sovereignty and territorial integrity of Central Asia. We will foster efforts to enhance resilience and democratic development in the five countries in this region. We will continue to work through the C5+1 diplomatic platform (Kazakhstan, Kyrgyz Republic, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan and the United States) to advance climate adaptation, improve regional energy and food security, enhance integration within the region, and build greater connectivity to global markets.

Though rooted in transatlantic strength and stability, our agenda with European allies and partners is global. We will work with the EU to strengthen trade, investment, and technological cooperation grounded in shared democratic values—promoting an open and inclusive global economy, setting high standards for trade, ensuring fair competition, supporting labor rights, driving decarbonization, fighting corruption, and protecting our innovations from uses that run counter to our interests and values. Through the G7, we will work with France, Germany, Italy, and the United Kingdom to galvanize international cooperation on the world’s most pressing challenges. We will jointly defend human rights, whether in Belarus or Xinjiang. To enact this ambitious agenda, we will deepen our strategic alignment—consulting regularly, sharing information and intelligence, and acting together.



Foster Democracy and Shared Prosperity in the Western Hemisphere

No region impacts the United States more directly than the Western Hemisphere. With \$1.9 trillion in annual trade, shared values and democratic traditions, and familial bonds, nations of the Western Hemisphere, especially in North America, are key contributors to U.S. prosperity and resilience. But the COVID-19 pandemic and ensuing recession have exacerbated longstanding structural challenges, fueled political and social unrest, undermining faith in democracy's ability to deliver, and spurred unprecedented levels of irregular migration to the United States and throughout the region. Recognizing the direct link between the region's prosperity and security and that of our own, it is vital for the United States to revitalize our partnerships to build and preserve economic resilience, democratic stability, and citizen security within the hemisphere. We will advance these efforts through regular interactions, multilateral and institutional collaboration, and regional initiatives, and by implementing the commitments made at the Ninth Summit of the Americas.

The movement of people throughout the Americas, including over six million Venezuelans forced to leave their homes since 2015, affects all of Latin America and the Caribbean and reinforces the need for regional action. The Los Angeles Declaration on Migration and Protection complements U.S. efforts at home to modernize its border infrastructure and build a fair, orderly, and humane immigration system with a bold hemisphere-wide partnership centered on the principle of responsibility-sharing, stability and assistance for affected communities, the expansion of legal pathways, humane migration management, and a coordinated emergency response. The United States is also leading the charge to expand legal pathways for migration and to combat illicit human smuggling and trafficking that prey on vulnerable migrants. These efforts combined aim to stabilize migrant populations and replace irregular migration with orderly flows that can fuel economic growth in the United States and across the region. We will pursue these collaborative efforts while ensuring a fundamentally fair, orderly, and humane approach to migration management that bolster border security and protects our nation.

Ending and mitigating the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic and advancing health security are imperative for the wellbeing of the entire hemisphere. In addition to donating over 72 million vaccines, through the Action Plan on Health and Resilience in the Americas we are partnering with the region to prevent, prepare for, and respond to future pandemic threats and other public health emergencies while also expanding the equitable delivery of healthcare and public services to remote, vulnerable, and marginalized populations. In addition to supporting countries, especially in Central America and the Caribbean, in reaching a 70 percent COVID-19 vaccination rate, associated partnerships are boosting increased vaccine manufacturing capability and helping train 500,000 public health and medical professionals by 2027 through the Americas Health Corps.

Together with regional partners we are deepening economic cooperation to ensure durable and inclusive economic growth that delivers for our working people. Our priority is to work with Canada and Mexico to advance a North American vision for the future that draws on our shared strengths and bolsters U.S. global competitiveness. Similarly, the Americas Partnership for Economic Prosperity will guide our regional economic engagement by focusing on the largest drivers of bottom-up and middle-out growth, updating tools for the new and complex challenges facing us today and in the decades to come with a focus on reinvigorating regional economic



institutions, securing supply chains, creating clean energy jobs and promoting decarbonization, ensuring sustainable and inclusive trade, and making game-changing investments that increase the effectiveness of public administration.

Tackling the climate crisis and harnessing the dynamism of the region will be central to our approach, and we will use mitigation and adaptation efforts to fuel a sustainable economic recovery and protect forest ecosystems, including by promoting trade and investment in clean energy to achieve a collective target of 70 percent installed capacity for renewable energy generation in the region's electricity sector by 2030 and mobilizing financing and other forms of support to promote conservation of the Amazon. The United States and the Caribbean Community also launched the Partnership to Address the Climate Crisis 2030 to expand access to project financing, attract private investment in clean energy infrastructure and climate adaptation projects, and enhance local capacity to assess, plan for, predict, mitigate, and respond to extreme weather events and related risks in a changing climate.

The United States derives security and economic benefits from the region's democratic stability and institutions, as our shared values provide a basis for collaboration and peaceful dispute resolution. To help preserve and enhance these traditions, we will support partners striving to build transparent, inclusive, and accountable institutions. Together, we will support effective democratic governance responsive to citizen needs, defend human rights and combat gender-based violence, tackle corruption, and protect against external interference or coercion, including from the PRC, Russia, or Iran. Through reinvigorated and representative Inter-American institutions, and in partnership with civil society and other governments, we will support democratic self-determination for the people of Venezuela, Cuba, Nicaragua, and any country where the popular will is suppressed. In Haiti, which suffers from an extended humanitarian, political, and economic crisis, we will mobilize the international community to help restore security, rebuild governing institutions, and support a foundation of prosperity by which the Haitian people can determine their own future.

We will also assist partners in facing security threats. These challenges may be internal—including from local gangs, or transnational, including from criminal organizations that traffic drugs and humans and undertake other illegal operations—or external, as malign actors seek to gain military or intelligence footholds in the region. These threats impact security throughout the Americas, including here at home, and we will therefore promote collaboration to help assist civilian police and, strengthen justice systems in the Americas, and expand information sharing with our partners.

These priorities—expanding economic opportunities, strengthening democracy, and building security—are mutually reinforcing and contribute to national, regional, and global stability. We have an overriding strategic interest in pursuing and strengthening collaboration through intensified diplomatic engagement with hemispheric partners and institutions based on the premise that advance a vision of a region that is secure, middle class, and democratic is fundamentally in the national security interest of the United States. The challenge and the stakes of this undertaking are accentuated by the backdrop of increased geopolitical and geoeconomics volatility, the interrelated challenges posed by phenomena like climate change, global pandemics, and mass migration, and the recognition that the security and prosperity of the United States hinges on that of our neighbors.



Support De-Escalation and Integration in the Middle East

Over the past two decades, U.S. foreign policy has focused predominantly on threats emanating from the Middle East and North Africa. We have too often defaulted to military-centric policies underpinned by an unrealistic faith in force and regime change to deliver sustainable outcomes, while failing to adequately account for opportunity costs to competing global priorities or unintended consequences. It is time to eschew grand designs in favor of more practical steps that can advance U.S. interests and help regional partners lay the foundation for greater stability, prosperity, and opportunity for the people of the Middle East and for the American people.

The United States has set forth a new framework for U.S. policy in the region based on America's unparalleled comparative advantage in building partnerships, coalitions, and alliances to strengthen deterrence, while using diplomacy to de-escalate tensions, reduce risks of new conflicts, and set a long-term foundation for stability.

This framework has five principles. First, the United States will support and strengthen partnerships with countries that subscribe to the rules-based international order, and we will make sure those countries can defend themselves against foreign threats. Second, the United States will not allow foreign or regional powers to jeopardize freedom of navigation through the Middle East's waterways, including the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab al Mandab, nor tolerate efforts by any country to dominate another—or the region—through military buildups, incursions, or threats. Third, even as the United States works to deter threats to regional stability, we will work to reduce tensions, de-escalate, and end conflicts wherever possible through diplomacy. Fourth, the United States will promote regional integration by building political, economic, and security connections between and among U.S. partners, including through integrated air and maritime defense structures, while respecting each country's sovereignty and independent choices. Fifth, the United States will always promote human rights and the values enshrined in the UN Charter.

This new framework builds on the recent progress regional states have made to bridge their enduring divides. We will continue to work with allies and partners to enhance their capabilities to deter and counter Iran's destabilizing activities. We will pursue diplomacy to ensure that Iran can never acquire a nuclear weapon, while remaining postured and prepared to use other means should diplomacy fail. Iran's threats against U.S. personnel as well as current and former U.S. officials will not be tolerated, and as we have demonstrated, we will respond when our people and interests are attacked. As we do so, we will always stand with the Iranian people striving for the basic rights and dignity long denied them by the regime in Tehran.

More broadly we will combine diplomacy, economic aid, and security assistance to local partners to alleviate suffering, reduce instability, and prevent the export of terrorism or mass migration from Yemen, Syria, and Libya, while working with regional governments to manage the broader impact of these challenges. We will seek to extend and deepen Israel's growing ties to its neighbors and other Arab states, including through the Abraham Accords, while maintaining our ironclad commitment to its security. We will also continue to promote a viable two state solution that preserves Israel's future as a Jewish and democratic state while meeting Palestinian aspirations for a secure and viable state of their own. As President Biden stated during his visit to the West Bank in July 2022, "Two States along the 1967 lines, with mutually agreed swaps, remain the best way to achieve equal measure of security, prosperity, freedom, and democracy for Palestinians as well as Israelis."



This new framework relies on a sustainable and effective military posture focused on deterrence, strengthening partner capacity, enabling regional security integration, countering terrorist threats, and ensuring the free flow of global commerce. In conjunction with the use of other instruments of national power, these military activities also help counter external actors' military expansion in the region. We will not use our military to change regimes or remake societies, but instead limit the use of force to circumstances where it is necessary to protect our national security interests and consistent with international law, while enabling our partners to defend their territory from external and terrorist threats.

We will encourage economic and political reforms that help unlock the region's potential, including by fostering greater economic integration to drive growth and create jobs. We will encourage energy producers to use their resources to stabilize global energy markets, while also preparing for a clean energy future and protecting American consumers. We will also continue to support our democratic partners and demand accountability for violations of human rights, recognizing that while true reform can only come from within, the United States still has an important role to play. The United States is the largest bilateral donor of humanitarian assistance and a longstanding champion for principled, needs-based humanitarian action. We will sustain our leadership on humanitarian assistance and manage long-term refugee and displacement crises, which help realize human dignity and bolster stability. And we will accelerate our support to regional partners to help them build greater resilience, as the future of the Middle East will be defined as much by climate, technological, and demographic changes as by traditional security matters.

Build 21st Century U.S.-Africa Partnerships

Africa's governments, institutions, and people are a major geopolitical force, one that will play a crucial role in solving global challenges in the coming decade. Africa is more youthful, mobile, educated, and connected than ever before. African countries comprise one of the largest regional voting groups at the UN and their citizens lead major international institutions. The continent's booming population, vital natural resources, and vibrant entrepreneurship, coupled with the African Continental Free Trade Area, have the potential to drive transformative economic growth. Our partnerships with African states over the past three decades helped lay the groundwork for this growth. To accelerate it, U.S.-Africa partnerships must adapt to reflect the important geopolitical role that African nations play globally.

Advancing America's national interests will hinge in part on working more closely, not only with African nations, but also with regional bodies, such as the African Union, subnational governments, civil society, and private sector and diaspora communities. We will continue to invest in the region's largest states, such as Nigeria, Kenya, and South Africa, while also deepening our ties to medium and small states. We will engage African countries as equal partners to achieve our shared priorities from health and pandemic preparedness to climate change. We will also press partners about human rights, corruption, or authoritarian behavior, and deepen partnerships with countries that make progress toward more open and democratic governance. In coordination with international partners and regional bodies, we will counter democratic backsliding by imposing costs for coups and pressing for progress on civilian transitions. And we will listen to African leaders and people as they articulate their vision for



their foreign partnerships, including expectations for transparency, accountability, fairness, inclusion, and equity.

Enhancing Africa's peace and prosperity will bolster Africa's ability to solve regional and global problems. The region's commitment and capacity to renew democracy, as well as anticipate, prevent, and address emerging and long running conflicts can lead to favorable outcomes for Africans and Americans. We will support African-led efforts to work toward political solutions to costly conflicts, increasing terrorist activity, and humanitarian crises, such as those in Cameroon, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ethiopia, Mozambique, Nigeria, Somalia, and the Sahel, and invest in local and international peacebuilding and peacekeeping to prevent new conflicts from emerging. Consistent with our broader counterterrorism approach, we will disrupt and degrade terrorist threats against the United States while supporting partners to prevent terrorist expansion. We will work with our African and international partners to tackle the root causes of terrorism, including by countering corruption, strengthening accountability and justice, investing in inclusive economic development, and advancing human rights, including women's rights, and also push back on the destabilizing impact of the Russia-backed Wagner Group.

We will support accelerating growth through private sector investment, help Africa unlock its digital economy, double down on tackling food insecurity, and expand clean energy infrastructure through the Prosper Africa, Feed the Future, and Power Africa initiatives. We will support climate adaptation, conservation, and a just energy transition, as sub-Saharan African countries are already experiencing severe climate impacts, compounding land use, migration challenges, and rising food and commodity prices, made worse by Russia's further invasion of Ukraine. Quality healthcare systems are essential to economic growth, and we will build on our decades-long partnerships to invest in health security and health systems infrastructure, and the ongoing COVID-19 response. We will also work with African governments to create the business environments and make the investments in human capital and capacity development to attract investors, grow businesses, and create good jobs across sectors—and to bolster U.S.-Africa trade and create new opportunities for U.S. businesses. We will seek to offer opportunities that reflect America's competitive advantages, promoting inclusive growth, respecting workers' rights, and protecting the region's resources for future generations.

Maintain a Peaceful Arctic

The United States seeks an Arctic region that is peaceful, stable, prosperous, and cooperative. Climate change is making the Arctic more accessible than ever, threatening Arctic communities and vital ecosystems, creating new potential economic opportunities. and intensifying competition to shape the region's future. Russia has invested significantly in its presence in the Arctic over the last decade, modernizing its military infrastructure and increasing the pace of exercises and training operations. Its aggressive behavior has raised geopolitical tensions in the Arctic, creating new risks of unintended conflict and hindering cooperation. The PRC has also sought to increase its influence in the Arctic by rapidly increased its Arctic investments, pursuing new scientific activities, and using these scientific engagements to conduct dual-use research with intelligence or military applications.

We will uphold U.S. security in the region by improving our maritime domain awareness, communications, disaster response capabilities, and icebreaking capacity to prepare for increased international activity in the region. We will exercise U.S. Government presence in the region as



required, while reducing risk and preventing unnecessary escalation. Arctic nations have the primary responsibility for addressing regional challenges, and we will deepen our cooperation with our Arctic allies and partners and work with them to sustain the Arctic Council and other Arctic institutions despite the challenges to Arctic cooperation posed by Russia's war in Ukraine. We will continue to protect freedom of navigation and determine the U.S. extended continental shelf in accordance with international rules. We must build resilience to and mitigate climate change in the region, including through agreements to reduce emissions and more cross-Arctic research collaboration. As economic activity in the Arctic increases, we will invest in infrastructure, improve livelihoods, and encourage responsible private sector investment by the United States, our allies, and our partners, including in critical minerals, and improve investment screening for national security purposes. Across these efforts, we will uphold our commitment to honor Tribal sovereignty and self-governance through regular, meaningful, and robust consultation and collaboration with Alaska Native communities.

Protect Sea, Air, and Space

People around the world depend on the sea, air, and space for their security and prosperity. The world's interconnected oceans, lands, waterways, and other ecosystems generate economic opportunity and enable critical commercial and military activity. They contain biodiversity vital to food security, clean air and water, a stable climate, and health and wellbeing. Threats to these systems—including excessive maritime and airspace claims, pollution and unregulated deforestation, and wildlife trafficking and illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing—impact governments' abilities to meet basic human needs and contribute to political, economic, and social instability. We will stand up for freedom of navigation and overflight, support environmental protection, and oppose destructive distant water fishing practices by upholding international laws and norms, including the customary international law rules in the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea. And we will promote Antarctica's status as a continent reserved for peace and science in accordance with the provisions of the Antarctic Treaty of 1959.

Space exploration and use benefits humanity, from creating economic opportunities to developing new technologies and enabling climate surveillance. America will maintain our position as the world's leader in space and work alongside the international community to ensure the domain's sustainability, safety, stability, and security. We must lead in updating outer space governance, establishing a space traffic coordination system and charting a path for future space norms and arms control. Working with allies and partners, we will develop policies and regulations that enable the burgeoning U.S. commercial space sector to compete internationally. We will enhance the resilience of U.S. space systems that we rely on for critical national and homeland security functions. These efforts aim to protect U.S. interests in space, avoid destabilizing arms races, and responsibly steward the space environment.



Sharpen Our Tools of Statecraft

Our national security institutions and workforce underpin America's global leadership and the security, prosperity, and freedoms of the American people. To achieve our ambitious aims, we must modernize and adapt our tools of statecraft for today's challenges. For example, we are:

- Strengthening American diplomacy by modernizing the Department of State, including through the recent creation of a new bureau for cyberspace and digital policy and special envoy for critical and emerging technologies.
- Adapting the Intelligence Community (IC), including by aligning our organizations to better address competition, embracing new data tools, and enhancing integration of open source material.
- Enhancing U.S. and global early warning and forecasting for infectious disease threats and pandemics by increasing support for the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's (CDC) Center for Outbreak, Forecasting, and Analytics and foreign assistance for global health security.
- Reorganizing the Office of the Under Secretary of Defense for Policy to sharpen its focus on emerging technologies and elevate senior leader attention to critical regions. Bolstering the Department of Homeland Security's (DHS) Cybersecurity Service by reimagining how DHS hires, develops, and retains top-tier and diverse cyber talent.
- Making development assistance more accessible and equitable by increasing engagement with and shifting 25 percent of U.S. Agency for International Development (USAID) funding to local partners, and double USAID's work on empowering women and girls.
- Expanding our engagement with stakeholders and build our capacity to partner with the private sector, philanthropy, diaspora communities, and civil society.
- Prioritizing technology's role in national security by elevating the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy to a cabinet-level agency and full member of the National Security Council.

The success of these efforts and our foreign policy will require strengthening the national security workforce by recruiting and retaining diverse, high-caliber talent. We are:

- Prioritizing diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility to ensure national security institutions reflect the American public they represent.
- Creating more effective and efficient hiring, recruitment, retention, and talent development practices, particularly in STEM fields, economics, critical languages, and regional affairs.
- Supporting professional development opportunities—for both leadership and technical skills—at all levels of the workforce.
- Opening opportunities for the national security workforce to move among institutions, both within and outside government, and carry the skills they develop back to their home agencies.
- Equipping the workforce with cutting-edge technology and better integrate data and analytic tools to support decision-making.
- Prioritizing human resources capabilities and personnel, who will drive and steward all of these initiatives.



The health of our national security institutions and workforce relies on faith in the apolitical nature of Federal law enforcement agencies, the IC, our diplomats, civil servants, Federally funded research and development institutions, and military as we work together in national service.



PART V: CONCLUSION

We are confident that the United States, alongside our allies and partners, is positioned to succeed in our pursuit of a free, open, prosperous, and secure global order. With the key elements outlined in this strategy, we will tackle the twin challenges of our time: out-competing our rivals to shape the international order while tackling shared challenges, including climate change, pandemic preparedness, and food security, that will define the next stage of human history. We will strengthen democracy across the world, and multilateral institutions, as we look to the future to chart new and fair rules of the road for emerging technology, cybersecurity, and trade and economics. And we will do all this and more by leveraging our considerable advantages and our unparalleled coalition of allies and partners.

As we implement this strategy, we will continually assess and reassess our approach to ensure we are best serving the American people. We will be guided by the indisputable fact that the strength and quality of the American project at home is inextricably linked with our leadership in the world and our ability to shape the terms of the world order. This National Security Strategy will be evaluated by an overriding metric: whether it makes life better, safer, and fairer for the people of the United States, and whether it lifts up the countries and people around the world who share our vision for the future.

We are motivated by a clear vision of what success looks like at the end of this decisive decade.

By enhancing our industrial capacity, investing in our people, and strengthening our democracy, we will have strengthened the foundation of our economy, bolstered our national resilience, enhanced our credibility on the world stage, and ensured our competitive advantages.

By deepening and expanding our diplomatic relationships not only with our democratic allies but with all states who share our vision for a better future, we will have developed terms of competition with our strategic rivals that are favorable to our interests and values and laid the foundation to increase cooperation on shared challenges.

By modernizing our military, pursuing advanced technologies, and investing in our defense workforce, we will have strengthened deterrence in an era of increasing geopolitical confrontation, and positioned America to defend our homeland, our allies, partners, and interests overseas, and our values across the globe.

By leveraging our national strengths and rallying a broad coalition of allies and partners, we will advance our vision of a free, open, prosperous, and secure world, outmaneuvering our competitors, and making meaningful progress on issues like climate change, global health, and food security to improve the lives not just of Americans but of people around the world.

This is what we must achieve in this decisive decade. As we have done throughout our history, America will seize this moment and rise to the challenge. There is no time to waste.

CHAIRMAN OF THE JOINT CHIEFS OF STAFF

NATIONAL MILITARY STRATEGY

2022



STRATEGIC DISCIPLINE



CHAIRMAN'S FOREWORD

The Joint Force is at an *inflection point* during what will be a *decisive decade*. Geopolitical relationships are shifting, economies are rising – and falling, rapid technological advances are fueling militaries' modernizations at scale, and external factors like climate change and pandemics are changing the way people live, work, and go to war. An undeniable and intentional violation of sovereignty has shocked the international system. Large-scale combat has now been introduced into the strategic competition between autocracies and democracies, further stressing the rules-based international order.



For the first time in our Nation's history, the United States faces two major nuclear powers that may employ nuclear coercion as a way to meet their national objectives. Both the People's Republic of China (PRC) and Russia possess the will and the means to pose an existential threat to our way of life. The PRC is our most consequential strategic competitor, modernizing its military and preparing to fight and win a war with the United States. Russia poses acute threats, pursuing power and influence through cyber-attacks and disinformation campaigns, while its attack on Ukraine represents a moment on par with 9/11 in terms of global consequence and challenge to U.S. and international security.

The current environment requires the Joint Force to strengthen and integrate deterrence across domains, theaters, and the spectrum of conflict; modernize the nuclear enterprise; assure allies and partners; and prepare to prevail in great power conflict. The United States must meet this challenge with alacrity, discipline, and fortitude – the window to seize the strategic initiative is *now*. This National Military Strategy (NMS) is a wakeup call: **Adapt Now, or Lose Later.**

This NMS renews our focus on campaigning now and building and sustaining warfighting advantage in tandem. Both are critical to prevail in war, and both are necessary to preserve the peace. War is a terrible endeavor, and Great Power War is especially terrible – but it is not inevitable, so our Nation strives for peace. As the U.S. does so, its Joint Force will defend, deter, modernize – and prevail if deterrence fails – realizing that the surest way to prevent escalation and war is always being prepared to defeat our Nation's foes.

The time is now and the window of strategic opportunity we have is closing. What we do in the next few years is going to set conditions for victory or defeat in the next war. We must adapt now in order to win the next war, and by doing so, we will deter the war from happening in the first place.


MARK A. MILLEY
General, U.S. Army

The 2022 NMS is the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff's (CJCS) strategic guidance that provides the logic and framework to achieve the 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS) priorities and build the future Joint Force. This NMS offers guidance for every Active Duty, Reserve, National Guard, and civilian member to take bold and transformative action now to protect the security of the American people and defend the democratic ideals at the heart of the American way of life. This strategy is about the Joint Force obtaining lasting positions of relative advantage in peace and achieving decisive victory in war.

STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENT

- ▶ **THREATS.** The classified NMS clearly describes the near and real threats faced by the Joint Force in the strategic environment. As our most consequential strategic competitor, the PRC is unequivocal in its pursuit to reshape an authoritarian world order with no democratic values. The PRC is the pacing challenge for the Department. Russia is an acute threat with aggressive intent – as seen by its brutal and unprovoked invasion of Ukraine – that seeks to consolidate and strengthen its perceived Eurasian sphere of influence to counter Western influence. Other persistent threats include North Korea, Iran, and violent extremist organizations.
- ▶ **GEOPOLITICAL TRENDS.** Amidst institutional and economic fragility and the ongoing health crisis, adversaries will test the post-World War II international order, attempting to weaken U.S. leadership and rewrite international rules and norms to their own benefit.
- ▶ **ECONOMIC TRENDS.** Growing economic strength drives global influence and undergirds other elements of national power, which will continue to fuel the PRC's coercive actions.
- ▶ **TECHNOLOGICAL TRENDS.** Both commercial and military technologies will advance rapidly and proliferate the global technology landscape. These capabilities alone may not ensure military victory, but creative application will shape the outcome of any contest.
- ▶ **EXTERNAL TRENDS.** Pandemics, climate change, demographic changes, and resource scarcity will destabilize the security environment and impose changes and constraints on domestic political contexts.
- ▶ **MILITARY TRENDS.** For the first time, the United States will simultaneously contend with two major nuclear powers. Future warfare will include advanced threats to the Homeland, elements in the Gray-Zone, and protracted conflicts in contested environments. Militaries that incorporate new technology with innovative operational concepts and develop leadership to harness the changes will create decisive advantage.



The nature of the problem the 2022 NMS aims to solve is meeting the Joint Force Strategic Objectives in the context of the strategic environment. The solution to the problem is informed by the NDS' strategic approach. The result is a theory of success that allows the Joint Force to operate from an advantageous position with respect to threats, maintain awareness of strategic trends, remain in line with civilian guidance, and advance toward our objectives.

So how does the Joint Force rapidly develop future warfighting advantage while deterring effectively today, with the PRC as the pacing challenge?

This is the central military problem this NMS seeks to solve.

The NDS strategic approach employs three strategic ways (integrated deterrence, campaigning, and building enduring advantage) to foster Integrated Deterrence. Aligned with the NDS, the NMS implements Integrated Deterrence through ruthless prioritization to calibrate decision-making and activities of the Joint Force now in order to succeed.

INTEGRATED DETERRENCE

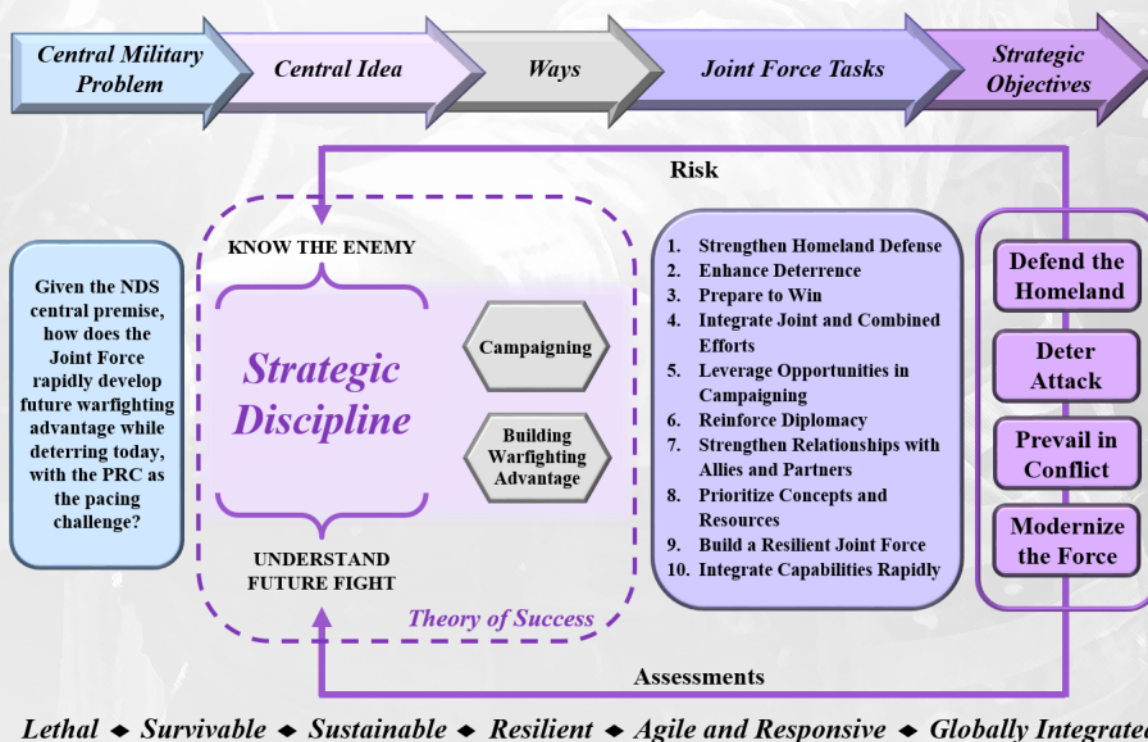
Integrated Deterrence, the NDS' principal strategic approach, generates warfighting advantages by synchronizing operations across warfighting domains, theaters, the spectrum of conflict, instruments of national power, the interagency, private sector, and allies and partners.

Integrated Deterrence influences adversary decision calculus by affecting perception of costs, benefits, and consequences of restraint.

The Joint Force's contribution to Integrated Deterrence is combat-credible forces, backstopped by a safe, secure, and effective nuclear deterrent.

Through the NMS' theory of success, the Joint Force contributes to Integrated Deterrence to reduce an adversary's perceived benefit and increase the adversary's perceived cost of aggression, incentivizing restraint as a result.

IMPLEMENTING INTEGRATED DETERRENCE



"You want to deter your potential opponent from even thinking or contemplating that they could have a war with the United States."

General Milley, CJCS
(Brookings Institution, 2 December 2020)

The NMS seeks to solve the central military problem within the framework of the NDS through an informed theory of success that enables disciplined decision-making by framing risk and assessing progress toward strategic objectives.

The NMS Theory of Success is to *exercise Strategic Discipline to continuously calibrate Joint Force weight of effort between campaigning and rapidly building warfighting advantage to deter now and reduce future risk.*

STRATEGIC DISCIPLINE

Strategic Discipline is the ruthless prioritization and calibration of Joint Force operations, activities, and investments, consistent with policy guidance and strategic aims, between the Joint Force strategic ways of campaigning and building warfighting advantage.

Strategic Discipline is enabled by a robust understanding of the strategic environment, including a deep awareness of our adversaries and ourselves, ally and partner equities, and the future character of warfare. This understanding is enhanced by strategic assessments that enable risk decisions to bias toward decreasing future risk. This approach provides the Joint Force with the agility to focus on enduring priorities and generate military options for emergent changes.

Campaigning

Campaigning is how the DoD sequences day-to-day defense initiatives and develops advantageous conditions to deter conflict, accomplish strategic objectives, and prevail against adversaries across the spectrum of conflict, to include the Gray-Zone.



Risk

To implement the NMS effectively, the Joint Force must take a globally integrated approach to risk while thinking across multiple time horizons. Decision-makers must consider transferring risk away from priority threats/theaters and be more risk tolerant in the present to reduce risk in the future.



Building Warfighting Advantage

Building Warfighting Advantage requires deliberate investment to develop leaders, concepts, and capabilities through materiel and non-materiel solutions in order to achieve strategic objectives in the future.

Assessments

Joint assessments guide the Chairman's military advice and the balance of resource decisions between future modernization and current requirements. These assessments guide iterative adjustments to implement NDS Defense Priorities and Joint Force Strategic Objectives.



1. **STRENGTHEN HOMELAND DEFENSE**

Modernize and integrate to protect our way of life.

2. **ENHANCE DETERRENCE**

Develop capabilities that deter adversaries from advancing their goals, employing their military strengths, or attacking U.S. interests.

3. **PREPARE TO WIN**

Ensure a properly trained and resourced combat force capable of defeating our adversaries abroad.

4. **INTEGRATE JOINT FORCE AND COMBINED EFFORTS**

Synchronize actions with allies, partners, and the interagency to address trans-regional, all-domain, and multi-functional challenges and continuously advance national security objectives.

5. **LEVERAGE OPPORTUNITIES IN CAMPAIGNING**

Proactively identify and leverage opportunities to frustrate adversaries' strengths, exploit vulnerabilities, and expand U.S. partnerships, access, and basing.

6. **REINFORCE DIPLOMACY**

Support diplomatic efforts to preserve the rules-based international order and provide credible military options that enable leaders to interact from a position of strength.

7. **STRENGTHEN RELATIONSHIPS WITH ALLIES AND PARTNERS**

Seek opportunities to collaborate and improve interoperability with allies and partners to confront enduring and emerging challenges. Foster strong relationships now — because we cannot surge trust in crisis.

8. **PRIORITIZE CONCEPTS AND RESOURCES**

Refocus our current warfighting ideas, systems, and practices to improve combat effectiveness.

9. **BUILD A RESILIENT JOINT FORCE**

Harness robust and effective combat capabilities that can resist degradation and quickly reconstitute in future combat.

10. **INTEGRATE CAPABILITIES RAPIDLY**

Timely integrate advanced capabilities to amplify existing warfighting advantages.



"We are now in the seventy-sixth year of the great-power peace following World War II and the structure is under stress. We can see it fraying at the edge. And with history as our guide, we would be wise to lift our gaze from the never-ending urgency of the present and set the conditions for a future that prevents great-power war."

General Milley, CJCS
(US Air Force Academy Graduation, 26 May 2021)

JOINT FORCE STRATEGIC OBJECTIVES

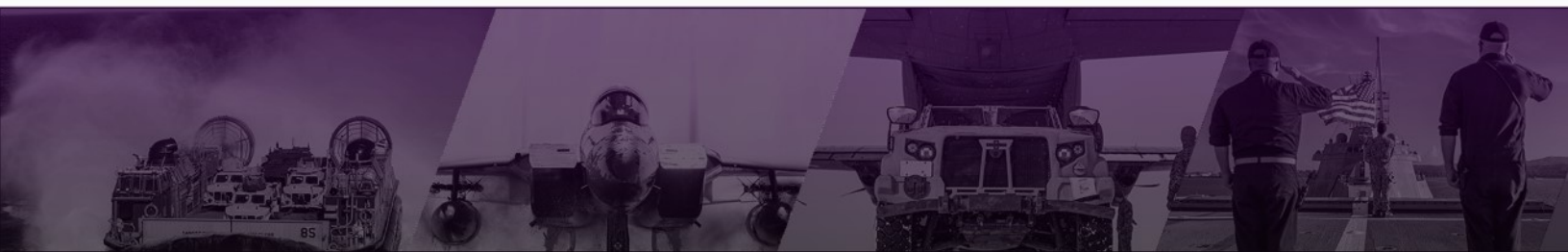
- ▶ **Defend the U.S. Homeland** against all-domain threats, prioritizing the PRC.
- ▶ **Deter strategic attacks** and other aggression against the United States, allies, and partners.
- ▶ Ensure the Joint Force possesses the combat-credible capabilities necessary to **prevail in conflict** against the PRC in the Indo-Pacific, then Russia in Europe.
- ▶ **Focus technical and non-technical modernization** into a resilient Joint Force and maintain the ability to respond to crises.



CONCLUSION

To meet the challenges described, now and in the coming decisive decade, this strategy outlines the Joint Force's vision to deter, and if necessary, to defeat potential adversaries now and into the future. We're at an inflection point, requiring the Joint Force to exercise Strategic Discipline to sustain and strengthen Integrated Deterrence – we must Adapt Now, or Lose Later.

The success of this strategy depends on the innovation and discipline of the Joint Force and its leaders at every rank. Future Joint Force success – like the past – will continue to be anchored by the American people and our values, the U.S. government, and our allies and partners. The Joint Force will defend, deter, modernize – and prevail if deterrence fails.



The National Security Council: Background and Issues for Congress

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Summary

On February 4, 2021, President Joseph R. Biden signed National Security Memorandum (NSM)-2, *Renewing the National Security Council System*. In it, the Biden Administration articulates how it intends to manage and coordinate national security issues among relevant departments and agencies. This report offers a brief historical overview of the formation of the National Security Council (NSC), clarifies the terms and structures associated with it, and provides a table of the NSC's current composition.

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Introduction¹

The National Security Council (NSC) was established by statute in 1947 to create an interdepartmental body to advise the President on matters of national security. More specifically, the NSC was created to integrate domestic, foreign, and military policies related to national security, and to facilitate cooperation among the military services and other government departments and agencies in matters of national security. Currently, statutory members of the NSC are the President, the Vice President, the Secretary of State, the Secretary of Defense, the Secretary of Energy and the Secretary of the Treasury. Other senior officials participate in NSC deliberations at the President's request. The Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff and the Director of National Intelligence are statutory advisers.

The President clearly holds final decisionmaking authority in the executive branch. Over the years, however, the NSC staff has emerged as a major factor in the formulation (and at times in the implementation) of national security policy. Similarly, the head of the NSC staff, the National Security Adviser, has played an important, and occasionally highly public, role in policymaking. This report summarizes the evolution of the NSC from its creation to the present.²

The organization and influence of the NSC have varied significantly from one Administration to another, ranging from highly structured and formal systems to loose-knit teams of experts. Although it is universally acknowledged that the NSC staff should be organized to meet the particular goals and work habits of an incumbent President, the history of the NSC provides ample examples of the advantages and disadvantages of different types of policymaking structures.

Congress enacted the statute creating the NSC and has altered the character of its membership over the years. Congress annually appropriates funds for its activities, but Congress does not, routinely, receive testimony on substantive matters from the National Security Adviser or from NSC staff. Proposals to require Senate confirmation of the Security Adviser have been discussed but not adopted.

Pre-NSC Coordination Methods

The Need for Interdepartmental Coordination

Successful national security policymaking is based on careful analysis of the international situation, including diplomatic, economic, intelligence, military, and morale factors. Based on a comprehensive assessment, effective government leaders attempt to attain their goals by selecting the most appropriate instrument of policy, whether it is military, diplomatic, economic, based on the intelligence services, or a combination of more than one. Although this approach has been an ideal throughout the history of international relations, prior to World War II, U.S. Presidents focused primarily on domestic matters and lacked organizational support to integrate national security policies. They relied instead on ad hoc arrangements and informal groups of advisers. However, in the early 1940s, the complexities of global war and the need to work together with

¹ The author is indebted to Richard Best, former Congressional Research Service Specialist in National Defense, whose report, "The National Security Council: An Organizational Assessment," forms the basis of the historical material contained within this piece.

² For a more in-depth treatment of this evolution, see CRS Report RL30840, *The National Security Council: An Organizational Assessment*, by Richard A. Best Jr.

allies led to more structured processes of national security decisionmaking to ensure that the efforts of the State, War, and Navy Departments were focused on the same objectives. There was an increasingly apparent need for an organizational entity to support the President in looking at multiple factors, military and diplomatic, that had to be faced during wartime and in the early postwar months, when crucial decisions had to be made regarding the future of Germany and Japan and many other countries.

In the postwar years, the United States' continuing worldwide responsibilities involved active diplomacy, sizable military forces, and sophisticated intelligence agencies, in addition to economic assistance in various forms. In response to these evolving responsibilities, the United States established organizational mechanisms to analyze the international environment, identify priorities, and recommend appropriate policy options. Four decades later, the end of the Cold War saw the emergence of new international concerns, including transnational threats such as international terrorism and drug trafficking, that have continued to require the coordination of various departments and agencies concerned with national security policies.

Past Modes of Policy Coordination

Coordinative mechanisms to implement policy are largely creations of the executive branch, but they directly influence choices that Congress may be called upon to support and fund. Congress thus takes interest in the processes by which policies and the roles of various participants are determined. Poor coordination of national security policy can result in calls for Congress to take actions that have major costs, both international and domestic, but an uncertain outcome. Effective coordination, on the other hand, can help achieve policy goals with minimal losses while providing the opportunity to devote material resources to other needs.

Until the 20th century, most U.S. policy coordination centered on the President, who was virtually the sole means of such coordination. The Constitution designates the President as Commander-in-Chief of the Armed Forces (Article II, Section 2) and grants him broad powers in the areas of foreign affairs (Article II, Section 2), powers that have expanded considerably in the 20th century. Given limited U.S. foreign involvements for the first 100 or so years under the Constitution, the small size of the Armed Forces, the relative geographic isolation of the nation, and the absence of any proximate threat, the President, or his executive agents in the Cabinet, provided a sufficient coordinative base.

However, the advent of World War I, which represented a modern, complex military effort involving broad domestic and international coordination, forced new demands on the system that the President alone could not meet. In 1916, the Council of National Defense was established by statute (the Army Appropriation Act of 1916). It reflected proposals that went back to 1911 and consisted of the Secretaries of War, Navy, Interior, Agriculture, Commerce and Labor. The statute allowed the President to appoint an advisory commission of outside specialists to aid the council.³ The Council of National Defense was intended as an economic mobilization coordinating group, as reflected by its membership, which excluded the Secretary of State. His inclusion would have given the council a much wider coordinative scope. Furthermore, the authorizing statute essentially limited the council's role to economic mobilization issues. The Council of National Defense was disbanded in 1921, but it set a precedent for coordinative efforts that would be needed in World War II.

³ Paul Y. Hammond, "The National Security Council as a Device for Interdepartmental Coordination: An Interpretation and Appraisal," *American Political Science Review*, December, 1960, p. 899; U.S. Bureau of the Budget, *The United States at War* (Washington: GPO, 1946), p. 2.

The President remained the sole national security coordinator until 1938, when the prewar crisis began to build in intensity, presenting numerous and wide-ranging threats to the inadequately armed United States. The State Department, in reaction to reports of Axis activities in Latin America, proposed that interdepartmental conferences be held with War and Navy Department representatives. In April 1938, Secretary of State Cordell Hull, in a letter to President Franklin Roosevelt, formally proposed the creation of a standing committee made up of the second-ranking officers of the three departments, for purposes of liaison and coordination. The President approved this idea, and the Standing Liaison Committee, or Liaison Committee as it was also called, was established, the members being the Under Secretary of State, the Chief of Staff of the Army, and the Chief of Naval Operations. The Standing Liaison Committee was the first significant effort toward interdepartmental liaison and coordination, although its work in the area was limited and uneven. The Liaison Committee largely concentrated its efforts on Latin American problems, and it met irregularly. Although it did foster some worthwhile studies during the crisis following the fall of France, it was soon superseded by other coordinative modes. It was more a forum for exchanging information than a new coordinative and directing body.⁴

An informal coordinating mechanism, which complemented the Standing Liaison Committee, evolved during the weekly meetings established by Secretary of War Henry L. Stimson, who took office in June 1940. Stimson arranged for weekly luncheons with his Navy counterpart, Frank Knox, and Cordell Hull, but these meetings also did not fully meet the growing coordinative needs of the wartime government.

In May 1940, President Roosevelt used the precedent of the 1916 statute and established the National Defense Advisory Council (NDAC), composed of private citizens with expertise in specific economic sectors.⁵ As with the earlier Council of National Defense, the NDAC was organized to handle problems of economic mobilization; by the end of the year, it had given way to another organization in a succession of such groups.

During the war, a number of interdepartmental committees were formed to handle various issues, and, while these did help achieve coordination, they suffered from two problems. First, their very multiplicity was to some degree counterproductive to coordination, and they still represented a piecemeal approach to these issues. Second, and more important, these committees in many cases were not advising the President directly, but were advising his advisers. Although their multiplicity and possible overlapping fit Roosevelt's preferred working methods, they did not represent coordination at the top. Roosevelt ran the war largely through the Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS), who were then an ad hoc and de facto group, and through key advisers such as Harry Hopkins and James F. Byrnes, and via his own personal link with British Prime Minister Winston Churchill.

The weekly meetings arranged by Stimson evolved, however, into a significant coordinative body by 1945, with the formal creation of the State, War, Navy Coordinating Committee (SWNCC). SWNCC had its own secretariat and a number of regional and topical subcommittees; its members were assistant secretaries in each pertinent department. The role of SWNCC members was to aid their superiors on political-military matters, and coordinating the views of the three departments. SWNCC was a significant improvement in civilian-military liaison, and it meshed well with the JCS system; it did not, however, concern itself with fundamental questions of

⁴ Mark Skinner Watson, *Chief of Staff: Prewar Plans and Preparations* (Washington: Office of the Chief of Military History, 1950), pp. 89-91, 93-94.

⁵ R. Elberton Smith, *The Army and Economic Mobilization* (Washington: Office of the Chief of Military History, 1959), pp. 103-04, 109-10; Bureau of the Budget, *The United States at War*, pp. 22-25, 44, 50-51.

national policy during the early months of the Cold War.⁶ SWNCC operated through the end of the war and beyond, becoming SANACC (State, Army, Navy, Air Force Coordinating Committee) after the National Security Act of 1947. It was dissolved in 1949, by which time it had been superseded by the NSC.

The creation of SWNCC, virtually at the end of the war, and its continued existence after the surrender of Germany and Japan, reflected the growing awareness within the federal government that better means of coordination were necessary. The World War II system had largely reflected the preferred working methods of President Roosevelt, who relied on informal consultations with various advisers in addition to the JCS structure. However, the complex demands of global war and the postwar world rendered this system inadequate, and it was generally recognized that a return to the simple and limited prewar system would not be possible if the United States was to take on the responsibilities thrust upon it by the war and its aftermath.

The Creation of the NSC⁷

Introduction

The NSC was not created independently, but rather as one part of a complete restructuring of the entire national security apparatus—civilian and military, including intelligence efforts—as accomplished in the National Security Act of 1947. Thus, isolating the creation of the NSC from the larger reorganization is difficult, especially as the NSC was much less controversial than the unification of the military and so attracted less attention.

Proposals

As early as 1943, General George C. Marshall, Army Chief of Staff, had proposed that the prospect of a unified military establishment be assessed. Congress first began to consider this idea in 1944, with the Army showing interest and the Navy opposing the idea. At the request of the Navy, these investigations were deferred until 1945, although by then it was clear to Secretary of the Navy James Forrestal that President Truman, who had come to the White House upon the death of President Roosevelt in April 1945, favored some sort of reorganization. Forrestal believed that outright opposition would not be a satisfactory Navy stance. He also realized that the State Department had to be included in any new national security apparatus. Therefore, he had Ferdinand Eberstadt, a leading New York attorney and banker who had served in several high-level executive branch positions, investigate the issue.⁸

With respect to the formation of the NSC, a key question posed by Forrestal to Eberstadt was,

⁶ Ray S. Cline, *Washington Command Post: The Operations Division* (Washington: Office of the Chief of Military History, 1951), pp. 326-27; John Lewis Gaddis, *The United States and the Origins of the Cold War* (New York, Columbia University Press, 1972), p. 126; U.S. Department of State, *Foreign Relations of the United States, 1944*, v. 1: *General* (Washington: GPO, 1966), pp. 1466-1470.

⁷ One of the most thorough studies on the creation and development of the NSC through the Eisenhower Administration, including hearings, studies, reports, recommendations and articles, can be found in U.S. Congress, Senate, 86th and 87th Congress, Committee on Government Operations, Subcommittee on National Policy Machinery, *Organizing for National Security*, 1961, 3 vols.

⁸ Demetrios Caraley, *The Politics of Military Unification* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1966), pp. 23-44; Walter Millis, ed., *The Forrestal Diaries* (New York: The Viking Press, 1951), pp. 62-63.

What form of postwar organization should be established and maintained to enable the military services and other governmental departments and agencies most effectively to provide for and protect our national security?

Eberstadt's response to this question covered the military establishment, where he favored three separate departments and the continuation of the JCS, as well as the civilian sphere, where he suggested the formation of two new major bodies "to coordinate all these [civilian and military] elements." Eberstadt called these two bodies the National Security Council (NSC) and the National Security Resources Board (NSRB). The NSC was composed of the President, the Secretaries of State and the three military departments, the JCS "in attendance," and the chairman of the NSRB. Eberstadt also favored the creation of a Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) under the NSC.⁹

Eberstadt's recommendations clearly presaged the eventual national security apparatus, with the exception of a unified Department of Defense. The NSC was also a useful negotiating point for Forrestal with the Army, as Eberstadt had described one of its functions as being the "building up [of] public support for clear-cut, consistent, and effective foreign and military policies." This would appeal to all the service factions as they thought back on the lean and insecure prewar years.¹⁰

War-Navy negotiations over the shape of the reorganization continued throughout 1946 and into 1947. However, some form of central coordination, temporarily called the Council of Common Defense, was not one of the contentious issues. By the end of May 1946, agreement had been reached on this and several other points, and by the end of the year the two sides had agreed on the composition of the new coordinative body.¹¹

Congressional Consideration

The creation of the NSC was one of the least controversial sections of the National Security Act and so drew little attention compared with the basic concept of a single military department, around which most of the congressional debate centered.

The concept of a regular and permanent organization for the coordination of national security policy was as widely accepted in Congress as in the executive branch. When the NSC was considered in debate, the major issues were the mechanics of the new organization, its membership, assurances that it would be a civilian organization and would not be dominated by the new Secretary of the National Military Establishment, and whether future positions on the NSC would be subject to approval by the Senate.¹²

⁹ Caraley, *The Politics of Military Unification*, pp. 40-41; see also Jeffrey M. Dorwart, *Eberstadt and Forrestal: A National Security Partnership, 1909-1949* (College Station, TX: Texas A & M University Press, 1991), especially pp. 90-107.

¹⁰ Ibid., pp. 86-87, 91; Hammond, "The NSC as a Device for Interdepartmental Coordination," pp. 900-901.

¹¹ Caraley, *Politics of Military Unification*, pp. 136-37; Millis, *Forrestal Diaries*, p. 222.

¹² The congressional debate over the National Security Act is summarized in Caraley, *Politics of Military Unification*, pp. 153-182; on the NSC, see p. 161. Examples of congressional opinion can be found throughout the lengthy debate. Some representative comments can be found in the *Congressional Record*, v. 93, July 7, 1947, p. 8299, and July 9, 1947, pp. 8496-97, 8518, 8520.

The NSC as Created in 1947

The NSC was created by the National Security Act, which was signed by the President on July 26, 1947. The NSC appears in Section 101 of Title I, Coordination for National Security, and its purpose is stated as follows:

(a) ... The function of the Council shall be to advise the President with respect to the integration of domestic, foreign, and military policies relating to the national security so as to enable the military services and the other departments and agencies of the Government to cooperate more effectively in matters involving the national security.

(b) In addition to performing such other functions as the President may direct, for the purpose of more effectively coordinating the policies and functions of the departments and agencies of the Government relating to the national security, it shall, subject to the direction of the President, be the duty of the Council

(1) to assess and appraise the objectives, commitments, and risks of the United States in relation to our actual and potential military power, in the interest of national security, for the purpose of making recommendations to the President in connection there with; and

(2) to consider policies on matters of common interest to the departments and agencies of the Government concerned with the national security, and to make recommendations to the President in connection therewith....

(d) The Council shall, from time to time, make such recommendations, and such other reports to the President as it deems appropriate or as the President may require.¹³

The following officers were designated as members of the NSC: the President; the Secretaries of State, Defense, Army, Navy, and Air Force; and the Chairman of the National Security Resources Board. The President could designate the following officers as members “from time to time”: secretaries of other executive departments and the Chairmen of the Munitions Board and the Research and Development Board. Any further expansion required Senate approval. The NSC was provided with a staff headed by a civilian executive secretary, appointed by the President.

The National Security Act also established the Central Intelligence Agency under the NSC, but the Director of Central Intelligence (DCI) was not designated as an NSC member. The act also created a National Military Establishment, with three executive departments (Army, Navy, and Air Force) under a Secretary of Defense.

Implicit in the provisions of the National Security Act was an assumption that the NSC would have a role in ensuring that the U.S. industrial base would be capable of supporting national security strategies. The Chairman of the National Security Resources Board, set up by the same act to deal directly with industrial base and civilian mobilization issues, was provided a seat on the NSC. Over the years, however, these arrangements proved unsatisfactory and questions of defense mobilization and civil defense were transferred to other federal agencies and the membership of the NSC was limited to the President, Vice President, the Secretary of State, and the Secretary of Defense.¹⁴ Thus, the need for a coordinative entity that had initially been perceived to center on economic mobilization issues during World War I had evolved to one that engaged the more permanent themes of what had come to be known as national security policy.

The creation of the NSC improved past coordinative methods and organization, bringing together as it did the top diplomatic, military, and resource personnel with the President. The addition of

¹³ 50 U.S.C. 402.

¹⁴ More specific information on the history of the transfers of defense mobilization and civil defense authorities may be found in Sections 402 and 404 of *U.S. Code Annotated*, Title 50 (St. Paul, MN: West Publishing Co., 1991).

the CIA, subordinate to the NSC, also provided the necessary intelligence and analyses for the NSC so that it could keep pace with events and trends. The changeable nature of its organization and its designation as an advisory body to the President also meant that the NSC was a malleable organization, to be used as each President saw fit. Thus, its use, internal substructure, and ultimate effect would be directly dependent on the style and wishes of the President.

How Does the National Security Council Function?

According to Title 50, U.S.C. §3021, the National Security Council today has four primary functions:

1. advise the President with respect to the integration of domestic, foreign, and military policies relating to the national security so as to enable the Armed Forces and the other departments and agencies of the U.S. government to cooperate more effectively in matters involving the national security;
2. assess and appraise the objectives, commitments, and risks of the United States in relation to the actual and potential military power of the United States, and make recommendations thereon to the President
3. make recommendations to the President concerning policies on matters of common interest to the departments and agencies of the U.S. government concerned with the national security; and
4. Coordinate, without assuming operational authority, the United States Government response to malign foreign influence operations and campaigns.¹⁵

Since its inception in 1947, the National Security Council, and the institutions that support it, has evolved from a statutorily mandated meeting of Cabinet-level officials into a complex system of coordination, adjudication, and in some instances formulation (as in the case of Dr. Kissinger's tenure as National Security Advisor) of policies among relevant departments and agencies. As a result, when individuals refer to the "NSC," they variously refer to the decisionmaking body created in statute in the 1947 National Security Act, the staff that supports that decisionmaking body, or the processes used by the White House to discuss and adjudicate decisions across different agencies of the executive branch.

- **The National Security Council** is the President's statutory advisory body on matters related to national and international security. Pursuant to Title 50 U.S.C. §3021, the NSC's statutory members are the President, Vice President, Secretary of State, Secretary of Defense, Secretary of the Treasury, and the Secretary of Energy. Other senior officials, including the National Security Advisor, participate in NSC deliberations at the President's request. The Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff and the Director of National Intelligence are the NSC's statutory advisors.¹⁶ The National Security Council is chaired by the President.
- **The National Security Council Staff.** The NSC's activities are coordinated and directed by the Presidentially-appointed National Security Adviser (NSA). They are supported by a National Security Staff (NSS, or NSC staff) comprising permanent employees of the Executive Office of the President and detailees from other government agencies serving temporary assignments. It is organized into

¹⁵ P.L. 115-232 §1043(a)(1).

¹⁶ This "statutory advisor" designation exists to help prevent the politicization of the military and intelligence inputs into the national security decisionmaking process.

offices that focus on a variety of long-term strategic issues and ad hoc working groups that address emerging topics. Each President configures the NSC to address risks to U.S. global security interests according to prescribed policy priorities. The size of the NSC staff and ratio of political appointees to detailees have varied with each Administration. In P.L. 114-328, the National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 2017, Congress limited the number of policy-focused individuals serving on the NSC staff to 200 persons. During the Obama Administration, the Homeland Security Committee and National Security Council staffs were combined into an organization called the National Security Staff.

- **Decisionmaking committees.** Coordinating and managing U.S. national security affairs requires routine coordination and discussion among relevant departments and agencies. Most Administrations have therefore set up a hierarchical system of committees designed to discuss, and when appropriate decide, national security matters. These committees meet as frequently as the White House deems necessary. The design and composition of the committee structure is the prerogative of the President, but the approach has often included some variant of the following:
 - **The Principals Committee (PC)** is a level below the NSC, convened by the National Security Advisor. The PC does not need to include all statutory NSC members, but it generally includes the heads of departments or agencies involved with the subject matter being discussed at a given meeting.
 - **The Deputies Committee (DC)** is convened by the Deputy National Security Advisor, and generally includes the deputy heads of departments (i.e., the Deputy Secretary of Defense or Deputy Secretary of State) involved with the subject matter being discussed at a given meeting.
 - **Interagency Policy Committees (IPCs)** are established by the National Security Advisor in consultation with the Deputies Committee and are responsible for day-to-day management of national security matters on a given region or topic at the Assistant Secretary level from relevant agencies. These are chaired by members of the National Security Staff whose subject matter portfolios are relevant to the issue at hand. Different Administrations have used various titles for these committees; under President Trump, this forum was called the Policy Coordination Committee.

Other Named NSC Positions

There are currently two positions within the National Security Council that were established by Congress:

- **The Special Advisor to the President on International Religious Freedom.** Established P.L. 105-277. According to Title 50 U.S.C., the Special Adviser should “serve as a resource for executive branch officials, compiling and maintaining information on the facts and circumstances of violations of religious freedom (as defined in Section 6402 of title 22), and making policy recommendations. The Special Adviser should serve as liaison with the Ambassador at Large for International Religious Freedom, the United States Commission on International Religious Freedom, Congress and, as advisable,

religious nongovernmental organizations. The position should be comparable to that of a director within the Executive Office of the President.”¹⁷

- **Coordinator for combating malign foreign influence operations and campaigns.** Established in P.L. 115-232 §1043(a)(2). This individual is to be an employee of the National Security and designated by the President as “responsible for the coordination of the interagency process for combating malign foreign influence operations and campaigns” and is required to brief Congress on the responsibilities and activities of the employees no less than twice yearly.

Overall, the NSC and its supporting processes and institutions are designed to be flexible, thereby affording the President maximum latitude to create a security advisory body that suits his unique decisionmaking style. Apart from appropriating the NSC annual budget, Congress has little oversight over the Executive Office of the President, and the National Security Council system in particular, due to the fact that most national security positions within the White House itself (as opposed to the senior levels of Departments and Agencies) are not currently subject to the advice and consent of the Senate. Some observers over the years have argued that the position of National Security Adviser should be subject to Senate confirmation and available to testify before congressional committees, as are officials from other government departments and agencies. Others argue that the President is entitled to confidential advice from his immediate staff.

NSC Functions: Theory vs. Practice

As noted earlier, the 1947 National Security Act established the NSC in order to “advise the President with respect to the integration of domestic, foreign, and military policies relating to the national security so as to enable the military services and the other departments and agencies of the government to cooperate more effectively in matters involving the national security.” Presidents have latitude to structure and use the NSC as they see fit. In practice, the NSC staff’s activities now extend somewhat beyond providing policy advice. First, as one former NSC official notes, “White House involvement is often needed for precise execution of policy, especially when secrecy is required to perform delicate tasks.” Second, the rise in strategic importance of transnational threats such as terrorism and narco-trafficking, along with post-Cold War military campaigns in the Balkans, Iraq, and Afghanistan, has increasingly necessitated “whole of government” responses that leverage diplomatic, military, and development tools from a variety of different U.S. government agencies. The NSC often coordinates such responses, and as the international security environment has become more complex, whole-of-government responses to individual crises have become more frequent, translating into even greater NSC involvement. This expanding role is leading many scholars and practitioners to question the appropriate size, scope and role for the NSC.

NSC Reform?

Currently, two primary schools of thought exist regarding what types of reforms are necessary. One view reflects the U.S. experience during the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan and maintains that interagency coordination issues prevented the United States from consolidating gains after achieving tactical military successes. Greater synchronization and integration of the instruments of national power are required to achieve desired campaign effects. According to this view, much of the needed policy synchronization is now occurring at the NSC rather than at lower levels due

¹⁷ 50 U.S.C. §3021.

to insufficient interagency coordination mechanisms. In the absence of meaningful interagency reform, the size of the NSS has grown in order to help manage U.S. policy in an era of greater complexity and to mitigate policy “immobilization” in the interagency. Under this school of thought, right-sizing and scoping the NSC therefore requires legislation akin to the 1986 Goldwater-Nichols Defense Reform Act, to promote better coordination among executive branch departments (see CRS Report R44474, *Goldwater-Nichols at 30: Defense Reform and Issues for Congress*, by Kathleen J. McInnis).

Others believe that the enlarged NSC staff itself is what drives the organization to take on “operational” roles that are inappropriate, given the NSC’s mandate to help the President formulate strategy and monitor its implementation. These observers point to the fact that the NSC staff in the early 1990s under the George H.W. Bush Administration averaged approximately 50 persons; by contrast, the current NSC comprises between 300-400 people, although during the final years of the Obama Administration, NSA Rice reduced its size by 10%. According to this view, the comparatively large staff (relative to prior Administrations) has resulted in the “micromanagement” of the activities of the Departments in the executive branch, often by relatively junior personnel. Some therefore believe that in order to force the National Security Staff to focus on its core, strategic responsibilities, its size should be limited.

NSC Executive and Congressional Liaison

As part of the Executive Office of the President, the NSC does not have the same relationship with Congress and its committees that the member departments and agencies have. Most briefings on intelligence matters are undertaken by the DNI; information on diplomatic and military matters comes primarily from the Departments of State and Defense. As noted above, the National Security Adviser is not subject to confirmation by the Senate.

Over the years, there have been a considerable number of congressional hearings and reports relating to the NSC. However, many have had to do with topics peculiar to a given period: wiretaps against NSC staff members allegedly ordered by Henry Kissinger, the unauthorized transfer of NSC documents to officials in the Joint Chiefs of Staff, and information on Al Qaeda prior to 9/11. More recently, as part of the 2017 National Defense Authorization Act deliberations, Congress examined the appropriate size of the National Security Council Staff, and whether it was inappropriately “micromanaging” the operations of the departments it oversees.¹⁸

Often annual hearings are held concerning the NSC budget, and occasional hearings have been held concerning NSC organization and procedures. Very few of these hearings and reports have served as briefings for Congress on current issues that the NSC might have been considering. NSC appropriations are handled by the Subcommittees on Financial Services and General Government of the House and Senate Appropriations Committees.

Congress’s role in NSC matters and its relationship with the NSC are limited. As noted above, the Senate does not approve the appointment of the National Security Adviser, although it does confirm statutory NSC members. Congress does have authority over the designation of those positions that are to have statutory NSC membership, as well as budgetary authority over the NSC. In 2007, as part of the Energy Independence and Security Act of 2007 (P.L. 110-140, §932), Congress added the Secretary of Energy to the NSC. However, notwithstanding the legislative provisions enacted as part P.L. 114-328, Congress has little direct say in matters of NSC

¹⁸ S. 2943.

organization, procedure, role, or influence, although a number of hearings on these topics have been held.

The NSC is not a primary and regular source of national security information for Congress. National security information is for the most part provided by those departments and agencies that are represented on the NSC. The NSC, as a corporate entity, rarely testifies before or briefs Congress on substantive questions, although in some Administrations informal briefings have been provided.

Conclusion

The NSC is an organ devoted to the workings of the executive branch in the broad area of national security. Its role is basically that of policy analysis and coordination and, as such, it has been subject to limited oversight and legislative control by Congress. Both in its staff organization and functioning, the NSC is extremely responsive to the preferences and working methods of each President and Administration. It would be difficult to design a uniform NSC structure that would meet the requirements of chief executives, who represent a wide range of backgrounds, work styles, and policy agendas.

Appendix A. Comparative Charts of Individuals Named as Members or Attendees of NSC and/or PC Meetings¹⁹

Table A-1 depicts the membership of the NSC, from the Reagan Administration through the Biden Administration. This report uses the following categories to classify NSC membership:

- **Statutory Members**—positions specifically designated as comprising the NSC by 50 U.S.C. §3021 during the indicated Administration.
- **Statutory Advisors**—positions designated by law as principal advisors to the President, the National Security Council, and the Homeland Security Council during the indicated Administration. Currently, 50 U.S.C. §3023 designates the Director of National Intelligence as the principal adviser to the President, to the National Security Council, and the Homeland Security Council for intelligence matters related to national security. The Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff is designated by 10 U.S.C. §151 as the principal military adviser to the President, the National Security Council, the Homeland Security Council, and the Secretary of Defense.
- **Other Members or Regular Attendees**—positions not statutorily designated as comprising the NSC by 50 U.S.C. §3021 during the indicated Administration, but explicitly identified as a “member” or “regular attendee” of the NSC in the presidential directive establishing the structure and function of the NSC for the indicated Administration.
- **Named Attendees**—positions not statutorily designated as comprising the NSC by 50 U.S.C. §3021 during the indicated Administration, but explicitly identified as an invited or required attendee of the NSC in the presidential directive establishing the structure and function of the NSC for the indicated Administration.
- **Situational Attendees**—positions not statutorily designated as comprising the NSC by 50 U.S.C. §3021 during the indicated Administration, but explicitly identified as an invited or required attendee of the NSC in certain specific circumstances in the presidential directive establishing the structure and function of the NSC for the indicated Administration.

Table A-2 depicts the membership of the PC, from the George H.W. Bush Administration through the Biden Administration.

¹⁹ The author is grateful to Heidi Peters, CRS Research Librarian, who compiled the NSC and PC participation tables.

Table A-1. NSC Membership in Presidential Administrations, as Established by Presidential Directive

Administration	Statutory Members	Statutory Advisers	Other Members or Regular Attendees	Named Attendees	Situational Attendees
Ronald W. Reagan^a	• President • Vice President • Secretary of State • Secretary of Defense	• Director of Central Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chief of Staff	See footnote 21 ²⁰	—	• Heads of other executive departments and agencies^b
George H.W. Bush^c	• President • Vice President • Secretary of State • Secretary of Defense	• Director of Central Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chief of Staff	—	• Chief of Staff to the President • Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (National Security Adviser)	• Secretary of the Treasury^d • Attorney General^e • Heads of other executive departments and agencies, the special statutory advisors to the NSC, and other senior officials^f
William J. Clinton^g	• President • Vice President • Secretary of State • Secretary of Defense	• Director of Central Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chief of Staff	Members— • Secretary of the Treasury • Representative of the United States to the United Nations • Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs • Assistant to the President for Economic Policy • Chief of Staff to the President²¹	—	• Attorney General^h • Heads of other executive departments and agencies, the special statutory advisors to the NSC, and other senior officialsⁱ

²⁰ Note that while Reagan’s NSDD-2 does not explicitly name the Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs as either a member of the NSC or an attendee of NSC meetings, the directive established that the Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs was “responsible for developing, coordinating, and implementing national security policy as approved by” the President; was to “determine and publish the agenda of NSC meetings;” and was to “ensure that the necessary papers are prepared and – except in unusual circumstances – distributed in advance to Council members.” NSDD-2 also established that the Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs was also responsible for preparing decision documents, and for disseminating such documents after approval by the President.

²¹ In presidential directives establishing the structure and function of the NSC, the participation of the Chief of Staff to the President in NSC meetings has differed by

Administration	Statutory Members	Statutory Advisers	Other Members or Regular Attendees	Named Attendees	Situational Attendees
George W. Bushⁱ	• President • Vice President • Secretary of State • Secretary of Defense	• Director of Central Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chief of Staff	Regular attendees— • Secretary of the Treasury • Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs	• Chief of Staff to the President^k • Assistant to the President for Economic Policy^l	• Counsel to the President^m • Attorney Generalⁿ • Director of the Office of Management and Budget^o • Heads of other executive departments and agencies, as well as other senior officials^p

Administration—in some Administrations, the Chief of Staff to the President is specifically designated as a “member” or “regular attendee” of the NSC, while other Administrations have characterized the Chief of Staff to the President as an invited or required attendee at NSC meetings.

Administration	Statutory Members	Statutory Advisers	Other Members or Regular Attendees	Named Attendees	Situational Attendees
Barack Obama^q	• President • Vice President • Secretary of State • Secretary of Defense • Secretary of Energy^r	• Director of National Intelligence^s • Chairman, Joint Chief of Staff	Members— • Secretary of the Treasury • Attorney General • Secretary of Homeland Security • Representative of the United States to the United Nations • Assistant to the President and Chief of Staff (Chief of Staff to the President) • Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (National Security Advisor)	• Counsel to the President^t • Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Advisor^u	When international economic issues were on the NSC agenda^v— • Secretary of Commerce • U.S. Trade Representative • Assistant to the President for Economic Policy • Chair of the Council of Economic Advisers When homeland security or counter-terrorism related issues were on the NSC agenda^w— • Assistant to the President for Homeland Security and Counter-Terrorism When science and technology related issues were on the NSC agenda^w— • Director of the Office of Science and Technology Policy As appropriate^w— • Heads of other executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials

Administration	Statutory Members	Statutory Advisers	Other Members or Regular Attendees	Named Attendees	Situational Attendees
Donald J. Trump^x (NSPM-2)	• President • Vice President • Secretary of State • Secretary of Defense • Secretary of Energy	• Director of National Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chief of Staff	Regular attendees— • Secretary of the Treasury • Attorney General • Secretary of Homeland Security • Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (National Security Advisor) • Assistant to the President for Homeland Security (Homeland Security Advisor) • Representative of the United States to the United Nations	• Assistant to the President and Chief of Staff (Chief of Staff to the President)^y • Assistant to the President and Chief Strategist^y • Counsel to the President^y • Deputy Counsel to the President for National Security Affairs^y • Director of the Office of Management and Budget^y	• Heads of executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials^z When international economic issues were on the NSC agenda— • Secretary of Commerce • U.S. Trade Representative • Assistant to the President for Economic Policy
Donald J. Trump^{aa} (NSPM-4)	• President • Vice President • Secretary of State • Secretary of Defense • Secretary of Energy	• Director of National Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chief of Staff	Regular attendees— • Secretary of the Treasury • Attorney General • Secretary of Homeland Security • Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (National Security Advisor) • Assistant to the President for Homeland Security (Homeland Security Advisor) • Representative of the United States to the United Nations • Director, Central Intelligence Agency (added in NSPM-4)	• Assistant to the President and Chief of Staff (Chief of Staff to the President)^{bb} • Counsel to the President^{bb} • Deputy Counsel to the President for National Security Affairs^{bb} • Director of the Office of Management and Budget^{bb} • <i>Assistant to the President and Chief Strategist (removed in NSPM-4)</i>	• Heads of executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials^{cc} When international economic issues are on the NSC agenda— • Secretary of Commerce • U.S. Trade Representative • Assistant to the President for Economic Policy

Joseph R. Biden

- President
 - Vice President
 - Secretary of State
 - Secretary of Defense
 - Secretary of Energy
 - Secretary of the Treasury
 - Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff
 - Director of National Intelligence
 - Attorney General,
 - Secretary of Homeland Security
 - Representative of the United States of America to the United Nations
 - Assistant to the President and Chief of Staff (Chief of Staff to the President)
 - Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (National Security Advisor)
 - Assistant to the President and Director of the Office of Science and Technology Policy (OSTP Director)
 - Administrator, the United States Agency for International Development
 - Director of the Central Intelligence Agency (in advisory capacity)
 - Counsel to the President
 - Deputy Counsel to the President
 - NSC Legal Advisor (NSC Legal Advisor).
 - The Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Advisor (serving as Secretary)
 - Secretary of Commerce
 - Secretary of Labor
 - Secretary of Health and Human Services
 - Administrator of the Environmental Protection Agency
 - Director of the Office of Management and Budget
 - United States Trade Representative
 - National Cyber Director
 - Assistant to the President for Economic Policy
 - Assistant to the President for Domestic Policy
 - Chairman of the Council of Economic Advisers
 - Assistant to the President for Homeland Security and Deputy National Security Advisor (Homeland Security Advisor)
 - Deputy Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Advisor for Cybersecurity and Emerging Technologies (Deputy National Security Advisor for Cybersecurity)
 - Deputy Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Advisor for International Economics (Deputy National Security Advisor
-

Administration	Statutory Members	Statutory Advisers	Other Members or Regular Attendees	Named Attendees	Situational Attendees
					for International Economics) • COVID-19 Response Coordinator • Special Presidential Envoy for Climate. • Heads of other executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials, as appropriate.

Sources: National Security Decision Directive-2 (1982); National Security Directive-1 (1989); Presidential Decision Directive/NSC-2 (1993); National Security Presidential Directive-1 (2001); Presidential Policy Directive-1 (2009); National Security Presidential Memorandum-2 (January 2017); and National Security Presidential Memorandum-4 (April 2017).

- a. As established by National Security Decision Directive (NSDD)-2, “National Security Council Structure,” January 12, 1982.
- b. NSDD2 established that the heads of Departments and Agencies that were not “regular members” would participate in NSC meetings as appropriate, “when matters affecting their Departments or Agencies are concerned.”
- c. As established by National Security Directive (NSD)-1, “Organization of the National Security Council System,” January 30, 1989.
- d. NSD-1 established that the Secretary of the Treasury would “normally” attend NSC meetings, “except that on occasions when the subject matter so indicates, he will not be asked to attend.”
- e. NSD-1 established that the Attorney General would attend “meetings pertaining to his jurisdiction, including covert actions.”
- f. NSD-1 established that the President intended to “invite the heads of other Executive departments and agencies, the special statutory advisors to the NSC, and other senior officials to attend meetings of the NSC where appropriate in light of the issues to be discussed.”
- g. As established by Presidential Decision Directive (PDD)/NSC-2, “Organization of the National Security Council,” January 29, 1993.
- h. PDD/NSC-2 established that the Attorney General would be “invited to attend meetings pertaining to his jurisdiction, including covert actions.”
- i. PDD/NSC-2 established that the heads of “other Executive departments and agencies, the special statutory advisors to the NSC, and other senior officials shall be invited to attend meetings of the NSC where appropriate.”
- j. As established by National Security Presidential Directive (NSPD)-1, “Organization of the National Security Council System,” February 13, 2001.
- k. As established by NSPD-1, the Chief of Staff to the President was “invited to attend any NSC meeting.”
- l. NSPD-1 established that the Assistant to the President for Economic Policy was “invited to attend any NSC meeting.”
- m. As established by NSPD 1, the Counsel to the President was to be “consulted regarding the agenda of NSC meetings,” and was to “attend any meeting when, in consultation with the Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs, he deems it appropriate.”

- n. As established by NSPD-1, the Attorney General was to be “invited to attend meetings pertaining to [his or her] responsibilities,” which was to include “those matters within the Justice Department’s jurisdiction and those matters implicating the Attorney General’s responsibility under 28 U.S.C. §511 to give his advice and opinion on questions of law when required by the President.”
- o. NSPD-1 established that the Director of the Office of Management and Budget was to be “invited to attend meetings pertaining to [his or her] responsibilities.”
- p. As established by NSPD-1, the “heads of other executive departments and agencies, as well as other senior officials,” were to be “invited to attend meetings of the NSC when appropriate.”
- q. As established by Presidential Policy Directive (PPD)-1, “Organization of the National Security Council System,” February 13, 2009.
- r. In December 2007, P.L. 110-140 (codified at 50 U.S.C. §3021(a)) added the Secretary of Energy to the statutory members of the NSC.
- s. In December 2004, P.L. 108-458 (Intelligence Reform and Terrorism Prevention Act of 2004, or IRTPA) abolished the position of Director of Central Intelligence (DCI), replacing the position with a new Director of National Intelligence (DNI). The DCI position was created by President Truman in 1946 (by presidential letter), prior to passage of the National Security Act of 1947 (P.L. 80-253). Provisions in the act authorized a “triple-hatted” arrangement in which the DCI simultaneously served as community manager for the intelligence community, Director of the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) and chief intelligence adviser to the President. IRTPA divided the DCI’s three major responsibilities between two new positions—the Director of the CIA (DCIA) and DNI—making the new DNI community manager and principal adviser to the President, and leaving leadership of the CIA to the DCIA.
- t. PPD-1 established that the Counsel to the President “shall be invited to attend every NSC meeting.”
- u. PPD-1 established that the Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Adviser “shall attend every meeting” of the NSC and would serve as Secretary.
- v. As established by PPD-1, the NSC’s “regular attendees” would include the named positions when related issues were on the NSC agenda.
- w. As established by PPD-1, the heads of other executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials, were to be “invited to attend meetings of the NSC as appropriate.”
- x. As established by National Security Presidential Memorandum (NSPM)-2, “Organization of the National Security Council and the Homeland Security Council,” January 28, 2017.
- y. As established by NSPM-2, the Assistant to the President and Chief of Staff; the Assistant to the President and Chief Strategist; the Counsel to the President; the Deputy Counsel to the President for National Security Affairs; and the Director of the Office of Management and Budget are “invited as attendees to any NSC meeting.”
- z. As established by NSPM-2, “invitations to participate in specific” NSC meetings are to be “extended to those heads of executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials, who are needed to address the issue or issues under consideration.”
- aa. As established by National Security Presidential Memorandum (NSPM)-4, “Organization of the National Security Council, the Homeland Security Council, and Subcommittees,” April 4, 2017.
- bb. As established by NSPM-4, the Assistant to the President and Chief of Staff; the Counsel to the President; the Deputy Counsel to the President for National Security Affairs; and the Director of the Office of Management and Budget are “invited as attendees to any NSC meeting.”
- cc. As established by NSPM-4, “invitations to participate in specific” NSC meetings are to be “extended to those heads of executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials, who are needed to address the issue or issues under consideration.”
- dd. As established in National Security Memorandum-2, “Memorandum on Renewing the National Security Council System,” February 4, 2021.

**Table A-2. NSC Principals Committee (PC) Membership in Prior Presidential Administrations,
as Established by Presidential Directive**

Administration	Regular Attendees	Other Participants	Situational Participants
George H.W. Bush^a	• Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (Chair of the PC) • Secretary of State • Secretary of Defense • Director of Central Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff	—	• Secretary of the Treasury—governed by guidelines for participation in NSC meetings, which established that Secretary of the Treasury would “normally” attend NSC meetings, “except that on occasions when the subject matter so indicates, he will not be asked to attend.” • Attorney General—governed by guidelines for participation in NSC meetings, which established that the Attorney General would attend “meetings pertaining to his jurisdiction, including covert actions.” • Heads of other executive departments and agencies, the special statutory advisors to the NSC, and other senior officials—when invited by the Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs, in consultation with the Secretary of State and the Secretary of Defense, where appropriate in light of the issues to be discussed.
William J. Clinton^b	• Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (Chair of the PC) • Secretary of State (if unavailable, the Deputy Secretary of State or the designee of the Secretary of State) • Secretary of Defense (if unavailable, the Deputy Secretary of Defense or the designee of the Secretary of Defense) • Representative of the United States to the United Nations • Director of Central Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff	• Assistant to the President for Economic Policy—“as appropriate.”	• Secretary of the Treasury—“invited as needed.” • Attorney General—“invited as needed.” • Heads of other executive departments and agencies—“invited as needed.”

Administration	Regular Attendees	Other Participants	Situational Participants
George W. Bush^c	- Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (Chair of the PC) - Secretary of State - Secretary of the Treasury - Secretary of Defense - Chief of Staff to the President	- Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Adviser (PC Executive Secretary)—to attend “all meetings” of the PC. - Chief of Staff to the Vice President—to attend “all meetings” of the PC. - National Security Adviser to the Vice President—to attend “all meetings” of the PC.	- Director of Central Intelligence—to attend “where issues pertaining to [his or her] responsibilities and expertise are to be discussed.” - Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff—to attend “where issues pertaining to [his or her] responsibilities and expertise are to be discussed.” - Attorney General—to be invited to attend meetings “pertaining to [his or her] responsibilities,” including both those “matters within the Justice Department’s jurisdiction and those matters implicating the Attorney General’s responsibility under 28 U.S.C. §511 to give his advice and opinion on questions of law when required by the President.” - Director of the Office of Management and Budget—to be invited to attend meetings “pertaining to [his or her] responsibilities.” - Counsel to the President—to be consulted regarding the agenda of the PC, and to attend “any meeting when, in consultation with the Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs, he deems it appropriate.” When international economic issues were on the PC agenda, the PC’s regular attendees included— - Secretary of Commerce - U.S. Trade Representative - Assistant to the President for Economic Policy (Chair for agenda items that principally pertained to international economics) - Chair of the Council of Economic Advisers - Secretary of Agriculture—when the “issues pertain to her responsibilities”
Barack H. Obama^d	- Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (Chair of the PC) - Secretary of State - Secretary of the Treasury	- Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Advisor—to be “invited to attend every meeting” of the PC. - Deputy Secretary of State—to be “invited to attend every meeting” of the PC.	When international economic issues were on the PC agenda, the PC’s regular attendees included— - Secretary of Commerce - U.S. Trade Representative

Administration	Regular Attendees	Other Participants	Situational Participants
	• Secretary of Defense • Attorney General • Secretary of Energy • Secretary of Homeland Security • Director of the Office of Management and Budget • Representative of the United States to the United Nations • Director of National Intelligence • Chairman, Joint Chief of Staff	• Counsel to the President—to be “invited to attend every meeting” of the PC. • Assistant to the Vice President for National Security Affairs—to be “invited to attend every meeting” of the PC.	• Assistant to the President for Economic Policy (who, at the discretion of the National Security Advisor, served as Chair) • Chair of the Council of Economic Advisers When homeland security or counter-terrorism related issues were on the PC agenda, the PC’s regular attendees included— • Assistant to the President for Homeland Security and Counter-Terrorism (who, at the discretion of the National Security Advisor, served as Chair) When science and technology related issues were on the PC agenda, the PC’s regular attendees included— • Director of the Office of Science and Technology Policy Invited as appropriate— • Heads of other executive departments and agencies, and additional senior officials
Donald J. Trump^e (NSPM-2)	• Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (Chair of the PC) • Secretary of State • Secretary of the Treasury • Secretary of Defense • Attorney General • Secretary of Homeland Security • Assistant to the President and Chief of Staff • Assistant to the President and Chief Strategist • Homeland Security Advisor	• Counsel to the President—“may attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Deputy Counsel to the President for National Security Affairs—“may attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Director, Office of Management and Budget—“may attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Advisor—“shall attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Deputy Assistant to the President and National Security Adviser to the Vice President—“shall attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Executive Secretary (Executive Secretary of the PC)—“shall attend all [meetings]” of the PC.	• Director of National Intelligence—to attend “where issues pertaining to [his or her] responsibilities and expertise are to be discussed.” • Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff—to attend “where issues pertaining to [his or her] responsibilities and expertise are to be discussed.” • Representative of the United States to the United Nations—“may attend as appropriate.” • Assistant to the President for Intragovernmental and Technology Initiatives—“may attend as appropriate.” • Cabinet-level heads of executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials—“who are needed to address the issue under consideration.”

Administration	Regular Attendees	Other Participants	Situational Participants
Donald J. Trump^f (NSPM-4)	• Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs (Chair of the PC) • Secretary of State • Secretary of the Treasury • Secretary of Defense • Attorney General • Secretary of Homeland Security • Assistant to the President and Chief of Staff • Representative of the United States to the United Nations • Homeland Security Adviser (Chair, as and when directed by the National Security Advisor) • Secretary of Energy (Added in NSPM-4) • Director of National Intelligence (Added in NSPM-4) • Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff (Added in NSPM-4) • Director of the Central Intelligence Agency (Added in NSPM-4) • <i>Assistant to the President and Chief Strategist (Removed in NSPM-4)</i>	• Counsel to the President—“may attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Deputy Counsel to the President for National Security Affairs—“may attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Director, Office of Management and Budget—“may attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Assistant to the President and Deputy National Security Advisor—“shall attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Deputy Assistant to the President and National Security Adviser to the Vice President—“shall attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Executive Secretary (Executive Secretary of the PC)—“shall attend all [meetings]” of the PC. • Deputy National Security Adviser for Strategy (Added in NSPM-4)—“shall attend all [meetings]” of the PC.	• Cabinet-level heads of executive departments and agencies, and other senior officials—“who are needed to address the issue under consideration.” • Assistant to the President for Intragovernmental and Technology Initiatives—“may attend as appropriate.” When international economic issues were on the PC agenda, the PC’s regular attendees included (Added in NSPM-4)— • Secretary of Commerce • U.S. Trade Representative • Assistant to the President for Economic Policy (who serves as Chair for agenda items that principally pertain to international economics)
Joseph R. Biden^g	• The National Security Advisor (serving as chair) • Secretary of State • Secretary of the Treasury • Secretary of Defense • Attorney General • Secretary of Energy • Secretary of Homeland Security • Director of the Office of Management and Budget	• Director of National Intelligence (in an advisory capacity) • Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff (in an advisory capacity) • Director of the Central Intelligence Agency (in an advisory capacity) • Principal Deputy National Security Advisor • Counsel to the President • NSC Legal Advisor	• Secretary of Labor • Secretary of Commerce • Secretary of Health and Human Services, • Administrator of the Environmental Protection Agency • United States Trade Representative • National Cyber Director • Assistant to the President for Economic Policy • Chairman of the Council of Economic Advisers • Assistant to the President for Domestic Policy • OSTP Director

Administration	Regular Attendees	Other Participants	Situational Participants
	• Representative of the United States of America to the United Nations • Administrator of the United States Agency for International Development • Chief of Staff to the President.	• National Security Advisor to the Vice President	• Deputy National Security Advisor for Cybersecurity • Deputy National Security Advisor for International Economics • COVID-19 Response Coordinator • Special Presidential Envoy for Climate • Homeland Security Advisor, who, at the discretion of the National Security Advisor, may serve as Chair (when homeland security-related issues are on the agenda) • Heads of other executive departments and agencies, along with additional senior officials, shall be invited as appropriate

Sources: National Security Directive-1 (1989); Presidential Decision Directive/NSC-2 (1993); National Security Presidential Directive-1 (2001); Presidential Policy Directive-1 (2009); National Security Presidential Memorandum-2 (January 2017); and National Security Presidential Memorandum-4 (April 2017).

- a. As established by National Security Directive (NSD) 1, "Organization of the National Security Council System," January 30, 1989.
- b. As established by Presidential Decision Directive (PDD)/NSC 2, "Organization of the National Security Council," January 29, 1993.
- c. As established by National Security Presidential Directive (NSPD) 1, "Organization of the National Security Council System," February 13, 2001.
- d. As established by Presidential Policy Directive (PPD) 1, "Organization of the National Security Council System," February 13, 2009.
- e. As established by National Security Presidential Memorandum (NSPM)-2, "Organization of the National Security Council and the Homeland Security Council," January 28, 2017.
- f. As established by National Security Presidential Memorandum (NSPM)-4, "Organization of the National Security Council, the Homeland Security Council, and Subcommittees," April 4, 2017.
- g. As established in National Security Memorandum-2, "Memorandum on Renewing the National Security Council System," February 4, 2021.

Appendix B. As Established in National Security Memorandum-2, “Memorandum on Renewing the National Security Council System,” February 4, 2021, National Security Advisers, 1953-Present

Robert Cutler	March 23, 1953	April 2, 1955
Dillon Anderson	April 2, 1955	September 1, 1956
Robert Cutler	January 7, 1957	June 24, 1958
Gordon Gray	June 24, 1958	January 13, 1961
McGeorge Bundy	January 20, 1961	February 28, 1966
Walt W. Rostow	April 1, 1966	January 20, 1969
Henry A. Kissinger	January 20, 1969	November 3, 1975
Brent Scowcroft	November 3, 1975	January 20, 1977
Zbigniew Brzezinski	January 20, 1977	January 21, 1981
Richard V. Allen	January 21, 1981	January 4, 1982
William P. Clark	January 4, 1982	October 17, 1983
Robert C. McFarlane	October 17, 1983	December 4, 1985
John M. Poindexter	December 4, 1985	November 25, 1986
Frank C. Carlucci	December 2, 1986	November 23, 1987
Colin L. Powell	November 23, 1987	January 20, 1989
Brent Scowcroft	January 20, 1989	January 20, 1993
W. Anthony Lake	January 20, 1993	March 14, 1997
Samuel R. Berger	March 14, 1997	January 20, 2001
Condoleezza Rice	January 22, 2001	January 25, 2005
Stephen Hadley	January 26, 2005	January 20, 2009
James L. Jones	January 20, 2009	October 8, 2010
Thomas E. Donilon	October 8, 2010	July 1, 2013
Susan E. Rice	July 1, 2013	January 20, 2017
Michael T. Flynn	January 20, 2017	February 14, 2017
LTG H.R. McMaster	February 20, 2017	April 9, 2018
John Bolton	April 9, 2018	September 10, 2018
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Dr. Valbona Zeneli, Marshall Center's professor of National Security Studies, talks about "Crime and Corruption," August 12, 2016, during Program on Countering Transnational Organized Crime (George C. Marshall European Center for Security Studies/Christine June)

Putting the "FIL" into "DIME"

Growing Joint Understanding of the Instruments of Power

By Cesar Augusto Rodriguez, Timothy Charles Walton, and Hyong Chu

Despite how long the DIME has been used for describing the instruments of national power, U.S. policymakers and strategists have long understood that there are many more instruments involved in national security policy development and implementation.

—JOINT DOCTRINE NOTE 1-18, *STRATEGY*

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While the U.S. military tends to view the instruments of power (IOPs) strictly through the lens of the diplomatic, informa-

tional, military, and economic (DIME) framework, it is increasingly imperative to consider additional IOPs such as finance, intelligence, and law enforcement (FIL). The U.S. military focuses primarily on the kinetic employment of the military, prioritizing the big *M* to demonstrate power, destroy the enemy, and celebrate victory. This military-centric approach often neglects other IOPs, resulting in suboptimal use of resources, the creation of an echo chamber, and poor transitions to other organizations, agencies, and/or national governments. The emergence of a new strategic environment necessitates an orchestration of multiple instruments of power. As a result, it is perhaps time to transition from a DIME to DIME-FIL concept.

U.S. peer competitors, namely Russia and China, have already developed alternative concepts to leverage IOPs to compete below the threshold of conflict. For example, Russia conceptualizes political warfare using nonmilitary and above-military categories (political, network, economic, financial, intelligence, legal, cultural, propaganda, drug, and so forth), which are similar to the DIME-FIL IOPs while continuing to emphasize the military instrument.¹ As peer competitors develop such fluid and threshold-based gray zone concepts, the United States must adapt in order to compete in a changing threat environment. To succeed, commanders and their staffs will need to understand, select, and synchronize IOPs to ensure a whole-of-government and international approach to these problem sets.

Currently, doctrine and planning emphasize the DIME model.² The scant literature on IOPs mentions the addition of FIL, but the focus has been its application to combating terrorism. The first mention of FIL pertaining to the National Security Strategy was in 2003, in a document that called for defeating terrorism through the direct and indirect use of DIME-FIL IOPs.³ Subsequently, similar language appeared in the 2006 National Military Strategic Plan for the war on terror and focused on cooperation among U.S. agencies, coalitions,

and partners to “integrate all instruments of U.S. and partner national power . . . DIME-FIL.”⁴

U.S. strategic direction and joint doctrine state the importance of synchronizing and incorporating a whole-of-government approach in order to utilize all IOPs for unity of effort. The Joint Force 2020 concept of globally integrated operations argues for a transregional, all-domain, and multifunctional approach and urges the joint force to prepare for the future competitive security environment by leveraging Service capabilities.⁵ However, this approach ignores the necessity of incorporating interagency and global partners and capabilities. Thus, a more strategic global integration concept is vital in today’s environment. *Global integration* is defined by Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Instruction 3100.01D and the *Summary of the 2018 National Defense Strategy of the United States of America* as “the arrangement of cohesive joint force actions in time, space, and purpose, executed as a whole to address transregional, multifunctional challenges across all domains through the seamless integration of multiple elements of national power—diplomacy, information, economics, finance, intelligence, law enforcement and military.”⁶ The concept addresses the importance of a unified effort across all elements of national power and could provide a framework to incorporate global integration for the commander and planners to truly leverage all government agencies’ strengths, achieve military objectives, and ultimately protect national interests.

However, there is little explicit information on the new IOPs and even less guidance regarding the potential application of a more granular conception of IOPs in a competitive environment. Failing to clarify or ignoring the DIME-FIL concept leads to a lack of synchronization and global integration in the whole-of-government approach. Therefore, U.S. military leadership should consider adding the FIL IOPs to the DIME construct and incorporating it into joint doctrine to improve interorganizational planning for an international and intergovernmental approach in

the new environment of Great Power competition.

Clarifying the definition of FIL IOPs, identifying key mission partners, and detecting potential applications for each of the new FIL instruments can mitigate the gap in doctrine and planning. An increased understanding of the FIL IOPs will allow the U.S. military to update doctrine, synchronize the IOPs, become more globally integrated, and perform in the competitive environment, ultimately achieving unity of effort and effectively protecting national interests.

Understanding the FIL Instruments

Financial. The financial IOP was born during the war on terror, as the United States sought to disrupt and dismantle global terrorist financial networks. The National Security Strategy for Combatting Terrorism identified the importance of affecting financial systems used by terrorist organizations that support their survival and continued operations.⁷ In relation to violent extremist organizations (VEOs), the financial IOP is characterized as the specific means by which insurgents acquire and distribute capital, whether via formal or informal banking and monetary exchange systems.⁸ The routine use, success, and precision of the financial IOP over the past two decades prove that it is an essential addition to DIME. Although the focus of the financial IOP has been on the VEO threat, it could be expanded to address other threats and actors including transnational crime organizations, state proxy groups, nonstate actors, and states. Generally, the financial instrument should be understood as the denial of access to specified individuals or groups from a formal or informal financial system, network, or source of funding.

At first glance, the financial and economic IOPs appear similar; however, they are fundamentally different in scope, enabling instruments, and associated activities. The economic IOP is used at the political level to influence the behavior of another state or organization.⁹ This is normally achieved through foreign aid, trade agreements, tariffs, embargos, or



Air battle manager with 16th Airborne Command and Control Squadron monitors radar system on E-8 Joint STARS aircraft flying off coast of Florida, July 14, 2018 (U.S. Air Force/Marianique Santos)

economic sanctions. These actions tend to be broader in scope and political in nature as they impact entire nations. As a result, the economic instrument relies on the diplomatic instrument to carry out these actions.

The financial IOP relies heavily on the Department of the Treasury, in close cooperation with banks, corporations, organizations, and international partners, in order to protect U.S. financial systems, combat adversary actors, administer sanctions, and freeze assets. Treasury wields a significant amount of power through the USA PATRIOT Act, requiring foreign banks to establish a contact for receiving subpoenas, scrutinize deposits from residents of nations that do not cooperate with U.S. officials, and impose sanctions on banks that do not provide information to law enforcement agencies.¹⁰ Through the PATRIOT Act and the Banks Secrecy Act, Treasury's Financial

Crimes Enforcement Network requires financial institutions, as of May 2018, to know their customer and perform customer due diligence to ensure customers are not involved in illegal activity and to cooperate with government agencies to detect and prevent money laundering.¹¹ Leveraging key mission partners enables the U.S. Government to prevent or deny access to financial systems to those actors that threaten national interests.

The financial IOP tends to be more agile in nature as it can specifically target countries, organizations, companies, and individuals utilizing banking systems to project power. A disruption of funding for a target entity can be achieved through compelling private banking institutions to deny currency loans or credit; blacklisting individuals, corporations, or states; utilizing financial sanctions; or freezing assets.¹² Disruptions are made possible because of U.S. worldwide

dominance in the financial sector. In 2014, the U.S. dollar was involved in 87 percent of the world's foreign exchange transactions, proof of its ability to influence financial institutions to comply.¹³ The intelligence IOP often pairs with the financial to detect and contain, and then the financial IOP deters and disrupts target adversary individuals or groups. The financial and intelligence IOPs are closely linked, delivering more precise effects related to financial systems and funding, whereas the economic IOP is tied to the diplomatic IOP, broader in scope and related to interstate commerce.

The benefit and relevance of the financial IOP is its precision. When targeting specific actors, the United States can achieve desired effects by focusing on critical vulnerabilities and capabilities without suffering second- and third-order effects caused by the economic IOP. This in turn can reduce the suffering of the



Afghan and coalition security force members conceal themselves in field during operation in search of Taliban facilitator in Sayyid Karam District, Paktia Province, Afghanistan, June 5, 2013 (U.S. Army/Codie Mendenhall)

population and improve U.S. legitimacy and credibility. The focus of the financial IOP has historically been VEOs, but it applies to all problem sets. In 2017, the United States targeted North Korea's ability to generate funds by potentially "suspending U.S. correspondent account access to any foreign bank that knowingly conducts or facilitates significant transactions tied to trade with North Korea or certain designated persons."¹⁴ In 2018, the restoration of sanctions on Iran targeted financial institutions, companies, and individuals tied to Iran's shipping, financial, and energy sectors, resulting in 700 additional companies and individuals on the sanction rolls, causing concern from the Iranian public and flaming potential unrest toward the regime.¹⁵

After the Ukraine conflict, the Office of Foreign Assistance Control created a blacklist to paralyze the financial dealings of a Russian billionaire friendly to the Kremlin, blocking transactions and payments from his bank by JPMorgan Chase, Visa, and MasterCard at a Russian embassy in Kazakhstan.¹⁶ In an attempt to halt Chinese global

investment, mergers to steal intellectual property, technology, and sensitive data, the Trump administration recently expanded the power of the Committee on Foreign Investment in the United States. National security reviews now include transactions in which a foreign investment was merely a minority interest instead of a controlling share and extend review powers into the real estate sector. Similarly, citing national security concerns, Australia, Canada, the European Union, France, Germany, Japan, and the United Kingdom have all joined an unprecedented global backlash against Chinese capital. Although many U.S. peer competitors tend to have nationalized industries, they must participate in the global market in order to be profitable, thus making them vulnerable to exploitation via the financial IOP. In turn, the use of these actions can result in slowing peer expansion and protecting U.S. national interests.

Intelligence. The multifaceted nature of intelligence makes it difficult to define. However, intelligence can be broadly broken down into three parts:

activities, products, and organizations. The organizations participate in the activities of "collection, processing, integration, analysis, and interpretation of available information" of hostile or potentially hostile forces that result in intelligence products.¹⁷ Activities are often associated with processes (such as the Joint Intelligence Preparation of the Operational Environment process, the targeting process, the intelligence process, etc.), as well as intelligence disciplines.¹⁸ The products are typically intelligence estimates and assessments that are often broken down into categories and could be in the form of written documents or verbal presentations, hard-copy publications, or electronic media.¹⁹ Organizations can be broken down into Department of Defense (DOD) agencies, other national agencies, foreign agencies, host-nation or local sources, and corporations. According to Craig Mastapeter in his Naval Postgraduate School thesis, "The intelligence instrument, or element, of national power integrates foreign, military, and domestic capabilities through policy, personnel, and technology

actions to provide decision advantage to policymakers, diplomats, financiers and economists, strategic communicators, warfighters, homeland security officials, and law enforcement.”²⁰ A more succinct and functional definition of the intelligence IOP that corresponds to both the joint concept and Mastapeter’s definition is the products, interdisciplinary activities, and organizations that convert disparate data about the environment, future capabilities and intentions, and relevant actors into coherent information to provide decision advantage for decisionmakers, both policymakers and commanders.

The term *intelligence* is often confused by operators and planners with the term *information*. Fortunately, the recent designation of information as a new joint function helped to shed some clarity on the difference in terms. As with all instruments of power, there is overlap, but the major difference is in the purpose, players, audience, and activities involved in each instrument. The focus of the intelligence IOP is the production of value-added data for the commander or decisionmaker to make informed decisions. Distinctly, the focus of the information IOP is to affect decision-making in the cognitive, informational, and physical dimensions of the target audience—whether friendly, neutral, or adversary—to create a desired effect.²¹ For example, the intelligence IOP may provide the critical information necessary for the commander to make a decision whereas the information IOP would help to create a desired effect in the target audience. Ultimately, the intelligence IOP provides decision advantage, and the information IOP is meant to influence a target audience.

The intelligence IOP involves many mission partners, all with varying and important missions articulated in the following categories: national agencies, allied partners and agencies, host-nation resources, and private sources. The U.S. Government has 17 national agencies with different mission sets utilized for intelligence-sharing and cooperation. Allied partners provide partnerships for intelligence-sharing and verification. Partner nations assist with local intelligence, while

the private sector provides independent investigation and analysis.

Access, speed, insight, the ability for direct action, and cover for U.S. interests are the advantages of utilizing mission partners outside of the United States.²² Commanders, however, must be judicious in their use of the foreign intelligence and host-nation and private-sector entities due to the disadvantages of conflicting interests, hostile collection, poor information gathering, and moral hazards.²³

It is vital to refocus U.S. intelligence efforts from the VEO threat to peer competition with Russia and China. Since 9/11, the reorganization of U.S. intelligence agencies has proved vital in disrupting terrorist and criminal organizations. To dismantle the VEO and criminal networks and neutralize high-value individuals, the U.S. Government and military have focused intelligence at the operational and tactical level for the past 20 years, relying heavily on intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance; dynamic targeting; and nodal analysis. The National Intelligence Council’s *Global Trends Report* indicates that the blurring of peacetime and wartime, the ease of disruption caused by nonstate groups, increase in standoff and remote attack capabilities, and new concerns about nuclear weapons and weapons of mass destruction are shaping conflicts that are more “diffuse,” “diverse,” and “disruptive.”²⁴ The 2019 National Intelligence Strategy provides some guidelines on the trends and focus areas such as strategic intelligence, anticipatory intelligence, current operations intelligence, and cyber threat intelligence.²⁵

The United States will need to harness the intelligence instrument to meet the new environment. Indications and warning intelligence as well as counter-intelligence will be critical to enable U.S. military and information instruments. Intelligence will need to emphasize attribution to identify criminal cyber and proxy actors that enable financial and law enforcement instruments to act. Data superiority and managing artificial intelligence and machine learning will

be necessary to navigate the sea of big data and to select and combine data in useful ways for decisionmaking. Finally, information-sharing between agencies and partnerships with external agencies and nations will be paramount to optimize intelligence activities, make faster decisions, and create unity of effort with mission partners.

Law Enforcement. Under the current DIME construct, the diplomatic and military IOPs’ legal efforts are not sufficient and are extremely complex. As a result, a separate IOP is necessary. The law enforcement IOP is challenging to define because it has two parts (legal and enforcement); encompasses the political, strategic, operational, and tactical levels; operates through other IOPs;²⁶ and relies heavily on national, international, foreign state, and local partners and organizations. Unlike other IOPs, the legal IOP is complex, incredibly diverse, and rapidly changing over short periods of time. A functional definition of the *law enforcement IOP* is the understanding and adherence to national, international, and local laws and the activities to support or carry out the enforcement of those laws and thereby restore order.

The *law* portion of law enforcement pertains to the legal expertise required to understand national law, international law, and foreign laws. This aspect is more strategic in nature and requires synchronization with the diplomatic instrument to avoid missteps in international and host-nation legal systems, carefully balancing the laws and interests of all national, international, and foreign entities. The *enforcement* aspect requires law enforcement agencies to work closely via the diplomatic IOP with data from the intelligence IOP to prosecute crimes and conduct activities at the tactical level through the military IOP or local law enforcement.

There are many key mission partners involved with the law enforcement IOP that include national, international, and foreign legal departments and law enforcement agencies.

The key U.S. organizations for the legal aspect are the Department of State and Department of Justice, which

provide legal expertise for national and international law while working with partner-nation justice departments to achieve an understanding of key legal issues. U.S. agencies, regional agencies, intergovernmental organizations, and host-nation partners are critical to enforcing laws and protecting the population. Through the diplomatic, intelligence, and financial IOPs, the law enforcement IOP is able to balance enforcing U.S. national laws and sovereignty with adhering to international law to maintain legitimacy while proactively detaining criminals to protect U.S. citizens and assist mission partners with their security needs.

A key U.S. strength is its alliances and leadership in the international system. U.S. competitors seek to attack partnerships, use the international system to slow actions, and delegitimize efforts across the globe. U.S. military legal expertise should broaden to international law and be incorporated into planning (not just law of armed conflict and rules of engagement). Commanders should also incorporate legal expertise from State or Justice into planning. Commanders could improve U.S. legitimacy with strategic communication, clarifying the message that the United States wants to enable countries to establish their own rules of law and improve their security and stability. Additionally, peer competitors increasingly use proxy, cyber, and criminal actors. International law and international law enforcement are key capabilities for defeating terrorist and adversary networks that span multiple national boundaries. It is therefore critical to reinforce whole-of-government, international, and interorganizational partnering to quickly identify, locate, and detain criminals anywhere on the globe, shortening our observe-orient-decide-act loop compared to our competitors and communicating attribution while defending U.S. national interests. The law enforcement IOP is crucial to achieving legitimacy by balancing national, international, and foreign law with national interests and partnering with local law enforcement entities to achieve unity of effort and accomplish objectives.

Recommendations: Putting the FIL into DIME

The DIME construct is overused and outmatched in our current environment. In order to perform in the competitive environment and navigate the gray zone, a full understanding of all IOPs is necessary. A more polished understanding of the new FIL IOPs is required to achieve unity of effort. In order to address the gap in understanding the FIL IOPs, it is critical to define concepts, incorporate them into doctrine, identify the appropriate mission partners, and apply DIME-FIL to the competitive environment. The following recommendations will improve the understanding and implementation of the DIME-FIL framework and allow the U.S. military to address the global problem sets, ultimately achieving unity of effort and effectively protecting national interests.

Update Joint Doctrine with DIME-FIL. The acronym *DIME-FIL* is colloquially being used in the joint lexicon, but the term has not been specifically defined or included in doctrine. Definitions provide the foundation for a common understanding of concepts and terms. The preliminary definitions addressed for the finance, intelligence, and law enforcement instruments provide a solid starting point to incorporate and update joint doctrine related to strategy, concepts, and planning. A clear definition can assist in the understanding, application, and synchronization of the IOPs for unity of effort in a competitive environment. Some logical publications to address the gap by defining, explaining, or listing the FIL IOPs are Joint Doctrine Note 1-18, *Strategy*; Joint Publication (JP) 1, *Doctrine for the Armed Forces of the United States*; JP 3-08, *Interorganizational Cooperation*; and the *Joint Concept for Integrated Campaigning*.

Identify the Mission Partners Involved with Each Instrument and Incorporate Them Early and Often in Planning. Planners and commanders are tasked with implementing the concept of global integration and executing different types of missions across the

spectrum that will be transnational, all domain, and multifunctional, so agility is key. Each line of effort will require a distinct and harmonious combination of the IOPs. Having a solid understanding of the key mission partners and their strengths across the DIME-FIL will enable commanders and planners to develop more creative plans that share the mission, tasks, and successes through a whole-of-government, international, and interorganizational approach. Incorporating partners early into planning will garner mutual trust and buy-in from partners who have a better understanding of their particular instruments. The U.S. military has more resources and planning experience compared to other agencies and partners, which provide a tremendous opportunity to coordinate, synchronize, and harmonize the instruments and subsequently the mission partners involved.

Train and Plan with DIME-FIL for Near-Peer Threats. Training should not be singularly focused on the big *M* and conventional warfare. Opening the aperture and adding more instruments of power to the U.S. lexicon signal that warfare has changed and that all instruments and partners are necessary for success. Planning should seriously consider harmonizing DIME-FIL, whole-of-government, and interorganizational concepts in the U.S. peer competition environment to compete in the gray zone and address U.S. problem sets. The DIME-FIL concept is a natural progression to a globally integrated approach that could be achieved through incorporating the key mission partners of all instruments in interorganizational exercises, the global campaign plan, and stability operations planning. These instruments should focus on creating effects on adversary critical capabilities and vulnerabilities, many of which will not be military in nature. Some key themes that may help us in the new environment are partnerships, strategic messaging, legitimacy, information sharing, decision advantage, technology, attribution, and tempo.

Additional IOPs have been identified, along with key mission partners,



Coalition-aligned security force Maghawair al-Thowra seize \$3.5 million in illicit drugs, including nearly 850,000 regional amphetamine Captagon pills, used to fund so-called Islamic State operations, in southern Syria, October 23, 2019 (U.S. Army/Kyle Alvarez)

that have the potential to result in better resource utilization, diversity of thought, and smoother transitions. It is the responsibility of planners and commanders to synchronize the instruments and create a more strategic globally integrated approach. The current doctrinal approach stymies the understanding of new IOPs, leaving commanders with plans that result in a limited conceptualization, a lack of creativity, and an echo chamber of DIME-centric operational approaches. By defining each of the FIL instruments, identifying key mission partners, and determining its application in the near-peer environment, commanders and planners are able to achieve understanding and apply the DIME-FIL framework to their way of thinking and approaching complex problem sets. The key aspect of the financial instrument is the denial of access to financial systems, mainly through

the Treasury Department, providing precision effects and denying adversaries access to financial systems. The intelligence instrument delivers decision advantage through activities, products, and organizations, mainly through national and international intelligence agencies, enabling value-added data for the rest of the IOPs. The two-pronged law enforcement instrument focuses on adherence to and enforcement of laws mainly through State and Justice, as well as DOD, granting the United States authority and legitimacy to take action and enabling the United States to detain criminals and restore order.

The “America First” strategy relies on U.S. partners to do more, which requires joint planners and commanders to leverage all resources, capabilities, and instruments in a concerted effort to achieve a more safe, stable, and secure world. The increased understanding

of the FIL IOPs allows the joint community to update doctrine, synchronize, and involve mission partners early in planning and perform in the competitive environment, ultimately achieving unity of effort and effectively protecting national interests. The DIME-FIL concept lends legitimacy to the U.S. cause and utilizes global integration to synchronize efforts, compete, and win in the strategic environment. JFQ

Notes

¹ Katerina Oskarrson and Robin Barnett, “The Effectiveness of DIMEFIL Instruments of Power in the Gray Zone,” *Open Publications* 1, no. 2 (2017), 8.

² Joint Doctrine Note 1-18, *Strategy* (Washington, DC: The Joint Staff, 2018), available at <https://fas.org/irp/doddir/dod/jdn1_18.pdf>; Joint Publication (JP) 1, *Doctrine for the Armed Forces of the United States*

(Washington, DC: The Joint Staff, March, 2013), available at <www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp1_ch1.pdf>; JP 5-0, *Joint Planning* (Washington, DC, The Joint Staff, 2013), available at <www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp5_0_20171606.pdf>; JP 2-0, *Joint Intelligence* (Washington, DC: The Joint Staff, 2013), available at <www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp2_0.pdf>.

³ *National Strategy for Combatting Terrorism* (Washington, DC: The White House, 2003), 15, available at <https://fas.org/irp/threat/ctstrategy.pdf>.

⁴ *Military Strategic Plan for the Global War on Terrorism* (Washington, DC: The Joint Staff, February 1, 2006), 6, available at <https://archive.defense.gov/pubs/pdfs/2006-01-25-Strategic-Plan.pdf>.

⁵ *Capstone Concept for Joint Operations: Joint Force 2020* (Washington, DC: The Joint Staff, September 10, 2012), 4, available at <www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/concepts/ccjo_jointforce2020.pdf?ver=2017-12-28-162037-167>.

⁶ Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Instruction 3100.01D, *Joint Strategic Planning System* (Washington, DC: The Joint Staff, July 20, 2018), A-1, available at <www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Library/Instructions/CJCSI%203100.01D.pdf?ver=2018-08-10-143143-823>; *Summary of the 2018 National Defense Strategy of the United States of America: Sharpening the American Military's Edge* (Washington, DC: Department of Defense, 2018), 4, available at <https://dod.defense.gov/Portals/1/Documents/pubs/2018-National-Defense-Strategy-Summary.pdf>.

⁷ Financial systems can include formal banking, informal systems, online value storage transfer systems, or cash couriers. See *National Strategy for Combatting Terrorism*, 15.

⁸ Carl Priecheufried, "Untying Our Hands: Untying Cyber as an Instrument of National Power," Master's thesis, Joint Advanced Warfighting School, 2017, available at <www.hsdl.org/?abstract&did=805121>.

⁹ The relationship with the state or organization could be adversarial, neutral, or friendly.

¹⁰ *Uniting and Strengthening America by Providing Appropriate Tools Required to Intercept and Obstruct Terrorism (USA PATRIOT) Act*, Pub. L. No. 107-56, 107th Cong., October 26, 2001, available at <www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/PLAW-107publ56/pdf/PLAW-107publ56.pdf>.

¹¹ "Customer Due Diligence Requirements for Financial Institutions; Final Rule," *Federal Register* 81, no. 91 (May 11, 2016), available at <www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/FR-2016-05-11/pdf/2016-10567.pdf>; Financial Crimes Enforcement Network (FinCEN), "Fincen's Mandate from Congress," n.d., available at <www.fincen.gov/resources/statutes-regulations>.

¹² Craig W. Mastapeter, "The Instruments

Joint Publications (JPs) Under Revision (to be signed within 6 months)

JP 1-0, *Personnel Support*

JP 2-0, *Joint Intelligence*

JP 3-0, *Joint Operations*

JP 3-05, *Special Operations*

JP 3-26, *Combating Terrorism*

JP X-XX, *Joint Electromagnetic Spectrum Operations*

JPs Revised (signed within last 6 months)

JP 1, *Doctrine for the Armed Forces of the United States, Vols. 1 and 2*

JP 3-31, *Joint Land Operations*

JP 3-40, *Countering WMD*

JP 5-0, *Joint Planning*

JP 6-0, *Joint Communications System*

of National Power: Achieving the Strategic Advantage in a Changing World," Master's thesis, Naval Postgraduate School, 2008, 237–240.

¹³ Leah McGrath Goodman and Lynley Browning, "The Art of Financial Warfare: How the West Is Pushing Putin's Buttons," *Newsweek*, April 24, 2014, available at <www.newsweek.com/2014/05/02/art-financial-warfare-how-west-pushing-putins-buttons-248424.html>.

¹⁴ Ankit Panda, "Trump Administration Introduces New Executive Order on North Korea Sanctions," *The Diplomat*, September 22, 2017, available at <https://thediplomat.com/2017/09/trump-administration-introduces-new-executive-order-on-north-korea-sanctions/>.

¹⁵ "Restored U.S. Sanctions on Iran Cover Shipping, Financial, and Energy Sectors," CBS News, November 4, 2018, available at <www.cbsnews.com/news/restored-u-s-sanctions-on-iran-cover-shipping-financial-and-energy-sectors-2018-11-03/>.

¹⁶ Goodman and Browning, "The Art of Financial Warfare."

¹⁷ JP 2-0, GL-8.

¹⁸ This includes all of the intelligence disciplines—geospatial, human, signals, measurement and signature, and so forth.

¹⁹ Some example categories include warning intelligence, current intelligence, target intelligence, estimative intelligence, counterintelligence, and so forth.

²⁰ Mastapeter, "The Instruments of National Power," 228.

²¹ JP 3-13, *Information Operations* (Washington, DC: The Joint Staff, November 27, 2012, Incorporating Change 1, November 20,

2014), available at <www.jcs.mil/Portals/36/Documents/Doctrine/pubs/jp3_13.pdf>. Summarized on page x and detailed in entire publication.

²² Erik Rosenbach and Aki J. Peritz, "Intelligence and International Cooperation," Belfer Center for Science and International Affairs, July 2009, available at <www.belfercenter.org/publication/intelligence-and-international-cooperation>.

²³ Ibid.

²⁴ *Global Trends: Paradox of Progress* (Washington, DC: National Intelligence Council, January 2017), 215–221, available at <www.dni.gov/files/documents/nic/GT-Full-Report.pdf>.

²⁵ *National Intelligence Strategy of the United States of America* (Washington, DC: Office of the Director of National Intelligence, 2019), available at <www.dni.gov/files/ODNI/documents/National_Intelligence_Strategy_2019.pdf>.

²⁶ The diplomatic, intelligence, and military instruments enable the law enforcement instruments of power.

STATEMENT OF
GENERAL CHARLES Q. BROWN, JR., USAF
21ST CHAIRMAN OF THE JOINT CHIEFS OF STAFF
DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE BUDGET HEARING
9 APRIL 2024

OVERVIEW

I am honored to represent our dedicated Joint Force, Department of Defense civilians, and their families who are focused on ensuring and supporting our national security. I thank Congress for your support and collective commitment to addressing our most pressing national security challenges. The Joint Force acknowledges and appreciates the diligent efforts of our Congressional members in securing the vital resources necessary to train, equip, and maintain our readiness, while also modernizing to prepare for the future.

The President's \$849.8 billion defense budget for Fiscal Year (FY) 2025 reflects our shared commitment to facing today's security challenges head-on, while also laying the groundwork to confront the uncertainties of tomorrow. This budget includes targeted program reductions to meet funding levels approved by Congress under the Fiscal Responsibility Act of 2023. Under these caps, this budget prioritizes Joint Force readiness and taking care of our people while reducing programs that will deliver future combat capability in the 2030s.

The 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS) identifies the evolving security challenges that the Department must address to safeguard our national interests. Implementing the NDS requires the Joint Force address these challenges while simultaneously accelerating modernization to maintain our strategic advantages. This budget resources our strategy and enables the Joint Force to invest in capabilities to remain the most capable military force in the world for decades to come. The NDS articulates four key priorities essential to our national security:

- Defending the homeland, paced to the growing multi-domain threat posed by the People's Republic of China (PRC)
- Deterring strategic attacks against the United States, Allies, and partners
- Deterring aggression, while being prepared to prevail in conflict when necessary
- Building a resilient Joint Force and defense ecosystem

The NDS makes it clear that the PRC remains our pacing challenge and "our most consequential strategic competitor for the coming decades." The PRC is the only state with the intent as well as the economic, diplomatic, military, and technological power to reshape its region and the global order. The Joint Force will focus efforts on addressing our pacing challenge while simultaneously preparing for and responding to the acute Russian threat and the challenges posed by North Korea, Iran, and Violent Extremist Organizations (VEOs).

This budget is threat-informed and built to ensure that our strategic planning, resource distribution, and capability development are responsive to current challenges as well as future threats. Through aligning this budget with the strategic and operational landscape, the Joint Force is postured to remain versatile, resilient, and capable to protect the American people, our prosperity, and our way of life.

Each branch and component of our Armed Forces plays a pivotal role in supporting and upholding these priorities. The connections from this budget request to the NDS, National Military Strategy (NMS), and the Joint Warfighting Concept (JWC) are clear and deliberate. The JWC, informed by the current threat environment, has linkages to our resource allocation and requirement planning processes.

The current strategic environment requires that our force continue to advance and adapt to the changing character of war. We must always be prepared to fight and win our Nation's next war. Our current strategic advantage gives us confidence against any adversary. We must continue to strengthen our national security and our warfighting advantage because our competitors and adversaries have not stopped advancing their capabilities.

I am confident in our Joint Force. Our Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen, Marines, Guardians, and civilian teammates form the most capable fighting force in the world—bar none. In my 2 October 2023, *Message to the Joint Force*, I articulated my expectations for the Joint Force:

- **Honing our warfighting skill has primacy in all we do**
- **Modernizing and aggressively leading with new concepts and approaches**
- **Trust is the foundation of our profession**

The Joint Force can only remain the world's most capable force if it is supported by the necessary resources to organize, train, equip, exercise, and employ the Total Force. We can only accomplish our mission and maintain our advantage with stable, predictable, and timely budgets. By passing an on-time budget, Congress enables the Department to execute our strategy with a full-year appropriation. We are challenged to implement our strategy and stay ahead of our pacing challenge when we are not resourced with an on-time full-year appropriation and funding is delayed due to another Continuing Resolution.

Our service members and their families sacrifice for our Nation and we owe them the tools they need to be successful in a dynamic, evolving strategic environment.

STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENT

The global security environment is extremely complex. The international order and its principles of sovereignty, democracy, and rule of law have underpinned global security for almost 80 years. Today, this system is under threat. The NDS identifies five key challenges that threaten U.S. national interests and our way of life: the PRC, Russia, North Korea, Iran, and VEOs. All five of these challenges are currently active at the same time and in some cases working together.

I have served as the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff for more than 6 months and during this time, each of our NDS challenges have confronted our defense and security goals. The PRC continues to undertake coercive and risky military behavior in the South China Sea, across the Indo-Pacific, and around the globe. Russia's unprovoked war of aggression in Ukraine has entered its third year seeking to overthrow a sovereign neighbor that posed no

threat. Iran sponsors and supports militia groups and terrorist activity threatening regional stability and U.S. forces. North Korea continues to test ballistic missiles and technology while also transferring ballistic missiles to Russia in direct violation of multiple United Nations Security Council resolutions. VEO activities around the globe spread violence, sow terror, and cause unnecessary suffering. These actors work to exploit perceived gaps in U.S. military might, seeking to expand their influence and challenge the global order.

Today's current global strategic environment requires the Joint Force to both address the pacing challenge of the PRC and focus efforts on the rest of the globe. We can and will do both.

People's Republic of China: The PRC's increasingly aggressive military actions in the South China Sea; actions to assist Russia, North Korea, and Iran; and increasing economic influence around the globe threaten to destabilize the global security environment. The PRC continues to expand military capabilities across multiple domains. We are entering a decisive decade where the PRC is challenging the future of the international order and the United's States' place in the world.

Though the Joint Force focuses on being ready for conflict, our goal is to deter and stay in competition. On 21 December 2023, I held a video teleconference with my PRC counterpart to discuss the importance of responsibly managing competition and avoiding miscalculations. Communication lines have reopened with the PRC across various levels across the U.S. Government, engaging in substantive dialogue which can reduce the likelihood of misunderstandings and inadvertent escalations.

Russia: Russia's war in Ukraine not only threatens European stability but also aims to undermine the global order to benefit its interests. The international community's support for Ukraine has been pivotal, emphasizing the global commitment to sovereignty and deterring future aggression around the world. Russia's focus on expanding and modernizing its nuclear arsenal further complicates the global security dynamic.

North Korea: North Korea's advancing nuclear program threatens U.S. interests and regional stability. Its ongoing and increasingly aggressive ballistic missile research and testing represent a threat to our homeland and to our Allies and partners in the Indo-Pacific. Additionally, recent information has indicated that North Korea provided Russia with ballistic missile launchers and ballistic missiles, which is a notable and concerning escalation in North Korean support for Russia.

Iran: Iran-backed militia groups have used the HAMAS terrorist attacks of 7 October 2023 to increase attacks on U.S. forces in Syria, Iraq, the Red Sea, and across the region. Iran's support for and involvement in these attacks contributes to larger regional instability. Additionally, Iranian aid has enabled the Houthis to initiate a campaign of missile attacks, since November 2023, against commercial ships in the Red Sea. Iran is also taking actions to improve its missile forces and continues to retain programs that would enable nuclear

weapon production. Finally, Iran provides support to Russia's aggression and continues to operate across the gray zone with coercive and malign activities.

Violent Extremist Organizations: Against the backdrop of these state actors, VEOs continue to sow terror and instability, with recent escalations further threatening regional peace. On 7 October 2023, HAMAS conducted a heinous and brutal attack on the people of Israel. The U.S. remains committed to supporting Israel's right to defend itself while actions to protect and provide humanitarian aid to the civilians in Gaza must increase. The threat landscape is further complicated by transnational extremist organizations such as ISIS, Al Qaeda, and others across Europe, Africa, the Middle East, and the Indo-Pacific. Despite experiencing significant setbacks, these groups persist in their violent campaigns, leveraging instability to expand their presence, manipulate populations, and disseminate radical ideologies.

The interconnectedness of these challenges necessitates a strategic approach that addresses the immediate threats while also preparing for future contingencies. The U.S. and its Allies must navigate this complex environment with a combination of military readiness, diplomatic engagement, and a commitment to the principles that have historically underpinned global order.

WARFIGHTING

Our military exists to fight and win our Nation's wars. That is why I'm adamant, honing our warfighting skill has primacy in all we do. We train and prepare every day to ensure we are so good at what we do, that we deter any adversary from engaging the U.S. in conflict. The FY 2025 budget will enable our force to train across the full spectrum of operations at varied levels of scope, scale, and complexity. The Joint Force works to implement the NDS through campaigning by linking together training, exercises, and activities to reach our defined objectives. This budget enables the necessary investments to carry out our Joint Force's crucial work and to do so with tactical and technical proficiency.

First and foremost, our service members are expected to master the warfighting skills of their individual service. Our service members must focus on being an adversary's worst nightmare in a fight. As the tactical expert in each domain of warfare, our service members are then required to integrate individual mission areas into a cohesive fighting force. With the changing character of war, future conflicts will be fought across all warfighting domains – land, sea, air, space, and information. Therefore, eliminating gaps and seams in Joint Force readiness will be a priority. This requires proper resourcing for training aides, employment ranges, and equipment to be able to practice like we fight across events from daily training evolutions to fully integrated high fidelity international exercises. This budget requests \$147 billion to sustain readiness and ensure the Department can counter near-term threats and prevail in long-term strategic competition.

In addition, any future armed conflict will be fought alongside Allies and partners, necessitating our Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen, Marines, and Guardians be able to integrate across the joint and combined force. My expectation is that America's service members are

able to execute tactically while also understanding the larger operational context and geostrategic environment in which they operate.

Finally, our service members understand that the United States military is only one component of our whole of government efforts to support and protect our interests in the global order. The U.S. must act with one end goal in mind and holistically bring together all our elements of national power.

Allies and Partners: The United States has an incredible network of Allies and partners with whom we integrate to achieve our security objectives. We can better leverage their contributions and capabilities by building them into our plans from the beginning. We cannot expect success when we focus on building U.S.-only capability and then adding on Allies and partners at the end. We must start at the beginning with the end in mind and account for our Allies and partners earlier in our planning, requirement, and acquisition processes. The FY 2025 budget will enable the Joint Force to plan, train, and exercise alongside our Allies and partners worldwide. It will also enable further research, development, and testing for joint capabilities and the integration of partner capabilities to collectively address global security challenges. Our Allies and partners are a powerful force multiplier and are crucial for our continued security.

Working together as a combined force enhances our capabilities immensely, demonstrated by the collective effort of Allies and partners around the world in delivering more than \$88 billion in security assistance to Ukraine since Russia's invasion in 2022. This security assistance has not only supported Ukraine, but it has also reaffirmed our resolve to work with our Allies and partners around the world as closely as ever. We have strengthened NATO, enhanced and recommitted our support to Israel and Taiwan against regional threats, and advanced efforts in the tri-lateral security partnership between Australia, the United Kingdom, and the U.S (AUKUS). This budget includes \$2.9 billion for the European Deterrence Initiative and \$9.9 billion for the Pacific Deterrence Initiative. This will fund capabilities to expand security cooperation with Allies and partners across Europe and the Indo-Pacific, ballistic missile defense activities in support of Guam, improved infrastructure, exercises, training, and experimentation activities. The \$4.0 billion for the submarine industrial base will strengthen the health and capacity of the submarine force and further advances AUKUS. In our globally interconnected world, relationships matter. None matter more than our close-knit ties with our Allies and partners.

During my more than 6 months in this job, I have had more than 145 engagements with my counterparts from around the world. My engagements have revalidated a well-known fact. U.S. leadership is wanted, needed, and watched. U.S. efforts are a catalyst for change—what we do drives action.

MODERNIZATION AND NEW CONCEPTS

Our Nation needs us to both be ready to fight today's battles and prepare for tomorrow's wars. We must prepare by modernizing and aggressively leading with new concepts and approaches. The JWC provides a framework for how the Joint Force will modernize and how

we will fight in a future conflict. The JWC guides the Department's future force development, design, and warfighting approach to ensure we have the right people, equipment, training, roles, and doctrine to deter and if necessary, win in a future conflict. We must modernize our force, through innovation and by building a bridge to the defense industry to deliver capability in a timely manner.

As we work to shorten the timeline between prototype and program of record, there is growing importance for collaboration between the Services and our industry partners to deliver at scale, develop training programs, and provide required sustainment so our warfighters can operationalize the delivered capabilities. With rapidly evolving threats and technologies, accelerating our modernization is crucial. Our adversaries are advancing quickly, and it is imperative that we equip our Joint Force with the most advanced tools and capabilities available.

Readiness and modernization depend upon consistent on-time, full year appropriations. We thank Congress for passing FY 2024 appropriations and we will work with Congress to deliver on-time appropriations for FY 2025. Continuing Resolutions of any length have long lasting impacts on the Joint Force. They significantly impact and degrade our ability to defend the United States. They slow progress, prevent new starts of programs, and delay our force modernization efforts. They damage our relationships with the defense industrial base, eroding trust and driving up costs as industry hedges against funding inconsistency. We have operated under Continuing Resolutions for 14 of the last 15 years, totaling 5 years' worth of lost time. Time we cannot get back.

Force Modernization: We continue the execution of several programs essential to Joint Force modernization, focusing on advanced platforms, long-range fires, and uncrewed systems. The Department continues to invest in capabilities and effects to outpace our competitors while divesting costly legacy platforms that no longer best meet our needs. While these choices may be challenging, they are crucial for directing resources towards the optimal mix of programs to fill the portfolio of requirements essential for our security.

In the FY 2025 budget, \$167.5 billion is strategically allocated towards procurement, solidifying our commitment to equip the Joint Force with unparalleled combat capabilities across every domain. Our air power will be elevated through a fleet of advanced fighter aircraft, the B-21 bomber, and tanker aircraft. Our sea power is strengthened with the construction of six battle force ships as well as the continued production of Ford-class aircraft carriers and Columbia ballistic missile submarines. Our combat force in the land domain will be modernized and reinforced with the most advanced equipment available including the Armored Multi-Purpose Vehicle, Amphibious Combat Vehicle, and the XM30 Combat Vehicle. This budget also includes significant development in uncrewed and autonomous systems to expand reach, access, and payload for operations across all domains. Together, these systems along with advanced weapons will challenge, target, and neutralize adversary capabilities while also affirming our technological edge in an era of strategic competition.

Additionally, this budget significantly advances our long-range fires capabilities with \$9.8 billion for the development and procurement of multi-domain hypersonic weapons and the improvement of long-range survivable subsonic weapon systems. These strategic investments ensure our Joint Force maintains a decisive edge in delivering precise strikes over vast distances to outpace emerging threats and support future warfighting concepts.

Across all domains, we continue to invest in the capabilities and technologies that will position the Joint Force to meet the pacing challenge of the PRC and the acute threat of a newly aggressive Russia. Furthermore, the Joint Force recognizes the importance of the space and cyber domains and is focused on those areas promising the largest return on investment in the near-term, such as space domain awareness, space command and control, space resiliency, cyber security, and the Cyber Mission Force. The \$143.2 billion FY 2025 budget request for research, development, test, and evaluation will enable the Department to develop the technology, innovative capabilities, and modernized approaches for the Joint Force to gain and exploit positions of advantage.

Nuclear Modernization: In alignment with our overarching strategy for Joint Force modernization, the FY 2025 budget underscores our commitment to the comprehensive recapitalization of our Nation's strategic deterrent. This deterrent not only protects the United States but also many Allies who depend on extended deterrence and assurance. We are in the midst of a generational change, undertaking the modernization of all three legs of the nuclear triad simultaneously with the development of the sea-based Columbia-class submarine, the airborne B-21 bomber aircraft, and the land-based Sentinel Intercontinental Ballistic Missile (ICBM). These systems will form the backbone of our Joint Force's ability to maintain a safe, secure, effective, and credible nuclear deterrent. Concurrently, we are enhancing and modernizing our Nuclear Command, Control, and Communications (NC3) systems to ensure they remain secure and reliable amidst evolving threats.

This concerted effort in nuclear modernization is foundational, enabling the broader strategic capabilities that underpin our national defense. It fortifies our extended deterrence commitments, amplifying the strength and cohesion of our global alliances and partnerships. A modernized, safe, secure, and effective nuclear triad provides an outsized return on investment to assure our Allies, deter aggression, and preserve our national security.

Our investment in nuclear capabilities reflects a judicious balance between advancing cutting-edge technologies and phasing out legacy capabilities. Nuclear modernization is a critical component of our strategy, ensuring the Joint Force remains equipped to navigate the complexities of modern warfare and emerging global threats.

Digital Innovation: The Joint Force is also advancing our digital modernization, acknowledging decision advantage will be a key offset in future conflicts. The Joint Force remains committed to realizing a fully capable Combined Joint All Domain Command and Control (CJADC2) environment and leveraging initiatives being demonstrated today in our Global Information Dominance Experiments (GIDE). A modernized and technologically advanced Joint Force will communicate seamlessly across platforms in all domains. This will

ensure we quickly identify viable paths capable of delivering command and decision dominance. CJADC2 will enhance warfighting readiness through improved access to and the interoperability of joint data at the strategic, operational, and tactical levels. This budget requests over \$1.3 billion to develop and improve our CJADC2 capabilities.

With investments in digital innovation, from command and control to modeling and simulation, digital modernization can improve all Department work, advance intelligence collection, streamline processes, and enable better data-informed decision making. The FY 2025 budget prioritizes artificial intelligence (AI), investing \$1.8 billion in research, development, test, and evaluation funds and in operations and maintenance funds, highlighting the strategic importance of AI to our Joint Force for both the near- and long-term.

Additionally, this budget allocates \$14.5 billion for cyberspace activities, supporting the Joint Force's defensive and offensive cyberspace operations capabilities and cyber strategy. This funding will enable the Joint Force to move at the pace of technology. Investments and relationships help the Joint Force accelerate software and technology production to scale ideas and move from concept to combat capability.

Munitions: This budget sends a strong signal to the defense industrial base through \$29.8 billion for munitions and the use of multi-year procurement authorities for critical munitions. Russia's war in Ukraine and Israel's operations in Gaza highlight the strategic nature of how munitions stockpiles directly impact battlefield operations. Producing advanced munitions can take years and depends on complex production lines with a skilled workforce that cannot be started overnight. To ensure the Joint Force is prepared for challenges around the globe, we must build out robust production capacity to stay ahead of need to address any emerging crisis. This budget continues to strengthen the defense industrial base and will support several investments to improve its capacity to meet current and future demands.

This budget prioritizes addressing our pacing challenge, the PRC, with procurement of the most relevant munitions—long-range cruise missiles, anti-ship missiles, surface-to-air missiles, torpedoes, and air-to-air missiles. The Joint Force takes a holistic approach to ensure we have the optimal balance of capabilities and capacity including hypersonic as well as subsonic, survivable, and large payload weapons. We continually manage and assess our stockpiles and procurement to ensure we have the munitions that our warfighters need.

Expanded multi-year procurement authorities for critical munitions will continue to enable us to deepen our inventories and decrease operational risk. Multi-year procurement authorities are essential to proactively address challenges with complex supply chains, long lead-time components, obsolescence, workforce shortages, and infrastructure shortfalls that must be overcome. These authorities directly support the capabilities we need to execute our strategy while managing and mitigating risks during crisis and conflict.

Defense Industrial Base: A strong and robust defense industrial base including logistical systems and global supply chains will enable the production of technologies and capabilities critical for our national defense. To fully modernize the Joint Force, we must provide a

consistent demand signal to the defense industrial base through clearly articulated priorities and resourcing. Doing so activates the defense industrial base to expand capabilities and capacity helping to enable contract performance and on-time deliveries.

This budget allocates investments towards revitalizing and expanding the defense industrial base, ensuring it is prepared to meet production demands required for current and future operations. Over \$8 billion is requested to fund several key defense industrial base sectors, including \$375 million for microelectronics, \$369 million for castings and forgings, \$193 million for strategic and critical materials, \$243 million for kinetic capabilities, \$3 million for energy storage and batteries, \$125 million for bio-manufacturing, \$4.0 billion for the submarine industrial base, and a \$112 million investment into a skilled industrial workforce. A strong and robust defense industrial base contributes to deterrence and provides a foundation for surging in the event of crises or conflicts.

TRUST

Trust is the foundation of our profession. The Joint Force must build upon and uphold the trust in each other, the trust with our families, the trust of our elected leaders, and the trust of our Nation. I am proud to lead a Joint Force that continually demonstrates dedication to the oaths we took to serve our Nation and to the professional standards expected by our Nation and its leaders. We strive every day to reinforce the trust placed in us, by the American people, to safeguard our country's values and interests.

Our Joint Force leaders have a responsibility to foster a cohesive environment where every service member has the opportunity to reach their full potential. I am committed to removing barriers to success, such as any type of discrimination, harassment, or assault, especially sexual harassment and sexual assault. The profession of arms is based on trust. We must maintain that trust by serving with integrity and professionalism.

Force Development: Our Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen, Marines, Guardians, civilians, and their families are the Joint Force's asymmetric advantage against our adversaries. Technology and capabilities are important, but the mission cannot be accomplished without a professional, organized, and trained Joint Force. The proposed budget includes strategic investments in critical areas such as advanced training programs, health and wellness initiatives, and career development opportunities to ensure our forces are not only prepared but also thriving. This includes improved pay to reflect the dedication and risks undertaken by our service members, enhanced healthcare services, and continued educational benefits for them and their families. We also remain committed to supporting spouse employment initiatives, career guidance, and licensure reimbursement. These investments are a clear signal of our unwavering commitment to maintaining the readiness and resilience of our forces.

Quality of Service and Quality of Life: Our service members and their families sacrifice a great deal for our Nation. It is our obligation, as leaders, to take care of them and ensure their success. Our Quality of Service efforts support and enable our service members by providing them the means and capability to hone their warfighting skills and to be ready when the

Nation calls. Our Quality of Life investments support our service members when they are outside of work and takes care of their families.

I am committed to improving Quality of Service and Quality of Life, through proper force development initiatives mentioned above, various housing initiatives, improved childcare programs, enhanced mental health resources, and robust programs to combat sexual harassment and sexual assault. The FY 2025 budget dedicates \$1.2 billion to sexual assault prevention and response efforts, including building a full-time workforce of over 2,500 dedicated prevention personnel. We remain committed to suicide prevention and this budget allocates \$547 million to reinforce and expand suicide prevention strategies, ensuring every service member feels supported in seeking help. Additionally, this budget includes \$2.3 billion for construction of barracks, dormitories, medical clinics, and childcare facilities as well as another \$2.0 billion for family housing construction and operations to ensure we have quality facilities for our service members and their families. It is our duty to provide our service members and families with comprehensive support and resources for their well-being and success.

Recruiting and Retention: We must provide the right capabilities, training, and education to recruit and retain a talented workforce. To be as effective as possible on the battlefield, we must leverage the strengths of everyone on our Joint Team. While the Services continue to encounter a challenging, but improving recruiting environment, retention remains high, indicating that our people are finding fulfillment and meaning as they proudly serve their Nation. We can make an impact on recruiting by engaging with the public. Only one percent of our society has served in the military and much of our society is not as connected to the Armed Forces as they once were. Our Joint Force and our veterans have an obligation to engage in their communities, providing an important connection between our military and the society that we serve. Whether in uniform or in some other capacity, we all have the responsibility to inspire the next generation to serve to the benefit of our Nation and our security.

CONCLUSION

Our Joint Force is the most capable and lethal fighting force in the world, and they will defend, deter, and if necessary, fight and win our Nation's wars. They are ready to respond to the myriad of challenges that currently exist across the globe. Our military strength is a crucial element of our national security, and it is most effective when used in concert with the full spectrum of our national power.

The PRC continues its expansion of its military, pursues increasingly aggressive actions in the Indo-Pacific region, and threatens the international order. Russia remains an acute threat as it seeks to impose its imperial order and expand its sphere of influence. Continued unrest in the Middle East also represents a challenge to our Joint Force, as we withstand and respond to attacks against our forces.

The FY 2025 budget ensures that the Joint Force can effectively address these challenges and all our NDS priorities. I thank Congress for its continued support and partnership in our

shared mission to defend our Nation, protect our citizens, and preserve our way of life. This budget request is not just a financial document; it is a clear statement of NDS implementation and our collective resolve to face the challenges of today and prepare for those of tomorrow. It is a commitment to our service members and their families, ensuring they have the tools, training, and support necessary to succeed. Given the convergence of the five NDS challenges, our Joint Force depends on long-term, stable, predictable, and timely funding. We are living in a consequential time. There is no time to waste.

Department of the Air Force Posture Statement

Fiscal Year 2025

**Department of the Air Force
Presentation to the Committees
and Subcommittees of the
United States Senate
and the House of Representatives
2nd Session, 118th Congress**



**Statement of:
The Honorable Frank Kendall
Secretary of the Air Force**

**General B. Chance Saltzman
Chief of Space Operations, United States Space Force**

**General David W. Allvin
Chief of Staff, United States Air Force**

OVERVIEW

The President's Fiscal Year 2025 (FY25) budget request continues the Department of the Air Force's (DAF) implementation of the 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS), while striking alignment with the 2023 Fiscal Responsibility Act (FRA). The DAF remains focused on the Department of Defense's mission to defend the U.S. homeland, safeguard and advance vital U.S. national security interests, and meet growing threats to a stable and open international system, especially those posed by our pacing challenge, the People's Republic of China (PRC) and the Chinese Communist Party. In line with the priorities of the Secretary of Defense, this budget request supports that **mission** and invests in the **people** and **teams** that are our decisive advantage.

The DAF is currently undertaking a Department-wide effort to optimize how we organize, train, and equip the Air Force and Space Force to meet the PRC pacing challenge. These efforts are necessary for us to remain competitive and are being undertaken with a strong sense of urgency. They cannot, however, substitute for the resources the DAF needs to execute its missions.

The total DAF budget request for FY25 is \$217.5B which includes \$188.1B for the Air Force and \$29.4B for the Space Force. This is an approximate 1.5% increase from the DAF FY24 enacted budget. The DAF had to implement some difficult tradeoffs and take risk in certain areas to stay within the funding levels provided under the FRA.

A forced reliance on funding through Continuing Resolutions has already significantly hampered the DAF's ability to keep pace with evolving threats by withholding authorization and appropriations to initiate new programs of record or increase spending on existing programs. Unfortunately, the time we have ceded cannot be recovered. Timely and consistent authorizations and appropriations for defense spending in line with this budget request are necessary to deter and, if required, defeat threats to our national security. Continued failure to provide on-time authority and appropriations will leave the Air Force and Space Force inadequately prepared for the dramatic geopolitical, technological, economic, and environmental challenges we are facing. To keep pace with the threats in the changing strategic landscape, we urge the Congress to enact this budget request without delay.

Responding to Increasing Threats

The threats to our national security are dramatically increasing. The 2022 NDS identified the PRC as the only country with the will and increasing capability to reshape the international order. In 2023, the PRC increased its annual military budget by approximately 7 percent with estimates showing it can support continued defense spending growth for at least the next five to ten years.

The People's Liberation Army (PLA) already fields the largest aviation force in the Indo-Pacific region. It has combined a growing arsenal of long-range precision weapons with improving space-based capabilities to expand the capability of its long range kill webs and enable strikes against U.S. and Allied forces, air bases, carriers, and high-value airborne assets.

In addition to using space capabilities to target U.S. and partner terrestrial forces, the PLA is

rapidly increasing its fielded suite of kinetic and non-kinetic counterspace capabilities. These include antisatellite missiles, “inspection and repair” systems that can grapple and disable satellites on orbit, laser weapons and jammers, and reusable spaceplanes with a range of potential military uses.

The PRC is also advancing its electronic warfare and cyberspace attack capabilities to threaten U.S. bases and capabilities in the region and the U.S. homeland. For example, the PRC has targeted critical infrastructure in Guam that could be used to disrupt U.S. air operations.

The PRC has also continued its rapid nuclear expansion, on track to exceed previous projections, with more than 500 operational nuclear warheads and a nascent nuclear triad. China is moving ahead of expectations to field a nuclear arsenal comparable to that of the United States. The PLA Rocket Force has at least 2,800 theater class ballistic missiles and 350 international-range ballistic missiles, including hypersonic missiles, highlighting its approach to diverse potential nuclear-delivery systems. Many of these systems have dual-use (conventional or nuclear) potential.

We must keep pace with the growing military capabilities of the PRC while also managing the acute threat from Russia, deterring threats from other regional actors, while remaining vigilant to potential Violent Extremist Organization threats. Russia continues to place a strong emphasis on modernizing strategic weapons that will allow it to hold the United States homeland at risk, particularly with hypersonic and other next-generation weapons. Russia is developing and deploying a range of counterspace systems including surface-launched, air-launched, and orbital anti-satellite weapons, laser weapons, electronic warfare systems, and cyber capabilities that can threaten military and dual-use space assets. Both Iran and North Korea are also working to expand their military capabilities.

In the midst of these growing threats, the capabilities of the Department of the Air Force are integral to the four priorities of the NDS: defending the homeland; deterring strategic attacks against the United States, our Allies, and our partners; deterring aggression and being prepared to prevail in conflict when necessary; and ensuring our future military advantage by building a resilient joint force and defense ecosystem. With budgetary pressure, the DAF budget request balances short-term risks and readiness against the need to rapidly modernize capabilities required to deter future threats and meet NDS priorities.

Complying with FRA

The DAF’s budget is aligned with the FRA. The global obligations and enduring missions of the DAF have not changed. Our global commitments have not changed. As a result, our force structure and human capital structure remain roughly constant from FY24. The requirements to maintain adequate operational readiness, support global deployments, and meet immediate mission requirements were met, but funded to the highest level of risk considered acceptable. For example, the so-called “foundational accounts” for Weapons Systems Sustainment, Facilities, and Flying Hours were funded at the lowest level considered acceptable in both the Air Force and the Space Force. This practice can be tolerated in the short term under the constraints of FRA.

With these “current force” related elements of the budget allocated, investments in the “future

force” were adjusted to manage risk. The DAF budget request protects essential modernization, especially the investments derived from our work on Operational Imperatives and Cross-cutting Operational Enablers, and chose to marginally reduce procurement of systems already in production in order to sustain as much as possible the planned pace of research and development funding for capabilities necessary to keep pace with existing and imminent pacing threats. Procurement accounts were adjusted downward in the Air Force from previously planned levels for some key programs, including F-35 and F-15E/X. Procurement accounts also decreased with fact-of-life delays in T-7 and E-7 production. The FY25 Air Force procurement account request is \$29.0B and the Space Force procurement account request is \$4.3B. These adjustments generally allowed research and development accounts to keep pace with inflation. They did not permit the desired growth over time. This is particularly true for the Space Force where transformational modernization is needed urgently.

Meeting National Defense Strategy Priorities

Defense of the Homeland

Our first priority remains defense of the homeland. The DAF supports this priority through investments in domain awareness, air and space defense, early warning that increases strategic deterrence and enables defense of critical infrastructure, and cyberspace defense programs. These investments are closely tied with the DAF Arctic Strategy and position the DAF to support implementation of the 2023 Homeland Defense Policy Guidance.

Deterring Strategic Attacks

Our second priority is to deter strategic attacks against the United States, our Allies, and our partners. The DAF provides two legs of the Nuclear Triad and 75 percent of Nuclear Command, Control, and Communications (NC3). The DAF’s full-scope nuclear modernization program recapitalizes all current systems and supporting infrastructure to deliver modern and credible deterrence capabilities, which are essential in today’s increasingly uncertain international environment. Decades of deferring modernization of Cold War-era systems, combined with adversary nuclear modernization, make it imperative to modernize U.S. nuclear forces to maintain a safe, secure, and effective nuclear deterrent to protect the U.S. homeland, as well as Allies and partners.

DAF nuclear capabilities provide unique, complementary, and credible options in support of integrated deterrence. Decades of deferred modernization have left little room for error in our recapitalization program if we are to maintain a safe, secure, and effective nuclear deterrent. The FY25 budget requests more than \$19.4B for nuclear modernization efforts including the Sentinel Ground Based Strategic Deterrent, B-21 Raider, Survivable Airborne Operations Center (SAOC), Long-Range Standoff Weapon, Next-Generation Overhead Persistent Infrared programs, and the Evolved Satellite Communication System. Additionally, the Space Force is in the early stages of developing and fielding a more resilient missile warning and tracking capability focused on tracking advanced threats by integrating new critical missile tracking capabilities. While B-21 and LRSO are currently close to planned cost and schedule profiles, other programs are experiencing difficulties, and these programs have not completed development. Sentinel is undergoing a critical

Nunn-McCurdy review due to cost and schedule increases. The SAOC cost estimate has also increased and is putting pressure on the DAF's budget.

Deterring Aggression and Prevailing in Conflict

The third priority of our NDS is to deter aggression and be prepared to prevail in conflict when necessary. The DAF needs immediate and significant capability modernization to keep pace with the growing military capabilities of the PRC. Each year, the threat continues to advance as does our effort to define cost effective competitive operational innovation. The DAF deeply appreciates the "Quick Start" provision placed in the FY24 NDAA and will take full advantage of this opportunity to save precious time. Our effort to Reoptimize for Great Power Competition is intended in large part to create institutions with the mission of ensuring continuous competitiveness against our pacing challenge. The seven DAF Operational Imperatives and the Cross-cutting Operational Enablers body of work continues to guide the DAF's modernization effort. The FY25 DAF budget request includes \$6.1B for these efforts, \$4.0B in the Space Force and \$2.1B in the Air Force excluding B-21 investments available at a higher classification.

Building a Resilient Joint Force and Defense Ecosystem

The fourth NDS priority is to build a resilient Joint Force and defense ecosystem to ensure our future military advantage. Our Airmen, Guardians, and civilian teammates are the decisive advantage in our strategic competition, and this budget request invests to ensure they can serve to their full potential. Programs that respond to the most pressing problems of our Airmen, Guardians, and their families are detailed for each DAF Military Service in the sections below.

UNITED STATES AIR FORCE

Strategic competition with the PRC while also managing acute and persistent threats requires the Air Force to modernize to maintain its preeminent status in the world. The Air Force continues to implement the programs identified under the Operational Imperatives and follow through on initiatives designed to maintain the Air Force's qualitative advantages over any competitor. The Air Force is investing in force structure and capabilities aligned with the NDS. As the strategic environment is rapidly changing and technology fundamentally alters the character of war we are in a time of consequence. The Air Force is determined to maintain its position as the leader in speed, agility, and lethality upon which the joint team, the Nation, and allies rely.

The FY25 Air Force budget request is \$188.1B. The Air Force budget invests in foundational accounts in an attempt to arrest the year-over-year degradation of the capabilities, operational readiness, and supporting infrastructure necessary to implement the NDS, but doing so mandates a slower rate of needed modernization which increases the risk to the DAF's overall readiness. The budget fully funds nuclear modernization programs to deter strategic attacks, continuing the most extensive recapitalization effort of the nuclear enterprise in the Air Force's history. (The recently announced Nunn McCurdy cost breach on the Sentinel ICBM program is still being addressed and final estimates are not available at this time.) It also continues investment in modernization focused on critical long-range kill webs (\$310.6M) and affordable mass (\$719.8M) central to the ability to deter and, if necessary, defeat aggression. This is in clear recognition of the

PRC pacing challenge and Russian acute threat. The Air Force budget request also invests in the Air Force's most precious asset--its Airmen--to ensure they remain the decisive advantage the Nation depends upon.

AIR FORCE'S ROLE IN DEFENDING THE NATION

For FY25, the Air Force must make difficult choices to balance risk today and into the future. Today, the Air Force is accepting risk across the Service's modernization accounts in order to maintain minimally acceptable near-term operational readiness. This places additional risk on the Air Force's ability to deter and defeat any adversary going forward.

The FY25 Air Force budget request prioritizes operational readiness in the current year and seeks to preserve previous years' substantial advances in modernization and procurement. The Air Force's operational readiness is near the minimum level acceptable for the Service to meet the Nation's demands.

While this budget attempts to sustain the modernization momentum created by the Operational Imperatives and Cross-cutting Operational Enablers, it takes risk in the medium term to balance immediate operational readiness needs at the level of maximum tolerable risk. The medium-term risk most noticeably impacts the Air Force's ability to field the Next Generation Air Dominance (NGAD) Family of Systems, as well as a mature Command, Control, Communications, and Battle Management (C3BM) system, the Air Force contribution to JADC2.

The Air Force is requesting \$2.1B to meet the immediate Operational Imperatives required to maintain the Air Force's qualitative advantage and ability to deter and, if necessary, win whenever called upon by the Nation. The Operational Imperatives provide the Service with critical capabilities, readiness investments, and the foundation required to transition and sustain a wartime posture against our pacing threat. Notably, the USAF FY25 budget request continues progress toward fielding an operationally optimized Advanced Battle Management System (ABMS) (\$174M) that will improve situational awareness and provide decision-support tools to close hundreds of kill chains within relevant timelines while operating in a highly contested environment. The FY25 Air Force budget supports achieving moving target engagement at scale (\$177M), which will be decisive in a conflict with a well-resourced peer- or near-peer adversary. Fielding the NGAD Family of Systems (\$675M), particularly Collaborative Combat Aircraft, will allow the Air Force to augment current and future platforms with lower-cost complementary systems that can cost-effectively achieve control of the air in highly contested environments. The B-21 and its Family of Systems (details available at a higher classification) will be the backbone of the Air Force's bomber force and provide critical operational capability for both conventional and nuclear missions and provide precision effects en masse against targets worldwide. The Air Force is committed to building resilient forward basing (\$594M) that ensures sustainable and networked bases capable of sufficient sortie generation and mission execution in a contested environment. The Service is also investing toward securing the critical readiness required to mobilize and move the Air Force and Joint Force into theater (\$232.9M), including hardening mobilization and support capabilities against cyber and non-cyber threats. These investments represent significant efforts in critical systems and assets required by the increasingly challenging threat environment.

Among the Air Force's highest priorities is achieving electromagnetic spectrum dominance and an information advantage in highly contested environments. The Air Force's budget includes a \$50M budget request in FY25 for investment in EA-37B Baseline 4 capability enhancements and advanced waveform development. Furthermore, the Air Force is investing in mission resilience and adaptability efforts such as the 350th Spectrum Warfare Wing's rapid reprogramming to ensure effective electronic attack, support, and defensive capabilities; synchronization efforts such as Air Combat Command's Electromagnetic Battle Management (EMBM). The Air Force's investments in electromagnetic spectrum dominance are vital to ensuring that the Nation's warfighters, Joint mission partners, and Allies build, achieve, and maintain mission effectiveness, survivability, and, ultimately, warfighting advantage over the Nation's adversaries. These efforts aid in maintaining the Air Force's credibility in both assurance and deterrence roles.

As the Air Force adapts to the changing strategic environment, we are reoptimizing every aspect of the Service around meeting the PRC pacing challenge. The Air Force is focusing organizations responsible for strategic readiness on current operational readiness, creating and/or elevating organizations that are critical to this strategic environment such as cyber and the nuclear enterprise, and creating a single command to focus on future capabilities. These reoptimization decisions make changes that are within the current authorities and, to the extent possible, the resources of the Department of the Air Force. As we strive to keep pace in a strategic environment where the competition has sustained and consistent growth in funding, these efforts alone will not be enough.

AIR FORCE'S ROLE IN TAKING CARE OF PEOPLE

The Air Force is committed to attracting and retaining the best Airmen in the world. In FY24, the Active Duty Air Force is currently on track to meet its recruiting goals. Air National Guard and Reserve recruiting are trending upward but continue to remain a challenge for the Service. The Air Force has continued to break down barriers to service and made progress thanks to Congress's significant support to provide requested pay increases and increasing economic security for Airmen through cost-of-living adjustments to basic pay, BAH, and BAS. Additionally, the Air Force is opening its bases to local communities to showcase the service to the public and connect with the Nation's possible recruits. The then VCSAF's cross functional team on Barriers to Service implemented 18 policy changes since Jan 2023 to expand future recruiting opportunities and increase eligibility to serve. These changes include accelerated naturalization at BMT, aligning the body composition to the DoD standard, and expanding the tattoo policy. These changes have provided tangible improvements without sacrificing quality. The CFT will continue to review and adjust DAF policies and initiatives to best address future recruiting challenges and amplify efforts to increase propensity to serve for all.

To maintain talent, the Air Force has focused on quality-of-life impacts for its Airmen, investing to ensure they have the resources required to thrive. The Air Force has concentrated on improving access to childcare; this budget request includes a \$40.0M MILCON submission for a CDC at Mountain Home AFB, on top of 11 CDC MILCON projects that the Air Force is executing in FY25, and \$50M in Facilities, Sustainment, Restoration, and Modernization focused investment in CDCs. The Service is also on track to implement the Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military's recommendations and programs as approved by the Secretary of

Defense, expanding victim care and support for victims of sexual assault. Specifically, the Air Force is increasing the presence of embedded mental health personnel in line units to prepare for contingency operations. Demand for these mental health services has increased twofold over the last decade while mental health manning has remained relatively unchanged. To offset the lack of providers, the Department of the Air Force is training service members at every level on basic mental health skills. The Air Force has also invested in Interpersonal and Self-Directed Violence Prevention and Response with \$451M in the FY25 budget request to implement initiatives supporting and protecting Airmen.

Quality of life also demands the best living and working facilities possible. Due to fiscal constraints resulting from the FRA, the Air Force was unable to reduce the \$46.8B of deferred maintenance and repair backlog, nor achieve the 2.3% plant replacement value (PRV) reinvestment goal envisioned in the Infrastructure Investment Plan. The FY24 budget request set this goal at 1.58% and the FY25 budget request reduces it to 1.5%. Additionally, the existing CR has directly impacted the Air Force's ability to release funds and award dormitory contracts in the current fiscal year. The inability to release funds increases risk to meet the Air Force's dormitory investment goal of \$1.1B by 2026, and the inability to fund and award dormitory projects in FY24 will roll into FY25. However, with this budget request, the Air Force will meet the FY22 NDAA requirement to invest at least 5% of the estimated replacement cost of the total inventory of permanent party dormitories for facility improvements. The Air Force is deliberately investing to sustain adequate dormitories. The FY25 budget request includes a planned investment of \$250M for future prioritization of dormitory repair, but that does not include FY24 rollover due to funding delays. The Air Force is also engaging with local leaders to increase the availability of affordable housing options for families. These moves, along with the substantial increase in BAH for many localities, have increased housing opportunities and living facilities for Airmen.

To be the best, we must manage our Airmen's talent. The Air Force is defining new Total Force skills required to meet the demands of Air Force Force Generation (AFFORGEN), Agile Combat Employment, and Future Force Design. As part of reoptimization, the technical tracks for Officers and Enlisted Airmen as well as the introduction of Warrant Officers for Cyber and IT, seek to attract and retain the critical talent needed in fast-paced and rapidly evolving critical technology sectors that are shaping the modern battlefield. We are also improving talent management by investing in processes and systems that increase agility, flexibility, and data access. The Air Force is exploring ways to identify the most innovative Airmen, network them, and ensure they can field innovative solutions to meet the Air Force's most significant challenges.

AIR FORCE'S ROLE IN SUCCEEDING THROUGH TEAMWORK

Teamwork is critical in the total Air Force, including the Reserves and the Air National Guard, all as part of the Joint Force meeting the NDS objectives. That teamwork begins within the DAF, where the Air Force relies on and supports the Space Force. Both Services depend on each other in developing and fielding the Operational Imperatives and achieving the Department's reoptimization efforts. Cooperation of both the Space Force and Air Force is required to meet the challenges posed by the nation's adversaries. The ability to conduct precision strikes, engage moving-targets, close kill chains, and build situational awareness in a highly contested environment requires the seamless integration of both Services. The Air Force and Space Force

are inexorably intertwined, ensuring that both services, the Joint Force, and our allies and partners will prevail wherever called upon.

Meeting our pacing challenge also demands that the Air Force seamlessly integrate with the larger Joint Force, the combatant commands, and our allies and partners. This is the essence of Integrated Deterrence. As part of the reoptimization efforts, the Air Force is executing large-scale exercises to test its capabilities against peer threats in highly contested environments and re-designing force presentation models to ensure combatant commanders most stressing operational needs are met. The FY25 budget includes \$428M in investment to support the integrated priority lists of the combatant commanders. The Operational Imperatives and capability investments across the Service are critical to ensuring the Joint Force can succeed against the pacing challenge.

While the Air Force focuses on supporting the Joint Force in meeting the NDS priorities, the Service also realizes that Allies and partners are a center of gravity for United States national security. Allies and partners facilitate access, basing, and overflight. The Air Force is committed to working with our Allies and partners, especially in the Indo-Pacific, Europe, and the Middle East, to advance an international order grounded in rules and norms. The Air Force continues to streamline FMS programs and work with allies to develop interoperable capabilities beginning from the initial design of systems.

Teamwork is also required with the Defense Industrial Base to ensure a robust industry that is the world leader in technology and production capacity that can adapt at speed and scale. As we promote the strength of the Defense Industrial Base, the Service is working with industry partners on delivering relevant capabilities with increased speed and capacity and ensuring mission-dependent supply chain and logistics resilience.

Teamwork inside the Department of the Air Force; the Joint Force; the Defense Industrial Base; and Allies and partners will be the cornerstone of integrated deterrence and combat capability in strategic competition with the PRC. The interdependence of these forces demands constant attention to drive seamless integration and interoperability. Unity in action and capabilities developed between the Air Force, Joint Force, and Allies and partners will provide our Nation and our Allies an advantage that no potential adversary can match.

Perhaps as much as any time in history, teamwork is required across the whole of our government to tackle the increasingly complex and dangerous challenges that face our Nation. The Air Force will continue to work transparently and collaboratively through the Department of the Air Force, Department of Defense, Executive Branch, and Congress to field and maintain the most ready and dominant Air Force for the Nation.

UNITED STATES SPACE FORCE

Since its establishment in 2019, the United States Space Force has focused on one, overarching imperative: *to secure the Nation's interests in, from, and to space*. As the threats in space to American prosperity and security both increase and become more sophisticated, the Space Force must transform and therefore, it is prioritizing investments that prepare the Joint Force and the Nation to confront the dangerous operating environment that space already has become. This

transformation is severely complicated by the constrained fiscal environment, which has forced the DAF and the Space Force to make hard choices.

SPACE FORCE'S ROLE IN DEFENDING THE NATION

The world's use of space is growing at an accelerating rate, making space simultaneously more important and more dangerous. The domain is no longer the benign expanse of the past. Counterspace threats continue to destabilize the environment, and space-enabled attack increasingly holds the Joint Force and our homeland at risk. The PRC, and to a significant extent Russia, have operationalized space. The United States has not kept pace. With space undeniably defined as a warfighting domain, the Nation depends upon the Space Force to secure its interests in, from, and to space.

To meet this challenge, the Space Force has organized its modernization efforts around a theory of success that aims to protect the Nation and its interests, while also preserving stability and long-term usability of the domain. This approach adheres to three guiding principles: (1) avoid operational surprise in the space domain, (2) deter attacks against U.S. interests in space and (3) prevent an adversary from using space to attack our homeland or the Joint Force. The destruction of forces in space risks creating long-lasting hazards and indiscriminate risks. For this reason, the Space Force's concept of space superiority seeks to protect U.S. interests without jeopardizing the future of the space domain.

Avoiding operational surprise in space requires the Space Force to maintain constant awareness of the battlespace, supplemented by a robust capability to accurately produce indications and warnings for malign behavior. Over 8% of the Space Force's FY25 budget is dedicated to this purpose. Specifically, the Space Force budget invests \$1.25B into the space domain awareness mission area, including funding for the Deep Space Advanced Radar Capability, SILENTBARKER, and Space Data Fusion. These programs extend the Space Force's umbrella of awareness in the space domain, by establishing a clear picture of the operating environment and denying adversaries the ability to strike U.S. assets without warning.

To deny the benefits of a preemptive counter-space strike, the Space Force must build resilient space capabilities that guarantee continuity of critical services to the Joint Force despite current and growing adversary counterspace forces. These critical services include missile warning; communications; targeting; and Position, Navigation and Timing. The Space Force must transform these services to make them resilient to attack. As airborne systems providing communications and targeting have become more vulnerable and as threat long-range precision strike systems have proliferated, the Joint Force dependency on space is significantly increasing. To that end, the Space Force budget invests \$2.58B, or 55% of the total space-based missile warning budget, to field a proliferated multi-orbit missile warning network. Operating across different orbital regimes and sensor types, this hybrid approach complicates an adversary's attack options against U.S. space assets, enhances resiliency of a no-fail warning mission, and assures critical decision-making data will be available at the tactical, operational, and strategic levels. The Space Force is procuring two additional GPS-III F vehicles. Presently, there are 31 satellites in orbit with four in storage and two slated for launch in FY25. Simultaneously, the Space Force is researching more resilient PNT options. The FY25 budget also devotes \$4.4B to developing satellite communications (SATCOM)

systems capable of operating through contested and degraded environments. The Space Force is working to ensure that all of its capabilities can deter, overcome, and operate through enemy action.

\$7.25B—nearly a quarter of the Space Force’s FY25 funding—invests in the ability to counter an adversary from using space to attack the U.S. homeland or the Joint Force. This set of investments, which cannot be discussed in detail in an unclassified setting, is a major transformational effort for the USSF because it enables the newest Space Force mission, space superiority. The need to gain and maintain space superiority over peer adversaries is the distinguishing characteristic of a transformed Space Force and it is a top priority. Unfortunately, the compounding effects of Continuing Resolutions and the FY25 top-line funding constraints under the FRA have had significant impact on the Space Force’s ability to meet the demands of this critical mission.

Finally, to reoptimize for the pacing challenge, sustain our long-term competitive advantage, and ensure the relevance of our technical investments, the Space Force is establishing a Space Futures Command. Overseeing the forward-looking force design process by which we determine our objective force, Space Futures Command will provide vital structures and processes for our force development activities. Working closely with the Air Force Research Laboratory this Command will routinely assess the relevancy of and make recommendations on the priority of areas of scientific research. This will provide a clear and consistent demand signal to all partners, unambiguously identifying the technologies we consider to be essential to our success.

The Space Force is in the early stages of a major transformation, from a force focused only on peacetime capabilities to a force that also includes the full range of warfighting capabilities. The Space Force we have today, no matter how ready it is, does not have the range of capabilities needed against the pacing challenge. Preserving current force capabilities is necessary but not sufficient. We must invest to transform our legacy space capabilities into a credible warfighting force to deter and, if needed, to defeat our adversaries; and we must do so with a sense of urgency. This requires on-time and stable funding. Continuing Resolutions force the Space Force to rearchitect programs, miss launch windows, and break delivery timelines, spreading mission delays across the FYDP. For example, hypothetical year-long CRs can force the Space Force to slow its launch procurements, precipitating impacts for years to come by reducing the capability it can get on orbit, creating industrial base challenges, delaying test and training activities, and generating more barriers to its transformation.

SPACE FORCE’S ROLE IN TAKING CARE OF PEOPLE

The Space Force’s small but technologically sophisticated workforce means the Space Force must deliberately manage talent on an individual basis. In 2023, Congress passed the Space Force Personnel Management Act. This landmark legislation will enable the Space Force to build a modern personnel management system that will better allow the Space Force to develop and retain the elite military cadre it needs to be competitive and successful. The permeability between full-time and part-time military service the single component creates will allow Guardians of the relatively small Space Force to flexibly manage their careers and better meet their personal and professional goals while meeting Space Force operational needs.

The Space Force is also piloting the Defense Civilian Training Corps in FY25. This program, which will act as a civil service counterpart to the Reserve Officer Training Corps program, will recruit civilian Guardians with desirable backgrounds following the completion of their undergraduate education. Additionally, FY25 resourcing will allow the Space Force to expand developmental opportunities for all Guardians. Here, the first step will be a redesigned Officer Training Course. Under this program, all newly accessed officers will attend the same initial skills training course to learn the fundamentals of cyber operations, intelligence, and space operations. This combined initial skills training will ensure all officers have a comprehensive operational background prior to pursuing more specialized duties like acquisition. The Space Force is truly committed to being operationally focused.

The demands placed on Guardians continue to grow as space becomes a more dangerous operating environment. To prepare for this challenge, Guardians must be able to develop, train, and exercise their operational tradecraft in a secure environment against high-fidelity simulated threats. To meet these requirements, the Space Force is building the necessary test and training infrastructure from scratch. In FY25, the Space Force budget invests \$438.7M into the Operational Test and Training Infrastructure (OTTI) program. The Space Force is also expanding its investments in the test enterprise to account for the electromagnetic and orbital warfare mission areas. Recently, the DAF organized all of these activities under a single Program Executive Officer, ensuring resourcing transparency, accountability, and interoperability across the test and training enterprise.

One personnel challenge the Space Force faces as a small service is creating the organizational capacity to perform current operations while simultaneously building operational readiness for a high-intensity conflict. To better balance these two, the Space Force is formalizing how it builds operational readiness in combat force elements. The Space Force is accomplishing this by implementing the Space Force Generation model for readiness, which is made possible by a requested additional \$344.2M invested across several accounts. This investment enables a rotational model for Employed-in-Place missions, allowing personnel to accomplish threat-focused combat training before they are presented to the combatant commanders for day-to-day operations.

SPACE FORCE'S ROLE IN SUCCEEDING THROUGH TEAMWORK

The Space Force is not just an important teammate, but an essential one to the Joint and Combined Force. Broader operational success across all domains and theaters will depend on the Space Force succeeding in its missions. First, the Space Force provides services that the Joint and Combined team must have, or they will fail. Achieving that requires not just fielding effective capabilities joint warfighters need, but also securing those capabilities from adversarial attack. Second, the Space Force protects the Joint and Combined team from space-enabled attack. The Space Force cannot succeed in either regard without robust relationships across the U.S. enterprise and with indispensable Allies and partners.

To that end, partnerships with the other Services and throughout the Joint Force is a top Space Force priority. In FY24, the Space Force established several service components to integrate Space Force capabilities and expertise into the Combatant Commands. For example, the Space Force established U.S. Space Forces Europe and Africa, giving both USEUCOM and USAFRICOM a

dedicated team of experts in space planning and operations. The FY25 budget invests an additional \$27.8M to build service components in support of every Combatant Command. Once fully implemented, this program will give every Combatant Command access to Guardians who can help integrate space capabilities into their joint operations.

Nationally, there are many agencies and organizations with equities in the space domain. This is why the Space Force is partnering with a variety of government agencies to unify effort and leverage common interests for mutual benefit in space. For example, space-based surveillance, reconnaissance, and targeting is a critically important emerging mission area for the Space Force. Therefore, the Space Force is working with the intelligence community, as well as industry partners, so that the Space Force can accomplish this important mission as part of the Joint Force.

As a highly technical service, the Space Force depends on a strong industrial base. An eighth of the Space Force FY25 budget is dedicated to commercial space services which will help reinforce and energize the space industrial base our nation depends upon. Moreover, the Space Force is continuing to develop its commercial space strategy within the larger DAF and Department of Defense industrial policy framework to identify areas for deeper partnerships with the diverse commercial space market.

The Space Force can no longer afford to delay its necessary transformation. Space capabilities are foundational to how the Joint Force projects power across the world and are increasingly at risk—they are old, vulnerable, and already not fully meeting joint warfighter needs. Lessening these risks requires transformational change—transcending the status quo and making smart investments in not just new systems, but also people—America’s Guardians

CONCLUSION

The Department of the Air Force is in a race for technological superiority against a well-resourced strategic competitor. The United States is now facing a competitor with national purchasing power that exceeds our own, a challenge we have never faced in modern times. The PLA is actively developing and expanding capabilities to challenge strategic stability, attack our critical space systems, and defeat our ability to project power, especially air power. Conflict in the Indo-Pacific region is not inevitable. The United States is actively working to prevent conflict by strengthening combat-credible deterrence. However, acute and persistent threats still exist, and the security and prosperity undergirded by the United States military for decades is increasingly challenged. The DAF FY25 budget request is focused on addressing this reality. The DAF has funded current readiness accounts at the lowest acceptable level while investing remaining resources in essential modernization. Some Air Force procurement has been deferred to free up funding for new capabilities in development. The Space Force lacks similar trade-off options, forcing delays in needed systems, especially counterspace systems. The DAF FY25 budget request is aligned with the NDS. It addresses mission requirements while taking care of people and fulfilling our role in the Joint, interagency, and combined team. We urge timely approval of this budget request to allow us to keep pace with the challenges facing the United States.

Introduction

Chairman Reed, Ranking Member Wicker, distinguished members of the Committee:

Thank you for the opportunity to testify in support of President Biden's proposed Fiscal Year (FY) 2025 budget for the Department of Defense.

I am joined for the first time by our outstanding new Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, General C.Q. Brown. I am also glad to be back with Under Secretary of Defense (Comptroller), Mike McCord. We are grateful for the partnership of Congress and of this Committee in sustaining the most formidable fighting force in history. We remain deeply committed to our mission of keeping the United States secure in a rapidly changing global security environment. Above all, we are constantly mindful that our greatest strategic asset is our people—especially the more than 2 million extraordinary active-duty, National Guard, and Reserve Service members who step up every day to keep America safe.

As always, we understand our duty to be the best possible stewards of hard-earned taxpayer dollars. Our request for resources is rooted in our strategy, even as it recognizes fiscal reality. For the third straight year, the President's defense budget request builds on the 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS). To responsibly and effectively implement the NDS and tackle the complex challenges we face, the budget hews to the performance-improvement initiatives that we established to improve the Department's capabilities, organizations, and management processes.

This budget request is consistent with the mandatory caps directed by Congress under the Fiscal Responsibility Act of 2023, allocating \$849.8 billion for DoD programs and initiatives for the coming fiscal year. Under these caps, we made difficult but responsible decisions that focus on maintaining our readiness and taking care of our people. I am confident that our budget request will continue to make the United States more secure. It will continue to bolster our ability to defend our country, paced to the growing, multi-domain challenge posed by an increasingly aggressive People's Republic of China (PRC). It will better prepare us to prevent strategic attacks against the United States or our allies and partners. It will strengthen the unmatched

global network of alliances and partnerships that magnify our power and deepen our security. It will expand our ability to deter aggression, even while it prepares our forces to prevail in conflict if necessary. And it will pave the way toward a more resilient joint force and defense ecosystem, built for the security challenges of the 21st century.

The NDS identifies the PRC as the Department's pacing challenge. This budget request therefore focuses on the need to strengthen our integrated deterrence and position the United States to prevail in strategic competition with the PRC.

The budget request will also help us meet additional challenges we face in today's shifting global security environment. The NDS singles out President Vladimir Putin's increasingly aggressive Russia as an acute threat. In February, Russia's unprovoked and indefensible full-scale invasion of Ukraine entered its third grim year. The United States has been the essential nation in rallying support for Ukraine's fight against Putin's aggression and atrocities.

The NDS also highlights the persistent dangers posed by Iran, global terrorist organizations, and other malign actors. Ever since Hamas's vile terrorist assault on Israel on October 7, 2023, the United States has steadfastly supported Israel's right to self-defense; worked to prevent the conflict in Gaza from igniting new eruptions on Israel's northern border; pushed to protect innocent Palestinian civilians and get far more humanitarian aid into Gaza; and moved decisively to deter Iran and its proxies from taking action that would escalate into a broader regional conflict.

Above all, the NDS demands even deeper investments in the Department's people, who remain the bedrock of America's security. We rely on the service and the sacrifice of our troops and our civilian workforce, and the President's budget request will dedicate the resources, services, policies, and programs needed to faithfully support them and their families.

Our commitment to maintaining enduring advantages for the United States is reflected in the Department's requests for procurement and for research and development—\$167.5 billion and \$143.2 billion, respectively.

Provisions of the Fiscal Responsibility Act forced tough choices related to further military modernization. The law's topline limitation requires the Department to make targeted reductions to programs that will deliver key capabilities in later years to preserve the joint force's ability to fight and win in the near term. This approach assumes some risk on mid- and long-term modernization efforts not intended to be delivered until the 2030s, but achieving our strategy will require making up for these funding delays with growth in future years.

Meanwhile, I take seriously Congress's goal for the Department to get a clean audit opinion by 2028. Americans should expect us to account for our dollars and our inventory. That is why this budget will continue to invest in the controls we put in place to ensure that we spend taxpayer resources as intended by Congress. And it is why I directed senior leaders to tie performance results to their organizations' audit objectives.

Notwithstanding our efforts at responsible fiscal management, the lack of timely enactment of full-year appropriations has seriously hindered the Department's operations and planning. I am grateful for congressional action to pass Fiscal Year 2024 appropriations, but when we are forced to operate under continuing resolutions, at the previous year's appropriations levels, the Department cannot start new initiatives or increase the rate of production for many high-priority programs. Stop-gap funding measures delay badly needed investments in our military infrastructure, inflict unnecessary disruptions on our Service members and their families, undermine our recruitment efforts, and give an unnecessary boost to our strategic competitors.

The single greatest way that Congress can support the Department of Defense and our troops is to pass predictable, adequate, sustained, and timely appropriations.

Since my first day as Secretary of Defense, I have been guided by three priorities: defending our Nation, taking care of our people, and succeeding through teamwork. As detailed below, President Biden's FY 2025 budget request will advance all three of these overarching priorities, providing the most lethal fighting force on Earth with the means to defend the American people in turbulent times.

As Congress develops authorization and appropriations legislation in the months ahead, I am grateful for your support of our budget request and the mission and the people of the Department of Defense.

Defending the Nation

To tackle the evolving challenges and threats from the PRC, Russia, Iran, the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK), and global terrorist groups, as well as transnational challenges such as climate change and pandemics, we must upgrade not just our weapons systems but also our ability to quickly field new capabilities. Today's rapidly shifting security environment demands that the Department ruthlessly prioritize to strengthen our warfighting capabilities, build a skilled and innovative defense workforce equipped for tomorrow's challenges, and work together more powerfully with our indispensable allies and partners.

Outpacing the PRC

As the NDS notes, an increasingly aggressive PRC is trying to shape the global system to suit its authoritarian preferences. This is a generational challenge, and the Department will continue to meet it. We also seek a free, open, and prosperous Indo-Pacific region in which all countries are free from coercion. The FY 2025 budget request will help us realize that goal.

In FY 2025 and beyond, we will strengthen U.S. integrated deterrence by advancing new operational concepts, investing in cutting-edge capabilities across all domains, and deepening our cooperation with our outstanding allies and partners in the Indo-Pacific. Across the region, we are experimenting with new technologies to expand our warfighting advantages and refine the way that we operate.

We have made historic improvements to our force posture in the Indo-Pacific. Last year was the most transformative year in a generation for U.S. force posture in Asia. In 2023, we made major infrastructure improvements in airfields, logistics, and domain awareness across the region.

Meanwhile, we are modernizing U.S. posture in Japan and have deployed additional forces in Japan, Australia, Guam, and, on a rotational basis, in the Philippines.

Through a \$9.9 billion request for the Pacific Deterrence Initiative, the Department continues to prioritize investments in our activities and infrastructure to reinforce security and stability in the Indo-Pacific region and bolster our advantages and those of our allies and partners west of the International Date Line. With our allies and partners, we will continue to increase the complexity and the scale of our exercises, which will boost deterrence and enhance interoperability. We also continue to staunchly support Taiwan's self-defense, consistent with our longstanding policy anchored in the Taiwan Relations Act, the three Joint Communiqués, and the Six Assurances.

Answering the Acute Russian Threat

Putin's unprovoked and unjust 2022 invasion of Ukraine has taken a harrowing toll on the Ukrainian people and threatened security in Europe and beyond. Putin's war is a frontal assault on the hard-won, post-World War II rules-based international order that has produced decades of prosperity without great-power war. If Putin prevails in Ukraine, it would embolden would-be aggressors everywhere. The world of chaos and conquest that Putin seeks—one in which autocrats think they can rewrite borders by force—would leave the United States far less secure. The price of U.S. leadership remains far lower than the price of U.S. abdication. There is no good reason to think that an emboldened Putin would stop with Ukraine, which could mean unthinkable high costs for the United States. This is not just about Ukraine's survival; it is also about America's security.

The United States has therefore rallied a broad coalition of allies and partners to support Ukraine's brave fight against Putin's war of choice. The FY 2025 budget request will position the Department to continue to oppose the Kremlin's aggression, while bolstering U.S. force posture in Europe and reinforcing our allies and partners.

As Putin's forces continue their attacks against Ukraine's front lines, cities, and civilians, support from Congress is more crucial than ever—especially the supplemental funding that Ukraine's brave defenders so urgently need. A supplemental would strengthen American security and save

Ukrainian lives; it would enable us to meet Ukraine's urgent self-defense requirements, even as we maintain our own readiness and advance our military modernization; and it would meet our commitments to our partners in Israel and in the Indo-Pacific region. Moreover, because the additional arms and ammunition provided to Ukraine would be produced by our own defense industrial base, the supplemental would invest billions of dollars in the U.S. economy, creating quality jobs for Americans and increasing the resilience of our vital supply chains.

Persistent Security Threats

Other malign actors, including the DPRK, Iran, and global terrorist organizations, continue to threaten the security of the United States and our allies and partners. Russia has deepened its ties to Iran, the DPRK, and the PRC—all of which seek new ways to undermine U.S. interests across the Indo-Pacific, the Middle East, and Africa. The FY 2025 budget request ensures that the United States is ready to deter and respond to these persistent threats.

In the Middle East, the Department remains committed to Israel's right to self-defense; to ensuring that Israel never has to endure another assault like October 7th; to the swift return of all hostages in Gaza, including American citizens; and to preventing the further spread of conflict. At the same time, we continue to press Israel to protect Palestinian civilians and to increase the flow of urgently needed humanitarian assistance into Gaza.

The Department is also focused on Iran, whose nuclear ambitions, dangerous proxies, support for terrorism, and threats to freedom of navigation undermine regional security and threaten U.S. forces, allies, and partners. Through investments including integrated air- and missile-defense systems, maritime domain awareness, and counter-uncrewed aerial systems, the FY 2025 budget request will help us strengthen our partnerships in the region and preserve our ability to deploy combat-credible forces when needed.

On the Korean Peninsula, we will continue to shore up peace and security, despite the DPRK's ongoing provocations. With our allies in the Republic of Korea and Japan, we are reinforcing our extended-deterrence commitment and strengthening bilateral and trilateral cooperation. That includes information sharing, joint exercises, new missile-warning data-sharing systems, and

increased U.S. rotations. The FY 2025 budget request will ensure that U.S. forces in and around the Korean Peninsula remain ready to respond to aggression by the DPRK.

Our ability to monitor and disrupt terrorist threats to our country and our citizens has grown dramatically in the two decades since the September 11, 2001, attacks by al-Qaeda. The FY 2025 budget request will continue to sharpen our over-the-horizon counterterrorism capabilities. The Global Coalition to Defeat ISIS—now in its tenth year, with 87 members—is a lasting example of the value of working with allies and partners toward our common counterterrorism goals

Investing to Win Across All Domains

We continue to strengthen our capabilities across all domains of potential conflict. To strengthen our sea power, this request includes \$48.1 billion for naval and shipbuilding capabilities to enhance and modernize our fleet. The Navy’s commitment to stable acquisitions remains the foundation of a healthy shipbuilding base. The Department plans to invest more than \$9 billion over the next five years to improve public repair yards through the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Plan.

We are also making a historic investment in our submarine industrial base to develop supply chains, attract and retain skilled workers, and ensure the on-time delivery of Columbia and Virginia Class submarines. The FY 2025 budget request includes \$4 billion for the submarine industrial base, which follows the nearly \$1.2 billion requested in FY 2024 and a supplemental request of \$3.3 billion. These investments account for existing production capacity at our shipyards and represent an investment strategy that will allow us to support both our domestic production goals and our commitments under the AUKUS initiative. These investments will enable the Navy to maintain undersea dominance, keep a strong presence in key regions, respond effectively to emerging PRC threats, and continue the transition to Distributed Maritime Operations.

The FY 2025 budget also requests \$61.2 billion in key areas to assure U.S. air dominance. This includes continued funding for the modernization and sustainment of the F-35 and F-22 fleets, while developing the next-generation fighters and autonomous collaborative combat aircraft

critical to maintaining superiority in the skies. Our request also prioritizes long-range fires, including hypersonic weapons; a modern air command-and-control framework; rapid global mobility; and preeminent electromagnetic-warfare capabilities. To further increase strategic deterrence, the FY 2025 budget request will invest in the development, production, testing, and deployment of the B-21 strategic bomber and the Long-Range Standoff Weapon, which will enhance the Air Force's penetrating strike capability.

On land, the FY 2025 budget requests \$13 billion to bolster Army and Marine Corps combat capabilities. It will continue to strengthen and modernize the Army's Organic Industrial Base, including improvements to its arsenals, maintenance depots, and ammunition facilities. It also invests in electromagnetic-warfare capabilities and command-and-control systems, as well as air- and missile-defense systems and land-based long-range fires. Additionally, the budget request will invest in technology to counter small uncrewed aerial systems, including sensors, a common operating picture, data libraries, and both kinetic and non-kinetic mitigation capabilities. And once again, we ask Congress to provide necessary flexibility for a portion of this funding to enable the Department to rapidly respond to emergent operational needs and evolving force protection requirements.

The FY 2025 budget request includes a \$29.8 billion investment in munitions, including procurement for critical weapons such as Maritime Strike Tomahawk and Long Range Anti-Ship Missiles at or near maximum production-capacity levels. The Department is committed to boosting the variety and quantity of our air-, sea-, and ground-launched munition inventories and to maintaining a consistent and predictable demand signal for our industry partners. Congressional support of the Department's previous requests for multi-year procurement authority would help grow the advanced munitions industrial base.

The FY 2025 budget request will support the Department's pursuit of base-resilience and base-hardening initiatives to protect our forces and installations from air and missile threats—and to recover quickly if struck. This request will continue to strengthen our missile-defense capabilities, including multiple new radars and launch systems for the Guam Defense System.

We are also seeking resources to improve infrastructure for our joint forces across the Indo-Pacific. We will increase the lethality and the survivability of our Army and Marine deployments in the Indo-Pacific by providing them with the capabilities they need to operate in distributed and contested environments. For our Air Force, this budget request will improve the resilience of our forward basing by funding hardening and dispersion activities.

In the space domain, we will continue to invest in the systems and the capabilities to build advantages over any competitor. The Department will commit \$33.7 billion to strengthen our space architecture, including strategic and tactical missile warning and tracking; communications; positioning, navigation, and timing; space sensing; and the supporting ground architecture. The budget request will also fund upgrades to our launch infrastructure to support more government and commercial launches.

Beyond our cooperation with the American commercial space sector, this budget request will also allow the Department to enhance our engagement with our allies and partners in the space domain. Consistent with the Space Strategic Review, these investments continue to focus on deterring hostile uses of space and ensuring that the United States can prevail should deterrence fail in this critical domain.

The FY 2025 budget request proposes an investment of \$14.5 billion in cybersecurity and other investments in cyberspace. This includes, among other things, developing and fielding advanced cybersecurity tools and techniques to protect our networks and critical infrastructure; expanding data-centric and artificial intelligence programs; upgrading our cyber-operations training platform; and accelerating our use of cloud-based capabilities.

Finally, the COVID-19 pandemic—which killed more than 1.1 million Americans—underscored the national-security risks from biological threats. It is important, therefore, that in August 2023, the Department released the Biodefense Posture Review. This foundational document outlines key reforms to posture the Department to prevail in the face of future threats, including from adversaries who seek to disrupt U.S. military operations. Building on these reforms, the

President's FY 2025 budget request will further enhance our ability to keep America safe from biological threats.

Innovating and Modernizing

A safe, secure, and effective U.S. nuclear deterrent is the ultimate check on strategic attacks against our country and our allies. The Department is committed to maintaining and modernizing all three legs of the U.S. nuclear triad even as we remain ready to pursue arms-control measures that enhance U.S. and allied security. The FY 2025 budget request includes an investment of \$49.1 billion to fund our nuclear enterprise and invest in U.S. nuclear command, control, and communications. This budget request will enable the Department to maintain our reliable and effective legacy systems while building and fielding their replacements.

The replacement for the ground-based leg of the nuclear triad, the Sentinel weapon system, remains one of the largest, most complex programs within the Department. The Department notified Congress in January that Sentinel had experienced a critical cost overrun, and we are now reviewing the program, as required under the Nunn-McCurdy Act. This robust review will be completed within 120 days after the submission of the President's budget. The Department remains determined to prevent gaps in capability as we modernize our intercontinental ballistic missile fleet.

The Department also continues to invest in cutting-edge defense capabilities, from uncrewed systems and smarter munitions to advanced energetics and manufacturing. We are integrating human-machine teaming, developing autonomous systems, and fielding reliable and resilient networks and data. At the same time, we are taking steps to optimize the practices and systems that are working best, while phasing out our technical debt—those quick fixes that we know will be costly or obsolete in the future. All this will make our operations faster, more lethal, and more survivable for our forces, allies, and partners. As I have repeatedly said, when we sharpen our tech edge, we expand our military edge.

In this sustained period of record or near-record low unemployment, the Department is finding new ways to develop and recruit the talent that will help us maintain America's position as the

global leader in research and development. We are cultivating skilled scientists and engineers through the Science, Mathematics, and Research for Transformation scholarship-for-service program and other initiatives. This budget request will also continue to pilot the Defense Civilian Training Corps and civilian cyber-workforce-incentive programs to strengthen skills in other critical fields such as acquisition, digital technologies, Zero Trust, and cybersecurity.

We are also investing in research partnerships focused on critical technologies with our allies and partners. Our unparalleled network of alliances and partnerships is key for technological development, co-investment in combined capabilities, and production capacity.

The Department continues to vigorously develop and test advanced weapons prototypes. The FY 2025 budget request will foster the development of several hypersonic weapons programs, prioritizing surface-launched boost-glide capabilities and air-launched cruise missiles. Also in FY 2025, the Army will field its third Medium-Range Capability battery and its second Long-Range Hypersonic Weapon battery. Our budget request will also invest in further improvements to our subsonic cruise missiles to keep them effective against rapidly evolving threats and targets.

To sustain U.S. technological superiority for the future force, the public and private sectors must work even more closely together. The FY 2025 budget will advance the work of the Defense Innovation Unit, which is working with venture-capital firms and tech innovators who are often doing business with the Department for the first time. By building bridges with private industry, we can acquire commercial technologies that will deliver game-changing capabilities at speed and scale. In 2022, I established the Office of Strategic Capital to provide the Department with new, loan-based tools to catalyze private investment in domestic production and manufacturing of the crucial technology supply base, at limited cost to the Department and the taxpayer. The recent passage of the FY 2024 appropriations bill will empower this new office to help attract and scale private capital to invest in the critical technology components that underpin our most important weapons systems.

We also continue to invest in programs to test and scale emerging technologies, such as the Strategic Capabilities Office, the Rapid Defense Experimentation Reserve, and the Accelerate the Procurement and Fielding of Innovative Technologies program.

Additionally, the Department will continue to work with Congress to tackle emerging concerns through the new Replicator initiative to accelerate capabilities from prototype to scale. The Department is currently focused on producing thousands of attritable autonomous systems over the next 18 to 24 months, creating a repeatable process that will enable the rapid delivery of future capabilities.

To improve the speed, quality, and accuracy with which commanders make decisions, we are actively pursuing the Combined Joint All Domain Command and Control capability, which seeks to integrate and deploy information across all domains and the electromagnetic spectrum. As Deputy Secretary Kathleen Hicks recently announced, the Department has delivered its initial iteration of this capability, an important step in scaling it across the joint force. The FY 2025 budget request will help the United States maintain our edge in command and control across all domains, as the pace and amount of information in warfare increases.

Improving Our Resilience

As the NDS warns, the climate crisis is reshaping the Department's strategic environment and threatening U.S., allied, and partner interests. Climate change is placing new demands on the joint force and challenging our readiness. Extreme weather events have inflicted billions of dollars of damage on DoD installations and assets. And in places such as the Arctic, climate change is creating new potential points of friction.

By working with allies and partners to enhance climate resilience, we strengthen our defense relationships and bolster our ability to respond to instability and humanitarian emergencies. Meanwhile, by reducing the operational energy demand of our platforms, we can act more nimbly and freely in contested logistics environments and sustain distributed operations.

This budget request will invest in enhancements to our operational capabilities, mission resilience, and readiness. This includes programs that reduce or avoid the risk of energy and water supply disruptions to military facilities—whether caused by extreme weather, cyber operations, or kinetic attack. The budget request also includes funding to improve the energy efficiency of combat operations and platforms, to enhance the joint force’s agility, and to reduce logistics risk in contested environments like the Indo-Pacific region. Throughout, our focus is on maximizing our operational advantages—and, when necessary, preparing to fight and win under any conditions.

Taking Care of Our People

Doing right by our people is a readiness imperative. This budget request therefore will enable the Department to invest in significant additional quality-of-life improvements, military pay raises, and benefits for our outstanding Service members and their families. Furthermore, it helps to implement historic military-justice reforms, counter the scourge of sexual assault, build positive command climates, and deepen our efforts to prevent suicide in our ranks.

Strengthening Support to Service Members and Families

Our Service members and their families deserve competitive compensation packages that make the Department an employer of choice. After troops received a basic-pay increase of 5.2 percent in 2024—the largest in more than 20 years—the FY 2025 budget request will support a 4.5 percent pay raise in the coming year. At the President’s directive, we will continue to examine compensation through the Quadrennial Review of Military Compensation.

The places where we work and live affect our people’s ability to carry out their missions and the overall recruitment and retention of the force. The FY 2025 budget request will build on recent investments in construction, maintenance, cleanup, and conservation, including \$2 billion for family housing construction and operations and more than \$1 billion in military construction for unaccompanied housing. This continued investment reflects the commitment in our “Resilient and Healthy Defense Communities” strategy to ensure that our people live, work, and train in healthy, functional, and resilient spaces.

The FY 2025 budget request will provide additional economic support to our Service members and families across a range of programs. The Department is making childcare more accessible and affordable, and we are expanding the availability of childcare-fee assistance through the Military Child Care in Your Neighborhood PLUS initiative. Additionally, in 2023, the Department established the opportunity for Service members and their families to contribute to dependent-care flexible spending accounts, which make the costs of childcare and other forms of care for family members easier to bear. I have also taken direct action to reduce commissary prices and to increase opportunities for our military spouses to excel in their own careers.

With thanks to Congress, the Department has implemented expanded parental-leave benefits for our Service members. New parents now receive 12 weeks of paid, non-chargeable leave, whether they become parents by birth, adoption, or long-term foster care. And when a Service member suffers the tragedy of the death of a spouse or child, DoD has implemented a bereavement leave benefit that Congress provided, which allows Service members who have not yet accrued significant annual-leave balances to take up to 14 days of non-chargeable leave in these times of grief.

Protecting Our Teammates and Ensuring Accountability

As I said on my first full day in office, sexual assault in the military is a scourge, and ending it is a leadership issue. Every member of the force deserves a workplace free of sexual assault, sexual harassment, and personal fear, which erode cohesion and trust within our units. The FY 2025 budget request will ensure that the Department will have the capabilities, the programs, and the integrated prevention workforce needed to implement the recommendations I approved from the 2021 Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military.

The Department also recently reached a milestone in strengthening accountability and increasing Service members' trust in the fairness and integrity of the military justice system. In December 2023, the Offices of Special Trial Counsel within the Military Departments reached full operational capability, shifting prosecutorial discretion for 13 serious criminal offenses away from commanders to specially trained and independent judge advocates who report directly to the Secretaries of the Military Departments. This landmark change to the U.S. military justice

system significantly strengthens the independent prosecution of sexual assault and other serious criminal offenses, such as domestic abuse and child abuse and neglect. It is the most important reform to our military justice system since the creation of the Uniform Code of Military Justice in 1950, and I am grateful to Congress for passing this important law.

The Department also remains laser-focused on preventing suicide in our ranks, and we are committed to implementing enabling actions informed by the work of the Suicide Prevention and Response Independent Review Committee. In September 2023, I announced a comprehensive suicide-prevention campaign plan implementing more than 80 actions, including steps to improve suicide-prevention training, reduce the stigma associated with seeking help, expand access to support services, and promote the safe storage of guns and potentially dangerous medications.

Addressing the Recruiting Challenge and Growing Our Talent

The Department of Defense must recruit and retain the best of America, building pathways of opportunity for all qualified patriots who seek to serve. Many factors can affect recruiting, including a competitive economy, shifting attitudes toward institutions, limited familiarity with the military, and the aftermath of the Iraq and Afghanistan wars. To push past the headwinds in meeting the recruiting mission, we must clearly convey the full range of opportunities and benefits offered by military service. Recent legislation and ongoing activities by the Services are opening pathways for recruiters to reach more young people while upholding our standards. Amid today's challenging recruiting environment, retention remains high. The Department has moved effectively to incentivize members to remain in the military, to strive for promotion and increased responsibility, and to enhance their skills and abilities. This budget request envisions additional ways to tap into the full range of talent across America.

The FY 2025 budget request will also support a properly sized, highly capable civilian workforce aligned to the Department's mission and workload. The Department will continue to work to make the best possible use of our deeply dedicated people, including our troops, our civilian workers, and our contractors.

The Department continues to provide exceptional opportunities for service and professional development. This means attracting more personnel with technological skills, foreign-language abilities, or other talents. We are investing in training and education, as well as creating scholarships for science, technology, engineering, and math. The Department is committed to attracting, retaining, and developing the best talent in America, especially rising stars with expertise on emerging technologies and cutting-edge capabilities such as AI, data analytics, digital modernization, and cyber operations.

Succeeding Through Teamwork

Our long-term security and success demand teamwork—across the Department and beyond. That means working closely and effectively with our interagency colleagues, Congress, industry, and our peerless network of allies and partners worldwide. The FY 2025 budget request will enable the Department to deepen our cooperation with the allies and partners who magnify our power and advance our shared security interests.

The NDS is rooted in the immutable military reality that strengthening our work with allies and partners deepens our common security and lets us share the burden of forging a safer and more prosperous world. For example, the Defense Security Cooperation Service that I established in May 2023 will improve the way the Department trains, organizes, and equips itself for security cooperation, which in turn will let us more swiftly and effectively deliver capabilities to our allies and partners. This budget request will support the initial phases of the establishment of this service, which will put our embassy-based Security Cooperation personnel on par with those in the Defense Attaché Service.

The AUKUS Partnership

I am grateful to Congress for its support of the historic AUKUS partnership, including passing legislation to allow for more seamless defense innovation and trade with two of our closest allies, Australia and the United Kingdom. The FY 2025 budget request will support the AUKUS initiative to forge a more secure balance of power in the Indo-Pacific region. Our three proud democracies are jointly tackling the threats of the 21st century, building on our proud work together in the 20th century.

Last year, the President announced our plans for the first major initiative of AUKUS: providing Australia with a conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarine. The phased approach to that initiative will allow us to provide this capability on the fastest possible timeline, while strengthening the nuclear nonproliferation regime. The first phase of that initiative is on track: the first Australian submariners have graduated from our nuclear-power school; two of our submarines have conducted port visits in western Australia; and Australian workers are building their skills alongside Americans in our ports in Hawaii and Guam. In December 2023, I hosted my U.K. and Australian counterparts at the Defense Innovation Unit in Silicon Valley, where we committed to seeking even greater innovation and interoperability among our defense industries. This AUKUS initiative will deepen trilateral cooperation in several areas, including artificial intelligence and autonomy, quantum technologies, cyber capabilities, hypersonics, and more.

We are also expanding our bilateral defense and security cooperation with Australia, particularly on force posture and capabilities development. In 2023, our two governments entered into an arrangement to collaborate on a flexible guided weapons production and maintenance capability to be located in Australia.

Allies and Partners in the Indo-Pacific

Our network of allies and partners in the Indo-Pacific is deep, wide, strong, and committed to a shared vision of peace, prosperity, stability, and deterrence. The FY 2025 budget request will ensure that the United States can continue to strengthen these key alliances and partnerships.

To deter the threat that the DPRK's nuclear weapons and ballistic-missile programs pose to the American homeland, we have increased rotations of strategic assets to the Korean Peninsula and returned to large-scale, combined, live-fire exercises with the Republic of Korea.

We are working closely with our Japanese allies to forward-deploy more versatile and resilient U.S. capabilities, to enhance Japan's counterstrike capabilities, and to modernize our alliance's command and control.

We are modernizing the U.S.-Philippines alliance by enhancing maritime cooperation, strengthening Philippine capabilities, and improving interoperability and information sharing. Under the Enhanced Defense Cooperation Agreement, we have expanded our rotational presence to four new strategic locations in the Philippines. These steps underscore our unwavering commitment to our Mutual Defense Treaty with our allies in the Philippines.

Our annual Cobra Gold exercise with Thailand helps strengthen relationships among participating regional partners. Last year's exercise saw the largest U.S. contingent in a decade, as well as the participation of dozens of other countries, in a welcome return to pre-pandemic levels.

With this budget request, we are beginning a new chapter in U.S.-India relations, under our Major Defense Partnership. Our militaries are accelerating joint exercises, information-sharing, and other operational activities to boost maritime security in the Indian Ocean. By bolstering the Indian military's capabilities, we can work together to uphold a more stable balance of power across the wider Indo-Pacific. We are committed to ensuring that the growing U.S.-India partnership supports the efforts of our broader network of allies and partners, especially the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue among Australia, India, Japan, and the United States.

The FY 2025 budget request will also enable the Department to remain engaged across the Pacific Islands region, in alignment with our Indo-Pacific strategy. That includes building on the Defense Cooperation Agreement that we secured last year with Papua New Guinea, as well as increased security cooperation and closer bonds with the Freely Associated States—Micronesia, the Marshall Islands, and Palau.

Strong multilateral cooperation, including with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), underpins all these efforts to foster a free and open Indo-Pacific. As I have said, the Indo-Pacific remains our center of strategic gravity.

European Security and Support to Ukraine

The United States continues to work closely with our allies and partners to support Ukraine's fight for freedom. The engine of our efforts is the Ukraine Defense Contact Group, the coalition of some 50 countries that I regularly convene to meet Ukraine's immediate battlefield needs and support its long-term security and sovereignty. Members of the Contact Group have organized new, multinational "capability coalitions," focused on supporting such areas as Ukraine's air force, integrated air and missile defense, artillery, maritime security, armor, information technology, de-mining, and drones.

Putin's war of choice poses the largest threat to European security since the height of the Cold War, and NATO is more united than ever. The greatest alliance in history has gained two more highly capable defense partners with the recent accession of Finland and Sweden, and the United States has moved urgently with our allies to further fortify NATO and bolster its defenses on its eastern flank.

Allies are also increasing investments in their own militaries at levels not seen since the end of the Cold War. More allies than ever are meeting their pledges to invest at least two percent of their GDP in defense—including, as NATO Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg has noted, a real increase of 11 percent in defense spending in 2023 across our European and Canadian allies. This is historic progress, and we will continue to encourage further investments and urge every member of NATO to meet its obligations under the Defense Investment Pledge.

Our commitment to Article Five of the North Atlantic Treaty remains ironclad. We will not be dragged into Russia's war of choice, but we will stand with Ukraine as it fights to defend itself, and we will continue to strengthen NATO's collective defense and deterrence. We cannot have a secure America without a strong NATO.

The Kremlin's war poses a direct threat to security in Europe and beyond. The world will only become more dangerous if Putin and his fellow autocrats conclude that they can wipe democracies off the map and force free people to live in fear. So we will continue to support

Ukraine's brave defenders—both because it is the right thing to do and because it is central to America's continued security.

Investing in America's Defense Industrial Base

The United States needs an adaptive, resilient, and robust defense industrial base to meet its 21st-century defense challenges. Today, our defense industrial base still relies heavily on foreign production and vulnerable supply chains. Providing military capabilities at the speed and scale necessary to maintain our competitive advantage—without relying on competitors for capital, technology, or raw materials—will require cooperation and investment from both the private and public sectors to build a modern defense industrial base.

In January, the Department published the National Defense Industrial Strategy, which will guide DoD actions—in partnership with industry and our allies—to meet the production demands posed by evolving threats. This budget request will shore up critical domestic and allied supply chains for sectors such as microelectronics, casting and forging, and batteries and energy storage. It will also help secure upstream supplies of rare earth elements essential to U.S. economic and national security, including by supporting programs to boost innovative manufacturing methods, the use of alternate materials, and strategic stockpiling.

The budget request also outlines investments to revitalize our submarine industrial base. That will create good American jobs, grow our manufacturing capacity, and strengthen our submarine supply chains.

When we invest in America's defense industrial base, we do not just strengthen our national security; we also boost our economy. The defense sector can catalyze innovation, create jobs, and make technological advances. Our relationships with industry can strengthen America's defense even as they sustain America's economic growth.

Such progress relies on a fully funded defense budget. Dependence on short-term funding measures damages our ability to invest in our defense industrial base. Under continuing resolutions, critical national-security programs are delayed or put on hold, and the fiscal

uncertainty destabilizes the U.S. economy. The only clear path for the United States to maintain our global strength and continue to outpace our rivals is for our valued partners in Congress to provide full-year appropriations. Building on Congress’s meaningful investments over the past three years, the Department is committed to working with Congress to ensure that our industrial base can continue to meet the needs of our warfighters—and ensure continued security for the United States.

Conclusion

As the President has noted, we stand at “an inflection point in world history.” Amid a global battle between democracy and autocracy, our friends, our rivals, and our foes are all looking to America. Our security in these turbulent times relies on American strength of purpose. We remain determined to meet this moment.

The FY 2025 budget request will ensure that the Department will be able to continue building the most lethal, resilient, and responsive military on Earth. We hope that our valued partners in Congress will help us make the critical, targeted investments to strengthen America’s security in this time of historic challenge. To that end, the single best thing that Congress can do to strengthen our national defense is to pass a full-year appropriation. Our competitors do not have to operate under continuing resolutions. When the Department does, it erodes both our country’s security and our ability to compete—today and in the future.

We make this request mindful of the need to be faithful stewards of taxpayer dollars. The American public, including of course our extraordinary troops and veterans, should never expect anything less.

Finally, I want to thank our Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen, Marines, and Guardians; their families, caregivers, and survivors; and our civilian employees. They are our greatest strategic asset—and they never waver in their drive to make our union more perfect, our country more secure, and our world more just.

Thank you.

7 March 2024

STATEMENT FOR THE RECORD GENERAL MICHAEL

“ERIK” KURILLA COMMANDER, US CENTRAL

COMMAND

BEFORE THE SENATE ARMED SERVICES COMMITTEE

ON THE POSTURE OF

US CENTRAL COMMAND

TWO VISIONS FOR THE FUTURE

OF THE CENTRAL REGION



I. INTRODUCTION

The Central Region faces its most volatile security situation in the past half century. Just a year ago, the region was on the verge of improbable and transformative progress. The strategic investments in our partners were transforming the security calculus in the region in ways unthinkable just ten years ago. The vision of an integrated and modernized region was on the precipice of actualization. The events of 7 October 2023 not only permanently changed Israel and Gaza, they also set off a series of reactions that have created the conditions for malign actors to sow instability throughout the region and beyond.

Today, a convergence of crisis and competition have enabled revisionist powers to fuel violence seeking a return to an unfortunately predictable pattern in the region's history. Iran and its expansive network of proxies saw a once-in-a-generation opportunity to reshape the region to its advantage. They have accelerated their efforts to expel Western presence and neutralize our influence in the region, enabling a long-term strategic goal to further their revolution and establish regional hegemony. Iran knows that its decades-long vision of dominating the region cannot be realized if the region's states continue to expand integration with each other and deepen partnership with the United States. ISIS and Al Qaeda, despite tremendous losses, remain committed to inflicting violence and suffering on anyone not aligned with their extremist ideology. ISIS retains the capability to threaten U.S. interests and is attempting to reconstitute in Syria. The People's Republic of China (PRC) and Russia demonstrate that they have little capability or will to reduce regional tensions and are quick to capitalize on instability. Collectively, Iran, Russia, and the PRC are strengthening their relationship, creating a

chaotic landscape favorable for their exploitation and the spread of extremism.

However, the region is not predestined to this fate. The path of integration and partnership remains open to us if we remain committed to following it. The stable future envisioned by our National Security Strategy (NDS) and National Defense Strategy (NDS) and shared by our partners can support broader U.S. national interests and is one worth striving to achieve. Despite Iran's best efforts, the region is holding open its doors to security cooperation with the United States. It is modernizing at an incredible rate, seeking to shake free from the turmoil of its past, and looking towards a future of security, stability, and prosperity. Our partners in the Levant, Arabian Gulf, and Central and South Asia, remain committed to advancing the region – preferably with the United States. The degree of U.S. investment across the instruments of national power and the success of security integration in the Central Region will be decisive in determining whether its future supports U.S. national interests. Our years of continuous engagement throughout the region serve as the foundation for this investment.

U.S. Central Command's strategic approach of People, Partners, and Innovation, codified in our Theater Strategy, reinforces the vision of a modern and integrated Central Region and supports a Whole of Government effort to secure our regional and global interests. Our strategic advantage in the region remains strong military-to-military partnerships, while our adversaries and competitors rely on parasitic and transactional relationships. We seek to integrate our partners, while Iran seeks to leverage instability to its advantage. We enable our partners to defeat violent extremists by catalyzing unified responses, while Iran threatens national sovereignty and regional stability by

supporting and enabling sectarian militias. In concert with our partners, we drive innovative approaches, concepts, and technologies to address the many threats we face, developing solutions for real time decision advantage and creating strategic depth in our force posture.

USCENTCOM is clear eyed about the task before us. The shockwaves of the past year will reverberate across the Central Region for some time. Iran intends to seize on its opportunity, and it will not be easily deterred. The fight against violent extremism is not complete. The PRC and Russia will exploit instability at every turn to undermine U.S. interests and advance their own strategic positions. Beyond the region, we acknowledge there are a myriad of global challenges that require deliberate risk and resourcing decisions by our national leaders. USCENTCOM remains committed to the vision of a prosperous and integrated Central Region in which U.S. national interests are advanced.

II. STRATEGIC CONTEXT

The Central Region remains vital to our national interests. USCENTCOM protects the security of the American people and supports the expansion of American economic prosperity and opportunity. We benefit from deep diplomatic ties and military-to-military relationships throughout the USCENTCOM Area of Responsibility (AOR), with many of the United States' most steadfast partners resident in the region or astride it. We also have critical economic interests to protect. The Arabian Gulf contains around 800 billion barrels of proven oil reserves and 2,800 trillion cubic feet of natural gas reserves – nearly half the world's oil and natural gas. Twelve percent of our imported oil comes from the region, and it supplies the world with 15 million barrels per day – much of

which goes to our global partners and allies through the Strait of Hormuz. Many of the resources that do not originate in the region traverse it, along shipping routes between Asia and Europe, passing through strategic chokepoints in the Bab al Mandeb Strait and Suez Canal.

There are also significant security challenges in the region. From Iran's regional hegemonic ambitions to the world's biggest concentration of violent extremism, the security of America's homeland, its interests, and the security of our partners are under threat from an array of actors seeking to prevent the vision of a free and prosperous Central Region from coming to fruition. We must ensure malign actors do not proliferate regional violence around the globe and to our shores. We must also be cognizant that our partners are weighing their options as they interpret signals that suggest we will reduce our commitment. Meanwhile, the burgeoning military alliance between Russia and Iran threatens to amplify their aggression across multiple theaters. USCENTCOM secures U.S. national interests and addresses these destabilizing influences through three lines of effort: Deterring Iran, Countering Violent Extremist Organizations, and Competing Strategically.

Deterring Iran

For several decades, Tehran has pursued a three-pronged strategy for regional dominance: achieve a threshold nuclear weapons capability, advance and proliferate its standoff weapons arsenal, and leverage a vast proxy network to sow instability throughout the region. It is that proxy network, known as the Iranian Threat Network (ITN), that provides Iran operational reach throughout the region and enables its offensive actions against our regional partners and global interests.

Iran continues to use its nuclear program for international blackmail. Last year, Iran continued to produce and stockpile highly enriched uranium well beyond what is needed for commercial use in hopes of gaining economic concessions from the international community. On 10 February 2024, the International Atomic Energy Agency announced Iran had amassed a 121.5-kilogram stockpile of 60% enriched uranium, and 5,525.5 kilograms of enriched uranium overall. Should Iran decide, it could enrich enough uranium for three nuclear devices within weeks. A nuclear-armed Iran would transform the region overnight and forever, likely igniting a regional race for nuclear weapons and creating a security umbrella for its hegemonic ambitions.

Iran also projects power through its ballistic missiles, unmanned aerial systems (UAS), and other advanced conventional weapons. Over the last 12 months, Iran continued to expand its arsenal of precision guided weapon systems including ballistic and cruise missiles with ranges up to 2000km and one-way attack UAS with ranges up to 3000km. These capabilities enable Iran to strike every country in the Central Region and to range key U.S. allies as far away as Europe. Iran distributes many of these weapons to proxies in the region, presenting a high-end, multi-axis threat to U.S. forces and those of our allies and partners. Iran's advanced weapons have been used by its proxies in Lebanon, Iraq, Syria, and Yemen continuously in the past five months, and they continue their illicit shipments – in violation of UN sanctions – on a daily basis. Finally, HAMAS's barbaric attack on Israel would not have been possible without years of Iranian material and training support.

Not only does Iran actively undermine the sovereignty of neighboring states in the region by providing sophisticated lethal aid to its various militias, it also supplies

countries like Russia, Venezuela, and Sudan with attack and surveillance UAS, with more customers lining up globally. Regardless of who pulls the trigger, Iran is unconcerned with ensuring its weapons are employed in accordance with the Law of Armed Conflict. Iran displays its growing UAS capabilities by attacking commercial shipping, striking merchant vessels more than 1,000 nautical miles into the Indian Ocean. In fact, since 2021, Iran attacked or seized 19 merchant ships in international waters, and still illegally holds five vessels and their crews against their will in Iranian ports.

Tehran has long driven instability in the region with its proxies, but 2023 saw an unprecedented activation of virtually every facet of the ITN across the entire region. After HAMAS attacked Israel, the Houthis in Yemen targeted the global economy, Iranian Aligned Militia Groups (IAMG) waged a campaign of violence to force the Global Coalition to Defeat ISIS out of Iraq and Syria, and Lebanese Hezbollah's increasingly escalatory attacks held Israel's northern border at risk. Iran saw an opportunity to demonstrate the capabilities of its so-called "Axis of Resistance," and manifested decades of conditioning, provisioning, and preparation. Since 7 October 2023, IAMGs like Kata'ib Hezbollah and Harakat al Nujaba, enabled by Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps Qods Force, have attacked Coalition Forces 71 times in Iraq, 102 times in Syria, and twice in Jordan, killing three U.S. servicemembers on 28 January 2024. The Houthis have attacked international shipping and Coalition warships over 50 times, sparking supply chain issues reminiscent of those during the COVID-19 pandemic and contributing to food aid delays in hunger-stricken Yemen.

Through the ITN, the proliferation of its ballistic missile and UAS capabilities, and the threat of nuclear breakout, Iran is executing a strategic encirclement of the region. They

are emplacing forces, ideology, and weapon systems that can threaten US interests, allies, and partners from multiple vectors and at critical chokepoints with little-to-no warning. Now, more than ever, Tehran has the capability to advance its regional goals and threaten global interests. Houthi attacks threaten the free flow of 15% of the world's commerce, while Iran itself repeatedly attacks and seizes international merchant vessels. IIMG attacks and Iranian political pressure jeopardize the hard-earned gains of the Global Coalition to Defeat ISIS. Iran's proliferation of advanced conventional weapons fuels conflict on three continents. All of this is underscored by Iran's status as a threshold nuclear state. With conditions now set, we assess Tehran perceives an opportunity to force the U.S. out of the Central Region, divide its neighbors, and take substantive steps to eradicate the state of Israel.

Opportunities for Deterring Iran

In line with the NSS and NDS, USCENTCOM leverages the United States' unparalleled ability to integrate partners in pursuit of mutual interests. USCENTCOM's role is gradually shifting from security guarantor to security integrator, and many of our regional partners are increasingly willing to coordinate with their neighbors to enhance the defense of their borders. Behind this trend is a growing recognition that Iran is their greatest threat. In response, we develop competitive overmatch among our partners by enhancing our collective capabilities and leveraging our network of regional security constructs. Middle East Air Defense (MEAD) is an example, as the regional integration of our partners' air defense capabilities has helped detect and intercept the unprecedented wave of missile and UAS attacks coming from the ITN.

Multinational organizations aligned against individual domains, such as the International Maritime Security Construct (IMSC) help to address specific Iranian threats, like illegal ship seizures and arms smuggling. Even groups designed to counter other threats, such as the Global Coalition to Defeat ISIS and the 41-nation Combined Maritime Forces (CMF) bring the world together in common cause to defend the rules-based international order, which Iran is actively working to undermine.

We must continue to strengthen our longstanding bilateral military-to-military relationships. Just as our partners count on our support, we depend on our partners. Faster and more transparent foreign military sales (FMS) will underwrite the trust among our partners and help bolster their capabilities relative to Iran as well as protect their own sovereignty. Beyond materiel contributions to any fighting force, our close partnerships enable access, basing, and overflight that will be critical to mission success. For example, our close relationship with Egypt allowed us unique access to expedite humanitarian aid at the outset of the Sudanese Civil War, in addition to our daily operations. Going forward, we must continue to develop the partner-enabled Western Access Network, which provides alternate routes to transport equipment and personnel throughout the USCENTCOM AOR. You cannot surge trust in crisis, and our partners must know we are there for them before we need something in return.

Risks to Deterring Iran

Iran believes it has the momentum to force a premature withdrawal of the Global Coalition to Defeat ISIS, allowing them opportunity to expand its land bridge to the Mediterranean Sea and revive the narrative of abandonment in the region. Further, the

PRC and Russia would undoubtedly capitalize in the information environment by characterizing our withdrawal as a demonstration of American unreliability, hoping to drive a wedge in our global partnerships and assault a core premise of the NDS and NSS.

Iran's potential pursuit of a nuclear weapon could significantly alter our risk assessment. Preventing Iran from acquiring a nuclear weapon remains a top priority with global implications. While we have not seen indications that Iran's Supreme Leader has changed his calculus to pursue a nuclear weapon, we will continue to develop military options for the Secretary of Defense and President, should they be necessary.

Countering Violent Extremist Organizations (VEO)

Five years after the fall of the physical ISIS caliphate, the group's extremist ideology endures. It endures in more than 5,000 fighters and operatives still at large throughout the Central Region and beyond. It endures in detention facilities, guarded by our Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF) partners, which hold approximately 9,000 detainees. Finally, it endures in pockets of camps for displaced persons like Syria's Al Hol, which currently holds approximately 43,000 men, women, and children. ISIS remains resolute in its quest to plunge the region into sectarian violence, impose its ideology, and eventually spread its influence globally.

Without the Global Coalition's continued focus, ISIS resurgence remains a threat. In 2023, Combined Joint Task Force Operation Inherent Resolve (CJTF-OIR) conducted 475 total ground operations and 45 total airstrikes, resulting in 164 ISIS fighters killed and 619 detained. We assess our high volume of partnered operations has kept ISIS at

bay; however, IAMG attacks on U.S. and Coalition forces degrade the D-ISIS campaign. Eliminating ISIS's ability to conduct terrorist attacks requires sustained investment in Iraqi security forces, partners on the ground in Syria and a robust counterterrorism apparatus consisting of intelligence community and interagency elements.

The barrage of Iranian-sponsored attacks after 17 October 2023 forced CJTF-OIR to come off plan as we prioritized protecting our forces in Iraq and Syria. The ensuing spike in ISIS attacks demonstrates the gravity of disruptions to the international effort to permanently defeat the group. In the first two weeks of 2024, ISIS conducted 275 attacks in Iraq and Syria, the highest rate of attacks in the last two years. The Government of Iraq is rightly concerned that ISIS is taking advantage of the Global Coalition temporarily letting up due to IAMG attacks. Furthermore, Tehran is exerting incredible political pressure on Baghdad to expel the Coalition, which would all but guarantee ISIS' return if it occurred before Iraqi Security Forces (ISF) were ready to stand on their own. We would also be challenged to support our Syrian partners without a military presence in Iraq. In Syria, we saw ISIS increase intensity of activity across multiple provinces, as it enjoyed more freedom of movement due to SDF conflicts with local tribes and Turkish airstrikes that restricted SDF operations. A spate of ISIS attacks in late 2023 drove up the annual average casualties per attack to twice the rate of the previous year.

Disruptions in Syria also forced temporary delays in training guards for detention facilities and displaced persons camps. We must ensure the SDF can sustainably hold ISIS detainees who have no prospect of rehabilitation while the international community repatriates foreign fighters. In addition to training guards, we assist with the maintenance

and refurbishment of the detention facilities to eliminate vulnerabilities ISIS may exploit in attempts to free detainees.

We also train our partner forces in Syria, many of whom are women, to guard the displaced persons camps. The training is key to keeping the residents safe, enabling access for aid organizations, and preventing the spread of extremism. Nonetheless, the longer that displaced persons remain in camps like Al Hol and Al Roj, the more likely they will succumb to ISIS ideology. Alongside our partners, we continue to identify and detain ISIS facilitators operating in the camps. To prevent the next generation of ISIS, the international community must sustain the recent momentum in repatriating and reintegrating displaced persons in their home countries.

Our Central and South Asian partners repeatedly share their concern over ISIS' pursuit of opportunity and capability to conduct external operations. The Taliban targeted some key ISIS-Khorasan (ISIS-K) leaders in 2023, but it has shown neither the capability nor the intent to sustain adequate counterterrorism pressure. In fact, this lack of sustained pressure allowed ISIS-K to regenerate and harden their networks, creating multiple redundant nodes that direct, enable, and inspire attacks. Additionally, the Taliban has shown little interest to apply counter-terrorism pressure against the Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan (TTP), presenting a significant threat to stability in Pakistan's border regions. We do not expect that dynamic to change.

These groups have leveraged poor economic conditions, lax governance in Afghanistan, and a sophisticated network to recruit, train, and sustain an expanding cadre of fighters.

Tragically, even as Iran undermines the Global Coalition in Iraq and Syria, ISIS-K killed 91 Iranians and injured 284 others in Kerman on 3 January 2024. This was the deadliest terror attack in Iran since 1979 and it is part of ISIS' efforts to exploit the war in Gaza to rejuvenate its global attacks. In retaliation, Iran further destabilized the region by carrying out strikes in Pakistan, Iraq, and Syria, drawing harsh condemnation from both Pakistani and Iraqi governments and reportedly causing civilian casualties in two of these incidents.

Al Qaeda, while weakened, still enjoys safe havens in Afghanistan and Yemen. Al Qaeda in the Indian Subcontinent (AQIS) operates training camps, safehouses, and religious schools in Afghanistan. Al Qaeda in the Arabian Peninsula (AQAP) launched a counter-offensive against Republic of Yemen Government forces in September 2023, likely to regain access to historically supportive areas in the southern governorates. Both AQIS and AQAP continue to call for lone wolf attacks on U.S. and Western interests via their global digital reach.

Opportunities to Counter VEOs

The enduring defeat of the ISIS depends on the repatriation and reintegration of displaced persons from camps like Al Hol and Al Roj, and our efforts to encourage this process gained traction in 2023. The international community repatriated 6,396 displaced persons from Syria, helping to reduce the population of Al Hol, the largest of the camps, by 18%. Iraq and Syria led the way on repatriating their citizens, while nations like the Kyrgyz Republic also set the example, conducting 332 repatriations in 2023. The Government of Iraq stepped up its efforts to shorten the average stay in its

rehabilitation centers, like Jeddah 1, which hold returning citizens until they can be reintegrated into society. This is also a moral imperative. In my six visits to Al Hol, I have met adolescent children who arrived in the camp as infants.

Our partners in Iraq and Syria, including Iraq's Counterterrorism Service and the Syrian Democratic Forces, continue to demonstrate improving capability, capacity, competency, and will. In 2023, the ISF conducted five independent D-ISIS operations without Coalition assistance. Funding mechanisms like the Counter-ISIS Train and Equip Fund (CTEF) are key to sustaining this progress and fully transitioning Iraq's security to Iraqi hands.

In August 2023, the D-ISIS mission in Iraq took a major step forward when the U.S. and Iraqi governments agreed at the Joint Security Cooperation Dialogue to form a Higher Military Commission (HMC), a consultative mechanism for the Coalition's transition. The HMC will enable the transition to an enduring bilateral security partnership between Iraq and the United States, on a timeline that factors in the threat from ISIS, operational and environmental requirements, and the capability of the ISF. CJTF-OIR, in lockstep with NATO Mission Iraq, will continue to train and develop the ISF until it is fully capable of independent operations.

In Central and South Asia, we can partner with countries like Pakistan, Tajikistan, and others to help them address the growing threat from the deteriorating security situation in Afghanistan. Our partners in the region consistently cite counterterrorism as one of their highest priorities for cooperation and combined training.

Risks to Countering VEOs

Despite gains in the Counter-VEO fight, various groups in the Central Region retain the capability and will to target U.S. interests abroad in under six months with little to no warning. We assess an attack on American soil would likely take longer. The reprioritization of intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance (ISR), targeting expertise, and linguists creates gaps and seams in our ability to detect and disrupt plots, increasing freedom of movement for VEOs to plan a strike against the Homeland. This could be partially mitigated by additional and alternative ISR assets and cooperation with our Central and South Asian partners.

Taliban pressure against ISIS-K temporarily disrupted the group's ability to plan and conduct attacks against the Homeland and Western targets, but that pressure has been intermittent and insufficient. ISIS-K and its allies retain a safe haven in Afghanistan, and they continue to develop their networks in and out of the country. Their goals do not stop there. They have called for attacks globally on anyone not aligned with their extremist ideology, and Taliban efforts to suppress the group have proven insufficient. The recent ISIS attack in Kerman, Iran demonstrates the group's resiliency and indicates that they retain the capability and will to conduct spectacular external operations.

Safe havens like Afghanistan also increase the risk of VEOs inciting regional conflict. VEOs killed at least 2,300 Pakistanis in 2023, with TTP in particular attacking Pakistan 881 times, the highest rate in over five years. In addition to hundreds of attacks by TTP, ISIS-K conducted at least three high profile bombings in Pakistan in 2023 and plotted to conduct more attacks throughout Central Asia. The Taliban's inability, or unwillingness, to rein in VEOs could destabilize Central and South Asia.

We must also prevent a premature Coalition departure from Iraq and Syria. If Iran and Russia were to succeed in their goal of pushing us out before our partner forces can operate independently, it is my assessment that ISIS would reconstitute the ability to seize territory within two years. The Global Coalition's sustained presence not only helps our partners in their fight against ISIS, it also prevents the reemergence of a physical caliphate and ensures the group does not have a safe haven in Iraq or Syria to plan global attacks. The eventual transition to a traditional security cooperation framework must be predicated on Partner Force Development and Security Sector Reform in Iraq, and continued repatriations, secure detention facilities, and a political pathway for the SDF in Syria.

Competing Strategically

Strategic competition is a contest of visions. The United States and our partners promote a vision in which the rules-based international order respects the sovereignty of nations and shared interests are advanced through the strength of partnership. The PRC, Russia, and Iran have deepened their partnership and collaboration as Iran seeks to strengthen its regional position, Russia leverages Iranian military support in Ukraine, and the PRC aims to exploit tensions in the region to afford them a position of advantage and diminishes US interests. According to public reporting, Supreme Leader Khamenei said in November 2023 that "death to America" is not just a slogan, it is a policy. The PRC and Russia increasingly contribute to Iran's goals through direct assistance or refusing to apply their own instruments of national power to discourage Iran's malign behaviors.

For nearly eighty years, since President Roosevelt met with King Ibn Saud aboard USS QUINCY, the United States has formed a network of hard-earned security partnerships with the Central Region. These partnerships are more than just objects to be guarded from competitors like the PRC and Russia, they must be nurtured and reinforced. Our partnerships are strategic high ground and represent a core strength of the United States. This is evidenced by our rapid response to recent trade disruptions caused by Houthi attacks in the Red Sea. The U.S. Fifth Fleet leveraged its decades-long relationships under CMF to bring together more than 20 nations under Operation Prosperity Guardian, which protects shipping through the critical Bab al Mandeb Strait in response to the Houthis' indiscriminate attacks. No other nation on Earth could generate an international response so quickly, and it would not have been possible without the trust and interoperability we have fostered among our allies and partners.

Our partnerships in the Central Region will become even more valuable as the transformation toward modernization and prosperity continues. Our partners want the United States to be part of this transformation, and our competitors know this. In 2023, the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia (KSA) continued to diversify its economy, exemplified by Western tourists strolling through massive shopping centers in Riyadh and ambitious megaprojects, while remaining dedicated to seeking peaceful coexistence with its neighbors. The United Arab Emirates (UAE) catapulted itself to global prominence in space, sending an astronaut to the International Space Station for six months and providing the world with a new map of Mars from its Hope Spacecraft, the second probe ever to successfully enter Mars orbit on its first try. Just a few months earlier, in November 2022, Qatar hosted the world's largest sporting event, the FIFA World Cup, for

the first time ever in the Central Region. American engagement has contributed to this transformation, and the Central Region of the future will remain open to those who continue to help it.

Strategic Competition with the People's Republic of China

With telecommunications and physical infrastructure, diplomacy, and security cooperation, the PRC is rapidly penetrating the Central Region and feeds misperceptions of American disengagement to try to supplant the United States as the security partner of choice. In late October 2023, the PRC's outgoing Naval Escort Task Force (NETF), which ostensibly counters piracy in the Gulf of Aden on rotational deployments since 2008, visited Kuwait, Qatar, UAE, and Pakistan before departing the theater. This unprecedented series of port calls was a milestone in the PRC's nascent campaign to gain security influence and access.

The term "security partner" means something very different to the PRC than it does to the United States. The PRC offers discounted sales and rapid delivery of military equipment, and the region is learning the hidden cost associated with these quick sales. When Chinese equipment performs poorly, there is no maintenance, logistics, or training architecture in place. Furthermore, the PRC shows no desire to support the region's security or stability with military forces. For example, the PRC's NETF in the Gulf of Aden has done nothing in the defense of international shipping under Houthi attack, nor has it responded to the recent series of piracy events in the Somali Basin, instead solely focusing on the protection of Chinese assets and interests.

Meanwhile, the PRC has also done little to rein in Iran's destabilizing behavior since

the much-touted rapprochement it brokered between Tehran and Riyadh in March 2023. Unfortunately, perhaps as evidence of the lack of depth of the arrangement and tepid commitment towards actual stability, Iran's actions following the agreement, including the continued arming of the Houthis, have undermined the very stability the relations were intended to achieve. It is noteworthy that the PRC buys 90% of exported Iranian oil, which they could use to influence Iranian lethal aid to the Houthis if they chose to. Instead, Beijing only helps Tehran evade sanctions and accelerate its destabilization of the region. The PRC's unwillingness, or inability, to enforce the terms of its own deal has contributed to Iran's disruption of the free flow of international commerce.

The Central Region is vital to the PRC achieving its goal of refashioning the international system to suit its interests and authoritarian preferences and become the world's leading power. Increased cooperation between the PRC and the Central Region advances its Belt and Road projects, strengthens bilateral relations, and helps regional countries diversify their economies. Trade between the PRC and the Central Region surpassed \$436 billion in 2022, and its investments in the region under the Belt and Road continued apace in 2023, with projects in telecommunications, construction, transportation, and more.

A key element of the Belt and Road seeks to create overland shipping routes between the PRC and Europe through Central and South Asia, which could bolster regional economies but also carries risk. For example, Pakistan is the world's third largest recipient of Chinese loans (behind Russia and Venezuela), receiving over \$67 billion to fund the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor. Now, amid its ongoing economic crisis, Pakistan is vulnerable to PRC influence.

We have also seen an incremental increase in Beijing's political investment in the region. In the past two years, Bahrain, Egypt, Kuwait, KSA, Qatar, and UAE became dialogue partners in the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, while Iran joined as a full member last year. This year, Egypt, UAE, and Iran formally joined BRICS. We now routinely see People's Liberation Army (PLA) general officers serving as Senior Defense Officials (SDO) or Defense Attachés, whereas just a few years ago, these would have been mid-grade officers.

The PRC relies on the region for its energy, importing 56% of its crude oil and 43% of natural gas from USCENTCOM AOR countries. The India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) announced last year by President Biden, along with six other countries and the European Union, offers a promising counterbalance to the PRC's Belt and Road. USCENTCOM's military-to-military relationships can provide critical and timely insight on projects that could be incorporated into IMEC. Time and time again, our partners tell us they would prefer to contract with U.S. or Western companies if a viable option were available.

We are at risk of deterioration in our strategic relationships and losing influence to Beijing in the Central Region if we cannot effectively assist our partners with their security needs. Our partners recognize the superior quality of our military equipment but, as the advent of drone warfare has demonstrated, even a third-rate product employed rapidly and in large quantities can be effective. Often, our partners cannot accommodate our FMS timelines and are forced to look elsewhere, opening doors for competitors like the PRC, who has increased arms sales to the region by 80% in the last decade.

We are also monitoring the potential expansion of PLA basing in the Central Region, beyond their current naval base in Djibouti and border outpost in Tajikistan. If the PRC were to secure additional PLA naval bases, it could give them the ability to hold our strategic lines of communication at risk. Even in ports where they have no intention of establishing a naval base, Chinese state-owned enterprises that own or operate terminals could give them considerable political influence to present us with logistical challenges in a future conflict.

Strategic Competition with Russia

Russia's goals in the Central Region are different from those of the PRC, but they are no less intent on diminishing American influence in the region. Russia's primary security interests in the region are maintaining its access in Syria, preserving its legacy Soviet status in Central Asia, and developing its military cooperation with Iran. Russia's two largest foreign bases are in Tajikistan and Syria, both in the USCENTCOM AOR. Further demonstrating the region's importance to Russia, Vladimir Putin's only international visits since he launched the invasion of Ukraine – outside of the PRC, Iran, and the former Soviet states – were to KSA and UAE.

Over the past year the collaboration between Russia and Iran grew into a nascent military alliance. Iran has delivered at least 1,000 attack drones, and dozens of multipurpose UAS, to Russia for use in Ukraine. With Iran's help, Russia plans to build 6,000 UAS domestically by 2025. After UN sanctions on Iran's missile program expired in October 2023, Russia now intends to purchase hundreds of Iranian ballistic missiles in the coming months, significantly increasing the risk of prolonging its war in Ukraine. In

return, Russia agreed to supply Iran with its advanced Su-35 fighter jets, attack helicopters, and training aircraft.

Our partners in Central Asia observed Russia's unprovoked invasions of Ukraine and Georgia, and its military's subsequent performance, raising doubts about its reliability as a security partner. Furthermore, the lack of intervention by the Russian-led Collective Security Treaty Organization in the conflict between Armenia and Azerbaijan, despite multiple Armenian requests, underscored the ineffectiveness of the alliance among the Central Asian states, many of whom are members. As a result, USCENTCOM has a generational opportunity to strengthen and expand our partnerships with Kazakhstan, the Kyrgyz Republic, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan.

We also have the opportunity to support U.S. European Command by coordinating across theater boundaries. When Russia uses the Central Region to evade sanctions or transport illicit war materiel, we can work with willing partners to frustrate its logistics. In addition, when we seize lethal aid that Iran smuggles to its proxies throughout the region, and when authorized by applicable law, we will work with the Interagency to transfer it to our Ukrainian partners, just as we did with 1.1 million rounds of seized rifle ammunition in October 2023.

The growing military alliance between Russia and Iran is expanding to new domains. Apart from Iran's proliferation of advanced weaponry with no export controls or end use monitoring, they are also cooperating in cyber and space. In March 2023, Russia sent Iran digital surveillance software, and Tehran is seeking more assistance. As of December 2023, the two countries are reportedly on the verge of signing a new long-

term comprehensive cooperation agreement covering defense, energy, and space sectors.

Russia welcomed Syria's reintegration into the Arab League in 2023, which boosted the status of one of its key regional partners while simultaneously ramping up pressure for the D-ISIS Coalition's withdrawal. Syria's reintegration was a lifeline for Assad, who has depended on a mixture of Russian and Iranian support and funding from drug smuggling to sustain his regime. Additionally, Russia's continued irresponsible and unprofessional behavior in Syrian airspace and on the electromagnetic spectrum needlessly raise the risk of miscalculation.

III. STRATEGIC APPROACH

USCENTCOM seizes the opportunities and mitigates the risks that arise in the Central Region through our strategic approach: People, Partners, and Innovation. My first two years in command reinforced the value of these three pillars. We've outlined this approach in our Theater Strategy, new Campaign Plan, and our approach to current operations. Our approach aligns with the 2022 NDS, which is a call to action to incorporate our unparalleled network of allies and partners. USCENTCOM will continue this approach as a security integrator in the region.

People

Our People – our servicemembers, civilian workforce, contractors, and supportive families – serve as the bedrock of everything we do. They are our greatest asset and our most critical resource. Our goal is to instill in them a sense of accomplishment, purpose, identity, and belonging. We recognize that the top talent in the workforce, both in and out

of uniform, have many options. As an actively engaged Combatant Command, we require the best, but also develop and cultivate expertise, so that the best want to work here.

We seek to attract and retain premier talent to meet our evolving needs. For example, we hired a team of experts to critically analyze our operations to ensure we do everything possible to preserve innocent life, in line with the Department's guidance to mitigate civilian harm. We also maintain a cadre of Interagency liaisons to support a Whole of Government strategy in the region, such as our USAID team that enables us to support humanitarian aid and disaster relief missions.

Our partners see the professionalism of our Service Members as we engage with them on a daily basis and seek to emulate their example through investment in reforms across their military formations. Our Non-Commissioned Officer (NCO) Corps is the envy of all other militaries, and we are working with many of our partners across the Central Region to build world-class NCO development and education systems. In Central Asia particularly, our partners are increasingly seeking our help with NCO development, as we've done with Kazakhstan over the past 30 years.

Our People are not just in our headquarters and in our subordinate commands, but across the enterprise that supports our operations, activities, and investments in the Central Region. Piecemeal reductions over time, such as rank reductions in our defense attaché positions and reallocation of analytical support across the intelligence community, have a cumulative effect. As necessary and logical resourcing decisions have been made to reprioritize assets against other emergent challenges, risk

accumulates over time if cuts are made too quickly or deeply. Much like blocks being removed from a Jenga tower, the impact may not be obvious at first, but eventually the tower will fall.

Finally, we are committed to bringing on individuals who can help accelerate innovation in USCENTCOM. In addition to our Chief Technology Officer, last year we hired our first Chief Data Officer and an AI & Robotics Advisor, both of whom will enable our digital modernization and shift toward data-centric operations. We then initiated our Technology Residency program in January of this year. The program will bring in exceptional talent from across the industrial base throughout the year to support us on a three to six-month timeline. The Residents will partner with elements of USCENTCOM staff and components to help tackle the friction points we encounter in our experimentation, aid in our data modernization efforts, and contribute key skillsets that are not organic to the Department of Defense.

Partners

Both the NSS and NDS emphasize the importance of partnership. The trusted relationships we've built with our partners over decades give us an advantage over competitors like the PRC and Russia, and sustaining that advantage is key to our strategic approach in the Central Region. We help our partners achieve competitive overmatch versus Iran and suppress VEOs through security integration and dependable cooperation, such as timely FMS and Foreign Military Funding. FMS in particular is a double-edged sword that can increase interoperability and strengthen partnerships, but the slow pace and complexity of the process often leads to resentment. Our partners

consistently express frustration with delays, issues, and insufficient explanations. In many cases, delays in our system – coupled with their security requirements – have led them to look to other nations to fill their needs.

Our fight against ISIS depends on multilateral constructs like NATO Mission Iraq and CJTF-OIR, and on our bilateral partnerships in Iraq and Syria. Our Coalition remains in Iraq at the invitation of the government. The Government of Iraq faces immense pressure from Iran to withdraw its invitation for Coalition presence, but they have resisted external manipulation thus far, even holding their first provincial elections in a decade in December 2023. Iraq is committed to cooperating with the United States, reforming its security sector, and realizing the full development of the ISF, which made strides in 2023. We are planning for an orderly transition to a normalized military-to-military relationship featuring traditional security cooperation. In Syria, the SDF remain committed to the enduring defeat of ISIS, in detention facilities, in displaced persons camps, and at large – despite facing an existential threat on their northern border and pressure from the Assad regime.

Our relationships with the militaries of the Levant Region helped keep HAMAS' attack on Israel from spiraling into a wider regional conflict. We have stood side by side with Israel, ensuring it has what it needs to defend itself, deter Iran and its proxies like Lebanese Hezbollah from getting further involved, and plan for a transition to post-conflict. Close coordination with our counterparts in Egypt, Jordan, and Lebanon allowed us to expedite the flow of humanitarian aid and facilitate safe operations for organizations like the UN Interim Force in Lebanon. Our partners in the Levant also contribute valuable forces and expertise to regional security constructs like MEAD and CMF.

Integrating the security efforts of our Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) partners is the linchpin of our strategy to deter Iranian aggression. GCC members are moving toward operational coordination in the defense of their territorial airspace and waters, bilaterally and via multilateral constructs like MEAD, CMF, and IMSC. Specifically, KSA is enabling interoperability by transforming its Ministry of Defense to more closely mirror the U.S. model for national defense. Qatar's Air Force contributes aircraft to our daily operations throughout the region. The UAE just completed its second company-level rotation to our Joint Readiness Training Center, with the goal of fielding a brigade completely interoperable with U.S. Forces by 2028.

Together, the GCC countries can stand strong against Iran. Still, the strategic importance of the GCC goes beyond any singular adversary. GCC countries host the U.S. Fifth Fleet in Bahrain, the headquarters for CJTF-OIR in Kuwait, and our theater air operations center and the largest U.S. military base in the region in Qatar. The Gulf is also home to the region's economic power centers in KSA and UAE, and the diplomatic efforts of partners like Qatar and Oman have helped resolve multiple crises and return American citizens home safely.

In September 2023, USCENTCOM held its Central and South Asian Chiefs of Defense Conference in Uzbekistan for the first time in two years, an indication of our steadily growing relationships. Our Central Asian partners are cautiously optimistic about the prospect of increased security cooperation, especially border defense, counterterrorism, institutional capacity building, and military medicine. We are also beginning more advanced training like cybersecurity and special operations with some partners. With the region's strategic location between Iran, Afghanistan, the PRC, and

Russia, this momentum in our military-to-military relationships is invaluable to our national security but it also places constraints on our partners. We intend to continue cooperation, via programs like International Military Education and Training and the State Partnership Program, at a pace with which our Central Asian partners are individually comfortable.

In South Asia, Pakistan has had a deep and multi-faceted strategic partnership with the PRC since the 1960s. Ties between the two countries deepened further in the early 2000's as the two countries developed shared concerns about the rise of India as a regional power. Since 2015, nearly 75% of Pakistani arms imports came from the PRC, which represents 40% of Chinese arms exports, making Pakistan Beijing's largest security customer. Nevertheless, Pakistan seeks U.S. security and economic assistance. Considering the weight that Pakistan carries throughout Asia, we must approach our relationship from the perspective of its own merits. Any security strategy in Afghanistan will require Pakistan's help. They have invaluable expertise, access, and geographic location for countering ISIS-K, and they are willing and capable counterterrorism partners as they face persistent threats from VEOs like TTP.

Finally, our global partners provide invaluable contributions to USCENTCOM operations in support of our mutual interests. Our "Five Eyes" partners (Australia, Canada, United Kingdom, and New Zealand) share intelligence and commit forces across all three of our lines of effort. In addition, France continues to be a ready and willing military partner in defeating ISIS, countering Russia, and deterring Iranian aggression at sea.

Innovation

In USCENTCOM, we are not just experimenting with new technologies - we are developing innovative processes, building innovative teams while encouraging individual contributions, and responding to emerging threats in innovative ways. Importantly, our personnel use the capabilities that we are developing in real world operations today. We are helping to create America's military of the future, not waiting for it.

USCENTCOM has implemented a wide range of mechanisms and processes to drive innovation. The Combined Joint All-Domain Command and Control (CJADC2) software suite USCENTCOM employs today is drastically different from the C2 systems used in counterinsurgency operations of the past twenty years. The persistent and multidomain threat created by Iran's ongoing proliferation of advanced weaponry to its proxies necessitates decision-making tools that enable seamless command and control functions from the tactical to the strategic level in real time. The importance of speed and a holistic approach in seeing, understanding, and acting cannot be overstated. The CJADC2 software suite we have tested, and now use daily, enabled us to thwart numerous ITN attacks. This momentum must be continued and accelerated through the Combatant Commands under the Department's strategy. These efforts are complementary to ongoing work across the Department, and we have hosted senior officials from across the entire enterprise to share our lessons learned and help the Joint Force modernize.

Since January 2023, we have conducted a series of quarterly digital exercises, preceded by month-long software sprints, to develop the tools needed for CJADC2. CJADC2 is more than just a concept for us, it is a daily activity that we are improving with

each exercise. By pairing operators with software developers, we are proving that we can use digital tools to improve our situational awareness, make our targeting more efficient and effective, improve our planning and sustainment processes, and embody true digital warfighting. Exercises like these demonstrate the value of hands-on training with live data and the centrality of robust networks in CJADC2. We nest our exercises and experimentation under DoD efforts such as the Global Information Dominance Experiment series.

In addition to quarterly CJADC2 exercises, we have driven other events to encourage innovative thinking and solutions. In 2023, we continued our Innovation Oasis, a “Shark Tank” style competition open to the entire USCENTCOM enterprise. The winning ideas are rapidly introduced to the force, such as an intuitive software tool for managing force flow into theater that won last year’s competition and is already in use across the Command. This is indicative of how we look for innovative responses to our most pressing challenges. For the counter-UAS problem, we developed a series of tailored “SANDS” exercises to address the problem’s many unique aspects, and established an integrated experimentation center in KSA where we can test the newest technology alongside our partners. Another example is cybersecurity. In 2023, we held a “Best Cyber Warrior” competition in Oman. Exercises and training events with our partners in rapidly developing fields like counter-UAS and cybersecurity are key to establishing regional competitive overmatch versus Iran.

We also organized our subordinate commands to encourage innovation, with each now operating an innovation task force tailored to their unique domain. On land, Task Force 39 is experimenting with additive manufacturing, counter-UAS technologies, and

unmanned logistics vehicles.

At sea, Task Force 59 has not only revolutionized how the U.S. Navy incorporates robotic and AI systems, but now contributes daily to regional maritime security, and encourages partner investments in unmanned surface and subsurface vehicles. Last year we launched Operation GATEKEEPER, the largest operational employment of multinational unmanned surface vessels in the world. GATEKEEPER allows us and our partners to not only increase maritime domain awareness across 18,000 square kilometers in the North Arabian Sea, but unlike an operation with manned assets, it enables continuous presence.

In the air, Task Force 99 is testing a wide range of new technologies to expand our air superiority, including long endurance ISR platforms that can fly for days and low-cost 3D-printed UAS, some built for as little as \$3,000 in eight hours. Task Force 99 is also experimenting with new tools for expeditionary aviation logistics and exploring new ways to detect and counter jamming.

Our special operations innovation task force, TF 179, is developing digital and unmanned solutions for ISR, target information sharing, electronic warfare, and payload delivery. For example, TF 179 takes advantage of USSOCOM's rapid acquisition capabilities to field disposable, swarming unmanned systems that can be employed unilaterally or through a surrogate force as a one-way attack platform, electronic warfare delivery, or tactical ISR.

IV. CONCLUSION

The United States cannot just articulate a vision of integration and partnership for a

brighter future that aligns the interests of the United States and our partners; we must match that vision with the commitment necessary to give partners the confidence to continue on that path with us. There is a narrative that the Central Region is too fraught with turmoil to be considered worthy of American investment. Twenty-plus years of American military engagement in both Iraq and Afghanistan play to this narrative. But the past, while it may serve as prologue, does not predetermine the future. The vision, the hopes, and the ambitions of our partners throughout the Central Region are palpable and they are real. Equally real are those recidivist forces attempting to undermine those who seek progress, pulling them back into a past checkered with violence and disorder.

We are and should remain engaged in every corner of the Central Region, from Egypt to Kazakhstan and from Lebanon to Pakistan, strengthening our partners and securing our vital national interests. Our Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen, Marines, Guardians, and Coast Guardsmen are executing critical operations that contribute to the collective security of the US and our partners. They operate in harm's way each day: whether it is an F-15 pilot flying missions in support of our Iraqi partners; the USS CARNEY patrolling the Red Sea and defeating Houthi attacks; a Patriot Battery protecting our forces and those of our partners; a Marine Task Force ready to respond to crisis; a U.S. Space Force detachment combatting adversary attempts at jamming; or a U.S. Coast Guard boarding team interdicting a shipment of Iranian weapons. The women and men of U.S. Central Command remain committed to the vision of a stable Central Region in which U.S. national interests are secure and our partners prosper.

UNITED STATES HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
ARMED SERVICES COMMITTEE

STATEMENT OF
GENERAL CHRISTOPHER G. CAVOLI, UNITED STATES ARMY
UNITED STATES EUROPEAN COMMAND

8 APRIL 2025

UNITED STATES HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
ARMED SERVICES COMMITTEE

Chairman Rogers, Ranking Member Smith, and distinguished members of the House Armed Services Committee, as the Commander, U.S. European Command (USEUCOM) it is my distinct honor to testify before you again on behalf of our dedicated service members and their families in the European theater.

Since the end of World War II, the security and prosperity of the United States have been linked with security in Europe. Transatlantic trade amounts to \$6.9 trillion annually, the most we share with any nation or organization in the world. In Europe, our “Access, Basing and Overflight” agreements give us the ability to intercept threats before they approach the United States, to project U.S. combat power globally, and to deter Russian aggression against NATO.

The Alliance’s military forces are in the process of an historic transformation to be fit for deterrence now and in the future. USEUCOM has a direct role in accelerating NATO’s modernization, readiness, and warfighting capabilities, which will drive the Alliance to assume greater responsibility and leadership for European security.

The Euro-Atlantic Security Environment

The United States today confronts the most challenging threats in the European theater since the end of the Cold War. Russia’s brutal war in Ukraine just entered its fourth year, and Russia remains willing to use military force to accomplish its geopolitical objectives. These include ambitions to expand its territorial control; broaden its influence regionally and globally; and diminish U.S. leadership and influence. Russia is actively conducting a destabilization campaign within Europe intended to create strategic dilemmas for the United States. Furthermore, Russia’s ongoing effort to develop a massive military larger than its pre-war force, combined with its propensity to absorb military, political, and economic costs to achieve its strategic goals, indicate that Russia poses an enduring threat to the United States, our NATO Allies, and global security. This threat is intensified by Russia’s strengthened relationships with the Chinese Communist Party (CCP), the Democratic People’s Republic of Korea (DPRK), and

the Republic of Iran (Iran). Together, this group of adversaries seeks to undermine U.S. and Allied advantages and challenge our vital interests at home and abroad.

Russia continues to pursue strategic objectives that undermine the United States. While the war in Ukraine has been Russia's focus and the most visible sign of Moscow's great power ambitions, Russia's strategic objectives are centered on attaining unencumbered influence in its near-abroad and greater international power while diminishing the leadership and influence of the United States. The Kremlin openly communicates its desire for an alternative to NATO as the European security architecture, to expand Russia's military, and to increase force presence in key locations along NATO borders. Following the old Soviet playbook, Russia is engaging in a calculated destabilization campaign through cyberattacks on infrastructure, public sabotage, targeted violence, weaponized migration, election interference, and information operations. These activities have serious consequences for the freedoms and prosperity we enjoy in the United States. Taken together, they confirm the chronic threat that Russia poses to U.S. interests.

Within this broader context, the war in Ukraine is fundamentally about creating opportunities for Russia to gain geopolitical advantages and denying them to NATO. The scale of violence on the battlefields in Kursk, Donetsk, and Bakhmut demonstrates Russia's willingness to employ brutal means in pursuit of its goals. Now entangled in an extended, large-scale war, the Russian regime has refashioned its military, economic, and social structures to sustain what it describes as a long-term confrontation with the West—systemic changes that illustrate Russia's intention to confront us into the foreseeable future.

Russian Reconstitution

Despite extensive battlefield losses in Ukraine, the Russian military is reconstituting and growing at a faster rate than most analysts had anticipated. In fact, the Russian army, which has borne the brunt of combat, is today larger than it was at the beginning of the war—despite suffering an estimated 790,000 casualties. In December 2024, Moscow ordered the military to

increase its strength to 1.5 million active service members and is recruiting approximately 30,000 troops per month. Russian forces on the frontlines of Ukraine are now at over 600,000, the highest level over the course of the war and almost double the size of the initial invasion force.

Russia is not just reconstituting service members but is also replacing combat vehicles and munitions at an unprecedented pace. Russian ground forces in Ukraine have lost an estimated 3,000 tanks, 9,000 armored vehicles, 13,000 artillery systems, and over 400 air defense systems in the past year—but is on pace to replace them all. Russia has expanded its industrial production, opened new manufacturing facilities, and converted commercial production lines for military purposes. As a result, the Russian defense industrial base is expected to roll out 1,500 tanks, 3,000 armored vehicles, and 200 Iskander ballistic and cruise missiles this year. (Comparatively, the United States only produces about 135 tanks per year and no longer produces new Bradley Fighting Vehicles.) Additionally, we anticipate Russia to produce 250,000 artillery shells per month, which puts it on track to build a stockpile three times greater than the United States and Europe combined.

Not all of Russia's military capability has been degraded by the war. Russia continues to hold the largest nuclear weapons stockpile in the world. Russia's nuclear arsenal is composed of an estimated 2,500-3,500 high- and low-yield warheads, which can be tailored for use on the battlefield or employed strategically. Recently, the Kremlin updated its nuclear policy, which is intended to communicate a lower nuclear threshold and outlines the range of contingencies that could justify the use of nuclear weapons. Russia also maintains robust chemical and biological weapons programs and has repeatedly used the chemical weapon chloropicrin and riot control agents as a method of warfare across the frontlines of Ukraine, in violation of its obligations under the Chemical Weapons Convention. Within its air and maritime capabilities, Russia has sustained only minor losses in Ukraine. The Russian Aerospace Force currently retains over 1,100 combat-capable aircraft that include Su-57 stealth fighters and Tu-95 and Tu-160

strategic bombers. Aside from some losses in its Black Sea Fleet, the Russian Navy remains intact, with over 60 submarines and 42 surface vessels capable of launching nuclear-tipped Kalibr cruise missiles.

Russian commanders still emphasize quantity and mass over skill and operational acumen. However, the poorly resourced and disorganized Russian forces we saw during the initial invasion have improved significantly. Russian formations are gaining combat experience. The military has demonstrated its ability to learn from the battlefield, disseminate new concepts across organizations, and counter Ukrainian tactical and technical advantages. It has implemented rapid cycles of adaptation and is developing new capabilities to accelerate force modernization. In November 2024, the Russian military conducted its first strike on a Ukrainian military facility with the new Oreshnik intermediate-range ballistic missile. Russian officials have stated this missile could be equipped with a nuclear warhead. We have seen Russian forces employ new, domestically produced electronic countermeasures against Ukrainian jamming technology to improve strike efficacy. Additionally, Russian ground forces are integrating reconnaissance and one-way attack drones into their offensives on the battlefield. Russia is also expanding its undersea capabilities through the addition of Severodvinsk-II class nuclear-powered cruise missile attack submarines, Dolgorukiy II-class nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarines, and other undersea reconnaissance capabilities both in the European and Indo-Pacific theaters. These new capabilities show that the Russian military is intent on gaining tactical and operational advantage for the future battlefield.

To support Russia's growing military apparatus, the Kremlin has established economic policies to restructure its financial institutions and defense industry. In September 2024, Russia announced a 25% increase in defense spending, which represents 6.3% of its Gross Domestic Product (GDP). This marks the fourth consecutive year that Russia increased its defense spending to fund the war in Ukraine and resource plans that expand its active military. All told, Russia's defense budget will account for 40% of all government expenditures which is at its

highest level since the Cold War. As a direct result of its defense spending, Russian investments in its industrial base have reduced national unemployment to 2.4%. The Russian economy is on a war footing and will remain so for the foreseeable future.

Russia's Strategic Partnerships

Further complicating the global security environment and threatening the United States are Russia's deepening strategic partnerships with our adversaries. Russia's increasing collusion with the CCP, the DPRK, and Iran serves as a force multiplier for Moscow's geopolitical goals. The group shares Russia's vision of a multipolar world and is providing an economic lifeline to Moscow. To avoid Western sanctions, the CCP and Russia are increasing the use of national currencies to conduct trade outside of SWIFT, using non-traditional finance options for business transactions, and employing financial techniques to bypass secondary sanctions. Half of Russia's energy exports currently go to China, and Russia's use of a "shadow fleet" allows it to circumvent the U.S. and G7+ partners' oil price cap policy.

Just as concerning as stronger economic ties is the increasing military collaboration between these nations. Russia's introduction of 12,000 North Korean troops into the Kursk oblast this past fall constituted an egregious escalation of the conflict. It also has global ramifications, creating the opportunity for North Korean soldiers to gain experience from modern combat and take their lessons back to the Indo-Pacific. The DPRK is providing millions of artillery shells, missiles, and weapon systems to fuel Russian operations in Ukraine, with more than 13,000 containers of supplies delivered to Russia in the past year. In exchange, Russia is almost certainly transferring missile technology to Pyongyang. The two countries further solidified their relationship by signing a mutual defense treaty in June 2024, reaffirming their wide-ranging cooperation. Iran also continued its material support for Russia, donating over 400 short-range ballistic missiles and hundreds of thousands of artillery shells. Beyond the munitions, Iran expanded its own industrial capacity to sell thousands of Shahed one-way attack drones. Tehran also provided Moscow with the licenses and technology to manufacture

thousands more Shaheds in Russia. And, similar to the DPRK, Tehran also signed the Iranian Russian Treaty on Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with Moscow in January 2025.

Russia's "no limits" partnership with the CCP is creating military opportunities for our adversaries to directly hold U.S. interests at risk. In the past year, Russia and the CCP conducted two combined bomber patrols—from Russia—one over the Bering Sea and another over the Sea of Japan. These patrols marked the first time Chinese bombers departed from the same airbase with Russian bombers, the first time Chinese bombers entered the Alaskan Air Defense Identification Zone, and the first time Chinese nuclear-capable H-6N bombers took part in a combined patrol. In the maritime domain, the CCP and Russia conducted their fourth annual combined naval exercise, while their coast guards conducted their first combined patrol in the northern Pacific. As the Arctic ice cap recedes, both the CCP and Russia are looking to exploit the new navigable waterways. Meanwhile in the land domain, Russia and the CCP continue to expand the scope of their regularly conducted, combined-military exercises and increase their training on more sophisticated weapons platforms.

The CCP also seeks to create opportunities in Europe to exert its global influence and fracture the West. For instance, the CCP's strategic investments with individual European countries cause potential strain within the NATO Alliance. CCP state-owned enterprises continue to make substantial investments into European commercial ports, handling over 10% of Europe's port capacity. Fourteen European ports near, or co-located with, logistics hubs that move equipment and forces have significant CCP investment, which creates risks for the United States and NATO Alliance. While many European countries recognize the national security risks associated with CCP state-owned enterprises, Beijing is pushing to expand telecommunication services, green-energy companies, and electric vehicle industries within Europe. These investments may create economic growth, but they also pose security risks and offer openings for China and Russia to degrade U.S. interests and sow disunity among Allies.

The deepening economic and military partnerships between Russia, the CCP, the DPRK, and Iran are indicative of a more intricate and global threat. These close partnerships underscore that the United States is increasingly likely to face multiple threats simultaneously. Moreover, our adversaries are learning from the war in Ukraine and accelerating the exchange of military technologies. These dynamics will shape the future threat environment, not only in Europe, but also in the Indo-Pacific and the Middle East.

Threats on the Periphery

Russia is exploiting the volatility in high-risk regions of Europe to expand its influence at the expense of the United States. In Georgia, the pro-Russian Georgia Dream party has aligned Tbilisi closer to Moscow. In Moldova, Russian influence in the November 2024 presidential election intensified as Moscow engaged in fraudulent vote-buying, election related cyberattacks, and false bomb threats against polling stations, as well as employing trained agitators to incite disorder. Since the spring of 2024, Russia has been working to steer the Western Balkans away from Euro-Atlantic integration through key-leader rhetoric, information operations, diplomatic outreach, and economic influence. Russia also courted Serbian and Bosnian-Serb officials who moved closer into the Kremlin's orbit following their participation at the October 2024 BRICS summit in Kazan, Russia.

Russia's intention is clear—it seeks to destabilize European security, increase its regional and global power, and decrease U.S. global strength. Russia is willing to sustain the high costs of a prolonged war in Ukraine; engage in a destabilization campaign against the West; build threatening relationships with the CCP, the DPRK, and Iran; and cause instability in other regions of the world.

USEUCOM's Strategic Imperatives

USEUCOM contributes to U.S. strength, safety, and prosperity through three strategic imperatives: Defend the homeland forward; Project U.S. combat power globally; and Deter Russian aggression.

By virtue of USEUCOM's strategic location in Europe, our fundamental mission is to defend the homeland forward. As an example, USEUCOM operates in the northern Atlantic Ocean to prevent Russian nuclear-capable undersea forces from maneuvering within cruise-missile range of the United States. Preventing a Russian breakout across the Atlantic requires USEUCOM, along with our Allies, to posture, integrate, and employ a suite of capabilities to deter and block Moscow from threatening the homeland.

Defending the homeland also requires deep intelligence structures and relationships that provide us with invaluable and sensitive information critical to U.S. national security. Our ability to gather this intelligence is enabled through enduring relationships with our European Allies. These relationships cannot develop episodically; they must be sustained by enduring U.S. engagement.

Projecting U.S. power is a fundamental task for USEUCOM. U.S. power projection platforms in Europe require "Access, Basing, and Overflight" agreements from the countries we seek to operate in and from. These legally binding and politically agreed arrangements enable the United States to project U.S. combat power not just within Europe, but globally. For example, the arrangements we have in Europe proved crucial in 2024 for the United States' support of the defense of Israel. USEUCOM directly supported U.S. Central Command's (USCENTCOM) efforts in the Israel-Hamas conflict by providing Ballistic Missile Defense (BMD) capable ships to the Eastern Mediterranean, as well as sharing sensor data that enables USCENTCOM BMD protection capabilities. These cross-Combatant Command operations demonstrate the efficiencies that USEUCOM's force projection capabilities provide against DoD's many global priorities. The politically binding nature of the agreements that enable USEUCOM's power projection capability require the host nations in Europe to know that we will honor and respect their interests and that we will not violate their hospitality. This requires trust and confidence between both the United States and individual European nations. In exchange, we enjoy unparalleled responsiveness in crises.

Finally, USEUCOM deters Russian aggression against NATO. Credible deterrence requires the presence of combat-capable forces and a sufficient force presence to convince Russia that any military action harmful to the interests of the United States will be met with force. Therefore, USEUCOM must prepare the forces assigned and allocated to us to fight and win; and develop key infrastructure throughout the theater to support readiness and operations.

USEUCOM Postured Across Europe

Our brave service members professionally represent the United States Army, Navy, Air Force, Marine Corps, Space Force, Coast Guard, and Special Operations Forces, all of whom remain steadfast in our mission to deter an expanding Russian threat. Their dedicated efforts secure the United States forward, advance American national interests, and advance the shared interests we maintain with our Allies.

USEUCOM currently commands nearly 80,000 American service members throughout the European theater. This is a reduction from the 105,000 service members postured in Europe after Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022 and represents about 20% of the U.S. forces that were stationed in Europe during the Cold War to deter the Soviet Union.

Deterrence is most challenging in the land domain. Russia continues to reconstitute its conventional forces, and possesses advantages in geography, domain, and readiness. A conventional fight with Russia will be decided on land, and it would likely begin with a comparatively large Russian force positioned on a NATO border in order to negate traditional U.S. and NATO advantages in, and preferences for, long-range, standoff warfare. Therefore, NATO, including USEUCOM, must be postured to blunt Russia's ability to rapidly mass numerically superior land forces.

In the air domain, USEUCOM and Allies require a combination of standoff and survivable, distributed capabilities to identify, target, and engage attacking forces at the outset of conflict in a heavily contested environment. USEUCOM established one F-35 squadron at Royal Air Force (RAF) Lakenheath in the United Kingdom, which is now fully operational. A

second squadron of F-35s will be complete this summer and will achieve full operational capability this fall. These two squadrons will replace fourth-generation aircraft currently stationed in Europe with more advanced fifth-generation capabilities. To enable aerospace lethality, USEUCOM continues to work with our Allies and partners to implement the U.S. Air Force's Agile Combat Employment (ACE) concept. Once fully realized, ACE is envisioned to support American and Allied aircraft with shared infrastructure in multiple locations throughout Europe, enabling our air forces to become more dynamic and survivable against our adversaries' air and anti-air defense capabilities. This includes integrating U.S. and NATO command-and-control structures that provide early warning and detection against Russian conventional and nuclear-capable forces. Should Russia mobilize its conventional forces, the NATO Alliance will be able to activate its defense plans and respond with force. If NATO's alert system detects Russian nuclear activity, USEUCOM provides an essential component of the U.S. nuclear umbrella that helps to guarantee our Allies' security.

In the maritime domain, surface, sub-surface, and land-based capabilities protect the homeland forward, ensure transatlantic-power projection, defend key maritime terrain and lines of communication, and represent a critical leg of our nuclear triad. The USS Oscar Austin, the fifth Arleigh Burke-class guided missile destroyer committed to the European theater, arrived in Rota, Spain this past October. The USS Oscar Austin expands our anti-air and anti-submarine warfare capabilities across the European theater. USEUCOM awaits the arrival of its sixth Arleigh Burke-class guided missile destroyer soon, as well as receiving a new Auxiliary General Ocean class surveillance ship to expand our underwater surveillance and detection capabilities. These maritime capabilities complement the U.S. Marine Corps' presence in the High North, Baltic Sea, Black Sea, and Mediterranean to enable sea control from the shore. USEUCOM also conducts air and maritime patrols in the High North alongside our Nordic Allies and the United Kingdom. These operations demonstrate freedom of navigation in Arctic waters and support international maritime law.

In the cyber domain, USEUCOM receives direct support from U.S. Cyber Command (USCYBERCOM) through the Joint Force Headquarters – Cyber. It is responsible for the planning, oversight, and management of cyber operations within the theater. Additionally, each service component has a robust cyber capability to protect its networks from external threats. Finally, USEUCOM collaborates with USCYBERCOM to enhance both offensive and defensive cyber capabilities, leveraging coordination with our Allies and partners. This initiative aims to deter advanced, persistent threats and bolster the resilience of the NATO Alliance.

In the space domain, our newest service component, U.S. Space Forces Europe and Africa, continues to build its capabilities since activation in December 2023. Capitalizing on our space capability advantages requires forward-positioned equipment and Guardians to operate it. These capabilities, particularly assets that are strategically tethered in Europe and supported by our Allies, provide us the ability to deliver space effects globally against all our adversaries. Our space component has rapidly built relationships with NATO Allies to increase Allied contributions to our collective security from space-based threats. It remains integral to creating a networked, joint-space architecture responsible for protecting space assets and to deliver space-related benefits across the entire globe.

USEUCOM's Special Operations Forces (SOF) maintain a persistent presence across 28 European countries. These forces focus on tasks to bolster deterrence and set conditions to prevail in conflict, recently expanding our relationships with Nordic nations. Moreover, Special Operations Command Europe and NATO Allied Special Operations Forces Command recently merged under U.S. command, which improves European SOF capability under the leadership of a single U.S. commanding general.

USEUCOM's Operations, Activities, and Investments (OAI)

USEUCOM's OAIs send a clear and credible deterrent message to Russia and other U.S. adversaries that the United States is ready, willing, and able to defend U.S. interests in the Euro-Atlantic area. Our OAIs don't just deter adversaries and promote stability, they also

reassure our Allies and partners of the U.S. commitment to security. This commitment is global: USEUCOM also conducts OAs in support of other U.S. Combatant Commands in order to deter interconnected threats from Russia, the CCP, the DPRK, and Iran.

USEUCOM's OAs are vital to our ability to build well-trained, interoperable, and combat-ready forces. We do this alongside our NATO Allies through an extensive joint and multinational exercise program. Continuing these exercises to build interoperable, combat-ready, and lethal forces is critical to expanding NATO's warfighting capabilities. To improve preparedness for conflict, USEUCOM and NATO are developing realistic training scenarios for these events that simulate the plausible pathways to conflict that provide a credible threat for our forces to train against. All told, these training exercises represent a mind-set shift toward collective defense and warfighting for high-intensity conflict alongside our NATO Allies.

U.S. investments through the European Deterrence Initiative (EDI) support USEUCOM's ability to build readiness and deter aggression. EDI funding supports the rotational deployment of U.S. forces to Europe, generates readiness through exercises and training, expands the pre-positioning of combat-credible forces, improves military infrastructure, and builds interoperability with our NATO Allies and European partners.

In executing EDI-funded projects, we seek to share costs with our Allies. For example, Poland leveraged NATO Security Investment Program funds to build a \$325 million storage facility for a U.S. armored BCT equipment set at the Army Prepositioned Stocks site in Powidz. The Polish Army will also maintain the equipment in accordance with the U.S.-Poland Enhanced Defense Cooperation Agreement.

In addition to deterring Russian aggression against NATO on behalf of the DoD, USEUCOM coordinates and executes U.S. security assistance to Ukraine. Since 2022, USEUCOM's Security Assistance Group – Ukraine (SAG-U) has delivered to Ukraine \$65.9 billion in munitions, weapons, vehicles, and other assistance. SAG-U's mission is to support security-assistance activities, coordinate training, oversee efforts to supply and equip the Armed

Forces of Ukraine (AFU), and enhance Ukraine's situational awareness. This security assistance has enabled Ukraine to defend itself from Russian attack, providing opportunities for the Joint Force to learn and adapt from observed battlefield successes and challenges.

In December, NATO stood up the NATO Security Assistance and Training for Ukraine (NSATU), which has assumed the mission to create enduring, predictable, and coherent support to Ukraine through the coordination of Allied logistics, training, and planning efforts. This also means NATO is responsible for defending logistical nodes on NATO's eastern flank that the Allies use to support and train the AFU. The creation of NSATU is a huge step for NATO to assume a greater role in supporting Ukraine's self-defense.

Our NATO Allies have also made substantial contributions to Ukraine's defense, allocating more than \$60 billion in military assistance to support Ukraine's war effort. In some cases, NATO Allies donated their entire inventory of certain weapon systems. To backfill these systems, our Allies purchased upgraded replacements from U.S. companies. From FY 17-21, the FMS portfolio for our European Allies averaged \$11 billion annually; but in FY 24 it was \$68 billion—a 600% increase. However, insufficient production capacity across the Defense Industrial Base (DIB) is delaying the replacement of these systems and creating strategic risks for not only our NATO Allies, but also U.S. forces. Despite foreign governments investing more into the U.S. DIB, many critical systems—such as HIMARs, F-35s, Patriots, and infantry fighting vehicles—are not delivering on time. The problem of slow production is compounded by frustration with an overly expensive, slow, and increasingly mistake-prone Foreign Military Sales (FMS) system, and Allies are increasingly likely to look elsewhere for armaments. USEUCOM engages with our Allies on this issue daily and is working with the DoD on FMS and broader armaments cooperation to encourage the U.S. defense industry to produce sustainable capabilities and deliver them quickly.

Strengthening NATO

Our NATO Allies have embarked upon an historic effort to modernize the Alliance's systems and readiness for collective defense, and they are demonstrating resolve in reorienting towards that traditional mission. Considerable progress has been made over the past year.

The three Regional Plans approved at the 2023 NATO Summit in Vilnius continue to serve as the blueprint for the modernization efforts. First, these plans define a force structure requirement that outlines the exact military capabilities that NATO will need to execute the plans—and assign specific capability targets for each Ally. Nations now have an objective, plans-based “shopping list” for their defense spending and are using this framework to drive their national procurement processes. To meet these requirements, nations are investing at an unprecedented rate.

Second, the Alliance has restructured its command-and-control systems to better synchronize multi-domain operations for high-intensity conflict. Headquarters are linked to specific terrain which enhances interoperability with assigned units and generates readiness for large-scale territorial defense.

Third, Allies have delegated operational decision-making and many basic military authorities to the Supreme Allied Commander Europe that had previously been withheld at the political level. This now grants Allied military structures the ability to act and react at the speed of relevance in the current security environment. There are already instances of these new authorities rapidly enabling activities, such as the ongoing efforts in the Baltic Sea to protect critical undersea infrastructure and employment of the Allied Reaction Force in the Western Balkans.

USEUCOM is accelerating NATO's modernization for collective defense and ownership of European security through the ruthless prioritization of warfighting capabilities and readiness within the Alliance. The United States leads the combined militaries of 32 Allied nations across the Euro-Atlantic. USEUCOM's warfighting-focused and plans-based approach builds the

Alliance capability required for collective defense while enabling the U.S. Joint Force greater strategic flexibility to address other global priorities.

Conclusion

USEUCOM maintains the capability and capacity to defend the homeland forward, project U.S. combat power globally, and deter Russian aggression against NATO in support of U.S. interests. Moscow's ongoing war in Ukraine, destabilization campaign against the West, societal mobilization for war, and growing strategic partnerships with our adversaries all indicate that Russia will continue to threaten U.S. security and economic interests well into the future. Therefore, the United States and NATO need to continue to prepare to meet this threat. USEUCOM is helping to prepare the Alliance by increasing European ownership of European security; prioritizing warfighting in everything we do; and building readiness to execute the defense plans. All of this requires U.S. leadership, continued investment in advanced capabilities, and a sustainable transition to an Allied-led defense in Europe. The global threats we face today are significant, perhaps never more so than since the end of the Cold War. Through USEUCOM, with the strength and professionalism of our forces and NATO's commitment to collective defense, our investments in Europe today will secure the peace for our future.

STATEMENT OF
GENERAL MICHAEL E. LANGLEY, UNITED STATES MARINE CORPS
COMMANDER, UNITED STATES AFRICA COMMAND
BEFORE THE
UNITED STATES SENATE
COMMITTEE ON ARMED SERVICES

3 April 2025

Chairman Wicker, Ranking Member Reed, distinguished Committee Members, United States Africa Command (USAFRICOM) is committed to and focused on safeguarding the homeland from threats emanating from Africa, protecting vital U.S. interests by countering adversary efforts, and responding to crises across the African continent. We are steadfast in our commitment to the American people, and our method is sound: we work together with likeminded Allies and partners to enable security solutions that protect our interests.

Africa is a “nexus theater” – a continent where global interests converge. The population will grow to 25% of the world’s population by 2050, and currently boasts the largest youth demographic, along with rapidly urbanizing societies. Africa accounted for 11 of the world’s 20 fastest growing economies in 2024, and the 54 sovereign countries make up more than 25% of the seats in the United Nations General Assembly. For these reasons, Africa is a continent from which the United States cannot afford to shift its gaze. It is imperative that we create conditions where terrorist organizations and malign actors are unable to threaten our homeland, while simultaneously creating conditions for American economic interests to flourish.

USAFRICOM will achieve peace through strength by countering terrorist organizations that are increasing their ability to threaten the homeland while countering activities of China and other adversaries. Capabilities like Airborne-Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (A-ISR) and Counter-Unmanned Aerial Systems (C-UAS) are critical to addressing the increasing threat. We are acutely aware that if ISIS and al-Qaeda groups continue their expansion, they will pose a direct threat to the U.S. homeland. Given this environment, USAFRICOM will work collaboratively with the intelligence community and interagency partners to keep the risk to U.S. national security interests low.

Our approach is *African Partner-led, U.S.- and Ally-enabled* to build partner capacity for African partner operational independence. At any time, leadership in these sovereign nations may change and our working relationship with them may subsequently evolve. Our legal and policy frameworks should remain flexible to maintain an enduring military to military relationship.

Strengthening the capacity of African partners to address security challenges and enhance regional stability reduces the long-term need for U.S. security assistance. Security cooperation is our primary tool through which USAFRICOM strengthens African security institutions toward operational independence. We achieve this through a wide array of training programs, joint exercises, and information sharing initiatives conducted across the continent. Our programs are unmatched by competitors. Flagship exercises such as FLINTLOCK and AFRICAN LION play pivotal roles in building the operational readiness of African militaries and enhancing interoperability among U.S. forces and African partners. FLINTLOCK, focused on counterterrorism and irregular warfare, brings together special operations forces from more than 30 nations to conduct realistic training, share best practices, and build trust. Similarly, AFRICAN LION provides a critical platform for joint, multinational training in a variety of domains, including land, air, and maritime operations. These exercises not only improve tactical capabilities but also foster stronger relationships between African military forces and their international partners.

EAST AFRICA

Due to its strategic importance and our robust counter terrorism operations, the preponderance of USAFRICOM's deployed forces are in East Africa. The region's proximity to the Arabian Peninsula, and its importance to global trade and commerce, cannot be overlooked;

20% of the world's oil moves through the Red Sea annually. Terrorist organizations also recognize the significance of the region and work to attack us and our allies. Our partnership with the newest Major Non-NATO Ally of the United States, Kenya, given that designation in June 2024, continues to grow stronger. Both USCENTCOM and USAFRICOM have a role to play in the security of East Africa and we work together daily to make sure the seam between our two Geographic Combatant Commands is as inconsequential as possible.

Our main effort in East Africa is collaborating with Partners and Allies to support Somalia's fight against al-Shabaab and ISIS-Somalia. Our strong relationship with Somali and African Union forces is key to this effort. Al-Shabaab is one of the deadliest terror organizations on the planet and continues to attack U.S. personnel and facilities in Somalia. Just last November, an al-Shabaab operative was convicted of plotting a 9/11 style terror attack on the U.S. For now, ISIS and al-Qaeda groups are focused on local interests, but they continue to expand and recruit fighters from around the world to position themselves to attack the Homeland. The dangerous capabilities of these groups, if not addressed, will continue to threaten U.S. interests.

The terror organizations in the East are well-resourced and enjoy freedom of maneuver. The Houthis, in Yemen, have moved beyond harassing attacks on commercial vessels, to complex, coordinated missile volleys against both commercial and military vessels. I am greatly concerned about indications of Houthi (part of the Iranian threat network) and al-Shabaab collaboration. The Houthis have the capability to attack the Djibouti Base Cluster, should they decide to escalate against the United States. If they establish a foothold in East Africa, the threat to global trade and shipping would increase significantly, bringing a highly capable, belligerent actor into a region already struggling against ISIS and al-Shabaab.

NORTH AFRICA

Through a variety of operations, activities, and investments in North Africa, USAFRICOM continues to advance U.S. interests by nurturing strong partnerships in a region that sits at the crossroads of Europe, the Middle East, and Africa. Exercise AFRICAN LION, led by the U.S. Army Southern European Task Force, Africa (SETAF-AF), stands out as USAFRICOM's premier annual exercise. The 2024 edition of AFRICAN LION took place from April 19 to May 31 across Morocco, Ghana, Senegal, and Tunisia, involving over 8,100 participants from 27 nations, including NATO contingents. The exercise showcases realistic, dynamic, and collaborative readiness training in challenging environments. AFRICAN LION takes place along multiple seams between geographic combatant commands—USAFRICOM, USEUCOM, and USCENTCOM—in close proximity to key maritime chokepoints and global shipping lanes, all of which magnifies the exercise's significance. AFRICAN LION not only strengthens multinational cooperation but also enhances readiness across all domains, highlighting USAFRICOM's commitment to training African partners for operational independence. Our training brings a level of lethality and professionalism that is unmatched from our competitors, which is why our U.S. training is valued so highly.

USAFRICOM aims to push Libyans to better stand on their own to build a unified military, subordinate to civilian control, which safeguards Libyan sovereignty, increases border security, and combats illegal migration and trans-regional terrorism. The competition between East and West Libyan security actors impacts both the country's development and stability, a situation which occasionally jolts global energy markets. While national re-unification must ultimately come from the Libyan people, through modest, calculated steps, USAFRICOM can

support multilateral security integration efforts to reinforce favorable conditions for U.S. interests and U.S. businesses.

North Africa is home to two highly capable Major-Non NATO Allies - Morocco and Tunisia, both of whom support our regional objectives. This past year, Tunisia hosted the 19th iteration of PHOENIX EXPRESS, a 12-day exercise that brought together North African, European, and U.S. naval forces as part of a global network to enhance cooperation and expertise in maritime security operations in the Southern Mediterranean Sea. Tunisia also hosted SILENT WARRIOR 2024, an event dedicated to enhancing operational effectiveness and mission success of African Special Operations Forces.

Morocco serves as a regional leader by exporting security and economic development throughout Africa, providing training to more than 1200 African partners annually, often at zero cost to the trainees. The training provided includes every level of military education from basic training to War College, spans all services, and includes professional medical, intelligence, airborne, and special operations training. Further, Moroccan trainers travel to neighboring countries using U.S.-produced C-130 aircraft to transport and train partner personnel in a myriad of tasks and skills.

This strong security exporter role is rooted in Morocco's position as a significant contributor to United Nations peacekeeping operations. Over 1700 Moroccan troops per year participate in UN peacekeeping missions in the Central African Republic and the Democratic Republic of the Congo. September 2025 will witness the inauguration of a state-of-the-art Peacekeeping Center of Excellence in Morocco, with the capacity to train thousands of personnel in critical skills, while also having the ability to host strategic-level defense engagements,

diplomatic summits, and senior leader peacekeeping training and discussions. This center is co-funded by the United States and will train thousands of Moroccan and other African partners.

Tunisia is another security exporter in North Africa; it remains a strategic partner on military cooperation, counter-terrorism, and broader regional security. As a growing regional military training hub, Tunisia is emerging as a key partner espousing and projecting Western military standards. Tunisia supports peacekeeping operations across Africa, primarily through strategic airlift capability with its growing C-130 fleet. Expertise within the Tunisian Counter-IED School, hard won in Tunisia's own counterterrorism fight during the prior decade, is sought after by African forces deploying to UN peacekeeping missions and now hosts African students regularly. In all, Tunisia has a significant capability to influence militaries throughout the Sahel and West Africa.

North Africa is also home to Algeria, traditionally a non-aligned nation but where the defense industry continues to make significant headway with direct commercial sales of defense articles, such as C-130 aircraft. In January 2025, the United States and Algeria signed a Military Cooperation Memorandum of Understanding – illustrating our two countries' shared vision to strengthen regional and international peace through strategic dialogue.

WEST AFRICA

West Africa is a dynamic region that includes both multi-party democracies and Sahel nations that experienced coups over the last few years. West African partners broadly welcome U.S. security cooperation despite our withdrawal of forces from the Sahel. The Global Fragility Act, being implemented in Coastal West Africa (as well as Libya and Mozambique) serves as a model for countering terrorist organizations and leveraging investments from allies towards this initiative.

A crucial moment in our partnerships and presence in West Africa in 2024 was the multi-national collaborative effort in the OBANGAME EXPRESS exercise, one of three annual regional exercises conducted by U.S. Naval Forces Africa (NAVAF) and sponsored by USAFRICOM. Hosted by Gabon, the event brought together military delegations from 13 nations across West Africa, Europe, and North America over the course of five days. Participants were from Benin, Côte d'Ivoire, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ghana, Greece, Guinea, Liberia, the Netherlands, Nigeria, the Republic of the Congo, Sierra Leone, Togo, and the United States. They engaged in lectures, practiced maritime security tactics, and conducted joint drills to enhance regional collaboration, maritime security capabilities, as well as counterpiracy cooperation between the African states in the naval and maritime domains. This exercise showcased the United States' unmatched convening power to bring together diverse nations for cooperative security initiatives.

West Africa has a complex mix of challenges. The region has recently experienced a wave of military coups, with countries like Burkina Faso, Guinea, Mali, and Niger facing upheaval as military officers ousted elected governments. These disruptions stem from entrenched corruption, slow economic development, weak democratic institutions, and limited strategic patience. Terrorist groups linked to al-Qaeda and ISIS have exploited these vulnerabilities, thriving in poorly governed regions and preying on underserved populations. Public discontent has intensified, fueled by lingering frustrations with former colonial powers. Central governments, often overstretched, have struggled to counter insurgencies, address corruption, deliver essential services, and resolve inter-ethnic disputes over limited resources.

In 2024, amid this challenging environment, USAFRICOM successfully conducted a safe, orderly, and responsible withdrawal of U.S. forces from Niger. This complex, multi-month

operation required seamless coordination across the Department of Defense, its service components, numerous partners, allies, and our Department of State colleagues, particularly at the U.S. Embassy in Niger. Through meticulous planning and execution, over 1000 personnel along with equipment worth over \$213M were safely redeployed in 133 flights. Without a persistent presence in the Sahel, we are limited in the ability to monitor the expanding influence of terrorist organizations in the region. Our assessment indicates that, if left unchecked, these organizations will continue to grow and their threat to regional stability, as well as to U.S. national security interests, will only intensify. We are increasing our efforts in intelligence sharing and information operations to monitor the growth of these groups and expanding relationships with willing partners elsewhere in West Africa like Benin, Cote d'Ivoire, Ghana and Nigeria.

Along the southwest coast of the Gulf of Guinea, recent developments in Gabon underscore the importance of U.S. leadership to counter China's efforts in West Africa. Our military support to Gabon includes plans to improve port security measures, enhance the country's coastal radar infrastructure, and improve Gabon's ability to monitor and protect its territorial waters. Additionally, collaboration with the U.S. Congress will enable the provision of maritime patrol vessels to Gabon, accompanied by comprehensive maintenance and operational training. Gabon's new collaboration with the West Virginia National Guard through the State Partnership Program will foster collaboration across all aspects of civil-military affairs and encourage meaningful people-to-people ties at the state level, including valuable training, exchanges, professional development, and economic projects. These efforts will not only further U.S. national security interests, but also help Gabon safeguard its natural resources and strengthen its overall maritime security capabilities, aligning with broader regional stability

goals. Our security cooperation approach in Gabon is a good example of our approach in all of West Africa – one geared towards encouraging independent operations and nations leading the way for their own security.

CENTRAL AND SOUTHERN AFRICA

Since the war in Sudan broke out in 2023, Sudan is host to the worst humanitarian crisis in the world. There is no U.S. military solution to the conflict in Sudan and Defense Department opportunities to contribute are limited following the military-assisted departure from Embassy Khartoum in April 2023. The Sudanese people bear the brunt of this crisis. Outside influences are pouring fuel on the fire in Sudan and all efforts need to focus on building conditions for a negotiated resolution to the conflict.

USAFRICOM has strong and growing partnerships in Southern African states like Botswana, Malawi, Zambia, and Angola, and closely monitors regional developments in Central Africa. Security cooperation programs focus on leadership and education so that partners can actively and independently contribute to regional crisis response. This year, Malawi hosted the first Africa Senior Enlisted Leader Conference on the continent of Africa, marking a major step forward in enlisted development. Malawi was an ideal host as they have the only Sergeant Major Academy (mirroring the U.S. Army) on the entire continent of Africa. Botswana co-hosted the 2024 African Chiefs of Defense Conference in Gaborone in June, attended by 33 African Chiefs of Defense from 32 countries, including representatives from East and West Libya. Bringing African military leaders together demonstrates our commitment to driving African solutions to shared security challenges.

Central and Southern Africa are well known for their wealth of critical minerals that serve as foundational materials for emerging technology products used in military and defense systems. The FY24 NDAA enabled the Office of Strategic Capital (OSC) to market financing solutions for critical projects that meet African partner and U.S. national security interests. USAFRICOM is establishing a Defense Economics Branch to collaborate with OSC and proactively target investment opportunities in priority countries and towards strategic objectives. What was known as a “blood diamond” in the past has turned into “blood tantalum” this century. Tantalum concentrated in the DRC is contributing to competition and conflict among state and non-state actors. The DRC has struggled for decades to effectively manage its natural resources for the benefit of its population. Rwanda’s activity in the east, China’s opaque business practices, and entrenched corruption and mismanagement have frustrated DRC’s efforts at reform in this key sector. To counter China’s harmful practices, the United States interagency is investing to improve the business enabling environment and to facilitate new investments in mining and infrastructure. USAFRICOM is supporting U.S. efforts to increase investments for responsible and mutually beneficial mineral supply chains in Africa.

CHINA’S INFLUENCE IN AFRICA

China increased their military and security activities in Africa, presenting new challenges to U.S. interests and partnerships. China seeks to expand security partnerships to protect its extensive infrastructure investments, loans, and economic partnerships under the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). While these investments contribute to Africa’s development, they also bring concerns regarding the debt servicing burden, public contract transparency, infrastructure quality and sustainability, and the potential to exert political leverage over African nations. Chinese financial institutions do not adhere to standard international law and financial regulations and

often rely on non-disclosure agreements to prevent African governments from applying a rigorous review to financial contracts.

In a continent where 70% of the protein comes from the sea, access to affordable fish is essential for Africans. China is the world's worst offender of illegal, unreported, unregulated fishing (IUU-F), much of it done in African waters. This activity decreases host nation revenues, increases the price of fish, and creates opportunities to exploit our African partners. China often employs soft and hard power strategies that run counter to U.S. efforts across the continent.

Foreign information manipulation and interference is prevalent as China exploits their relationships in Africa for economic gain and to secure critical minerals and resources. Unfortunately, CCP information manipulation is significantly outpacing our effort to counter their campaigns. CCP investments in digital TV services in Africa and satellite networks allows them to secure restrictive content sharing agreements with local media outlets. Unchecked, China's efforts could reshape the information landscape in Africa, creating biases and gaps that could lead African nations to make decisions to subordinate their economic and security interests to China's own interests.

We work to expose CCP information manipulation and interference, build African resiliency to false information, shape the environment to better support our interests. This growing presence by China complicates the already volatile security landscape and highlights the critical need for sustained U.S. engagement and robust support for regional partners to adequately compete.

The increasing presence of China highlights the growing strategic importance of Africa, emphasizing the need for proactive U.S. engagement on the continent. USAFRICOM plays a

critical role in countering foreign malign influence through military cooperation, capacity-building, and diplomatic initiatives. Our largest facility in Africa, located in Djibouti, is only a few minutes' drive from China's only overseas military base, underscoring its deepening military investments in the Horn of Africa and across the continent. USAFRICOM seeks to counter China in the security cooperation space, where African nations consistently recognize the advantages of partnering with the United States. In comparing the quality of training, equipment, and security assistance, USAFRICOM's offerings outperform China's. While U.S. assistance is often preferred by African militaries, the time-sensitive nature of security challenges means that some partners choose to turn to China when U.S. timelines cannot meet their immediate needs. As we continue to improve the efficiency of U.S. government programs, USAFRICOM remains committed to strengthening these relationships and supporting regional stability.

CONCLUSION

The African continent is a wide and vast space that presents the United States – and our competitors – with challenges and opportunities. We remain fully committed to making effects-based and resource-informed decisions across the continent by matching capabilities to threats, and continue to believe that solutions for lasting security, stability, and prosperity in Africa involve investment across the instruments of national power: *diplomatic, information, military, and economic*. The men and women of USAFRICOM work diligently to make informed decisions to address challenges and capitalize on identified opportunities. We seek to maintain access and foster productive relationships with our African Partners and our Allies. In this way, USAFRICOM contributes to stability and helps create conditions that are less conducive to malign actors, while better enabling security and prosperity for the United States.

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POSTURE STATEMENT OF
LIEUTENANT GENERAL WILLIAM J. HARTMAN, USA
ACTING COMMANDER, UNITED STATES CYBER COMMAND
BEFORE THE 119th CONGRESS
SENATE COMMITTEE ON ARMED SERVICES
SUBCOMMITTEE ON CYBERSECURITY
9 APRIL 2025



UNCLASSIFIED

(U) Chairman Rounds, Ranking Member Rosen, and distinguished members of the subcommittee, thank you for your support and for the privilege of representing the men and women of U.S. Cyber Command (USCYBERCOM).

(U) I value this opportunity to discuss the changing strategic landscape, the Command's accomplishments in 2024, and the prospects ahead for us in 2025. USCYBERCOM creates an enduring advantage for the Joint Force, for the nation, and for its partners. Our Command is fostering a warrior ethos and lethality by building and sustaining mastery in our cyber forces. We are implementing national strategy and re-establishing deterrence by buying down risk for the Department of Defense (DoD), and by harnessing our Service-like authorities, such as Enhanced Budget Control. Congressionally granted authorities and oversight are crucial to USCYBERCOM's success, helping us to anticipate changes in the strategic environment, and to act with speed, scale, and agility.

(U) New technologies are changing the dynamics of cyberspace and the character of conflict. Cyberspace operations demand and reward agility and rapid capability development, and thus we require acquisition and programming processes that move at the speed of relevance. The unique authorities granted us by Congress allow USCYBERCOM to be ready, but this also means added expectations on our Command. I shall explain below how we are responding to this challenge.

(U) USCYBERCOM possesses operating, equipping, and sustaining responsibilities for the nation's joint cyber force. Each of the Armed Services develops and presents personnel to

our Cyber Mission Force (CMF). Each of the Service Cyber Component commanders also serves as a Joint Force Headquarters-Cyber commander executing missions in and through cyberspace. It is also important to mention here our direct-report components: our sub-unified command – the Cyber National Mission Force-Headquarters (CNMF-HQ) – along with our Joint Task Force Ares, and our Joint Force Headquarters-DoD Information Network (JFHQ-DoDIN). Congress recently directed the latter to be elevated to a sub-unified command under USCYBERCOM and that elevation will take place later this year. In addition, USCYBERCOM operates closely with Coast Guard Cyber Command, an element in the Department of Homeland Security (DHS). These components, in combination, provide robust capacity and capability for the Department of Defense and for the nation.

(U) USCYBERCOM, through its components, executes four assigned missions. The Cyber National Mission Force defends the nation from malicious cyberspace actors who threaten our critical infrastructure and democratic processes. Joint Force Headquarters (JFHQ)-DoD Information Network (DODIN) operates and defends the DODIN to ensure our warfighters can execute missions globally. Our service-led Joint Force Headquarters – JFHQ-C (Navy), JFHQ-C (Army), JFHQ-C (Marines), and JFHQ-C (Air Force) – integrate options and capabilities into Combatant Command campaigns and plans, posturing the command to support the Joint Force as we collectively re-establish deterrence against adversaries and prepare to win our nation's wars. Finally, we bolster the effectiveness of our allies and partners, empowering them to accomplish their missions as well as to assist the Department's efforts.

(U) The National Security Agency (NSA) is our Command's closest partner. I serve as both the Acting Commander of USCYBERCOM and the Acting Director of NSA. Every day I see how the Agency's roles, responsibilities, and unparalleled capabilities complement those of USCYBERCOM. The synergy between these two organizations drives a unity of effort that strengthens the Department, the Intelligence Community, and ultimately the nation.

(U) At USCYBERCOM, our Code is "We win with people." This guiding principle highlights our dedication to building a culture where initiative, innovation, collaboration, and the expertise of our personnel drive mission success. The people of USCYBERCOM are dedicated to defending our networks, countering threats, strengthening our partners, and providing a decisive advantage for policymakers and military commanders in competition and conflict. We amplify the impact of federal, military, foreign, and private-sector partner activities, synergizing the application of all instruments of national power against our adversaries. We are dedicated to ensuring our people have the necessary resources to optimize readiness and resilience as they face disproportionately large adversary forces.

(U) SHIFTING THREATS

(U) USCYBERCOM is in daily contact with determined and sophisticated adversaries, primarily state-sponsored cyber actors. DoD systems and data – as well as critical civilian infrastructure in the United States – have come under significant risk, while our responsibility to defend them remains a no-fail mission for the Department and the nation.

(U) We have witnessed bold efforts by state-sponsored cyber actors to achieve strategic objectives against the United States and its allies and partners. We focus on adversaries probing the DoDIN, U.S. weapons systems, and U.S. and Western critical infrastructure to hold vital economic and national functions at-risk. Adversary cyber actors also target Western defense industrial base networks to steal weapon-system technology.

(U) China is our pacing adversary. Beijing seeks a world order more in conformity with the Chinese Communist Party (CCP)'s vision and ideology – and Beijing views cyber as a critical domain for modern warfare . Not only is it our closest competitor in cyberspace; but it is also aggressively expanding its influence in the Pacific while insisting that it is only acting to defend itself. China employs the world's largest cyberspace operations workforce, supported by capable and adaptive enablers in its defense, cybersecurity, and information technology industries.

(U) Our Command gratefully acknowledges the importance that our allies and partners provide in defending our common interests and re-establishing deterrence in the Pacific. The United States cannot unilaterally match the quantity of resources that China can devote to cyber operations, but together we can exceed it in the quality of our people and our capabilities. That is the advantage that allies, partners, and industry provide us when we collaborate and synchronize efforts.

(U) Russia appears determined to continue its persistent threats to the peace of Europe and to the global order. Moscow violates international norms with its eleven-year old aggression

in Ukraine, coupled with its overt and covert attempts to intimidate Ukraine's supporters. As with China, Russia's sophisticated military and intelligence cyber forces actively support its strategic objectives. Russian cyber actors work to subvert Ukraine and divide the Western allies, seeking to undermine them both abroad and internally. In the Russian case, moreover, the Kremlin encourages, or at least tolerates, brazen cyber-criminal enterprises that often serve state purposes against foreign targets.

(U) Iran and North Korea sponsor increasingly capable cyber actors. We assess Iran seeks to increase penetration and targeting of industrial control systems to disrupt critical infrastructure in Israel and elsewhere. Pyongyang focuses its cyber actors on the circumvention of international sanctions and the generation of illicit revenue through cryptocurrency exploitation and IT workers. that likely supports the regime's nuclear weapons and ballistic missile programs.

(U) Non-state cyber actors remain a threat in cyberspace. Cyber criminals services continue to find new victims in the United States and globally. We are particularly concerned about the criminal enablers of such activities, such as those providing ransomware-as-a-service to all manner of bad actors. In addition, violent extremist groups still operate in cyberspace. Though their capabilities have been eroded, the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria (ISIS), al Qaida, and other terrorist groups maintain the intent to target Americans. Our Joint Force Headquarters-Cyber (Marines) works in conjunction with U.S. military and diplomatic efforts, supporting allies and partners who are disrupting terrorist propaganda and mobilization online as well as to provide critical intelligence.

(U) Cyberspace is a dynamically evolving domain that sees accelerating technological change. New technologies do not represent a direct threat in themselves, but they are nonetheless forcing every military and cyber force to adapt even more dynamically. That, in turn, is affecting our resources and organizational arrangements. Artificial intelligence (AI), of course, holds the potential to change the character of war. USCYBERCOM is leveraging AI to enhance our capabilities in collection, detection, exploitation, maneuver, and command and control, generating greater speed and scale. There is no inherent obstacle to our adversaries using AI for similar purposes – or even more. Automation and autonomy – in cases enabled by AI – are transforming ideas from theory into real and even disruptive weapons and tools on battlefields and in competition across the globe. Our allies, partners, and adversaries are all engaged and propelling this technological progress. I shall say more about our response in a moment.

DEFENSE OF THE NATION

(U) USCYBERCOM defends the nation against threats in and through the global and interconnected domain of cyberspace. This work begins with the defense of the DoDIN but extends directly and indirectly to government, critical infrastructure, and partner systems as well.

(U) Our Command guards the military systems and data that provide warning, situational awareness, synchronization, and sustainment for our fellow Combatant Commands in their geographic and functional areas of responsibility. This is our supported mission at USCYBERCOM. All of the Combatant Commands support our execution of it because every

Combatant Command's operational plan depends on the ability of leaders and commanders to communicate orders and data securely. USCYBERCOM's responsibility, executed in particular through JFHQ-DoDIN, includes working with the other Commands, with the DoD Chief Information Officer (CIO), and with the Defense Information Systems Agency (DISA) to identify key cyber "terrain" and ensure they – and we – have cognizance of its status as well as clearly defined roles and assignments for defending it. When necessary, our Cyber Protection Teams work with local network defenders to identify and expel would-be intruders on Joint Force and DoD systems.

(U) The Defense of the Nation is integral to re-establishing deterrence. USCYBERCOM is strengthening the defense of critical infrastructure and the DoDIN by investing in and implementing stronger, more proactive cybersecurity measures; investing in artificial intelligence and machine learning to improve threat detection, response times, and predictive analysis; enhancing the knowledge, skills, and the capabilities, of our workforce; leveraging new and existing authorities; and working with our Allies, partners, and industry to create a more difficult target for our adversaries.

(U) I am pleased to add here that we are increasing resources and focus of on behalf of the Combatant Commands directly engaged in defending the American homeland against other actors. This emphatically includes support for USNORTHCOM in securing our borders. We are also working with partners to counter foreign drug cartels. Our efforts should help make a difference against the flow of fentanyl as well. Finally, we support USSPACECOM and other DoD entities in bolstering defenses against missile attacks against the United States.

(U) USCYBERCOM dynamically employs our assigned forces to achieve multiple objectives and priorities. Our forces are tasked with safeguarding critical infrastructure and the DoDIN, conducting operations to disrupt, deny, and deter adversaries, and supporting joint operations worldwide. The employment of the cyber force is continually evolving in response to the shifting threat landscape and technological advancements. This demands effective coordination, robust intelligence, and a deep understanding of both the cyber domain and the broader geopolitical context.

(U) Our Command recognizes the vital role that we play in supporting the Joint Force in Pacific contingencies, focusing on the strategic and operational challenges that China presents in cyberspace. In particular, we assist USINDOPACOM in its mission to deter aggression and defend its area of responsibility. This commitment extends to the other Combatant Commands that would be involved in a Pacific crisis, particularly U.S. Transportation Command (USTRANSCOM), U.S. Strategic Command (USSTRATCOM), U.S. Special Operations Command (USSOCOM), and U.S. Northern Command (USNORTHCOM). We also work with U.S. Government partners and industry to counter China-based cyber threats to our homeland, allies, and partners. We are defending against Beijing's cyber operators persistent access to U.S. critical infrastructure systems pre-position for attack in a contingency or crisis scenario. We are also hardening DoD's cyber "terrain" across the Pacific region to make it more defensible against any attacker.

(U) USCYBERCOM supports U.S. Central Command (USCENTCOM) and USSOCOM in their work to re-establish deterrence and, if necessary, defeat Iran. With USCENTCOM, we

have helped bolster the cyber defenses of Israel and other regional partners. The Command has focused on securing key networks in the region, and provided actionable information, insights, and options to policy makers.

(U) Defending Joint Force and military systems and data parallels our efforts to support the defense of adjacent cyber terrain, particularly government, critical infrastructure, and partner networks. We work intensively across the Joint Force and with a variety of partners to do this – what we call “Setting the Globe” – because systems in one region often depend on the working and the security of other systems hundreds or even thousands of miles away.

(U) Our job is to work with an array of U.S. and foreign partners to ensure that adversaries cannot impair that connectivity or our decisionmakers’ trust in its security. Foreign adversaries continuously update how they operate, and frequently work through (unwitting) American-owned networks and devices. USCYBERCOM seeks to foster unity of action across partners like the Service counterintelligence agencies, the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI)-led National Counterintelligence Task Force, and DHS’s Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA), sharing actionable intelligence to counter adversary activities. In addition, USCYBERCOM and NSA enable efforts by the Department of the Treasury, the FBI, and other partners to disrupt ransomware, cryptocurrency theft, and other criminal activities, and vice versa.

(U) Consistent with Congressional intent, USCYBERCOM shares information with industry to help bolster private companies’ ability to defend themselves against exploitation by

malicious cyber actors. We aim to broaden as widely as possible the sharing of insights that both our industry partners and we gain from this collaboration. Our UNDERADVISEMENT program, a voluntary collaboration with dozens of private partners, links cybersecurity expertise across industry and government. This partnership has cued significant operational successes, enabling network owners to close vulnerabilities and eradicate threats from their systems; this frustrates adversaries and makes their campaigns more expensive for them and less consequential for us.

(U) USCYBERCOM's Cyber National Mission Force (CNMF) conducts missions to counter malicious cyberspace activities, supporting all aspects of our defend-the-nation mission set. CNMF personnel have deployed more than 85 times to over 30 countries in partner-enabled missions to hunt on host networks. They conducted more than two dozen "hunt forward" missions in 2024, generating insights and constraining adversary freedom of maneuver. We conduct such missions in all Geographic Combatant Command regions. These missions have led to public releases of malware samples for analysis by the global cybersecurity community. Such disclosures have made Internet users around the world safer on-line, and frustrated the military and intelligence operations of authoritarian regimes. In addition, CNMF is leading our Command's effort to explore and apply artificial intelligence to the cyber mission set. The AI Task Force in CNMF already sees success in a growing series of pilot projects, which are having operational impact today.

BUILDING AND SUSTAINING MASTERY

(U) USCYBERCOM will create advantages for warfighters, the Department, our partners, and the nation in 2025, operating globally by enhancing readiness, implementing Service-like authorities, and advancing mission partnerships. I am pleased to report that all our Service cyber components have now attained foundational readiness standards across the forces they present to our Command. This objective, as you know, took years to achieve even with the dedicated efforts of the Services to improve the manning, training, and equipping of their respective forces. That milestone having been reached, however, we must now focus on what comes next. Readiness alone will not suffice given the magnitude of the task we face. Sustaining cyberspace operations at-scale against a determined and capable adversary that can build many more cyber elements than we can was a requirement not fully projected when the Department established USCYBERCOM in 2010 and authorized our Cyber Mission Force in 2012.

(U) Our response includes an initiative titled CYBERCOM 2.0, which we designed to foster mastery across the force so it can overmatch quantity with quality. The Department recently approved several concepts to update USCYBERCOM's force design and the ways in which it builds and sustains specialization and expertise in our teams. Together with the Services and our Components, we are crafting proposals to maximize capacity, capability, and agility, harnessing a stronger, more lethal force in more innovative and exciting ways. These include ways of fielding new technologies rapidly, finding ways to ensure they are tested and scalable. These steps were prompted and facilitated by recent National Defense Authorization

Acts' provisions on readiness and force generation that collectively gave the Department the opportunity to modernize the cyber force and reshape USCYBERCOM.

(U) Coupled with the readiness efforts highlighted above and organizational efforts to streamline the force, CYBERCOM 2.0 provides a pathway to maturation for the Command through the evolution to mastery. The initiative focuses on key enablers such as recruiting and retaining top talent, advancing training and education for the cyber force, and fostering an innovation ecosystem that moves at a mission-relevant pace, producing mission-relevant technologies. Overall, this results in a more experienced, better-trained, and better-equipped cyber force capable of adapting to the dynamic environment.

(U) Our cyber force aims to build mastery that in turn fosters speed and agility. In an environment transformed by AI and big data, operational and strategic advantage accrues to the side that sustains speed and efficiency in collecting and ingesting data, building and employing models and algorithms, and deploying and updating them at-scale—while also denying similar advantages to adversaries seeking to exploit our systems and data. We are focused on ensuring our data and analytic infrastructures deliver advantage, and that those systems attain sufficient resilience to function even under attack. Some of this work proceeds under the auspices of the DoD- and USCYBERCOM-developed five-year AI Roadmap, which guides the appropriate people, data, organizations, and infrastructure to deliver AI capabilities for all cyber mission sets; to counter AI threats and seize emerging opportunities; and to enable AI adoption.

(U) Strong partnerships with government, industry, academia, and foreign colleagues amplify our effectiveness and in turn create advantages for our partners. They force dilemmas upon our adversaries, and broaden the perspectives and insights we can utilize and exploit. Our Components, when working in unison with diplomatic, military, law enforcement, homeland security, and intelligence capabilities, make a powerful combination that can disrupt the plans of malicious cyber actors wherever they hide. In addition, our Regional Cybersecurity and Engagement Strategy in the Indo-Pacific guides efforts with partners to counter and contest foreign adversaries. Much of our effort at USCYBERCOM goes into fostering capacity building among partners, promoting interoperability, and reducing barriers to information sharing and combined activities.

(U) Congress enhanced our attractiveness to new partners by designating USCYBERCOM a federal lab for technology transfer. Why does that matter for a Combatant Command? Because as a lab, USCYBERCOM is authorized to sign Cooperative Research and Development Agreements (CRADAs) with industry and academic partners. We have reached several such agreements, allowing tighter collaboration between our operators and technical experts and, for example, local network defenders seeking to enhance their capabilities to detect whether their systems have been compromised. USCYBERCOM also has signed Education Partnership Agreements (EPAs) with several universities. Finally, our Academic Engagement Network (AEN) of more than 120 institutions is facilitating new partnerships and bringing fresh ideas to shared challenges.

(U) The Enhanced Budgetary Control (EBC) authority and resources granted in increments by Congress since 2018 are now hastening the Command's transformation. Fully implemented less than a year ago, this suite of authorities is already making a difference in our relations with DoD, the Services and our Components. EBC entrusts nearly \$3 billion of the DoD budget to USCYBERCOM, and streamlines how we engage the Department's planning, programing, budgeting, and execution processes. EBC is promoting the transparency that facilitates tighter alignments between authorities, responsibility, and accountability in cyberspace operations. Greater accountability, in turn, facilitates better cybersecurity as well as faster development and fielding of new capabilities.

(U) We recognize that innovation is vital to achieving speed, agility, and scale across operations, capability deployment, data sharing, and procurement. Agile acquisition is crucial to creating advantage for our commanders, Components, and operators. The Command partners with the Services and DARPA (among others) to ensure our acquisition strategies achieve agility, scale, and precision at the rapid pace demanded by the cyber-domain. For example, USCYBERCOM partners with DARPA on an effort called CONSTELLATION to swiftly bridge the proverbial "valley of death" for new capabilities and rapidly transition emerging tools to the operational user.

(U) USCYBERCOM's new acquisition authorities promote agile methodologies for rapid AI development and iteration, enabling swift adaptation to evolving cyber threats and operational needs. Coupled with the Joint Cyber Warfighting Architecture (JCWA), the Command has a framework ensuring AI solution interoperability and integration across cyber domains. This

supports rapid prototyping, streamlined software acquisition, and the integration of commercial AI advancements.

(U) Key to speed and agility in operations is JCWA, a suite of systems with associated capabilities that facilitate a full spectrum of cyberspace missions and foster overmatch against sophisticated adversaries. Our Command is employing new systems engineering and integration authorities (granted by the Department) to oversee the fielding of JCWA and ensure it develops efficiently in accord with a common vision. By defining interoperability standards between the Service-managed subcomponents of JCWA, this has accelerated JCWA's interoperability, tool development capacity, and data flows within and across the Command and mission partners. Finally, the Department is working with USCYBERCOM to build our JCWA Program Executive Office (PEO), and ultimately to provide our Command with milestone decision authority for Service-managed JCWA programs of record.

(U) USCYBERCOM's efforts depend on the initiative, motivation, and excellence it sustains in its people. We must hire and retain key expertise, and keep our personnel ready to meet the challenges of competition and conflict in and through cyberspace. We are working to grow uniformed cyber leaders at all levels, up to and including the officers who will eventually succeed me in this post. The staffing and training of our teams improves every year, and the Command's cyber readiness system now ingests data directly from the Joint Staff's Defense Readiness and Reporting System (DRRS) without manual input. Furthermore, USCYBERCOM's authorities as Joint Cyberspace Trainer facilitates joint training standards

across the entire Department, boosting DoD's ability to defend networks while enabling CMF teams to focus on hunting and contesting foreign adversaries.

(U) Last year the Department of the Army took over the Combatant Command Support Agent (CCSA) role for USCYBERCOM. The Army's military and civilian leaders were superb in managing this transition and ensuring our civilians experienced a virtually seamless transfer. Department of the Army specialists are helping us fill our civilian billets, driving down security and personnel processing times, and we look forward to accelerating hiring actions to fill vacancies across the Command. We are using special hiring authorities offered in 10 U.S.C. 4092 to attract top technical talent to join USCYBERCOM, and look forward to hiring more experts in 2025. We are also maximizing use of DoD Cyber Excepted Service authority to streamline civilian hiring and offer competitive employment incentives.

(U) USCYBERCOM is exploring innovative ways to enhance our operations using the expertise resident in the National Guard and Reserves. We operate side-by-side daily with activated members of the Reserve Component integrated into our teams, and we collaborate with National Guard units on State Active Duty and State Partnership Program engagements. We look forward to expanding ways to make the Reserve Component integral to our efforts, and invite your ideas for doing so.

(U) Last year the Department established the Assistant Secretary of Defense for Cyber Policy as the Secretary's Principal Cyber Advisor to increase focus on cyber activities. The ASD will continue to be instrumental as USCYBERCOM implements new authorities and evolves to increase domain mastery and warfighting readiness.

(U) CONCLUSION

(U) USCYBERCOM creates advantage for the Joint Force, for the Department, for our partners at home and abroad, and most of all for the nation. We campaign in and through cyberspace to support national strategic goals in competition and set conditions for the Joint Force to prevail in crisis and win the nation's wars. We must do so faster and better in 2025 because the United States and our allies face increasingly sophisticated cyber threats from both state and non-state actors. We are meeting that need, and posturing our people and organization to accelerate their efforts. And we will proceed, of course, with scrupulous regard for the privacy and civil liberties of U.S. persons, and in an objective, non-partisan manner.

(U) Our operational experience reinforces the importance of campaigning globally in and through cyberspace across the conditions of competition, crisis, and armed conflict. The Command has authorities to set and validate requirements, to plan and execute programs, and to control budgets and resources. It is working with the Services to organize, train, and equip the force, and has achieved sustainable readiness levels. Its goal now is promoting mastery across our force, using the new resources and authorities Congress and the Executive Branch have provided. I am committed to creating a more lethal cyber force, operating with the speed, scale, agility, and precision that the cyber strategic environment demands.

(U) The men and women at USCYBERCOM are grateful for the support your Committee has given to our Command. Our Service members and civilians are the best I have encountered in my 36-year career, look forward to demonstrating how they can manage their responsibilities,

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employ the resources that you have provided, and accomplish their missions to defend our nation. With continued strong partnership with Congress, I know we will succeed. Thank you, and now I look forward to your questions.

STATEMENT OF

**GENERAL XAVIER T. BRUNSON
COMMANDER, UNITED NATIONS COMMAND;
COMMANDER, UNITED STATES-REPUBLIC OF KOREA COMBINED FORCES COMMAND;
COMMANDER, UNITED STATES FORCES KOREA**

BEFORE THE 119th CONGRESS

SENATE ARMED SERVICES COMMITTEE

10 APRIL 2025



INTRODUCTION

Chairman Wicker, Ranking Member Reed, and Distinguished Members of the Committee, thank you for the opportunity to provide a written statement on the security environment in the Republic of Korea (ROK) and Northeast Asia. Thank you for your steadfast and critical support to the servicemembers, civilians, and families of the “Tri-Command,” the ROK, and the 18 United Nations Command Member States who work tirelessly to create a future defined by security, freedom, and prosperity. The U.S.-ROK Alliance remains a beacon of stability and strength in the Indo-Pacific. Our two nations share common values and focus on advancing democracy, economic prosperity, security and technical innovation. The ROK sits at the heart of Northeast Asia, which remains a critical region among great powers and regional actors. China, Russia, the Democratic People’s Republic of Korea (DPRK), and Iran are strengthening relations and conducting activities that undermine the security and stability of the Korean Peninsula and region writ large. These activities are growing increasingly insidious.

As the Commander of United Nations Command (UNC), the U.S.-ROK Combined Forces Command (CFC), and United States Forces Korea (USFK), I have a triple-hatted role with responsibilities that are inextricably linked. In UNC, we enforce the terms of the Armistice Agreement and support peace and security on the Korean Peninsula. In CFC, we deter aggression against any adversary to maintain regional security in Northeast Asia. In USFK, we act as the physical manifestation of the U.S.-ROK Mutual Defense Treaty. Our unwavering commitment to the ROK remains steadfast. However, the Korea Theater of Operations (KTO) has undergone significant changes over the past five years, presenting new challenges and opportunities that require continued attention and adaptation.

Among those shifts include the DPRK’s status on the global stage, emboldened by its

international relationships and illicit gains. DPRK's chemical, biological, and nuclear weapons programs and formidable missile force (ballistic and cruise) pose a threat to the U.S. homeland, U.S. forces in the Indo-Pacific, and allied nations. The DPRK claims to have the capability to strike major cities worldwide, including the United States and 17 of 18 UNC member state capitals. It has reinvigorated its relationship with Russia, its original major benefactor, providing forces and military equipment to support Russia's war efforts while maintaining cooperative ties with China. The DPRK signed a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership agreement with Russia in 2024, mirroring its ties with China through the long-standing Mutual Aid and Cooperation Friendship treaty, codified in 1961. The DPRK has shipped millions of artillery rounds and dozens of ballistic missiles to Russia over the last year as well as deployed more than 10,000 troops to fight against Ukrainian forces. In return, Russia is expanding sharing of space, nuclear, and missile-applicable technology, expertise, and materials to the DPRK. Russia's expanded cooperation will enable advancements of DPRK's weapons of mass destruction (WMD) program across the next three to five years. Contrary to predictions of collapse due to food shortages, the DPRK is more stable than ever, bolstered by substantial resources generated through new revenue streams. These include the world's largest cryptocurrency heist in February 2025, valued at approximately \$1.5 billion, in addition to revenue from weapons exports, international trade, and the export of cheap labor.

Our complex strategic environment frames our missions and priorities. U.S. forces in the ROK represent the only American forces deployed on the Asian continent. This presence is critical in a region that remains significant to U.S. national interests. We meet any challenge, driving forward alongside our ROK allies and a growing trilateral relationship with Japan. Our presence in the region provides a robust deterrent to aggression on the Korean Peninsula and Northeast Asia while promoting security and American prosperity. Building on this foundation, our missions are

guided by USFK's four Lines of Operation (LOO): Defend the Homelands, Strengthen the Alliance, Prepare for Combat, and Build Coalitions. These priorities continue to define our strategy, inform our decisions, and focus our efforts.

No matter how you look at it, our servicemembers, civilians, and their families are our single greatest and most precious resource and advantage. We can do none of our local and regional activities without them. I want to thank Congress and this committee for maintaining the Fiscal Year 2025 National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA) language to maintain our presence of 28,500 U.S. servicemembers deployed to the Republic of Korea. This manpower floor demonstrates our unwavering commitment to the U.S.-ROK Alliance.

Recently, accompanied tour lengths in Korea were aligned with other overseas locations and approved for extension to 36 months. This change is part of an effort to modernize our assignment policies under a flexible, conditions-based model, which establishes 36-month or 24-month tours for accompanied personnel, 12-month tours for unaccompanied personnel, and a limited number of 12-month tours only when accompanied tour requests exceed capacity. This change will deliver significant returns on investment in readiness, continuity, and financial savings. It will reduce the burden on the Military Services to source 7,400 servicemembers for 12-month tours each year, resulting in up to \$104 million in annual savings on Permanent Change of Station expenses. To support this initiative, we are focused on ensuring service members and their families enjoy a high quality of life and make a constant effort to maintain Korea's status as a rewarding and attractive assignment location. While the analysis is ongoing, with these changes will come requirements for infrastructure updates and improvements to housing, schools, and commissaries.

USFK has experienced historical challenges in Behavioral Health Care due to scarcity of providers, in addition to language and cultural barriers in referring patients to Korean providers.

Recently, Korea has been recovering from a year-long protest by their medical service providers which has exacerbated the already constrained health care system. To help mitigate these challenges, I appreciate Congress' effort to add Telehealth mental health services to the FY25 NDAA, encompassing every location, and maximizing coverage for our servicemembers and their dependents.

GAINING & MAINTAINING INFORMATION ADVANTAGE

The Tri-Command is always in contact with our adversaries through, and within, the information environment. Our ability to seize the initiative in the information environment is as critical during Armistice as it is during conflict. Our strategic approach synchronizes our public facing communication, OAI, and strategic intentions to contest unfavorable or false narratives. Our three-pronged effort to Inform to Educate, Inform to Engage, and Inform to Influence across the Tri-Command multiplies our efforts and allows us to gain and maintain information advantage.

Each component of the UNC/CFC/USFK provides a different function and capability needed to protect friendly and domestic audiences and prevent strategic miscalculation. While we can operate across all domains, it is vitally important that we continue to integrate and synchronize our strategic communication to counter adversary narratives. Because of increased adversary cooperation in the region, including initiatives being advanced by China, Russia, and the DPRK, the Tri-Command stands ready to support national narratives, conduct planning for operations in the information environment, and generate informational effects in support of each Tri-Command mission, deterrence, and USINDOPACOM. In the Tri-Command the LOEs are integrated into every single LOO and are critical to the success of that effort. The first, and most important, LOO is to "Defend the Homelands." I added an "s" to the end of homeland because I am also responsible for the 18 United Nations Command Member States currently operating in the Republic of Korea.

DEFEND THE HOMELAND(S)

As we continue to defend our homelands, recent developments offer a nuanced and evolving regional security landscape. In Korean history there have been periods of enhanced diplomacy which have reduced tensions on the Korean Peninsula, but DPRK has increased efforts to develop ballistic missile technology and WMD programs in violation of multiple UN Security Council resolutions. It is critical to recognize that a potential conflict on the Korean Peninsula could have far-reaching implications for U.S. interests, regional, and global affairs. Recent developments have brought these concerns into sharper focus, with rising tensions between the ROK and DPRK over the past year. Contributing incidents include DPRK balloon launches carrying trash and waste into the ROK, the resumption of propaganda broadcasting along the Demilitarized Zone (DMZ), and GPS jamming in the West (Yellow) Sea. In response to the balloon launches and DPRK suspending the Comprehensive Military Agreement (CMA), Seoul subsequently suspended the same agreement in 2024. We must remember that the Korean War has not ended with the 1953 Armistice Agreement leading to a cessation of hostilities. It is still being fought in the diplomatic, information, economic, cyber, and technological development arenas of competition. At the 8th Party Congress in January 2021, Kim Jong Un (KJU) laid out a five-year plan and has since aggressively worked on advancing DPRK's missile and nuclear weapons program. In 2021, DPRK launched six ballistic missiles, conducted the first test of a Hypersonic Glide Vehicle (HGV), and the first test of a rail-launched missile system. The DPRK launched a record 70 ballistic missiles in 2022, achieving diversified land-launched platforms, and tested new Intercontinental Ballistic Missile (ICBM) and Submarine-Launched Ballistic Missile (SLBM) capabilities. In 2023, KJU unveiled ten nuclear warheads, a new solid-propellant ICBM, and advancements in underwater and cruise missile systems. The DPRK also launched 31 ballistic missiles and three satellites, including one that successfully entered

orbit. In 2024, the DPRK focused on cruise missile and HGV research and development (R&D) program advancements, launching 47 ballistic missiles and one failed satellite launch attempt. KJU also had two highly publicized visits to DPRK nuclear sites, supporting his stated intent to advance his nuclear weapon program. Over the past year and a half, the DPRK demonstrated a new ability to provide external support while simultaneously advancing domestic capabilities. So far this year, DPRK has launched at least eight ballistic missiles, including the most recent salvo on 10 March. In the coming year, we expect DPRK to work toward HGV and Multiple Independently Targetable Reentry Vehicle (MIRV) capabilities to complete KJU's 8th Party Congress goals. To counter this, we must dedicate our unwavering attention and investment.

This threat environment underscores the importance of Integrated Air and Missile Defense (IAMD) to defend against the DPRK's ballistic missile threats. The U.S. and ROK possess a robust, layered, and persistent IAMD network of sensors and shooters ready to defend military and civilian critical assets from ballistic missile and cruise missile threats. Along with Japan, we also now have a real-time trilateral missile warning data sharing mechanism against DPRK threats that enables communication of simulated and live adversary data. This sharing occurs across multiple platforms, including AEGIS ships and ground-based surveillance radars. U.S.-ROK Ballistic Missile Defense forces are rapidly enhancing their interoperability while fielding advanced sensors and weapon systems. The U.S. is scheduled to field and employ the IAMD Battle Command System during 2025-2026 which is a significant milestone toward enhancing IAMD across the region.

Moreover, USFK has established a nascent Strategic Integration Element (SIE) focused on extended deterrence cooperation. Since its activation, the element has supported the U.S. and ROK bilateral Nuclear Consultative Group (NCG), assumed increasing responsibility for bilateral Conventional-Nuclear Integration (CNI), including leading a series of CNI-focused tabletop

exercises (TTX), and built productive working relations with ROK Strategic Command. USFK has activated this new organization in response to an evolving threat and to support a tailored approach to meeting our commitment to the ROK. The Operations, Activities, and Investments (OAI) of this element will enhance strategic deterrence against the DPRK, the assurance of the ROK and regional allies, and USFK's contributions as the joint force integrator on the Korean Peninsula. My next LOO is "Strengthen the Alliance" and is focused on activities that deter the DPRK and regional adversaries, underscore to the DPRK that provocative actions will carry negative consequences, and positive actions will be met with positive responses, and assure the Korean people that the United States stands with them should that be required.

STRENGTHEN THE ALLIANCE

Our Mutual Defense Treaty with the ROK has remained in effect for over 70 years and serves as the linchpin for stability in one of the world's most significant economic regions. It commits both nations to provide mutual aid if either faces an external armed attack, but it does not specifically name an adversary. That fact is even more relevant in today's strategic environment and in this region, where authoritarian collusion presents evolving and growing threats to U.S. and ROK interests in the region. We must remain ready and proactive regarding enhancing our cooperation with the ROK government to better support the UNC mandate. These opportunities can include, but are not limited to, pursuing Defense Cooperation Agreements, Visiting Forces Agreements, and improved information sharing, so that we can fully integrate the capabilities of the UNC member states and optimize their effectiveness. The fellowship born out of the Korean War must be refreshed and revitalized should they be called upon again. Ultimately, our Alliance with the ROK and multinational partnerships will play a critical role in our efforts to maintain stability and prevent further escalation of these tensions toward a global crisis.

The persistent presence of U.S. military forces in Korea has modernized the ROK fighting force and defense industry. The ROK invests heavily in acquiring U.S. defense technologies which allows for multi-domain interoperability in a dynamic security environment. As a result, the ROK is familiar with an increasing number of major U.S. platforms, allowing the potential performance of Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul (MRO) work. As of January 2025, the ROK has invested over \$30 billion in active government-to-government sales cases with the U.S. under the Foreign Military Sales system. These investments include MK 54 Lightweight Torpedoes, Precision Guided Munitions, the F-35 Joint Strike Fighter, P-8A Patrol Aircraft, Patriot Advanced Capability-3 missile systems, Global Hawk Unmanned Aerial Vehicle, KF-16 aircraft Upgrades, Aegis Combat Systems, Harpoon and Hellfire Missiles, and AH-64E Attack Helicopters. This strength in our industrial partnership, backed by shared sacrifice and common purpose, ensures both our nations have the resources and capabilities to maintain peace and stability on the Korean Peninsula and across the region.

The U.S. investment in ROK security yields returns over several areas. Economically, the ROK, backed by American strength, has grown to support nearly 450,000 American jobs and 2,100 U.S. companies located in Korea and in the United States. Militarily, ROK contributions reduce the U.S. costs by as much as 18% across all military expenditures. The ROK provides over \$500 million annually to USFK military construction needs, covering most non-relocation program construction requirements. Korean labor contributions in support of American military activities costs around \$412 million, accounting for 85% of appropriated-funded Korean labor costs on the Peninsula. Additionally, the Korean Logistics Cost Sharing program is valued at around \$145 million and offsets the supplies and services costs associated with USFK and its components. These strategic investments underscore the enduring partnership between our two nations, demonstrating a

shared vision for economic cooperation and collective prosperity.

Critical to the defense of Korea is readiness. Across the Tri-Command, activities and investments are designed to contribute to our ability to fight, as U.S. servicemembers, as an alliance, and as a coalition of like-minded states. My third, and most noticeable LOO, is to “Prepare for Combat.”

PREPARE FOR COMBAT

CFC has dual missions of deterrence and defense and receives its guidance from ministerial and general officer level forums. Our Alliance is defensive in nature, but if we must fight, CFC must be ready to win. To that end, our readiness, developed through combined training on the peninsula, is essential to deterring aggression. We accomplish this by conducting constructive, live, and virtual training during our exercises, such as FREEDOM SHIELD (FS), ULCHI FREEDOM SHIELD (UFS), and FREEDOM EDGE. These exercises ensure U.S. and ROK forces are postured to respond to any threat. In our most recent exercise, FS 25 in March, we conducted approximately 53 combined field training exercises covering tactical to strategic activities. The KTO is uniquely complex, with a combined, joint, all-domain, and interagency operating environment. To maintain CFC’s forward momentum, we must continue to adapt to shifting dynamics of the regional security environment, economic development, and combined military advancements to outpace any adversary.

As the premier Joint Force, USFK operates in all domains with our allies and partners, demonstrating the United States’ unwavering commitment to the U.S.-ROK Mutual Defense Treaty. USFK deters DPRK aggression, builds combat readiness, plans and executes joint operations, and pursues interoperability with the ROK military. We also protect U.S. forces and citizens on the Korean Peninsula and serve as the primary conduit for ROK military relationships

with the U.S. Combatant Commands. As the USFK Commander, I lead and oversee the support that the U.S. component commands provide to the ROK.

Last year, we took a significant step forward in our combat readiness when the new combined Operations Plan (OPLAN) was signed. Over the past several years, Alliance planners worked diligently to construct and develop this plan, constantly testing and validating its concepts through execution during our bi-annual FS and UFS exercise events. In response to the evolving security environment, where the DPRK's WMD and missile capabilities are increasingly sophisticated, the new OPLAN better prepares CFC prior to armed conflict. We will continue to use this plan, refine it, conduct exercises, and develop our OAs to support it. As we continue to shape and refine our exercise program in accordance with our new OPLAN, we look for additional opportunities to improve integration and interoperability.

Our combat readiness within the Alliance is further strengthened by the active participation of both military and civilian national security leaders including senior ROK leadership, enabling us to maintain a strong combined defense posture. The high level of participation in our large-scale UFS and FS exercises, demonstrates our warfighting capabilities and sends a clear message of U.S. and ROK resolve to our adversaries. This, in turn, underscores the importance of a regional defense posture, where like-minded nations work together to address common threats and challenges. The U.S. bilateral defense treaties with the Philippines and Japan, the Mutual Defense Treaty with the ROK, and global cooperation with the UNC Member States form a critical foundation for this posture. Operating under the nuclear shadows of China, Russia, and DPRK, the U.S. extended deterrent, coupled with multinational forces and capabilities, enables a more robust and coordinated deterrence strategy. Combined training further enhances interoperability and ensures rapid and

effective responses to emerging threats in the region. By working together, we can leverage our collective strengths, share best practices, and present a united front against aggression.

Moreover, U.S. strategic asset deployments to the Korean Peninsula allow training opportunities with multinational forces, operationalize extended deterrence, and signal U.S. commitment to the security of the ROK. Further, our role in the USINDOPACOM trilateral FREEDOM EDGE exercise seeks to enhance strategic coordination between the U.S., Japan, and Korea. This exercise brings our trilateral security cooperation to the next level and further fosters peace and security in the Indo-Pacific. Combined and Joint All-Domain training confirms our readiness and must be achieved through integration with Carrier Strike Groups, through trilateral air operations, employment of bomber task force missions, and joint, combined ground live fire exercises. We continue to see increased ROK participation in multilateral exercises as well as the involvement of U.S. personnel from multiple Combatant Commands. These efforts demonstrate U.S. commitment to the region and reinforce our shared commitment to stability by enhancing our collective defense capabilities across all domains.

It is essential that we draw upon the capabilities and capacities of our coalition of allies, partners, and friends to be prepared for any potential conflict. My last LOO is to “Build Coalitions.”

BUILD COALITIONS

To leverage our alliance network and partnerships on the Korean Peninsula, UNC hosts a monthly Round Table, where Ambassadors from member states gather to share perspectives on key issues affecting the ROK and engage in dialogue. This effort is part of our broader strategy to Build Coalitions, which provides a unified framework for engagements with bilateral, trilateral, and multilateral allies, partners, and friends. As the UNC’s international legitimacy is vital to maintaining regional stability, I am committed to reinforcing its role. Ultimately, the KTO must include the 18

United Nations Command Member States whose diverse resources, capabilities, and expertise are essential to advancing peace and security through demonstrated strength and unparalleled cooperation.

Operating under the UN flag, UNC enhances the ability to deter aggression, respond to crises, and oppose actions that are incongruent with international norms. UNC provides the following two enduring functions: First, UNC enforces the Armistice Agreement and maintains communication with the DPRK. Nothing is more tested than the Armistice Agreement and the weight of our international commitments in preserving security, freedom, and prosperity in the Republic of Korea.

Second, UNC coordinates the multinational contributions from the 18 countries that contribute forces and capabilities to the Command's mission. UNC Member State coalition building fosters multinational cooperation and offers strategic depth. We have observed growing contributions of our member states, including their continued participation in FS/UFS exercises with over 100 reinforcements for FS 25. Additionally, Germany joined UNC Headquarters in 2024, and we anticipate potential additions from other nations in the future. These efforts are examples of increased "buy-in" to the KTO that we need to maintain our advantage in the region.

Underscoring the need for continued innovation and adaptation in our strategy, the DPRK's capabilities to target command-and-control nodes, satellites, undersea communications cables, and infrastructure pose a significant threat to regional stability. To stay ahead, we must prioritize the integration of artificial intelligence-enabled common operating pictures, command-and-control, mission partner environment cloud-based communications, and enhanced data interoperability. The Tri-Command is committed to deepening trilateral and coalition cooperation to strengthen collaboration, defense technology sharing, and supply chain integration while also pursuing rapid access to the frequency spectrum for advanced surveillance and battle management systems. By

doing so, we can ensure the necessary speed and agility to respond to emerging threats and maintain our strategic advantage in the region.

The collective action by our allies and partners ensures we are strategically predictable, while being tactically and operationally unpredictable. We appreciate the interest of new nations to join UNC or contribute additional capabilities to our mission and thank those nations who have consistently demonstrated their commitment through their ongoing support and partnership in the defense of the ROK.

CONCLUSION

The security environment on the Korean Peninsula and in Northeast Asia requires untiring attention and a multi-faceted approach. The DPRK's evolving nuclear and missile programs, coupled with its strengthening ties with Russia and China, necessitate a united front among allies. The U.S. remains dedicated to its unwavering commitment to the combined defense of the ROK, continuously modernizing defense strategies, enhancing interoperability with regional partners, and employing advanced technologies to counter emerging threats. Through surgical diplomacy, robust posture, and an unyielding commitment to peace, the U.S. and its allies will continue to safeguard stability and prosperity in this critical region. We remain focused on maintaining readiness and strengthening deterrence. In Korea, we train and operate in a combined, joint, and all-domain environment every day. The U.S.- ROK alliance is stronger than it has ever been. Thank you to the U.S. Congress, Service Components, USINDOPACOM, and the Office of the Secretary of Defense.

Under One Flag!

“Katchi-Kapshida” We Go Together!

Fight Tonight!

AIR & SPACE FORCES MAGAZINE

The Fallujah Model

Feb. 1, 2005

Commanders engaged in urban warfare long have regarded airpower as a blunt instrument. In battles from Stalingrad in the 1940s to Grozny in the mid-1990s, airpower's primary purpose was to turn buildings into rubble—and fast.

Such no longer is exclusively the case, however.

With more than 150,000 US soldiers and marines on the ground in Iraq and Afghanistan, the public focus understandably has been on land war. Yet behind the scenes, coalition air forces have been deeply involved in urban “stability” operations. In fact, the November 2004 sweep of the Iraqi town of Fallujah has become the benchmark for airpower in urban joint force warfare.

Fallujah marked the unveiling of an urban-warfare model based on persistent air surveillance, precision air strikes, and swift airlift support. Together, these factors took urban operations to a new and higher level.

When President Bush declared that the major combat operations phase of Operation Iraqi Freedom was at an end on May 1, 2003, he was announcing the start of one of the most difficult and uncertain transitions in warfare: the switch from battle to stability operations.

The term “stability operations” was relatively new when Iraqi Freedom began on March 20, 2003. It was derived from an Army doctrine change in

the mid-1990s. Operations in Panama and Bosnia convinced the Army that contending with conflict after a regime change would be an important part of future military missions.

Stability operations joined offensive operations, defensive operations, and support operations as major parts of combined-arms doctrine. Army planning put Phase IV, Stability Operations, right after Phase III, Decisive Combat Operations.

Phase IV Stability Operations in Iraq turned out to be a major test, one which created unprecedented demands on air and space forces as well as ground forces.

Twitching Regime

OIF decapitated Saddam's regime but left some body parts strong—especially in the north. Baathists who dominated the government bureaucracies and army also had used Iraq as a source of personal wealth. A variety of insurgent groups sought to tip the political balance through violence aimed at the coalition and the interim Iraqi government.

It was, by definition, an urban battle—Iraq's 16 biggest cities held 70 percent of the country's population.

From the very start of Phase IV, the town of Fallujah—35 miles west of Baghdad—was a hotbed of revolt. Tribal loyalties, nationalism, and dislike of foreigners were strong. These political features led to friction with coalition forces soon after they occupied the city in late April 2003.

In Fallujah, the “insurgency” comprised not only hard-line Baathists but also foreign jihadists such as the Jordanian-born terrorist leader, Abu Musab al-Zarqawi.

It was not until March 31, 2004, however, that Fallujah became notorious as the focal point of the insurgency. On that day, Iraqi gunmen ambushed and killed four American contract workers, whose bodies were subsequently burned, mutilated, dragged through the streets, and hanged from a bridge.

Later that same day, five soldiers were killed by a roadside blast a few miles north of the city. In US Central Command's judgment, the killings demanded a response.

Fallujah was located in the easternmost region of the Marine Corps sector of Iraq, and thus responsibility for taking action fell to the I Marine Expeditionary Force commander, Lt. Gen. James T. Conway. He was ordered to attack on April 4.

Operation Vigilant Resolve featured 1,300 marines from I MEF, along with some Iraqi participants. The marines surrounded the city, and then teams made forays into it in an attempt to locate those responsible for the slayings and draw out other insurgents.

From the start, the hunt for the ringleaders featured airpower. Air Force AC-130 gunships targeted specific sites, and marines called in precision air strikes against buildings harboring terrorists or Sunni insurgents. "I never thought I'd be calling for mortars and air strikes and all that," Marine Corps 2nd Lt. Joshua Jamison, who was among the first to go in, told the North County (Calif.) Times.

After a few days, however, US Central Command commanders halted the operation. They were responding to political pressure brought to bear by Iraq's interim governing council and to the problem of deaths of Fallujan civilians. Negotiations got under way. Iraqi forces were formed into the Fallujah Brigade, which was to take control of the city while the marines remained outside.

This abortive April foray demonstrated an emerging set of goals for operations against insurgents in the urban environment. This was no pitched battle of army on army. The key to the strategy lay in isolating insurgent leaders and strong points inside the city.

Manhunt

It was, in part, a manhunt. Secretary of Defense Donald H. Rumsfeld said marines were "systematically moving through the city, looking for targets

that are identified, that they have photographs of,” and that “they know who they want and what they want and why they want that person.”

Even after coalition ground forces pulled back, air operations continued. Gen. Richard B. Myers, the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, said AC-130 gunships and fixed-wing aircraft went on attacking targets. “There were a lot of enemy [fighters] that died there,” he said.

Still, Round 1 in Fallujah left questions about use of airpower in urban operations. In some cases, ground forces just wanted to use their own organic direct and indirect weapons, rather than airpower.

Making positive identification and a collateral damage estimate—both requirements for an air attack—were cumbersome. Commanders wanted to exhaust all other means before going through that process. Only if the time was right and it was necessary would they call in an AC-130 or a fixed-wing platform to drop precision guided munitions.

In Fallujah, the goal of coalition leaders was not so much the taking of the city as it was about altering conditions there. Gen. John P. Abizaid, the coalition commander, explained that there were “certain things we will not tolerate in Fallujah,” such as the presence of foreign terrorists.

“We insist that the heavy weapons come off the streets,” added Abizaid. “We want the marines to have freedom of maneuver in Fallujah, along with Iraq security forces and Iraqi police.”

Through the summer and fall, the air component joined in what might be described as an ongoing hunt for prime insurgency targets in Fallujah and other cities.

Counterinsurgency efforts across Iraq relied heavily on persistent intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance from air and space platforms. Operation Enduring Freedom and Operation Iraqi Freedom had already proved the value of persistence. Now, for stability operations, the role of persistent surveillance was doubly important.

That is because the air component was not dealing with a battle roster of military targets such as Taliban trench lines near Kabul or Republican Guards tanks in a field. Every target struck from the air in this stability operations phase had to be carefully developed and massaged, keeping recent intelligence and overall political goals in mind.

The result was a steady pace of air attacks, even though there were no US ground force attacks in Fallujah. Example: Sept. 13 air strikes targeted a suspected Zarqawi hideout in Fallujah. According to the Associated Press, there had been at least five series of air strikes over the previous week.

Turning to the air component in this way was a significant change in joint operations. A few years earlier, it would not have been possible.

Since Kosovo

Take, for example, the pursuit of Serbian police and military forces in Kosovo during Operation Allied Force, which unfolded in 1999. Serb forces went house to house, killing ethnic Albanians. Some 600,000 were forced to flee to refugee camps across the border in Albania.

The only way to stop the ethnic cleansing was to go to the heart of dictator Slobodon Milosevic's power base in Belgrade and to interdict his forces in the field. Eventually, it worked—after a 78-day air campaign. At the operational and tactical levels of war, however, airpower did little to stop the house-to-house terror.

The USAF Chief of Staff, Gen. Michael E. Ryan, summarized the situation this way: “There was never any delusion that airpower was capable of stopping door-to-door thuggery—at less than platoon level and squad level. ... You're not going to stop that directly with airpower.”

Ryan likened attempts to do so to hitting “leaves and branches” instead of striking at the roots of a problem.

In Fallujah, however, the air component proved it could do quite a lot to target those engaged in door-to-door thuggery. The situation was different

from Kosovo, in that enemy forces were fewer, but the combination of persistent ISR and on-call strike aircraft was nothing short of stunning.

Heading the list of star systems was the Predator UAV. Its full-motion video had proved its utility in Afghanistan and in the major combat operations phase in Iraq. However, the swiftness of the coalition's assault on Baghdad left Predator's urban operations talents largely untested—along with those of many other sensor and shooter platforms.

Round 2 in Fallujah, which unfolded in November 2004, was to show the full impact of the new sensor and shooter technology when integrated with other forces in joint operations.

For several weeks before the main assault, air strikes and artillery fire targeted key sites in the city as they were identified. The hunt for insurgents evolved into battlespace shaping.

Beginning in July 2004, the CAOC focused ISR coverage on building a picture of the insurgent network in Fallujah. Persistent ISR, ranging from imagery to electronic and signals intelligence was important, “particularly with a determined adversary” with a “low signature,” said Lt. Col. John Johanson of the CAOC's ISR division. He said that constant ISR was required, lest “collection gaps create a collection bias” that could skew the overall assessment and characterization of the enemy network.

It culminated in August and September with a series of preplanned strikes that took out key insurgent targets—and did so with great precision. One such strike targeted a weapons-carrying vehicle moving between a residence and a small warehouse. US forces were watching it with Predator and waiting for the target to drive back to the walled compound of the residence. When it did, the driver parked the vehicle under the carport. “We put a Hellfire over the wall [of the house] and under the carport with no damage to the house,” said Johanson. “That's the payoff.”

Operations began on the night of Nov. 7, 2004, as lead elements of the 10,000-strong coalition force seized a hospital that doubled as a known

insurgent base of operations. Aircraft hit preplanned targets—such as barricaded insurgent sites—then shifted to on-call response.

After eight days, Fallujah was “secure”—meaning that 100 percent of it was passable for coalition and Iraqi forces, although sporadic fighting continued. By the end of the month, it had been cleared of most insurgent resistance. Strike sorties across Iraq that week surged to 379—a one-third increase over the average. ISR sorties for Iraq also hit a peak of 161 sorties, the highest total that fall.

Sharper Focus

From the start, the air component was able to focus on the urban area and provide major advantages scarcely seen in urban warfare. These included expanded situation awareness down to the tactical level, rapid precision strikes, and airlift support.

Planners had also mapped Fallujah “down to the street addresses,” as one said. Information about a total of just under 800 buildings was fed into a database, to be shared among air planners, aircrews, and ground forces. For each building, mensurative coordinates already were in place.

When joint tactical air controllers called for strikes, data about a particular building often was already in the database. Alternatively, controllers could use the data to call for strikes on a building near a mapped site. “One of the huge successes of Fallujah II was the ability to preplan and get the playbook to everyone,” said Maj. Eric Grace, an air planner.

In both April and November, Lt. Col. Greg Harbin spent time on the ground controlling air strikes. Harbin said “a big lesson” of Fallujah is that “preplanning shortens the kill chain.” He added, “We knew their alleyways better than they did.”

On the front lines creating that new level of situation awareness was Predator. “It’s Predator TV, a God’s-eye picture for troops on the ground, that saves lives every day,” Lt. Col. Stew Kovall, 17th Reconnaissance Squadron commander, explained to a Texas CBS News affiliate. He was

speaking about Predator's focus on battlefronts from Afghanistan to Iraq. However, the value of the real-time overview was intensified in urban operations.

Restricted lines of sight had always been a factor that favored defenders. Predator—along with other tactical UAVs such as Pioneer—helped overcome that in many cases.

Direct feeds via satellite to command centers and selected forces on the ground opened up a full-motion video perspective on the street battle. Insurgent forces often were unaware of how closely they were being watched by airborne sensors.

For many coalition forces, watching such action was an eerie experience.

“We’ve seen people setting up mortars,” said Capt. Catherine Platt, a Predator sensor operator with the 17th RS, to CBS News reporters in Dallas, “and actually located improvised explosive devices [known as IEDs], and were able to prevent somebody with weapons from being able to shoot or injure any of our troops.”

Thanks to laptop links to the aircraft, troops on the ground in Fallujah got the same view of the battlefield as that given to Predator operators and command center duty officers.

The sensors of other aircraft, such as the AC-130 gunship, also got a tremendous workout in counterinsurgency operations. A widely circulated piece of video footage showed the gunship's ability to track, monitor, and target insurgents, make a positive ID, and then destroy them according to the rules of engagement.

Here were the main features of the air component operations for Fallujah:

- Complete air dominance. Despite the later discovery of a handful of SA-7 surface-to-air missiles in Fallujah, there was no doubt the coalition had complete air dominance there, courtesy of years of no-fly zone operations and the OIF air campaign. Air dominance over Fallujah and other hotspots

permitted ISR assets and fighter, bomber, and gunship pilots to take the time required to build situation awareness, work with joint tactical air control parties on the ground, and select weapons ranging from Hellfire to the satellite guided Joint Direct Attack Munition.

- Layered 24-hour support. With air dominance, the air component could put its top sensor and strike platforms in holding patterns over the city and acquire from above a level of battlespace awareness never before seen in an urban fight. As with Baghdad in the spring of 2003, the air component planned its air support for Fallujah meticulously. Task one was deconflicting platforms over the city's airspace by time, altitude blocks, and ingress and egress routes. Planners referred to the aircraft in the stacks as the upside-down wedding cake—"layered all the way up," as USAF Lt. Col. David Staven said to a reporter for the Associated Press.

- Joint integration. In those layers, fighters were on call for designated time slots. Air component planners scheduled their in and out trips to achieve 24-hour coverage with no gaps. That gave the teams of special operations forces, Air Force, and Marine Corps tactical air controllers a constant resource. Improved consistency and training, plus better connections with higher command centers, now kept the flow of air support running smoothly even with multiple teams on the ground. Joint assets—Navy carrier-launched aircraft and land-based Marine Corps aircraft as well as Air Force aircraft—supplied the stacks. AC-130 gunships with their combination of sensors and precise artillery fire once again proved immensely popular with the ground forces they supported.

- Strafing. Gen. John P. Jumper, USAF Chief of Staff, cited what he called a "surprising" amount of strafing. He said that it was necessary at times "in order to get precision." Harbin, referring to his personal experiences calling in strafing in Fallujah, said, "It's a wonderful thing. We were ambushed, and an F-15 strafed and got us out of that. I've seen enemy break and run just because you have a fighter down low."

In addition to strafing, said Jumper, "we had a significant number of airplanes in there, working against individual buildings. There are many

accounts of our GPS-guided weapons plucking buildings out of the middle of very populated areas.”

- Heavy ISR tasking. It took a much greater percentage of ISR sorties to sustain urban operations during the Fallujah fight. In OIF in 2003, strike sorties flown outnumbered ISR sorties by more than 12-to-1. For Fallujah, the ratio was just over 2-to-1. That made ISR a top contributor to modern urban operations.
- Demand for first-strike success. In Fallujah, the targets for fighters, bombers, and gunships were generally clusters of insurgents being identified by ground forces or other sensors in real time. The targets ranged from buildings to trucks to snipers. Aircrews tasked with the strikes had to hit targets the first time to be effective. The nature of the close support operations also meant there was rarely an opportunity to go back and restrike the same target.
- Immediate follow-on attacks. As a result of operations throughout the prior months, airmen already knew what to do when insurgents fled a site under air attack. Ideally, air component systems would follow them and hit the next building they entered and resume the attack. The Washington Post reported the details of such a one-two punch that took place Nov. 10. Air strikes hit one house holding insurgents, then struck a second smaller house where the survivors had fled. That combination took persistent surveillance, communications, and striking power.
- Airlift and medevac. Positioning people, equipment, ammunition, and supplies heavily taxed the air component’s mobility forces. At Balad AB, Iraq, mobility airmen on one day tripled their typical daily transport average to 1.3 million pounds. Air Force strategic and tactical airlift surged to put in place the pieces needed for the renewed offensive. Medical evacuation moved wounded to higher-level care facilities rapidly.

It wasn’t only the marines on the ground who were using innovative tools and tactics in the urban fight. The air component worked hard to maximize accuracy and minimize collateral damage. America’s powerful military force

could, if it wished, quickly turn Fallujah into a pile of rubble, but there was no point to doing that. Making rubble was the old ideal, precision the new.

Ideal Weapon

When large quantities of the 500-pound GBU-38 JDAM arrived in the theater in fall 2004, the system quickly became a top air weapon for use in the urban environment. The GBU-38 caused less collateral damage and eliminated uncertainties associated with laser guided bombs.

“This was the right weapon for the job,” said the F-16 lead pilot who flew the first GBU-38 mission. “If we used any bigger [weapon], we would have caused unnecessary damage.”

Air component support increased ground force efficiency. The end result was a speedy offensive that focused firepower where it was needed.

As with other campaigns in recent years, commanders were admonished to keep attacks precise. Reported Marine Corps Col. Mike Regner, the I MEF operations officer: “Not a piece of ordnance goes into that city that I don’t watch” in one way or another.

Regner also described how air attacks used laser guided bombs to topple a minaret hiding snipers, without causing damage to an adjacent mosque.

In Regner’s view, the weapon precision was unprecedented.

“Is this like Vietnam?” he asked. “Absolutely not. ... Hue City ... was leveled, and there wasn’t precision targeting, and they didn’t secure it in the amount of time that we’ve secured” Fallujah, he said.

There was no doubt the second battle for Fallujah was a necessary one. Many of the estimated 2,000 insurgents in the city were killed and their sanctuary eliminated.

“Besides being a safe haven for leadership command and control, Fallujah was a center for making the IEDs that were being produced and used in

other parts of the country to attack the coalition,” said USAF Lt. Gen. Lance L. Smith, CENTCOM deputy commander.

Fallujah was hardly left unscarred by recent operations there. Destruction was great. Even so, the evolution of airpower changed the calculus for insurgency operations in the urban environment. Air and space power working together can now engage targets with dial-up precision and immediate command and control.

The model unveiled in Fallujah adds to the margin of superiority for forces on the ground and takes the pursuit of major targets to a new level of competence through persistent ISR and on-call strike.

Rebecca Grant is a contributing editor of Air Force Magazine. She is president of IRIS Independent Research in Washington, D.C., and has worked for Rand, the Secretary of the Air Force, and the Chief of Staff of the Air Force. Grant is a fellow of the Eaker Institute for Aerospace Concepts, the public policy and research arm of the Air Force Association’s Aerospace Education Foundation. Her most recent article, “Bomber Harris,” appeared in the January issue.

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THE JOINT TEAM



U.S. AIR FORCE



Airmen,

Today, we find ourselves in an era of strategic competition against adversaries who seek to outpace and eventually overtake us. They are building and refining their military capabilities while simultaneously seeking to disrupt the rules-based international order. The future challenging and uncertain environment requires an adaptive, innovative, and ready force that can effectively operate with any and all Services. The importance of having a capable and lethal Joint Force cannot be overstated.

To that end, every Airman needs to know what is at stake in strategic competition and to understand the critical importance of synchronizing our capabilities. Throughout our careers, we have seen the capabilities of our joint partners and how they amplify our own strength and power. As technology and information change at a rapid pace, the persistence of our Airmen, Guardians, Soldiers, Sailors, Marines, and Coast Guardsmen to innovate and solve complex problems is imperative to winning against those who challenge our way of life.

Each of us is part of a larger team, bringing our individual talents to add value to a cause much bigger than ourselves. We must all stay rooted in the conceptual knowledge of the Joint Force and what each service member brings to the fight. Likewise, we must recognize the operational importance of airpower and apply it across the full spectrum of warfare.

This guide provides us the knowledge of the Joint Force and outlines expectations for us all to know, articulate, and implement across the Air Force. Understanding the value each service brings to the fight is paramount when it comes to competing, deterring, and winning the high-end fight. Employing the concepts in this “Purple Book” is the first step toward a unity of effort that will allow us to develop the military our nation needs and to ensure the capabilities we bring to the fight – together – will always be unmatched!

Aim High!

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'JoAnne S. Bass'.

JoAnne S. Bass
Chief Master Sergeant of the Air Force

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Charles Q. Brown, Jr.'.

Charles Q. Brown, Jr.
General, USAF
Chief of Staff

PURPOSE

Since 1947, The United States Air Force has been a critical component of every conflict, humanitarian mission, and military presence around the globe. Every Airman contributes to the delivery of sovereignty and freedom through their specialized skillset, thereby generating airpower—anytime, anywhere. To continue to advance with the speed and agility required to keep pace in a dynamic and competitive environment, our Joint Force provides capabilities that validate the strength of the United States, its allies, and its partners. In order for our Soldiers, Marines, Sailors, Airmen, Guardians, and Coast Guardsmen to deter our adversaries and respond to threats in any environment, we must understand, articulate, and demonstrate jointness.

This guide explains our Joint Force. It is built upon the foundation of contextual knowledge of joint doctrine, the National Defense Strategy, and the National Military Strategy. It clarifies the fundamental questions all Airmen must be able to answer: “How do I fit into the Joint Force, and how can I ensure I hone and deliver my unique capabilities to assure its success?” This guide will help Airmen internalize what it means to fight jointly, understand the missions of the Joint Force, appreciate the joint organizations that are leading the fight, comprehend how to integrate in a joint warfighting environment, and identify how the Air Force fits into the joint construct.

Leaders within the Department of Defense continue to stress the importance of every service member building an understanding of the emerging dangers that face our Nation. All warfighters must acknowledge the threat that our adversaries pose as they attempt to close the gap that presently exists between their capabilities and our own. That can never happen. Our Joint Force is comprised of professional, agile, and, adaptable men and women who serve with the highest level of integrity and commitment to their service, the Joint Force, and our Nation.

Information presented within this guide is intended to help Airmen understand the Joint Force. It is also meant to inform joint partners of the capabilities and knowledge that Airmen bring to their Joint Force formations. There are no previous versions of this guide.

THE JOINT TEAM

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